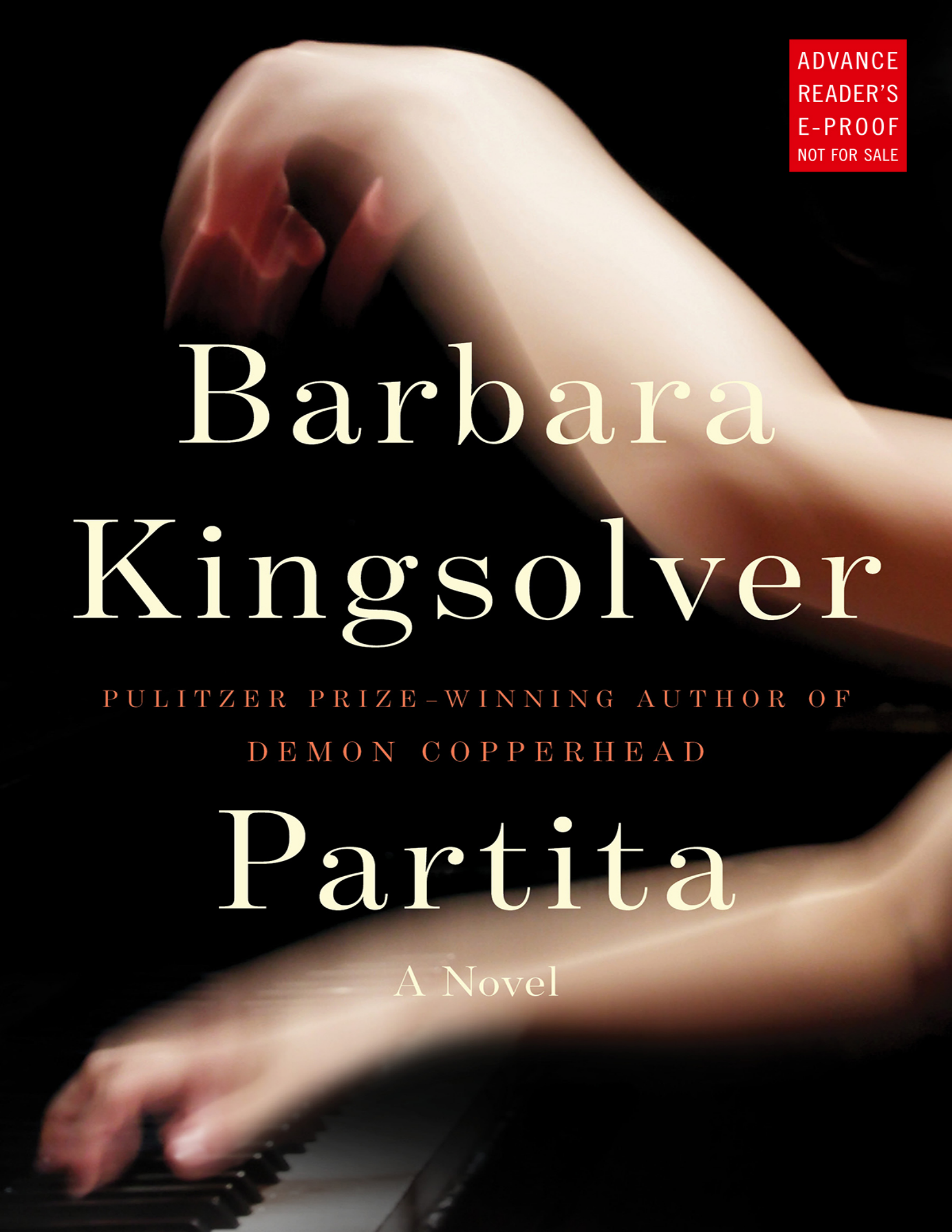

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Partita
A Novel

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Partita

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Dedication

For Steven

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Epigraph

Sometimes you don’t survive whole, you just survive in part. But the grandeur of life is that attempt.

—Toni Morrison

Contents

Cover
Title Page
Also by Barbara Kingsolver
Copyright
Dedication
Epigraph

Listening List

Overture
Prelude I
Allemande
Prelude II
Toccata
Prelude III
Sarabande
Prelude IV
Fugue
Prelude V
Pathétique
Prelude VI
Da Capo
Prelude VII
Al Fine

Acknowledgments
About the Author

About the Publisher

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.....

Listening List

p. TK—Frédéric Chopin, Prelude in D-flat Major, Op. 28, No. 15 (“Raindrop” Prelude)

p. TK—Miriam Makeba, “Emabhaceni”

p. TK—Edvard Grieg, Piano Concerto in A Minor, Op. 16

p. TK—Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, “Rondo alla Turca” (Piano Sonata No. 11, K. 331, third movement)

p. TK—Maurice Ravel, “Ondine,” *Gaspard de la Nuit*

p. TK—Franz Schubert, “Erlkönig”

p. TK—Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart, Requiem in D Minor

p. TK—Ludwig van Beethoven, Seventh Symphony, second movement

p. TK—Frédéric Chopin, Prelude in B Minor, Op. 28, No. 6

p. TK—Cornelius Gurlitt, “Night Journey”

p. TK—Edward Elgar, “Salut d’Amour”

p. TK—Johann Sebastian Bach, Partita in C Minor, Allemande and Sarabande

p. TK—Erik Satie, *Gnossienne* No. 3

p. TK—Maurice Ravel, “Le Gibet,” *Gaspard de la Nuit*

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Overture

Here's my question: How does a person step in front of a train and leave everything right there? Inhale, no exhale.

It tilts you on a slant, to walk your whole road with a question like that and no answer to balance it out. Answers are such everyday things to count on, reliable as your teeth. You only notice when one goes missing, leaving its partner to grind on empty air. In life or art or music, it's the same. Object and shadow. Eight measures of statement, eight measures of response—that's how a scrappy German orphan named John Bach got the whole world in his pocket a few hundred years ago, and keeps a lot of us there still. He threads a promise into your ears, weaves it around through soft brain folds and down to the needful heart where he delivers you this conclusion: *Rest easy. This all comes out right in the end*.

A song without any answer in it, though? That's the sound of waiting. For years, I woke up asking nobody and everything, the stupid happy morning light of every day, *How did he do it?* And back it would come as I fell asleep, nudging the base of my skull like somebody's thumb pressing there. I didn't need any reminding, as I am now whenever I see a train or drive over the tracks. In the first years after it happened, we were haunted every minute. I don't mean to say my brother was hanging around the house in a body-shaped bag of light or whatever people mean when they say "ghost." But I saw him, his long shins and overlong feet like a young dog growing

into itself, his hair he kept a little too long to be taken for a jock, the way he splayed himself on the floor to read or think, as if he took gravity harder than the rest of us. Dark eyes looking up, offering no answer to this question that stuffed our throats like cotton wool. It even damped out my mother's favorite warning against getting above myself: *It's not the whistle that pulls the train.* She found other ways to say it, Lord knows. But that word left our station.

It was a long time ago. People say that as a comfort, as if the broken-glass edges of our damage get worn down by years. And in the meantime, you do what? Stare at the train wreck, pick at the scar, play the scorching memory over and over like a hard piano passage you're determined to memorize, trying to dull the cutting edge. Even if it adds up to the pursuit of misery as an occupation. I've studied the angles, read the accounts you can find in the news, a few police reports I probably shouldn't have seen, and these stories get me no further. Right up to the question mark, still empty air on the other side. How did my brother go off and leave me like that? With determination, some self-medication, people assumed: *Drunk or high, fell asleep on the tracks.* But it takes some doing to choose that particular bed, and what about waking up at the last minute with the animal drive to save your own skin? How would a soft body stay put against all that power. Screaming brakes, the instinct for surviving. The people who needed you to stay.

Cyrus's death broke my parents, but I had to go on being somebody, a sister and not a sister, a person on my own. I was eleven when it happened. We all know eleven-year-old girls, with their wide eyes and sincere belief that every terrible thing that happens is their fault. Except for the carefree few who think nothing is. Maybe for some of us, when it comes to the ties that bind us one to another, it has to be all or nothing. Maybe I've wished for the mercy of *nothing*. Maybe I still do.

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Prelude I

The first night after Sigurd called, I put down the phone with my hands shaking and a sick feeling that I'd been waiting for something like this. Not a train, but a reckoning coming at me. This phone call, out of a blank silence of twenty-some years. (I'm pretending I don't know exactly how many years.) His voice I'd known instantly. The idea of him coming here, seeing him in person, felt like a bomb he'd put in the phone that might explode in my ear. I told him I needed time to think. Seven days, then. He would call back on the weekend to find out what I decided. I couldn't put any name to the shock I felt. Either choice, yes or no, carried the feeling of a disaster.

I've had plenty of practice at masking nerves, or did have when I was younger and played for audiences, but that was faint help getting me through supper across the kitchen table from my husband. Trying to think of questions I should ask him about the chance of rain, the hay he had to put up. Staring at the patterned Formica tabletop that has irritated me for what feels like a hundred years, because it looks like dancing rubber bands. Listening to the clock tick. What if that call had come an hour later? Instead of buzzing in my apron pocket while I was frying the apples, my phone could have been ringing on the counter right then. Charlie could have been watching the life drain out of me while I said *Okay* and *Where?* and *Let me*

think about it. Watching me fall into the sinkhole in my middle so deep, a lot of other things might collapse into it.

That's not what he'd have seen, though. Charlie would ask if I was okay, and when I made up something, a student rescheduling a lesson, he would believe me. Pick up his knife and fork and cut up his pork chop. That's the man he is, solid and good, which makes him sound ordinary, or I guess maybe the enviable side of ordinary as husbands go, but it's more unusual than that. His mind could no more hold thoughts of betrayal than a good strong hand can hold water. Just not built for the task.

I was young when I'd known Sigurd, only twenty and barely more than a child, even if I thought otherwise. Years ago, anyway, time enough for forgiving and forgetting trespasses, even if they felt murderous at the time. So I told myself while dishes were washed, while the newspaper was folded to the local section and read, while we said our good-nights before Charlie turned in. But an hour after midnight, I was still playing Chopin in the dark house, trying to stop time. If I didn't ever go to bed and get up again, if six more days didn't pass, we could go on here, unrattled by this earthquake I didn't ask for. At least I knew my playing wouldn't disturb Charlie. He is early to bed and early to rise, a farmer to his bones, and could sleep through the Second Coming. He's told me if he ever does turn over in our bedroom upstairs and wake up to one of my nocturnes, the sound of me sends him right back to his dreams. So there he lay above me while I sat in the dark living room playing all the Chopin preludes I could remember, then the mazurkas, and after that the nocturnes.

My hand was cramping like a fiend, and I finally quit on Chopin in the middle of a cadenza. Right hand is the bad one. That was Sigurd's fault, and one ruined hand the least of it. I snapped on the little brass music lamp on the piano, stood up too fast, and took hold of the fallboard to steady myself, not wanting to trip over the dog curled at my feet or ding my hip on some sharp corner in the dark. That's bodies for you, underneath all the mind's drama, just pitiable flesh. My legs had fallen asleep. I saw the shoes under the piano and said quietly without thinking: "Oh, Mom is here."

Gaz looked up at me with his ears pricked, pale eyes curious in the sudden light. He looked at the shoes and back to me, assuring me that whatever I was thinking, he agreed. "Nobody's here," I told him. "Just you and me."

But somebody was, or something. These were not my dead mother's shoes, obviously. I'd taken them off there when I sat down, needing to feel the cold pedals under my bare feet. Empty leather flats with the sad, squashed look of weariness, just like the ones she used to park beside her recliner every time she gave up on another day, accepting her life as the sum of its disappointments. If an elephant had scuffed around the kitchen all day in those, I used to think to myself, they would not look worse. A child can't hate her mother without putting the load-bearing walls of the known world at risk. I settled for hating her shoes.

I hooked two fingers into their backs and carried them with me outside to the porch. I breathed in the late-summer smells of mown hay and ragweed while I watched Gaz make a quick check of the perimeter of the yard. All I could see of him in the dark was the rippling gait of his white feet and the tip of his tail, the rest of him all one with the night. I rubbed my hand where it always ached with too much use or any change in the weather. The ancient injury. He didn't even know. If I were to tell Sigurd now, it could not be kind: I am sundered past the repair of any steel pins. I stood awhile under the accusing stars with heartless crickets singing in my ears: *If this is true, if this is true.* If I'm no better than the sum of my disappointments.

Does every woman turn into her mother? My sister-in-law, Mickie, used to say so. But that was all of a piece with becoming a mother herself, in those years when we drank coffee and visited in her kitchen between the interruptions of shrieks and tears, the U shape of bite marks on a pudgy arm, the discovery of the naked Barbie show behind the couch. She confessed to hearing her own mother come out of her mouth: *Because I said so* and *Right this minute, young lady*, words that ooze down through leaks in the roofs we build between generations.

Mickie loved her children madly, it was plain to see. The eye-rolling was probably her way of apologizing to me for this miracle she knew I could never have. The other ancient injury. But what was motherhood to me? The sting of a wash-damp hand on a cheek. Or words, of the kind that can sting parts of a child more tender than flesh. Her curdled fortune inside me would not get passed on. What happened to me was for the best.

I left the shoes outside the back door and went upstairs to bed. I always thought of my mother as old back then, older than dirt, but she wasn't. Late thirties or so when she lost Cy and gave up on the rest. I was younger than that when I lost everything.

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Allemande

The first time I ever laid eyes on Sigurd, I thought: *I know him.* Which wasn't true, he was a stranger, and I realized the mistake as soon as I'd made it. But I've wondered. Did I recognize the instrument of my downfall? Should we know it when we see it?

"Who is that man?" was the question I asked aloud. *That man*, because he was a little too old to be one of us, and plainly not a professor. Shirtsleeves rolled to the elbow, well-fitting jeans worn soft at the knees on a body that didn't sit around thinking for a living—you couldn't miss the muscles in the rear view. A townie, then. Hawking some tabloid, a thing people did back then, to inform a reader of the world's collapse and the one sure path to salvation, be that guided meditation or the club that meets at six p.m. in the Women's Studies Lounge. This was 1989, a year of earthquakes and oil spills and iron curtains starting to crash, so our options then were different and also maybe about the same. But trafficking in high-mindedness was the business of students, not town folk, I'd have thought.

I was crossing the campus with a professor I worked for as an accompanist, a French horn player clicking along beside me in shiny kitten-heeled pumps and a blazer. She was an older woman with a household of her own, husband and all that, so it surprised me what she answered: "Mercy, whatever he's selling, I'll buy it."

We both laughed, but didn't cross over the grass to get a better look at his goods. We were running late for something, headed to the MAC for a dress rehearsal probably—it wasn't usual to practice in that giant auditorium unless we meant business. But with that little glimpse, he got in my head and stayed there the rest of the day: his way of standing on the sidewalk, body presented to the world, bundle of papers tucked under one arm as he cradled the flame of a lighter inside his cupped fingers to light a cigarette. Arms and wrists like Michelangelo's *David*, I swear, with power you could see in the muscle and sinew but tenderness in the hands. I shivered. As if those hands had touched me already.

It was springtime, there was that. Smell of reviving grass and all God's earthworms coming up for air after a winter that nigh had killed me. It wasn't my first winter in Indiana, but I never got used to that level of cold that makes the little hairs in your nose freeze and bristle like cactus spines, till you want to stop breathing. Months of ice and mud, and now here came crocuses, songbirds, light winning over dark like something out of the Bible. All of that could surely rouse a body into rut. Also too, the French horn professor had said what she did—*I'll buy it*—so it was him doing the selling. No special failing on my part.

I would go home that evening to a sweet boy who'd recently spoken of marriage. To me specifically: Jon Link and myself being married. I was meant to be walking on the clouds now, not looking over the fence. Even if I'd learned not to make too much of the marriage business. We lived among young people who could argue you down to the gristle on which was the better Brahms piano concerto, first or second, but shrugged off marriage as a so-called piece of paper. Unlike the people I'd come from, who held no act before the sight of God to be more important, for people generally but a girl certainly. It had been my mother's main argument against my running off to college: *What boy do you think will have you if you go on getting above yourself?* None likely, I granted, sitting that last day in her kitchen, talking to her back as she boiled potatoes, absorbing disapproval along with the potato smell I dreaded would follow me out of that house. I wanted to ask: *What boy do you think will have me now?* But that was her point. I was too peculiar. And run off, I did, pulled onto the Greyhound bus by a music scholarship that felt like a rope thrown to the drowning. Finding at the end of it a whole new world of peculiar. I'd never imagined so much.

I'd had almost three school years since then to find my bearings, two spent with Jon Link in the apartment that went from being his to more or less ours. (One-third of the rent was what I could afford.) A musician's life is about the skills of performance, starting with looking calm while your heart gulps blood and drums against your ears. I'd been doing that on a piano bench since I was ten. Now I could do it in classrooms, in a cafeteria, in a musical debate or beery party with classmates who had no idea how they cowed me with their confidence and straightened teeth and their ways of knowing and judging. I worked as hard at my calm expression as I did on my Hanon technical exercises, carrying it right into the apartment I shared with my boyfriend, listening with a neutral face as Jon Link discussed applying for married student housing in the fall when he started his second year as a grad student. On campus for the convenience, more space for the same money. Hearing myself say, "Sure, or for less money maybe," so we could drop some of the prima donnas off our lists. We both spent a lot of time supporting other musicians in more starring roles, which we felt cheated us from our own devotions, piano in my case, woodwinds and conducting in his. More time for our own work. In married student housing. There it lay between us: a plan for next year and, by quiet agreement, many more after that.

It made no sense, then, to find myself bothered by intrusive thoughts of a handsome stranger I'd seen from a distance. After my distracted rehearsal, those thoughts followed me home. How I spent those hours together with Jon Link I can't really say, but could guess, because our life was made of predictable things: the free Commodity Cheese I got in giant yellow blocks and melted into macaroni. The whopping blue metal cans of discount-brand coffee that should have lasted us a semester instead of a month, three small rooms of furniture I'd retrieved from sidewalks and sometimes changed out for better on undergraduate moving-out days. I was amazed by the bounty of goods those students—people my own age!—could fling out on the sidewalk. Jon Link had no previous experience with saving money. My scavenging made him nervous. But he had no real interest in housekeeping either, so he accepted my economies in lieu of my full share of expenses.

I made the place comfortable, evidently, because it came to be such a gathering spot, I felt like one of those cat ladies feeding roaming bands of strays. Jon Link's friends were mostly male, entirely musicians, and so domestically hopeless as to be impressed by my budget mac and cheese. As

his apartment became mine too, so did his friends, especially our most regular drop-ins Percussion and Bassoon, so called because that's how Jon Link first introduced them to me, and all three of us found it funny enough to keep. Percussion was the more outgoing and inebriate of the two, and regularly ended up sleeping over on our secondhand sofa. He and I together wore down Jon Link's suspicions about living on other people's trash, until he could joke with the rest of us about the debaucheries our old plaid couch might have hosted.

When Jon Link and I were alone, that sofa cradled our long, earnest bodies as we read books and studied scores, my legs on his legs, my hand on his back unconsciously pressing the notes of a Bach fugue or invention into his skin. Always Bach. I only ever realized what was playing in my head after he'd pointed it out, and after a while, he stopped mentioning it. Nor did he complain in winter when those same hands, frozen, pressed to his chest and my icicle feet wedged between his calves, hunting the salvation of body heat. Jon Link was from Boston and teased me for my dismay at the cold, enjoying this leaked hint of Southern frailty. For the most part, I was as sturdy as our furniture. Chivalry was no part of our bargain.

If that life sounds drab, we didn't know it. We were grown-up children ruled by the schedules and economies we knew. Even our lovemaking was on the order of what bread and cheese might do to conceive a sandwich. But it delighted us enough that we made it more often than we didn't. Our togetherness had arrived gradually, starting in my first music theory class, where he was a teaching assistant and I was an astonished pilgrim in a new world where notes didn't just have tongues to sing, but also eyes for their chosen friends and arms for embracing their dissonant and consonant kin, sorting themselves into family trees, sharing a secret language that crossed oceans and all of time. I'd loved music all my life, with that burning feeling I assumed other people must have when they wanted to get married. I was shocked to find out now I'd only been looking at my beloved through a keyhole. Now I was invited in, to caress and inhale and pledge an ecstatic devotion that stretched me near to breaking. Sometimes after theory class, I had to sit on a bench outside the building and stare up into the maple trees and catch my breath. Sometimes Jon Link sat with me there, a quiet, smiling witness to those heady first months of my life when shared music could be a glue between people, not a repellent that pushed them away like

the wrong end of a magnet. Music pulled the two of us together as passionate colleagues, then roommates, then lovers. It was my first partnership of any real kind since my brother died, and I wasn't looking for anything better. I should be able to remember, now, what kindnesses we showed one another in those last hours when I still thought our perfectly good life would go on being perfectly good. To my shame, I can't. It was snuffed out that quickly.

He was there again in the morning, in a shirt as red as some brazen flag, standing at the same intersection of sidewalks outside the music addition, surrounded by some students. Not townies. They all had the painstakingly tousled hair meant to look uncared for, the layers of oversized flannels and jeans explosively blown out at the knees, which was the look of our time. Or anyway the fashion of the well-heeled, ironically. In my rural Tennessee county where a few households still strived for indoor plumbing, the goal in high school was to carry off some sheen of prosperity. So I was gobsmacked here by the everyday sight of ragged pajamas in class. Or exercise gear, for lounging around. Sorority girls in tiny shirts that bared their middles in the dead of winter. It all seemed oppositional to purpose. We music students were tidier in general, ever ready to step into a performance. I'd dressed self-consciously that morning but probably looked the same as always in my non-shredded jeans, thick green sweater on top of my thinner blue sweater. (Springtime had called all bets off overnight.) My long hair spent its life in a braid down my back, except for high concert days, when I combed out all three feet of it and set it free. This wasn't that high of an occasion, I didn't think. But after three early hours alone in a practice room, I found myself thinking about him. Curiosity nudged me out of the building and shyness nearly turned me back inside, when I saw he was busy with other people. Then, suddenly, he handed each of them a sheaf of orange papers and they all walked off in separate directions.

The waters parted for me. It could have gone differently. I still think about that.

I crossed the squishy spring grass of the quad and watched him putting things away in his bag, which wasn't a student backpack but a worn leather satchel similar to the pouch my father had sometimes used as a mail carrier. He also wore Red Wing boots like the men I knew back home. The

sidewalk was blotted with fallen white petals of the flowering pears that turned into plaster under our shoes. I thought he'd been about to leave, but he saw me approaching and produced the tabloid from his bag: *The Militant*, a proper-looking newspaper with excited headlines about a murdered striker on a Greyhound picket line. Seventy-five cents for that. I told him I didn't have three quarters to spend on something I wouldn't have time to read.

"My condolences," he said. "Can I ask who's working you so hard for such bad pay?"

I shrugged at the limestone world around us. "You get what you sign up for. My tuition is covered, but I have to feed myself on work-study and freelance jobs with skinflint professors."

"And government cheese?"

I must have looked surprised. He grinned. Since the day I landed here, I'd not met another person who knew about Commodity Cheese.

"Did you know," he asked, "there are countries where students like yourself have unions?"

"You don't mean *union* unions, like the Teamsters."

"I do. The ones that go on strike to win themselves better deals."

I did *not* know that. I did wonder if he was making up fairy tales to keep me there. His eyes were more green than blue, a pale water color that was very striking. He ran one hand through his rumpled hair like a boy, endearingly, though I guessed he was ten years older than me. I am tall, but he was taller and, as I've said, well-built. Up close, noticeably so. The tendons running the length of his inside arms made me think of piano wires. What I am saying is that my mind bounced around like a hard rubber ball in my head while he told me about organized labor.

I asked if he worked on campus, and he said he didn't, that he did some organizing on the campus but worked elsewhere, which struck me as fishy. What business did he have with students? A grown man on these grounds as some kind of peddler didn't really belong. I didn't either, in spite of a lot of trying, and something about this man in his red flannel shirt and work boots made me bold. "If you're selling worldly wisdom," I offered, "you'd do better to move away from the music buildings."

He widened his eyes at me. A thin scar alongside his left eye gave his smile a cheeky emphasis on one side. I thought of the word *syncopation*.

“Are you saying artists can’t handle the real world? Because I don’t think that’s true,” he said. “I could name names.”

“I bet you could, but that’s not what I meant. It’s more a point of pride.”

“*Could* handle it, just would rather not?”

“Right. The real-world thing . . .” I rolled my eyes, pretended to yawn. God knows where I’d found this store of cockiness. “Unless you’re discussing Dvorak’s *New World* Symphony, then we’re all over it. Or Holst’s *Planets* Suite.”

“There’s no Earth,” he said. “In that *Planets* thing. He left us out.”

He met my eye and held it, grinning. I was too surprised to ask how he knew about Gustav Holst. And embarrassed to catch myself at snobbery. Anybody might have asked me the same when I washed up here in a drift of hand-crocheted ponchos and Tennessee vowels.

“Biggest disappointment of grade school,” he said. “We had this music teacher lady that brought in that record every Thursday for months, trying to get us to like it.”

“That poor woman,” I said, and meant it, too. I could feel her Thursdays like a heavy meal in my stomach. “What else did she try to force down your grubby little ears?”

He closed his eyes for a few seconds. “Nothing that stuck,” he conceded, opening his eyes again to the bright sun, and I saw his pupils adjust. “I only remembered the one about the planets because you said it just then. I might be able to pick some others out of a lineup. One about the spring? Pagan rites, I want to say? She was a walk on the wild side, Miss Vormelker.”

“And you didn’t? Come around to liking *The Planets*?”

“I kept waiting for Earth. That’s probably why I still remember it. We got to the end, and none of it was really about us. I felt ripped off.”

“Did she tell you why?”

“Why no Earth? No. Not that I remember.”

“The *Planets* Suite is about how we feel looking out at other places. Exploring them, imagining them. So it’s *all* about us, really. But we can’t see ourselves while we do that. The ground we’re standing on is taken for granted, I guess.”

His face changed, as if he’d been waiting for this since fourth grade. I couldn’t tell if he was putting me on. “I would have paid more attention if you’d been there to explain it.”

“Glad I could clear that up for you.”

“But I’m guessing grubby little ears aren’t your game plan.”

I bit my lower lip, wondering why I wasn’t walking away from this. “I don’t know that I have a game plan, but I’ll tell you something. Miss Vormelker gets in all our heads. She gives us panic attacks whenever we consider taking the practical teaching major.”

“And why is that, because she’s knocking herself out for nineteen thousand a year?”

“And living by herself in a mobile home, sipping Baileys every night while she listens to recordings of all the good men that are gone? No, that’s not even the worst of it. It’s the classrooms full of juvenile delinquents.”

He shifted his papers around and put one hand in his back pocket, seeming just delighted, for no good reason I could see. “Sounds like we’re looking at multiple charges here.”

“Against you? No. She made her choice and that’s how it stacks up. The little boys win. Miss Vormelker and her boyfriends Holst and Beethoven are spitball targets. God love her.”

“You’re the real thing, then,” he said. “A musician. Not a teacher, a maker.” He wasn’t asking. He looked at my hands and then my mouth, the rest of me, the way I’ve watched so many artists study a borrowed instrument before they pick it up. I could feel my nipples against the inside of my sweater. I needed to shell out for his tabloid or find another exit.

“Sorry,” I said. “I’m scaring off your customers.”

We stood together in a silence between the carillon bells, with pear blossoms falling around us in slow spirals like dreamy snow. Classes in session, too cold for Frisbee or sunbathing. This quad was more deserted than I’d seen it since winter break.

“Just so you know,” he said, “I’m not here to make a living in quarters. This is an assignment, but I’ve only been on this campus three or four times. And not much liking it so far.”

“No? You look pretty comfortable here. Like you own the place, honestly.”

“You too. But you were about to tell me you’re not.”

“Was I?”

He waited me out, the syncopated grin modulating from sunny to something softer. All the time in the world, this man seemed to have. *What in the everloving hell*, as my brother used to say. I was used to people saying, *Gotta go, so stressed out!* True or not, you had to say so. This is

what I'd learned in college—people here ranked human worth in units of work overload and sleep-deprived exhaustion.

"I'm a musician, yes. The real thing?" I shrugged. "I should let you go."

The questions you get asked as a music major are always the same, an ascending scale in the key of pipe dream: Instrument? Ensemble? Performance or pedagogy? Bachelor's, master's, doctorate? He didn't ask any of those. He asked if I wanted to go to lunch. I said yes.

I have no excuse for some of the things I said that day. It was a school music teacher who rescued me from my self-taught mire of flat-handed technique and muddy pedaling, and my debt went well past that. But some current turned over in me that morning and off I went, running down my chosen field with a flood of doubts that, all of a sudden, I couldn't hold in.

It was Gorgo's where this happened. I thought we'd head for the student union, that black hole pulling bodies into its echoing noise and baffling student photography exhibits. But we escaped the Memorial Union's orbit and walked down into a slim strand of woods along the meander of creek, headed for the southwest gate, passing many tightly strung students with their eyes trained hard on the sidewalk. This little grove, right in the middle of everything, was a refuge that had helped keep me inside my own skin on that stone-toothed campus. The redbuds were blooming along the water that day, I remember. He led me out of the woods, through the stone gate into the college-town clutter of 3rd Avenue, right into the greasy spoon on Hunter where I'd worked part-time my freshman year, before I learned how to line up music jobs. I hadn't been back in a while, but it was the same, tall booths, a smell of baking pizza dough that relaxed me instantly. This restaurant had been a lifeline. The servers were mostly townies, moms with small kids or older women who mothered me on our smoke breaks, divided our tips equally to the dime, and told me how far I needed to go from campus to find affordable groceries.

I didn't see anybody I knew, but out of loyalty to the guild, I ordered the three-dollar egg salad sandwich. At the student union, I could have pulled out the sandwich I packed every day of my church-mouse life. Seventy-five cents up front would have been the better bargain, plus a newspaper. What *was* the bargain, I didn't know. Only that I'd stumbled onto a listener and found I'd been waiting for somebody to hear my confession.

He asked if it was something that ran in my family. Did he mean musicians or college? The question put the sick scent of damp laundry into my head. I hunkered into the wooden seat and tried to explain the family line, delivered in weekly phone calls: All that way from home. Just for messing around with the music. Ungodly tuition. (Which we weren't paying, but she still brought it up on principle.) In year three, when I had to choose, and chose performance over pedagogy, I left off hoping to convince my mother and started into myself. Who did I think I was? What livelihood is out there for pianists? Even if my technique and interpretation were exceptional, how much *exceptional* classical piano will the world keep above water? Where would I live, what would I eat, would I grow lean and grizzled playing "Clair de Lune" in a hotel lobby?

I staved off those worries by losing myself in the technical work, the practice, the juries and commendations, all of which and five bucks will buy you breakfast down at the Inkwell. We tell ourselves we are the chosen until we're so consumed by our passions, we might struggle to tell you what year it is or who is the president, these questions asked of a person after a blow to the head. I didn't say all of this exactly, but we got into it far enough. I told him I'd only ever loved one thing in my whole life, and was starting to think it was not going to love me back.

For an awful second, I thought he'd laugh. But he was working out the right thing to say. What he came out with made *me* laugh. He asked, "Can I offer you a Marxist analysis on that?"

"I don't know. Does Dr. Marx take student health insurance?"

"Well, he's dead. This is just my own thinking. Music is your labor, not your floor manager. You're the means of production. Without you, it doesn't exist."

"Oh, it exists," I told him. "It's all written down. We come and go, it lives forever."

"But it's not really here, is it? Until you play it. Are you going to pass music sheets out to people on the street and say music is happening?"

I told him he should go over to the music school and give that a try. "You might hear notes ringing straight out of people's heads, like a skull carillon." Student irony was a language I'd learned through practice, like playing scales. But he wasn't a student and didn't laugh.

"Okay, by and large, no," I conceded. "Out there in America the beautiful, like the entire county where I grew up, no. Music wouldn't

happen.”

“You’re disregarding your power in the relationship of manufacture.”

This man was a stitch. “Manufacture of *music*?”

“It’s your product. Workers are always taught to underestimate their own value. When you can’t take ownership of your labor, you feel worthless yourself. That’s alienation.”

“Good to know.” I kept a grin on my face at half-mast, the mask against gullibility I’d worn for so long I got stuck that way. Me, with my lily-white hands on ivory keys, a laborer. I told him I wasn’t *above* the idea, I came from working people, and despite what they thought, I hadn’t come to college to make myself better than them. “Maybe the opposite. Sometimes I feel like I’m getting trained here to be unessential.”

“That’s alienation,” he said again, pronouncing it like a disease, as if my unusefulness might also have a cure. But he wasn’t dispensing medicine. He just asked questions, things I couldn’t believe he’d really care about. My interests, my plans. Our food came quickly, or maybe I was frozen inside a stopped clock, watching his eyes and hands, the faint brushstrokes of black hair at the open neck of his red flannel shirt. I felt too self-conscious to take off my heavy sweater because the one underneath was thin and I never wore a bra. I was practically as narrow and flat-chested as a boy in those days. Expensive underwear was wasted on the likes of me.

I told him about my work-study job, cataloguing and reshelving in the music library, and my work as an accompanist. He asked how I ever had time to study. He didn’t even know about the twenty or thirty hours a week in practice rooms. I told him about the stars we musicians hitched our wagons to—a spot in the New York concert series, a summer festival in Munich.

“Have you done that? Gone abroad?” he asked.

I laughed. “I only last year learned what a passport is. The only place I ever went is here.” I felt suddenly sheepish discussing the fancy ambitions, as if I were laying out play money on the table. College is a cloister. You go a few years without knowing anybody older or younger or different from yourself, and you forget what a thin little spine you are on the big loud bookshelves of the living.

He wasn’t as much older as I’d thought. Twenty-six, the age my brother would have been. He’d trained as a welder, worked in auto shops, lived in other Indiana towns smaller than this one. Had been to community college.

But was nothing like a student. He smoked, for instance. I hadn't had a cigarette in almost two years, but could smell it on him and was jonesing to beat the band. I grew up in a household of smokers. My brother always warned me not to start, but still slipped one to his baby sister now and again, and I'd kept it up because I was alive to do it. Jon Link always made me stand outside the sliding door of our tiny patio, even in freezing weather, until shame made me quit. He and our friends were contemptuous of the previous generation's filthy habit, evil tobacco barons, and surely the people who grew it, if they even gave farmers a thought.

I know, it's the job of young people to condemn the vices of parents and wear shocking new sympathies on their sleeves. My generation's pop goddess named herself after Jesus's mother and wore pointy bras outside her clothes. While I was dealing in the currency of four-hundred-year-old church music, and this kind man tried to sell Marxism to Chicago bank managers' kids who gave revolution a thumbs-up but wouldn't quite look at him because he dressed like their parents' gardener. Maybe we were in the same boat, maybe we weren't, but he was the first person I'd met in three years who seemed perfectly happy to be himself. I wanted to get close to that. The audacity of the red shirt. I always wore the muted colors of a rainy day and was married to black and white keys. Now my hands were itching to stray. I'm a person who leads with my hands, a "tactile learner" is the proper way it's said, but this wasn't proper by a long shot: fingers craving to know the sandpaper of his jaw, the pulse I'd feel at the delicate spot on his wrist. The dense, wavy black hair that fell in his eyes and could have used a trim.

His eyes seemed to want to absorb me. Or consume. It was both thrilling and outside my powers to think of myself as anything but a skinny girl with very long hair, brilliant hands, and a knack for invisibility. Jon Link's friends were always joking about "the dweeb that caught the goddess," and for most of a year, I'd failed to grasp the compliment. I thought they were discussing some opera I didn't know about.

I made myself talk about the apartment I shared with Jon Link. Possibly making too much of the practical side. Walking distance, small but affordable. Roommate. He was attentive to his food while I said this, adjusting an anemic slice of tomato that slithered out of his burger.

"Johnlink," he said simply.

“It’s Jon, and it’s Link. He always uses first and last names together, even with friends. He says it goes back to a kindergarten overstocked with Johns and Johnnys.”

“A person might get past that,” he said.

“I’ve thought so. My theory is, those two tiny names need each other to stand up.”

Was that infidelity already? Was Sigurd aiding and abetting? That was his name, Sigurd, which as a name was nothing to write home about either, let’s be fair. I misunderstood it initially as an adjective: *I’m ciggered*, the extended hand out on the sidewalk, it took me a second to sort out. Now I asked what kind of name it was, and he said Viking, as far as he knew. His mother claimed she’d always liked it, but probably had run out of other ideas. He was the youngest of nine.

“*Nine*,” I blurted, unfortunately with sandwich in my mouth. I chewed, swallowed. “Sorry, I’m not judging. I come from farm country, we’re all about big families down there. Word has it, my parents underachieved.”

“What kind of farms?”

I told him tobacco and dairy cattle, which is about all the farming to be done on land as steep as east Tennessee. He said my accent was hard to place. I didn’t say how deliberately I’d worked on training my clever ear on new vowels and inflections and even that higher-caste feminine laugh, self-dissolving. From the day I stepped off the bus, my plan was to be a new person in college: happy, likeable, maybe loveable. Remaking myself in the eye of the beholder.

“So it’s just you? In your underachieving family?”

“Two kids, originally. Now just me.”

He gave me room to explain, which I filled by taking a long drink of water, and I think he got the picture. He asked if I had my own piano in my apartment. I laughed and told him I’d never even lived under the same roof with one in my whole life. Even though I’d spent more time with pianos than with any living person. As a child, I’d learned and practiced on the one at church, starting with plinking around after the service, picking out the melodies of hymns we’d sung while my parents did their main socializing of the week.

“How old were you when you started?”

I had to think. “Six, I guess? Barely old enough to read. I remember thinking music was nothing like ciphering out letters and words.”

“Different how?”

“Easier. Like something I didn’t have to go after because it wanted to give itself to me.”

I tried to explain how I would hear the melody in my head; then the alto, tenor, and bass lines would unfold themselves like a letter sent from the vibrations in my ears, holding me inside the music for however long the adults left me there. Our church pianist Mrs. Dotson died when I was nine years old, and I replaced her as pianist for Cross Creek Methodist services. I was keen to do it sooner, as she was in poor health, but I couldn’t reach the sustain pedal until third grade.

I must have been drunk on his attention, telling him these things I’d never even confessed to Jon Link. My childish pride, as the one who was always asked to play for school functions. The risk in that, for a girl especially, among people who let you know there is no greater sin than *parading yourself around*. How easily pride can get chased into a burrow of humiliation. I’d once gone to the school auditorium to practice and found a cluster of boys around Dwight Meade on the piano bench, egging him on as he pounded nonsense with both hands, weaving his body dramatically. It had taken a minute for me to understand what—who—he was mocking.

Sigurd looked like he wanted to take my heart in both his hands when I told him that story. We attended to our food for a little while. Somebody behind me was talking about carrying a person down three flights of stairs. Sigurd asked me if *Livia* was short for *Olivia*, which it isn’t. I chalked it up to my mother’s lack of energy for the extra syllable, but he told me *Livia* by itself is a real name. A famous Roman lady named Livia got herself known by poisoning men. We both laughed at that, and our mood shifted again. It felt like we were touching.

He seemed to know a lot about history, considering his line of work. He was a typesetter. The print shop where he worked wasn’t far from campus. He worked second shift, headed that way soon. The work was okay, and the hours gave him mornings free for organizing. Short answers are what he gave me. I’d known men like this, who didn’t seem eager to talk about themselves unless pointedly asked. But I hadn’t met one since coming to this temple of high minds. By *organizing*, Sigurd meant selling the newspaper, as I’d seen, but mostly trying to expand union membership in his shop, because the jobs were precarious.

“Precarious,” I repeated, thinking of giant paper cutters, hazardous boiling lead. That was not the kind of precarious he meant. The jobs could be replaced with machines or sent overseas, which made his coworkers reluctant to show disloyalty. To unionize, he said, he had to give them a sense of bigger allegiances that would matter more in the long run.

My fellow students would dismiss Sigurd as weird, I knew. I was so used to trying to stay in their narrow zone of approval, I’d lost faith in my own judgment. I did know people could care about worldly matters. Our government’s various scurrilous meddlings stirred up the campus regularly into placard-wielding mobs of protest. But Sigurd wasn’t a performer. Unionizing was a project on his calendar. He mentioned a political party he’d joined after moving to Bloomington, with *Socialist* in the name. I asked him if it was some kind of cult, and was he going to kidnap me?

He looked up from his plate. “Is that what you think this is?”

I’d only meant it as a joke. Surely it wasn’t possible in the first hour of an acquaintance to disappoint somebody so much. I looked at my hands, looked at my fork, thought of stabbing the hand with the fork. I apologized and told him I wasn’t used to conversations like this because all the people I knew were lotus-eaters. Then corrected that to “musicians,” because *lotus-eaters* was the kind of baffling phrase my mother used as proof I’d come to college to spite her. I asked many careful questions after that, which he answered carefully. A cult is controlled by one individual. His Party had members in branches all over the country, with elected officers and platforms like any other. They put up candidates for president, though I’d never heard of the woman he mentioned. A *woman*, though. He shrugged, saying that was the world they had in mind. He sold the newspaper on campus a few times a week because education was part of their work, and they all rotated through the campus assignment.

I asked him if he was liking it better today.

He was still a little wary. “I think I’m off the clock at this point.”

“Don’t count on it. I might be educable.”

I stared him down, tongue between my teeth, holding his green eyes with mine until the syncopated grin crept back. Warmth flooded my lower body. I was going over some kind of edge. I pulled the heavy green sweater over my head, holding the clingy one underneath at my waist so as not to expose myself entirely. But exposing enough. Whatever was happening earlier, before I stupidly deflated him, I wanted it back. He seemed comfortable

talking about himself in this one vein, so I tapped it. He said joining the Party had made him feel more hopeful about the future than he'd ever been. Then he went into the nuts and bolts of it and I got a little lost, but if public school country kids learn one thing in college, it's to become very good at conversations you don't quite understand. He talked about history and workers controlling production and a global agreement called the Fourth International. I was mildly hypnotized by the thin scar along his eye and the occasional crashes I heard from the kitchen. I thought about the comfort I'd once found here in the camaraderie of wage labor, when the campus was a place of inscrutable rules and people who wore deliberately torn jeans but smirked at a girl in thrift-store clothes.

Was Sigurd a spate of homesickness, then? I didn't think so. Home was no place I could have named anymore. I sure as hell was not thinking about taking him home to my parents.

We needed to go, and didn't want to. He paid for lunch and gave me the newspaper, plus the orange leaflet I'd seen him handing out earlier, advertising a meeting of a student alliance connected with his Party. He didn't say he would be there, only that I'd be welcome. He didn't give me his number or ask for mine. I shoved the leaflet into my music folder, thinking how that color would scream among the white pages like a wrong note, daring anybody to notice it.

When we stepped outside, he lit up on the sidewalk, then recognized my look and lit a second cigarette for me. Our little communion of smoke felt illicit and free, like swimming naked in a farm pond. I asked if he'd ever done that, skinny-dipped in a farm pond. He said yes, but in a river. This was a version of me I didn't recognize, Livia who flirted. It was light, but it wasn't trivial, what I felt. More like touching solid ground, finding purchase, after swimming for a long time.

I was late for Advanced Composition. Simple words for an unthinkable event. Like many a scholarship kid, I could tell you the dollar value of every hour of class, and hadn't skipped one in three years of heady spring days, flu-plagued autumns, winter mornings cold enough to freeze your showered hair right onto your scalp. Ten minutes late, and for the next forty-five, I regretted everything about that deceptively uncreative class. Advanced Composition was not going to be my purpose in life. Before that hour, I'd avoided the question of needing one.

The orange flyer dogged me all week. I set my will against the idea of going to that meeting. Tried to shut out ridiculous expectations. For his part, Jon Link never even noticed the lurid page sticking out of my music folder, so I tried to convince myself it wasn't the seed of the pox that had fallen on our little house. Suddenly we couldn't stop fighting.

Jon Link had finally gotten the news we'd been holding our breath for: He was going to Munich for the summer. Which created some urgency for our *situation*, meaning our vague plan of getting married. Which I suddenly didn't feel like talking about, however much he tossed around "keeping it simple," like that solved anything. I hadn't told my parents. This upset him. I asked if he'd shared our news with Percussion or Bassoon or any other of his friends, which of course he hadn't. He said that was different, they weren't family, they wouldn't care that much. I suggested we probably didn't either, so he should just concentrate on Munich for now. I was happy for him! First chair oboe and first assistant to a conductor he revered! But if we planned to do this thing, he felt we should go together to Tennessee at semester's end to tell my parents.

It's not that I'd been trying to keep secrets. My parents were very fuzzy on our whole arrangement. Years earlier, when Jon Link and I first became friends, I'd tried to tell my mother about him and she didn't disapprove, just didn't listen or retain any of it. Every time I mentioned his name, I had to start over again with "which one of them he was." She was equally uninterested in what pieces I was learning, maintaining her long-standing exhaustion with any musical ambitions beyond hymns in church. How could I explain such indifference to a son whose parents flew in from Boston for his recitals? No one in my family had been on an airplane. They did almost none of the things I overheard Jon Link discussing with his parents, who had calendars filled with concerts and wellness check-ups and book clubs and friends they met regularly for playing bridge. My parents were practical people. Bridges were for crossing rivers.

Jon Link always insisted his family wasn't wealthy, and I insisted mine wasn't poor—we were about like everybody else we knew. "So were we," declared Jon Link. He came from parents and even grandparents who had gone to college, and a world that had revealed itself to me as a series of shocks I'd had to absorb quietly, one by one. Jon Link's father read the *New York Times* every day, even though he didn't live there. His mother had some kind of monthly subscription to be in a special program for keeping

thin. (I imagined my father's opinion of this. Paying money to go hungry.) Jon Link had a brother and two sisters, all of whom lived in different states from his parents, who did not seem to find this a tragedy or a disgrace. Neither did they see any shame in music as a vocation, even if that meant Jon Link might end up traveling or living abroad. They were thrilled about his summer in Munich. They saw their children only a few times a year but took pride in all their jobs and promotions, daughters and in-laws included. There was an engineer, a chemist, and several mystifying jobs having to do with money or banking. There was a divorce in there somewhere, a stepchild, a son who lived with his girlfriend without being married, and even this, all of it, was untroubling. A failure in school would have been troubling to them. Dropping out, moving back home, the one thing I could have done to make my mother happy—*that*, for Jon Link's family, would have been the disgrace.

I had learned, or was learning, to bridge the gulf between myself and my classmates, but I couldn't imagine bringing my family across it. Now that we were fighting about them, I swore to Jon Link my reluctance had nothing to do with his being an unreligious Jew, a Northern city boy who had never lifted a hammer or owned a vehicle. Not really. But in the course of our arguments, he convinced himself they were bigots and that I shared their small-mindedness. I'd run into these assumptions so often, my muscles of defensiveness were sturdy, and I flexed them now. He didn't know a thing about my home, I said, when he called it a white-bread place. (I did not admit that prior to college, I hadn't known there was any other bread.) Practically half my high school friends were Asian, I declared, which was true if you overlooked the fact that none of them went to my school, and *friendship* was a generous word for any of my associations. My house wasn't a place for having friends over. My social life was regional competitions and piano classes and workshops with student musicians from Knoxville and other cities, kids who could say *Suzuki* when they were toddlers. None had ever met my parents.

I held my ground for a few days, maybe a week, and then felt too tired and confused to keep it up. The thought of Jon Link's family looking down their noses at us was crushing. But it was more than that. Jon Link's delicate exoticism had turned for me, like milk gone sour. After only a few hours with a man I might never see again. Standing on the spring grass, sitting in a close booth. Eyes, forearms. I slammed every door against

thoughts of him, embarrassed and ashamed. I watched Jon Link's thin wrists as he buttoned his white cuffs and pulled on his shapeless black jacket for a concert, and whatever it was I felt, it was not attraction.

I covered my guilt with outrage. We blew up over nothing and everything, rattling our thin apartment walls until the two shy chemistry majors living next door pounded their pleas for quiet. Our friends were embarrassed by the hostilities and stopped coming around at mealtimes. I curled my fists against the urge to strike something flat-handed, and lowered my voice to a growl. *Now* Jon Link was interested in where I came from? *Now* he needed to meet my family, and to tell them what, again? I needed him to say it. Engaged? Sorry, I hadn't quite noticed. Takes a little more of your attention span, where I come from. They'd want to see a ring.

He was flummoxed by this testy stranger in his life who bristled at his overtures, indignant over surprising things, flinging my clothes into the hamper and refusing to pick up his from the floor before stalking off to the laundromat. His shock was no greater than mine. It felt like goblins had come out of the grass to carry off the partner I'd been in our comfortable life, leaving this dead-hearted creature in her place.

Then we stopped arguing and went quiet. It happened all at once, in that shivering, ear-ringing way the last chord of a symphony dies in a concert hall. Jon Link was going to Munich. I would stay here and sort through whatever it was in my plain existence that had fallen so recklessly out of key.

The orange-flyer meeting was students, and only students, crowded into a lecture hall in the sociology-anthropology building in a part of campus that might as well have been another city. I still had trouble believing the size of this school, with more people inside its halls and dormitories than we had in the whole county I grew up in. I folded Sigurd's flyer into a tight rectangle in my back pocket and navigated the campus the way I'd done in my earliest days there, squaring a printed map with landmarks I could recognize, then tucking the map away to avoid looking like a freshman. Up stairs and down hallways, finally following the voices, I found forty or fifty students jammed into a lecture hall with more energy than I'd ever seen in any classroom.

To their credit, the student leaders sitting down in front did a fair job of keeping a lid on the hubbub. Somebody had written an agenda on the blackboard, which they discussed in those terms, “The Agenda,” and worked through with surprising formality: motion, second, discussion, vote, next item. Every bit of it went into one of my ears and out the other. An anti-nuclear protest on the weekend. Also coming up, an “educational on Divestment,” something that seemed to need no explanation in this room. They were still fundraising for the speaker from Berkeley, but she had committed. The room exploded with applause for the photo they held up, a glamorous woman with an Afro the size of California. A committee was working on transportation for the musical group for this event, whose name I didn’t recognize and didn’t expect to. What regular people my age called music might as well have been happening on a different planet.

One agenda item chalked near the bottom of the list, “Unionizing Grad Students,” stirred some hope, but I made myself stop scanning the room. Sigurd wasn’t there. I was not going to see him again. I’d felt so sure of that lunch as some kind of opening move, our allemande, but he just wanted to recruit me to the cause of nuclear disarmament and Black Power. I was that stupid.

I slipped out during the third or fourth round of voting, lurching like some self-pitying moth from streetlight to streetlight until I found myself back on home ground, in the circular, tiled hall of the practice building. Most of the rooms would be reserved every hour through midnight, but the Yamaha with mushy action that we all hated would be vacant.

I threw myself at the keys, playing the most desolate piece I’d ever learned by heart: Chopin’s Prelude Opus 28, No. 15. It’s called the “Raindrop” Prelude because of the steady thrumming of the A-flat in the left hand, like falling rain, until it roars up into basso ostinato thunder in the middle section. He wrote it one stormy evening when his beloved George Sand didn’t come home, and Chopin convinced himself she had died in a carriage accident. He saw the whole thing in a trance as he transcribed the notes that played in his head: Her precious broken body in the road. The icy rain.

She was fine, as it turned out, just running late. Sand was a notorious free spirit who slept around a good deal, and she left him in the long run. I had loved this piece since my early teens, never failing to feel through my hands

the forgone conclusion of his loss. We connected that night across the centuries, one brokenhearted fool to another.

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Prelude II

Tuesday, the second day after the phone call, I finally slept. Just for a few hours in the early morning. I woke up startled, as if my phone had rung again with his voice inside waiting to puncture me. I lay still listening to Charlie breathe until I couldn't stand how that felt, how far apart we were beside each other in bed. Charlie, who was blameless, who knew nothing.

I slipped downstairs and paced the kitchen without turning on any lights. If I made coffee, most of the pot would go stale before Charlie got up at dawn. There was nothing to clean—I keep a tidy kitchen. Gaz got up from the foot of the stairs when I came down, weaving himself around me so I felt his soft coat against my bare legs, asking what was menacing me in the dark. I wished I could say. We went outside and he searched out the right spot, stretching himself out in relief before coming back to my side, visible only in the thin white stripe down the middle of his upturned face. Those heartless crickets, still singing. Those cold stars.

Self-punishment was the only choice that felt right. We got in my car, and I drove the half mile to my mother's house, barefoot, wearing my nightgown. A rash thing to do, but not impractical. Nobody would see me but Gaz, who viewed me as holy in any raiment, as the Bible would put it. If daylight eventually shamed me into putting on clothes, I could find no end of possibilities up there at the house. The velvet dress I wore for my eighth-grade recital, just for instance. Clothes of my mother's in every size

from the medium slim of young motherhood to the XL she eventually settled into. Clothes of my long-dead father's, if I felt inclined to that kind of madness. Or of my brother's.

My mother didn't throw things away. Didn't, couldn't. Not a newspaper or the blue plastic sleeve it came in. Not the dead, long-replaced appliances that slowly ganged up in a line against the basement wall and drowned under piles of old toys and boxes of broken dishes. Before I understood this tendency of my mother's as a sickness, I spent years casting my judgments—materialism, sentimentality, laziness, but mostly I thought of it as unkindness. Her way of showing my father and me that we mattered less than the used plastic butter tubs she washed and stacked in yellow columns filling every cabinet. Less than the junk mail piled into mountains that avalanched their rectangles across our dining table, driving us to carry our bowls of supper into separate cramped corners of the house. Driving away any thoughts of inviting a friend over, so I could never learn how to be a girl who did that.

Now she was dead, and her trove was mine. The furniture stacked upon furniture, the piles of magazines, the desk drawers stuffed with receipts from businesses shuttered so long ago, few people in town would remember them. The black trash bags bulging mysteriously, piled boulder-like on either side of the paths she followed in her last years from kitchen to TV chair to bed, all of it dusted with shame and the whispery business of mice. Mine, all mine. Books shelved two layers deep in the bookcases, with the pulp novels and Christian tracts of her later life on the outside like brick walls closing off our earlier eras of reading—my brother's Scout manuals, my Nancy Drews, the *World Book Encyclopedia* we'd both used to shore up our homework as we sprawled side by side on the living room floor. Both things seemed squelched from the record now: that I'd had a brother, that our home had a floor we could sprawl on. One loss abrupt; the other almost geologically slow, like continents shrinking into the sea. Shirts, jackets, mothy wool coats, pilled sweaters, dresses old and older, plain and fancy, year by year stuffed into closets, eventually wedged in so tightly on their wire hangers, it was impossible to shove a hand between them. The bedrooms that used to be Cy's and mine were also stuffed that way, so that opening either of their doors left you nothing to do but sigh and close it again.

That's what she left me. The job of excavating a well-built three-bedroom farmhouse, which we badly needed to sell, from the chaff of her life's proud misery.

I've tried to see it that way, as her misery. On a good day, I could make the case: She held onto objects in place of the people she couldn't. Trying to fill a void. That, and the special mix of brain chemicals that will tip some people over into saving junk mail, others to washing their hands till they bleed or counting the pickets in fences. Or maybe sitting on a piano bench for the inhuman number of hours it takes to memorize and physically, manually absorb a Bach partita. These urges can run in families, was the point, suggested to me by a friend of Mickie's, with good intentions, I have to think. This friend was Mickie's coworker at the high school, a counselor who mostly dealt in truancy and pregnancy dramas, but she also had the background and words to explain how my mother's hoarding was a disease, like heart failure. Not caused by me or directed at me, just part of my medical history, good to know about. I was loaned several books with *Your Loved One* in the title, and I want to say they helped. Until the next time I walked through the door. Here she still was. Getting the last word.

Gaz let out a sad little whine when he saw where we were going, and slunk from the car to follow me in. His feelings about this house matched mine. Despite the mythic meaning of his proper name, Gaspard, "keeper of treasures," he was no fan of my mother's hoard. The only thing that upset him more was being apart from me, and it was awful to make him choose. Maybe that was my excuse, which I needed, for the pitiful progress I'd made here since she died in June. I did try, in fits and starts. Charlie gave me a hand when he could, coming in to move heavy furniture once I'd cleared space to start sorting out what we could sell at an estate auction or a yard sale, or give to the church charity. Our brother-in-law, James, Mickie's husband, borrowed a dumpster from one of his construction sites that he let me keep out front, ready to pull it off to the county dump whenever I filled it to the top. Mickie sometimes came over on Saturdays, often with her mother, Faye, blessed woman, who could find a daisy in hell's weed patch. They'd even bring Mickie's teenage kids on the rare day they had time for it, and those days were the best, even Gaz cheered up, for Ethan and Betts turned it into a game. Who could find the weirdest chicken-related item, the oldest date on a receipt, the cutest mummified mouse? On from there. A discovered stash of Barbie clothes and several mummified mice combined

for a hair-raising fashion show. Faye tried to draw the line, mindful of our being in a dead woman's shrine, but we'd still yet end up laughing until the dust made us wheeze. We needed it.

I needed it now. Sitting on the floor of my mother's bedroom with a box of pictures of strangers on my lap. Nobody I knew, mostly cut out of newspapers and magazines. All boys in uniform. Gaz lay watching me, vigilant in the doorway. A border collie is an instrument perfectly tuned to anticipation, always foreseeing the gate through which his flock may exit, stationing himself right there. I was sum total of Gaz's flock, and plainly desperate to bolt.

I'd mostly avoided this room till now. Eyeing this mess from the doorway was bad enough, these stacks and stacks of dun-colored shoeboxes with their adhesive dead of old age, the cardboard corners standing apart at the seams. They covered her desk and the floor all around it, going back all the years I could remember. Finally this morning I'd opened one. I could give Sigurd credit at least for the sleepless, early-morning jitters that sent me over here and straight to the inner sanctum. Misery seeks its own level, I guess, the way water does. Now I had the sick feeling of walking in on my mother's privacy. I'd flipped the top off a decrepit box expecting mice to run out, finding these boys instead. A hodgepodge of photos and clippings, not a soul I recognized. Ethan and Betts would be making up names and silly life histories, but mostly it was their mother I wanted to talk to. I'd call her eventually, or she'd call me, we always checked in, but it wouldn't be for hours. My head ached from exhaustion, and nobody else was awake yet. This day would be the death of me. I sorted through what I could tell her and what I couldn't, because she was my husband's sister. I'd failed from the beginning to untangle that. Not one person in my life knew about my disaster with Sigurd. A secret that big, kept this long, is a betrayal of its own kind.

I abandoned the shoeboxes to make coffee, then made myself get back at them. Daybreak was just finding the dusty windows when my phone rang somewhere in the mess. It was dangerous to come in here in a garment without pockets.

"How's the Wreck of the *Hesperus*?" she asked, very much too cheerfully.

I brushed the debris of disintegrated cardboard off of my nightgown and shoved aside a garbage bag so I could sit on the bed. The bag was oddly

light and made hollow clocking sounds when I moved it. “How’d you know I was over here?”

“I heard your car go by. At four in the damn morning. What’s up?”

I untwisted the tie to look in the bag. Easter eggs, the plastic ones that pop in half. Did she do that for us, an Easter hunt? I had no memory of it. “You know my car by sound?”

“If anybody else came up that road in the black of night, Tipper would bark his head off.”

Gaz relaxed at the tone of my voice. He always knew when it was Mickie.

“But you were awake?” I asked.

“Sister-in-law drama, followed by teen-girl drama. Long night. You don’t want to hear it.”

Her husband’s older sisters were her cross to bear. We’d all grown up together in this place—Mickie and Charlie, my brother and me, James and his sisters just up the road—and certain things you don’t forget. When Mickie was very small, those Barnes girls tied her to a tree one time and threatened to burn her, just for instance. Now they just resented her happy life. Their little brother got the family business; they got the deadbeat husbands.

“I asked about *you*, Livia. What’s wrong?”

What was wrong. I’d had a shocking phone call that left me feeling my whole life might be precarious. “Nothing’s wrong.”

“You could burn it down, you know. We’d all still love you.”

Her words made my heart scudder. Then I understood: She meant the house. Every member of my husband’s family had at some point made the gesture of striking a match when the subject came up. Even before my mother died, they did that. Long before.

“Could I, please? If we insured it first?”

“Talk to Bobby Mitchell down at State Farm, he could make this work for us. You know I dated him in high school, right?”

“You did not. You’ve been with James since you were twelve. One of my students’ parents told me she learned what French-kissing was from watching you two on the bus.”

“*Who* told you that?”

“Are you denying it?”

“Well, but you know. We had to take a few breathers.”

She was the one to name this house the Wreck of the *Hesperus,* and the rest of us took it up without knowing it was a poem, about a shipwreck. Mickie is Mrs. Michaela Barnes, AP English teacher. She gave me the poem to read. It turns out we are a story for the ages, my mother and me: the refusal to accept help, the daughter chained to the mast. Now even the frozen corpse, though technically Mom was in the ground and it was late August, so nobody was frozen.

"Here's a question. What was she doing with a gazillion pictures of boys?"

"Who, your mom? I mean. What was she doing with a gazillion everything?"

"Okay, but specifically."

"You're saying *boys*. Like, little boys? Which would be creepy. Or is it like . . . oh my God! Are you saying cheesecake stuff?"

I laughed. "No. It's some military obsession, all these young men in uniform. But they're nobody I recognize. It's like a *collection*. Mostly clippings. No captions, no names."

"Oh, honey. That's about your brother."

That sobered us both right up. "No. He wasn't, he never did . . ."

"Enlist. I know. But they wanted him to, right? She and your father, wasn't that part of the whole thing?" She hesitated. "I'm not saying I remember anything, I was too young. But Charlie has told me bits and pieces."

We were parallel families, both of us younger sisters of only brothers, which was unusual in our circles. But the gap between Mickie and Charlie was a little wider—seven years—and she was a late-life baby. Mickie's theory was that her parents conceived her as insurance against total loss, after they had a terrible close call with Charlie.

"There was talk about Cy enlisting," I told her, "but that was a nonstarter. I remember thinking, do they *know* him? Cy wouldn't even watch war movies on TV."

"Okay."

"I'm stuck for some good reason Mom would care so much about these unknown soldier boys in a shoebox."

"And so little about leaving you with a giant mess to deal with. I'm sorry, Livvie."

“I shouldn’t be trying to make sense out of nonsense. I’m just here to take out the trash.”

“You probably shouldn’t be up there alone so much,” she said quietly. “It’s not safe.”

“I don’t think anything here really qualifies as toxic waste.”

We hoped this was true. In my mother’s last years, I’d hired a woman named Ruby Lewis to come in twice a month to see to that, selectively taking out genuine garbage, emptying the refrigerator and bringing in new groceries. She had an outstanding nose for mouse bait. My mother had hated Ruby’s industry, needless to say, but Ruby was athletic and outpaced her.

“I mean toxic for you specifically,” Mickie said. “You and her. The situation.”

I got off the bed and sat on the floor again, still holding the phone and using the other hand to shove all those boys into a garbage bag. I felt Mom watching me from the doorway. Could practically see her standing over Gaz, the hostile glare hovering above, his devoted one below. I assembled my thoughts carefully: Her coffin being lowered. Her body inside the coffin, down under the dirt, in the cemetery next to Dad, having pretty much the same conversation they’d had for years before he died.

“I’m over it,” I told Mickie.

“I think ‘over it’ is a moving target in this case.”

A sharp puff of air came out of me with a little sound, like *huh*. Mickie is that friend who nails the truth to the wall for you while you were looking for it out in the weeds. I lay back against a trash bag stuffed with shoeboxes, feeling all the corners jutting against my back.

“I mean, how could you ever be, really?” she pushed. “Your mother is supposed to be the great love of your life.”

“Is there some part of my sad story that bears talking about right now?”

“I’ve been thinking about it all summer. Since the funeral. I always thought there would be some kind of, I don’t know. Resolution? And there’s no chance now. I hate that for you.”

Resolution was the word, I thought. The dissonant, unsettled chord that makes your teeth ache for how badly it wants to relax into sweetness. Here I sat, quaking under her dead gaze, still waiting.

“It would have been all up to me, Mickie. She was never going to change. You know what she used to tell Cy and me when we were little?

‘You get what you get and you don’t throw a fit.’”

Mickie laughed. “Livvie, I’ve said the same thing to Ethan and Betts. Maybe a few thousand times.”

“But they go on and have fits anyway. Because you love them and they know it.”

“Okay. But she had to love you at *some* point. When you were little, before the bad stuff.”

I thought about it. “When we were little, Cyrus and I had this thing we’d say after one or both of us got strapped. We’d *call* it: ‘Good day’ or ‘Bad day.’ Based which end of the belt she used on us, leather end or buckle end.”

“Good God,” Mickie said quietly. “I guess I always thought you must have some happier memories from, you know. Early days. Before you two stopped talking.”

“We never stopped talking.”

“You know what I mean. People change. Tragedy can turn people hard.”

“Not always. Look at your parents, they must have gone through hell with Charlie’s accident. There could have been blame, but I never saw a shred of that in Faye and Teddy. You’re all good as gold. Same as before.”

“My parents are saints. And my brother didn’t die. Obviously.”

“He almost did. And he didn’t get through it in one piece, obviously.”

“And look what he’s got now, the best wife in the world. People mend different ways, I guess. Or they don’t.”

Best wife in the world got me like a bee sting. I closed my eyes against my mother’s bitterness, trying to keep her out of me. In the absence of children to wreck, I could still wound my husband. How cruel, to think of our contentment as something I’d settled for. A consolation. I hated these goblins rising out of the grass. Called up by a voice on the phone.

“Mothers and daughters, jeez,” Mickie said. “I’m about ready to kill Betts right now. *And* I want to hold her on my lap and sing her to sleep. All six-foot, volleyball-playing, sweaty hormonal mess of her. We were about to the end of our rope last night, or this morning, I guess, when I heard your car going up to the house, and it had me thinking about you and her. How is it even possible, like, chemically or whatever? For a mother not to love her child?”

“I wouldn’t know.”

A silence stretched between us as she realized how the question might hurt. Most women did self-conscious little two-steps around my childlessness, treating me as some brand of special being. I appreciated that Mickie didn't. We ran deeper. But her candor involved some risk for me.

"What I'm trying to say," she said finally, with scrupulous kindness, "is that you deserved better. I hoped there was a time in your life when she was good to you. It would make me feel better to know that, honestly. So that's my bad. That's me being a selfish friend."

"No, you're not. It's okay. Tell me what's going on with Betts."

Pregnant rang in my head, but that wasn't it. Betts had a tattoo—that was the catastrophe. She'd planned on hiding it three more years until she turned eighteen. Inked by a friend at a slumber party where they'd all inflicted these on each other. Discovered by accident, *You can NOT tell Dad,* and so on. The exquisitely intense, impossible expectations of the young.

"It's not heroin," I said.

"Thank you for the perspective." It wasn't out of the question, we both knew, not just from our time around high school students. More than one of Mickie's sisters-in-law had tangled with prescription meds.

"As much as she deserves it, you won't kill your daughter," I told Mickie. "You said it wasn't chemically possible, meaning what? Some physical thing happens when you give birth, to make you sure you've done the right thing?"

"Oh, well, that's a mystery." She went quiet, probably racking her brain for language to explain something so large to the uninitiated.

There were only two big things Mickie didn't know about me, and this was the other one: I'd carried a child. It was such a dangerous question for me to ask. Such a ragged state I was in. Sigurd's call had raised my twenty-year-old self from the dead, making me wonder. What crucial maternal benchmark did I miss?

"You know what I remember? Actually losing my mind. Right after Ethan was born. I got obsessed with all the things that might go wrong. But I mean bona fide crazy-town level of obsessed. Like, I made James take all the knives out of the kitchen and hide them. Because what if somebody used one of them to hurt my baby?"

I swallowed.

"What I'm really saying is, *me,* what if *I* hurt him? That's what scared me to death. I was afraid of every single thing I might do wrong, or might be

capable of. For the rest of my life. All the sudden, I had this terrible power I couldn't ever reverse. I'd just have to grow into it."

I wasn't sure this answered the question, but Mickie had to get ready for work. We signed off. Gaz watched me with grave concern.

"Let's quit breathing this poison," I told him. "Just let me get decent first."

I rolled off the bag of boxes whose sharp corners probably left dents in my back. It was fully daytime now, and I felt vulgar in my nightgown. I ran my fingers through my hair, quickly rebraiding it, a sequence my hands knew better than any piano piece. I'd never worn my hair any other way. Just below my shoulders now, not the Rapunzel rope I had in college. After my other important assets were catastrophically axed, the lavish hair had to go too.

I got up and dug in her closet and pulled out a light cotton twill coat that would work as a dress. Summer weight, pale blue, with a belt covered in the same fabric. I remembered her wearing this a lot when I was in middle school. The first year after Cy was gone. I put it on, imagining what it felt like to live inside that year, that person she was. A grimace is what I pictured. Her way of humming under her breath, one phrase of a hymn on repeat while she cooked or cleaned. She had a good clear voice but only used it in church. I always noticed; hers was one of the few that held fast to the pitch. My mother's voice in church could bring the drifting herd back into the fold. But the humming at home was unfocused, just a dark furze clutched around her like this house. Her song of barely managed tolerance of a life she despised. I did up the buttons and found a circular silver brooch pinned to the collar. A gift from my father, maybe. Back when he was still trying. Before we all stopped talking.

I pulled the shoeboxes back out of the trash bag and settled their warped lids back on. Everything here made of paper was riddled with the slithery paper-eating bugs we called silverfish, reason enough to want these boxes gone. I had many more. And still yet, here they stayed. I stacked them for another day, on her desk beside the old telephone with its coiled cord and awful color that people carelessly used to call "flesh." I held the dead receiver to my ear, replaced it, sat on the bed, and felt my spirits sink with the bad mattress. My brother and I used to call this extension her "secret phone," for gossiping behind her closed bedroom door. Idle talk about people we knew from town, church, school. The divorced lady on Mill

Road with different cars parked in her drive overnight. Mr. Summits, who ran the Western Auto, called by some people “a three-dollar bill,” which we thought had to do with the money in his cash register. That he didn’t give people enough change, or maybe too much. We never got the real stories, my brother and me. We had to make up our own. My mother wasn’t one for answering questions.

Gaz followed me out of the house, waving his white-tipped victory flag. He’d seen me through another morning of this. I’d have to go home soon, to meet other obligations.

“Look back,” I said, and stood on the porch steps watching him thrill to full speed, arcing out of the front yard to circle the acres of steep hayfield rising beyond it. *Look back* is the shepherd’s command to leave the flock and scour the pasture for any animal that might have straggled away from it. He knew there was only one of me, but appreciated the chance to remember his muscles and go have a look, just in case. He would circle that giant field for as long as I let him. Come back straight as a bullet when I whistled.

I sat on the steps to think. *Before we stopped talking.* I knew what Mickie meant, but we did *speak*, right up to the last hospital visiting hours. Pillows and ice chips, tapioca or Jell-O. A long time before that, our words could have been chosen from a hospital menu devoted to blandness. Which isn’t really speaking, fair enough. Could I pin it on a calendar? Would it solve anything?

The horrible Easter call, then. April, the same month I met Sigurd, she and I had a phone call I knew would be the last one, if it was up to me. Which it was. Every Sunday afternoon I called home, first from a dorm phone, then the apartment I shared with Jon Link. For three years, I spent Monday through Saturday gathering my dread of the next one. They took some planning to get through. But I learned. First, to avoid sharing bad news, because any complaint got the same reply: “Well, if you’re not happy, come on home.”

I’d sooner have sacrificed a limb than admit she was right. But I had no happiness to report for a long time. In my stupefyingly hard, required non-music classes—French, intro biology, English composition—my classmates had already learned everything in high school, it seemed, and were just there for review. My steady panic even carried over into music, where I’d hoped to be safe. At my first meeting with my piano instructor, Dr. Betis,

within minutes of my taking the bench, he'd corrected my pronunciation of his name ("Bay-TEE") and also *Satie* and *Debussy* and *still* (it has only one syllable) and *well* (a *whale* is a sea creature), eyeing me like a mouse that got in through the cracks. Later that week, one of his other students told me not to take this the wrong way, but Dr. Bay-TEE was asking for me to be reassigned. (Dr. Betis was the top piano instructor.) It didn't happen, so he must have reconsidered after hearing me play, or maybe he'd never said it at all. Would he really be discussing me with his other students? I had to think it was possible. I heard a lot of news that year that began with *Don't take this the wrong way*.

Better things came along in time. Music theory was miraculous, like a set of equations that made every piece I'd ever struggled to memorize fall clickety-clack into place, even retroactively back to the two-part inventions that had tripped me up in middle school.

"You did used to always go blank in those recitals" was my mother's comment on that.

Always. In my long career of recitals, it happened *once*: a Bach fugue, the spring I was thirteen. And I did not go blank, just couldn't find my way out of it as the repeated phrases kept rolling from my hands—exposition, subject, answer, subject—as unendable as a snake swallowing its tail, until I left off mid-variation and took a quick, embarrassed bow. In all the years since then, I'd never had another memory lapse. I hung up from that phone call with a poisoned feeling in my gut that took a lot of hours in practice rooms to expel.

Other miracles followed. In my evening work-study hours at the mostly empty music library, I listened to whatever got left on the desk before I reshelved it, randomly stretching my horizons past piano literature into opera and Renaissance krummhorns and Gregorian chants, all on the university's dime. Second semester, I mustered the courage to stop eating alone, and found lunch companions who allowed me into the kind of talk I had never let outside of my own head before. Love or hate: Wagner, John Cage, the bizarre twelve-tone compositions of Schoenberg? I was starting to form opinions but mostly listened, lest I be found out for loving or hating the wrong things. They let me stay. I tried explaining this tentative camaraderie to my mother, who asked if I was putting on weight.

"Why would you think that?" I asked, startled. I had the figure of a scarecrow.

“You said cafeteria,” she answered, as if that settled it. “I tried teaching you decent cooking. But you wanted to be off down at the church for your practicing.”

I failed to budge her misunderstanding of my new life. To clarify that college offered me no form of kitchen, just for instance, even if I’d been a whiz at using one. She’d moved straight from her father’s home to her husband’s when she was my age, so it was beyond her to picture a woman living her whole life in classrooms, practice rooms, and a shared bedroom hardly bigger or better furnished than the milking stalls in my father’s barn. If he’d been on the phone, I would have explained our dorm room that way and he’d have laughed. I could tell him about the job I’d found as a waitress too. The yelling in the kitchen, the waitstaff rolling our eyes at student diners and their awful manners. He’d have smiled to picture me in the middle of all that.

But he almost never came to the phone. I had to call in the evenings, and she didn’t want to get him up out of his chair. “Dad says ‘Okay,’” she’d report, and I pictured him giving me the sign he’d always flashed across the barn, or as I was walking out to the school bus: a circle with his thumb and index finger: *We’re o-kay*. Even if we weren’t. Even if I’d wanted to yell for help, watching him through the frosted laundry room window as she bent us over the washing machine and stung our bare bottoms with a belt. Seeing the moving gray shapes of him and his dog Dolly against the still gray shape of the barn. “CyLee Dairy” painted in tall white letters across it, named for us kids. My father’s love for us, always in sight but out of earshot. When I left for college, he’d just turned fifty but already was worn out by the end of each day, crippled with arthritis in his spine. From his years driving the mail route, he said, working the pedals and reaching across from the driver’s seat to mailboxes outside the right-hand window. I was amazed, my first fall in Bloomington, to see a little square mail truck with the steering wheel on the passenger’s side. I told him about the mail trucks. So we did speak, when I asked for him. But mostly I had to picture him in his old recliner, Dolly attached to his side, watching TV with the sound off. The problem of Livia was my mother’s job.

I made it easy for her. She heard no more about my new friendships, or my confusion over how they all seemed slightly stained because of my accent or whatever it was, the poor public schooling, the place or the people. I never had a perfect handle on what I was doing wrong. Until the

marvel of Jon Link, who was kind to the point of reverence for my skills. Any daughter might keep quiet about discovering sex with a friend, but I also kept quiet about how he pushed me to make bold choices. Tackling Liszt for my spring-term jury was his idea. When Dr. Betis heard my proposal, he stared at me through his horn-rimmed glasses for such a long time, I assumed I'd mispronounced *Mephisto*, or probably even *Liszt*. He took more offense from my accent than my errors in technique. But no, he just didn't think I could play it. I asked him to let me have two weeks on it, and in that short time, as I gathered Liszt into my hands, Dr. Betis had to reckon with his notions of this country girl. His spoken praise after that jury —in front of everybody!—shifted the ground under my other relationships, salting them with the admiration and envy that made me think I might someday fit in this place. A few days later, still heady, I couldn't stop myself telling my mother about the parts she might understand: the perfect performance, Dr. Betis, the other instructors, all of them applauding.

She exhaled to a count of eight, nine, ten. "It's unbecoming to put on airs. But I guess that's how they do, up there."

I apologized. Then told her I wouldn't be coming home at the end of term. I'd been offered a summer job as rehearsal accompanist for a choral group. My jury triumph meant more paying jobs would follow. My mother wouldn't even know dormitories closed for summer, so I didn't have to explain the alternate arrangement. Jon Link's clarinetist roommate had scored a position with the Los Angeles Philharmonic, and I'd scored a position as the new roommate.

After that, I took care to remember: It's not the whistle that pulls the train. I went on making these calls, but never again did I toot my horn. I kept them short—because of the expense, we said. But her irritation went past money. Year after year, I wanted to ask: *What is my offense? My music or me.* Clearly the combination. It had always been there: A smack for not helping with dishes, but really for being too long at the church practicing. For alleged insolence after a good recital. My offense was that I'd been marking time in high school and was marking time here until I'd taken the piano playing as far as it went and came home to begin a normal life. I tried to keep a safe distance from my fear she might be right. I settled on one quick thing to report each week, small, so her indifference wouldn't hurt, and in this way, we passed two more years. Arriving at a Sunday when the thing I needed to tell her was about getting married.

Her hello was always the same: “Well, Livia. What are *you* up to?” Emphasis on the *you*. She knew other people’s sensible business all right. *I* was the nonsense. I didn’t even want to talk about Jon Link right now, when we seemed to be falling apart. I tested the waters by telling her about my friend’s good news, the summer festival overseas. I said “job” because *festival* would strike her as something flighty. She was impatient with the subject and changed it.

“You’ll be home for Easter, won’t you.”

I was startled. Did my plans matter to her? I tried to work out when Easter might be. I’d heard a rehearsal of the Mahler *Resurrection* going on that very day, bells and all, so it must not have happened yet. When had I ever gone home for Easter?

This was her point. I hadn’t, and had now used up all the grace a mother could sensibly offer. Her friends at church asked if I had “gone atheist.” I assured her I was still every bit the Christian I’d been as a child, which was true. (I was only ever in it for the music.) She said Easter was one of the most important Sundays. “Out of all of them,” she clarified.

Something in me fluttered at being wanted, so I tried earnestly to explain. My work-study job, classes, performances by musicians who’d be sorely let down if their pianist skipped town.

“They don’t give you the Lord’s Day off, then.”

I felt knocked off my pins: It had been so long since anything I did seemed worth her interest. I wouldn’t know for months that my father had been diagnosed with cancer, and she was scared. She mentioned only people at church, my spiritual status. As regard’s the Lord’s Day of rest, I explained I didn’t have classes on Sundays, but there were other duties. I would need several days to get the bus to Tennessee and back, a freedom I truly didn’t have.

My mother, who had never had to answer to an employer in her life, was quiet for an unusually long time. Then said, “If you loved your family, you’d be here.”

I quietly set the receiver into its cradle on the telephone that hung on the wall of our kitchen. Black telephone, yellowish wall. I slid down the wall to the linoleum floor and spent a long time sitting like that, staring into the darkness under the stove. It was an old-fashioned thing on squat legs, with a secret landscape under its belly: a macaroni shell, a spoon, a thick nap of

gray dust covering everything. I felt a pressure behind my eyes, but no tears came. Only a tightness in my throat that wouldn't let me swallow.

That moment is hardened in my memory, like a bronzed baby's shoe. It's unbelievable that my father's devastating news was no part of it, but it wasn't. I know exactly when I found out, and it wasn't my mother who told me. What shattered me that day was a prospect she dangled and then yanked away: *If you loved your family.* Meaning, you have one, and you could love each other. I hadn't for years thought of this ritual as "calling home." But whatever it was, I decided there on the floor I wouldn't do it again. And I didn't, for many months, until I was desperate for any home that would have me.

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Toccata

The tail end of Indiana winter always bullied me, for I knew of another world where dogwoods were already blooming, calling me home to a place I didn't want to be. I felt myself turning into dead air as Jon Link and I moved around each other without touching. He stayed up working on scores after I'd gone to bed. When he slipped in on his side later, I pretended to be asleep. We honored our dead attachment like a corpse between us. Gone were the little gestures, the quick kiss in the kitchen tasting of pickles as I made a sandwich and he ran off to a rehearsal. He did a lot of running those last weeks, moving full-speed toward summer and Munich. Our angry flare-up passed over and left an emptiness I had no heart for poking at. I also put Sigurd behind me, or would have said so, but grieved for something I was ashamed to think about.

The one thing I knew how to do was to double down, forever earning my place in the world I still wanted to think I'd chosen. I had a new word for it now: *precarious*. Pretty soon I would play the hardest jury of my life. All year, I'd been considering Ravel's *Gaspard de la Nuit* for my May recital, not because I loved it—though I did, everybody does—but because I was afraid of it. Fear is a powerful engine. I'd started learning it part by part, then would set it aside again, still unsure. Now, from the bottom of my stupid gloom over Sigurd, *Gaspard de la Nuit* woke me up with a different shine: Distraction could save me. This was a trial by fire that I actually

could fail. *Gaspard de la Nuit* is a triathlon. The sensuous, shimmery opening movement is sneaky in the way ballet is sneaky: all ease and smoothness, giving no hint of the arduous neuromuscular coordination backing it up. Next comes the slow, aching middle section, not so hard. Then, last, the "Scarbo," which literally uses every note on the keyboard and is well known to be impossible. Ravel himself couldn't play it. I decided I would.

I was thinking about the "Scarbo," how to break the movement into manageable pieces, as I walked from class toward the practice building. The day had a lusty warmth to it, the kind that caused students to forsake most of their clothing. Winter had given up the fight, and the worst was surely behind me now: April, heartbreak, the last call to my mother. Here, finally, were forsythias exploding golden around me and the rushing creek and trees bathed in the greenish smell of furred baby leaves. Springtime was all up in my nose, the black-and-white complexities of *Gaspard* crowding my mind's ears, and then came something that pulled me out of myself.

Singing. Here, outdoors. Not the silly a cappella of fraternity boys. Women's voices braiding around something unearthly and beautiful. I changed my course, taking the path that cut back toward Showalter Plaza, tracking the trail of those voices like an ear-hound.

A crowd of students filled the plaza, spellbound like me. The singers stood on a platform with a red-lettered banner behind it, so huge it hid the fountain. "FREE SOUTH AFRICA," it commanded. I only had eyes for the singers. Four women, young or maybe medium young, all African, I had to guess, not just from the unfamiliar language of their song but also the beads and shells of their jewelry and printed-cloth head wraps and dresses. Their sound was beyond description, voices sliding around together, harmonizing in eerily doubled, ringing parallel thirds and fourths, exotically pentatonic. Parallel octaves, even. Every single thing about this music was breaking the rules I'd learned in Theory I.

I looked around, wondering if any other music students were witnessing this, but didn't see any. I recognized a poster poking up out of the crowd here and there: the woman from California. The orange-flyer meeting. This would be the event they were discussing. What a night that was, facing down my humiliating, love-struck illusions, drowning them in a practice room Chopin pity party. I closed my eyes, refusing any connection between that mess and these exquisite voices. I let them take me over. The music had

movement in it that pulled my heart to speed up. Homophonic parallelism. My mind was transcribing notes and outlaw parallels and the fact that these women were precisely in tune but sliding in between what my ear knew as the proper notes of a scale. Perfect pitch can be a cross to bear. I made myself stop analyzing. Cut the wire between ear and brain, and just listen. One of the four women was older and bigger voiced and was leading, calling out each musical phrase in her smoky, hearty voice for the others to answer. One of them pushed the beat with a beaded gourd she thumped against her thigh, but really it was all voices, moving perfectly together around a leading melody, following its rhythm and contour. I thought of a flock of birds wheeling around in the sky, undulating in that way that looks magical because there's no predicting where they'll go next, but all together they go. The bird flock of voices rose and rose, fell and rose, bursting sometimes into cries and clicks and the high, vibrating wail only women can make, called ululation. It made me shiver. I didn't want it ever to end.

It did, though. The crowd applauded and whistled, and a woman wearing crew cut hair and baggy jeans with a big leather belt stepped up to the microphone and called out the name of the singing group with such rapture and pride, you would think she'd given birth to them herself. Mosadi Welela or something similar to that. She asked the crowd for another round of applause, but we hadn't yet stopped the first round. She thanked the women and they left the stage, carefully minding the steps in their long, narrow dresses. It seemed impossible for these magical voices to come this far and not keep singing all day into night.

A long afternoon of *Gaspard de la Nuit* was calling me. The woman in the too-big jeans was introducing their main speaker now, and the California woman swept onstage to roaring cheers, looking ready for battle in a red caftan and a necklace so big and shiny it resembled a breastplate. I was backing up through the crowd when I caught sight of him. To the side of the stage, almost behind it, he was doing something with the giant sound system and talking quietly to the belted-jeans woman, who nodded, indicating something to Sigurd. He disappeared behind the stage.

I stayed, telling myself the women might sing again. Meanwhile, the speaker was fiery and well practiced, urging us to demand that our university stop investing our tuition money in South Africa and bring down their racist regime, a noble project that was beyond my powers. I wasn't paying to come here; they were paying me. She talked about schoolkids

getting shot during a protest, and a friend of hers she called “Mama Africa” who was from South Africa but not allowed to go back there because of a song she’d written about the kids getting shot by the police. Apparently the singers had opened their set with that one. I was sorry to have missed it. People circulated through the crowd to pass out flyers in various colors with suggestions for how we might make ourselves useful in a world of woe. The upshot here was that Black people in Chicago or South Africa or anywhere are victims of the same racism and capitalist oppression. I had no disagreement on principle. I took every flyer that was handed to me, and kept my eye out for another appearance of Sigurd.

Suddenly it was all over, and people started clearing out fast. Finals were right around the corner, which everybody was happy to forget about for a brief interlude of global outrage, but now it was back to the grind. I moved upstream against the current of bodies, toward the stage and around back, where people on the steps of the fountain were packing up sound equipment. Sigurd stood in the middle of this buzzing hive of mostly female students, who were asking him questions and just generally hopping to it, bringing cables he pointed to, coiling them around their wrists and elbows before he packed them into cloth-lined cases. All eyes were on Sigurd, who seemed focused on getting the gear packed up. They must have been renting it by the hour. I wondered why he wasn’t at the print shop. Maybe his hours had changed. I stood shuffling through my collection of flyers, pulled a pencil from my back pocket and scribbled on one of them, waited some more. *Now or never*, I thought, and stepped into the snake’s nest of cables. For the first split second after he looked up, he was trying to place me. I saw it.

Then his face lit up, like the break of day. “Planets!” he called out, as if that were my name. Some of the helper girls turned and looked at me.

“I’m sorry to tell you, there’s still no Earth.”

“Oh, but there is,” he said. “You just can’t see what you’re standing on.”

I regarded the cordons flanking him like a female military brigade and walked right into it. “I’ve tracked down the information you were asking for,” I told him, and quickly handed him the folded flyer with my telephone number written inside.

I came home the next afternoon to find a message on the little pad we kept by the phone. Before he left for his rehearsals, Jon Link had jotted a number and a note: “Siegfried. Call him back, or he’ll break your sword and let loose the bear.”

I read it several times with my heart beating in my ears, wondering if they’d had a conversation. Surely Wagner’s opera was no part of this. Jon Link misheard Sigurd’s name, assumed he was some visiting basso I was working with, made a lame joke and that was that. I couldn’t ask. But had nothing to hide either, I told my pounding heart. One lunch was nothing. Except for how hard I was waiting for the second one.

It was the print shop number. I could hear a lot of noise when I called him back, a predominant rhythmic pounding. Sigurd wasn’t chatty but quickly proposed lunch again at the same diner. I tried not to sound breathless with gratitude when he suggested we meet the next day. If I’d had to wait longer, I’d have wasted crucial practice days in a fog while *Gaspard* went in one ear and out the other, leaving muscle memory untouched.

I did waste an hour trying not to arrive early, and still did, by a few minutes. As I lingered by the entrance, one of the cooks, Amadeo, came out of the kitchen to give me a bear hug. Amadeo was a burly music-lover who’d been a port in the storm of my first college year. He told me his mother had taken him as a boy to every free concert Chicago had to offer, and the rest of the story of an Italian immigrant child named after Mozart winding up in a Bloomington diner is a long one. But he happily transferred the family ambitions onto me, bragging to the other cooks and waitstaff that I was “the next Maria Tipo.” Not necessarily my idol of choice, but a fine pianist certainly, and evidently a goddess to Italians. I might as well have been the woman herself, for the way he scolded me about carrying hot plates and not taking care of my hands.

Amadeo was making a full inspection of those hands, front and back, when Sigurd came in. I saw him register me and this bear of a man tenderly regarding my slender fingers. Amadeo got the message and quickly handed me off, literally putting my hands into Sigurd’s. It was the first time we’d ever touched, and I swear I felt electric current move from his body to mine. It must have been visible to Amadeo. “Lucky mister,” he said, waving us toward the slightly private booths at the back. “Take care of our

maestra's hands. I'm watching," he said with a wink. Sigurd didn't let go of me until we sat down.

When he dropped it, my hand felt bereft.

He picked up the big laminated menu, so I did the same, though I was too nervous to eat. I didn't know how I would get through this lunch. He'd lived large in my imagination, to put it mildly, but *talk* was not an aspect of being with Sigurd that I'd really covered.

He pulled glasses out of his pocket to look at the menu briefly, then put them away again. A little vanity? The man was so perfect, he could use a few flaws to temper the shine. He looked up at me then, flashed the syncopated grin, and I felt solid enough to answer his questions: How did I know Amadeo, what was it like to work here? What was the thing about my hands? He teasingly called me "Planets," the same as when I'd surprised him backstage. Inexcusable moxie. But it got us here. I told him the hand thing was a fetish. Pianists are neurotic about their hands, practicing certain exercises to ward off the dreaded muscle spasms of focal dystonia, but sillier things too: wearing gloves to bed, refusing to do heavy lifting. I told him I wasn't like that. I'd insisted on doing the same jobs as everybody else here. I even liked rearranging the furniture in my apartment by myself, as a stress reliever. All true—Jon Link thought I was nuts, as regards the furniture. But I was overly keen to let Sigurd know I wasn't a pampered artist.

I ordered a burger, going on faith that the power to eat it would arrive in time. I'd dressed with some care, which wasn't something I really knew how to do. I had exactly two outfits in my closet for anything that required ceremony: one long black concert dress, and a blue silk jacket with little shoulder pads that I'd bought secondhand. Other than that, jeans. A few dresses for warm weather. I'd opted today for one of those, a blue peasantish thing with embroidery and a smocked bodice, maybe from another era. Secondhand was all the shopping I did. Jon Link once told me I looked pretty in this dress, the only compliment he ever gave me that was unrelated to musical skill. I understood that I was now using that compliment against him.

Sigurd had been thinking about me. If I'd never had a piano of my own, or in my household, he asked, did I learn from playing at church? Did I teach myself? I told him you don't get into a conservatory like this one by teaching yourself, then blushed for how arrogant that sounded, but he just

seemed to take it as information. He probably had no idea of the school's imposing rank among the world's piano programs.

I explained that it's a combination of function and beauty, with complex skills behind actions that look easy. You need teachers. I'd just about pulled teeth to get them. Begged my mother, then worked on my father separately, to land lessons with the one piano lady in town. She taught me to read notes, and rapped out rhythms with a ruler on the fallboard of her upright Acrosonic. On I went from there, requiring a whole lot more than Miss Edna's ruler to get me to the Indiana University School of Music, but I loved that he thought that was possible.

Our food came, and I felt I could tackle the fries, one at a time. I told him about the middle school music teacher who tapped me for the big leagues. I thought I'd already risen to the top of my game, at twelve. Who else but me could play the peppy marches to walk people into assemblies or accompany the choir? It was a given. If you're tall, everybody assumes you'll be on the basketball team. But there was only one of me, the piano girl. "Until one winter, we had a substitute chorus lady, after the regular one got in a wreck. Sandy Avalon, Lord have mercy."

"She changed your life."

"Well, first she embarrassed the life out of me. Miss Avalon was *intense*. She said I had to get to a good instructor in a bigger town before I was ruined. I told her my mother wouldn't drive me, and she said fine, she would drive me herself. I was like a mission for her."

"Saving pagan piano babies from darkness."

"Exactly. She found a good teacher in a town forty minutes away, and I went for my weekly scorching with Mrs. Sagraves. I was doing everything wrong, basic, basic things like pedaling, hand position, but she was so nice about it. I worked my heart out to please her. Some nights, I'd fall asleep on the piano. My mother said they should leave me there to starve, but Dad would take pity and fetch me." I felt a pang of affection remembering that. Dad's hand on my shoulder, gently waking me. Blinking myself back to where I was, Cross Creek Methodist, my face striped from lying on the keys. Hoping to God I hadn't drooled. *Sorry*, he'd apologize, and I knew he really was. Sorry, always, for that. Taking me back to her.

I took a few bites, watched Sigurd watching me. I'd not told Jon Link any of this. His parents would have carried him to his lessons on a pillow—how could he understand? My father milked in the morning, then drove a

mail route, then milked again. My mother acted like it was a big imposition to stop folding sheets for a couple of hours. Transportation was hit or miss, especially after Mrs. Sagraves decided I'd passed her up and handed me over to a new teacher. Dr. Leopold lived even farther away. "But the minute I was old enough to drive myself, bang. Life began. I found the scene. Regional competitions, other kids as deep into music as I was. Piano was my whole social life in high school. I didn't date. I competed."

He laughed. "Dating *is* competition."

"Oh, for sure. High school dating especially. Who has the best tits, the best car, who puts out and who doesn't. I was thrilled to find an arena where I had better odds."

I looked at my plate, surprised to see I'd eaten everything on it, including the decorative lettuce. This magic he worked on me, Jesus. Even though I'd vowed this time to talk less and ask him more about himself. The man relaxed my tongue like a drug. I'd convinced myself that couldn't have been real; I'd imagined it. Now I couldn't stand being separated from him by the width of a table. My left hand was idly pressing something into the tabletop without my direct consent. The toccata I played in eighth grade. Literally, *toccata* means "touched." The way you play this dance, I remembered my teacher saying, is to hold that word in mind, hold it in every part of your body.

I slid the toe of my shoe gently between Sigurd's feet, and then, as if it might be accidental—we were both long-legged in that narrow booth—rested my calf against his. His eyes lifted quickly to meet mine, and he clasped my leg between his. The syncopated grin. And there we were. Touched.

Anybody could fall for what he was. Attentive, funny, distractingly handsome. But something else about him was making me own up to myself, after years of trying to be invisible. Only occasionally did I snap out of it to wonder what he was seeing in me. I'd known people to fall under my spell before, but only when I turned myself into rapturous musical performance. Now I was drumming my fingers on a wooden table, very much without my secret weapon. Possibly even running down its value. Did he want to save me? Or recruit me? I waited for him to ask if I'd gone to the orange-flyer meeting, but he didn't. I had to go there myself.

"When you bought me lunch before, were you hoping I'd go to that meeting?"

I saw him thinking about how to answer. “I’m dedicated,” he finally said. “But I don’t have the time or money to bribe people into the movement. It doesn’t work like that.”

“Sorry. I just wanted to know. I did go, but I don’t think I’ll go to another one. Obviously I also went to the thing on the fountain plaza, where I saw you.”

“The South Africa rally.”

“The music? That was amazing. Those African singers. But I should tell you I’m not a joiner. I’m a person who spends her life alone in a room.”

“With your piano.”

“The piano isn’t mine, and the music isn’t either, really. But yeah. It’s what I do.”

“And it doesn’t love you back. You said.”

“I did. Or I’m afraid that it won’t. You’re the first person I’ve ever told.”

I felt his knees grip mine, and he gave me a look that made me feel hugged. “I can see that would be scary. But if you’re looking for permission to leave it, I can’t give you that. It’s your life.”

“I don’t know how to do anything else,” I said. “Or, obviously I do, I can make breakfast or balance a checkbook. But I’m not, like, insanely good at anything else.”

“Most of us aren’t insanely good at anything.” He shrugged, smiling.

“But if you *are*, it feels like there’s a rule that you have to keep doing it. Not just that you owe it to yourself, you owe it to the world. Maybe to God. As payback on the borrowed gift.”

“That’s something to talk to your teachers about it. Or your musician friends? They must have the same doubts.”

“No, they don’t.”

“You’re sure?”

I told him doubts were not allowed in our line of work. Or anyway, not discussed. Our lives were a staircase we climbed, and the only way forward was up. In the early years, I was hyperfocused and weird and never fit in at school, but somehow, in the back of my mind, I thought there was a musical wonderland somewhere. I’d get there, and it would feel great.

“And does it?”

“It comes and it goes. At first, I thought I just needed to learn how to fit in. Here were all these other people living and dying for Brahms and Beethoven. If I had a tribe on earth, this was it. But . . .” I shook myself,

like a dog shuddering off water. “It’s not important. Your turn. Tell me something. All those brothers and sisters that used up the good names. No offense, See-gourd!”

He laughed. They were Catholic, he said. Or his mother was, to the extent of the nine children. His father was an army technician who maintained and repaired air-defense artillery equipment. They’d moved all around, which explained how he sounded. I have a good ear and had learned to sort Midwest from West from moneyed East, and anybody on scholarship. Sigurd was none of those. He said if he had to pick, he was mostly minted in Oklahoma but also New Mexico and Washington state and a stint in Germany when he was too young to remember.

He asked if we were religious. I told him, for me, religion was music. Our church was a little one on the bank of a river where they used to have baptisms but now just had picnics. Cross Creek Methodist, named for the shallow spot in the river where wagons used to cross before there was a bridge. Church was my mother’s social life, but even so, she acted like it was a chore to cross off her to-do list. Same for Dad. Something on *her* to-do list. I’d heard him call it Cross-to-Bear Methodist, but that was my father. He bore crosses.

I didn’t understand where the religion question was leading until he asked point-blank. About the two-kid family that became just me. I tried to offer the shortest possible version of the story: My brother would have been the same age now as Sigurd, but wasn’t, because of a terrible accident when I was eleven and he was seventeen.

“I’m sorry,” he said. “You must miss him.”

“Every day. And also I guess I’m mad at him. If that’s allowed.”

“I think it’s a pretty usual thing to resent the dead. For leaving us.”

“He did that, all right. I got written into an impossible family story without my consent.”

Sigurd asked what was impossible about our story, as opposed to just sad. I had to think about it. “If I look at old family photos of the four of us, it’s hard to see those two kids without seeing the future ghost and the one of us who gets to stay. I was the less beloved, the not-so-valuable girl, but stupid fate picked me. To stick around and shore up the family.”

I had never put it that way before. Now that I’d said it, my complicated family seemed to make sense, the way a Bach fugue does. Themes and responses.

“And you walked out of that story.”

“I keep trying, but it’s quicksand. I grew up, grew out of the family we were, left them with no kids at all, and it feels unforgivable. And required. My mother pushes me away and she’s mad at me for being gone. Both.”

Sigurd did this, drew out confessions like sap from a tree. I didn’t want to go on leaking. I wanted pity to have no place in our attachment, whatever it was. But he asked so kindly, I couldn’t stop myself from telling him the rest of it. That one night, a few months shy of his eighteenth birthday, my brother left the house carrying nothing in his hands or pockets, walked to the tracks a half mile from our house, and stepped in front of a train. There was a noise, an unusual whistle and scream of brakes, that woke me up. But I didn’t think anything of it until later, when two state troopers knocked on our door. Men we knew. One had been Cy’s Cub Scout leader; the other one was often at our school and gave me a Tootsie Pop once when I missed the bus. They sat for the longest time, side by side on our sofa, holding their dented, flat-brimmed trooper hats on their laps, before they told us. It made no sense. We were sure Cy was upstairs asleep in his bed. I didn’t go in the living room; I watched from the door. Then I went up to Cy’s room and lay down on his rumpled bed and didn’t go back downstairs when I heard my parents making awful sounds, my mother crying out, telling the police officers to get out of the house.

“There was no note?” Sigurd asked. “You didn’t see it coming?”

“Nothing, no. The last thing he and I ever talked about was playing the piano. That same day, earlier, he came in my room and said let’s really do it. Secret piano lessons. We’d always played a little when he came to pick me up from my practicing. I’d teach him ‘Chopsticks’ or some dumb thing. But now he was like . . . I can still see the expression on his face. He was *earnest*. He wanted to meet at the church after school every day, or every day we could, and I would really teach him to play. I thought he was joking. I said sure, we can cover by telling our parents we’re at the high school gym playing basketball.”

“Why secret? Was he musical too?”

“He wanted to be. He had a good ear, like me. After I got into piano, he asked if he could take lessons, which my mother said was ridiculous. She said Cy could try out for the high school band if he wanted to do that. Something like drums might be okay for him.”

“Something more masculine.”

“I think that was her meaning, yeah.”

“And instead, he played basketball.”

“No, he didn’t. That’s why I made the joke. He hated the whole idea of basketball.”

Sigurd looked confused. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” I said, even though my throat felt hard and I was preoccupied with a need to swallow, but couldn’t. “He was tall, we both take after my dad that way, so he was already six feet something in ninth grade. This great-looking kid, the type people call a heartbreaker. It was looked on as a *duty* for him to play basketball for Steele County. But he hated PE, hated getting balls thrown at him, wanted absolutely nothing to do with sports. Or breaking hearts, for that matter, he didn’t date.”

“Not at all?”

“Not that I knew about. And he felt like people held it against him, these things they thought he should want to do. Cy told me everybody was judging the book by its cover, but nobody wanted to read the book. He didn’t like anything that felt competitive. He would teach me dumb games like speed and gin rummy, but then he’d let me win, one hundred percent of the time. Maybe because I was so much younger. But you know how people are in the world, right?” I shook my head. “They take advantage, is what they do. That’s a rare thing, to accommodate weakness. That was Cy.”

“The book nobody would read, except you.”

I nodded. “But I made that stupid joke about basketball. Instead of saying, ‘Yes, I will give you real piano lessons.’ And then—” I looked away from our table, at nothing. The empty wooden booth across from us. “Then he was gone.”

“I’m sure it was nothing to do with you,” Sigurd said.

Of course it was. “I don’t think anybody gets to be sure” is all I said.

He stared at me. “How do you get through something like that?”

“Alone, if you do it at all. The world turns its back on you, that’s for sure. Kids at school, obviously. Kids are appalled by death, so you end up feeling *embarrassed*. But it isolated my parents too. Their church friends kept us at arm’s length. Normally, if it had been . . . what do I mean? What’s a normal kid death, a swimming accident, leukemia? Lord, they’d have been organizing casserole hullabaloos. But this was . . . awful. We were a poisoned family. His suicide was something we should have prevented, and now we might spread it.”

I swallowed with intention, stopping whatever else might come out. *How do you get through it?* was not the question I ever asked myself. I wanted to know why I'd *had* to get through it, how he did that to me. Leaving all the broken pieces behind.

Sigurd's green eyes on mine made me feel touched, physically, even before he reached across the table and moved his thumb across my cheek. I hadn't known I was crying. He conjured the check and paid it and pulled me up by the hand and took me out of there. I had no idea where we were going, but he did. He pulled me into the main gate and threaded us between buildings to a tiny, centuries-old cemetery inside the campus grounds. It was a place I knew and visited pretty often to sit and read the tilted gravestones, wondering how these somber dead had managed to hang on to their real estate here, smack in the middle of student life. I'd hidden out here with them, after all manner of insults and missed marks and episodes of hopelessness. The place was walled and deep and quiet, four or five stone steps down below the level of the sidewalks, so the green mossy ground felt out of time. Students were hurrying past us now outside the stone walls, with no idea of us here on the damp ground with our backs against the cool wall. Marveling at how life keeps on growing around the bygone dead, closing them in.

For a quarter of an hour or so, according to the bells that ruled the campus, we were quiet like that. Shoulders touching, knees drawn up in front of us. He held my hand in his, tightly, and I willed myself to stop the tears leaking from my eyes. After what felt like forever, he turned and touched my face again, pushed my hair out of my eyes and tucked it behind my ear.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to talk about this," I told him.

"Don't be," he said. "You have every reason for your feelings."

But I *was* sorry. I didn't want to be sad just then. I'd squandered so much time on grief. Now I was with this lovely man whose eyes kept telling me he found me beautiful, and I wanted nothing in the world but to be kissed. And we were in a cemetery. I smiled, convincingly, I hoped. "You're lucky," I told him. "In a family with all those other kids, maybe any one of them could be considered expendable."

He laughed at that, so openly I could see the flat surfaces of his molars. He had gorgeous, perfect teeth. How could one person have so many beautiful surfaces?

“I like these gravestones,” I told him. “Seriously, I come here a lot. But right at the moment, I’m trying to get my mind off death, and the company’s not really helping.”

He laughed again. “Do you want to go somewhere else?”

“Do you have time before you go to work?”

“Not very much time,” he said. “Where would you like to go?”

“No idea.” I thought about it, then laughed. “That Kinsey museum place, have you ever been in there? They have exhibits about sex through the ages. I’m not kidding you. Somebody told me they have thousand-year-old Chinese paintings of people having intercourse in unworkable positions.”

He looked at me as if were losing my mind. Which I was.

“Or we could stay here,” I said. “Here is good. The audience is discreet.”

He threaded his fingers through my hair at the nape of my neck and pulled me toward him. My whole body shuddered at the slow approach of his kiss, first the roughness of his jaw below my ear, his lips on my neck. Then, finally, his mouth to my mouth, his beautiful teeth pulling with excruciating gentleness on my lower lip. Never in my life had I wanted anything so much. Anybody so much.

Lucky me.

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Prelude III

Wednesday. What in the everloving hell was I supposed to do about this man? *Now* he calls. Not just years but decades after I thought I'd put him away where he couldn't touch me again, maybe even into the ground, for all I'd heard from him. He wasn't well, he'd told me on the phone. Not dying, he was quick to say, but struggling with a diagnosis he didn't go into. A team of doctors at the Vanderbilt hospital thought he might be a candidate for a special treatment. So he'd been thinking, Sigurd said. About me. Since he was going be in the neighborhood.

We're more than three hours' drive from Nashville, I told him. Tennessee is not just one little barnyard, and anyway, how did he find me?

My mother's obituary caught his eye, back in June. Caught it how, exactly, I wondered. He lived in California now. My mother's death was twelve lines in our local *Courier*. I do know what a sticky web the internet can be, how it takes you places you never meant to go, and I'll grant that her name—my name back then, the one he knew me by—is very unusual. But come on. He had to be looking. He had things he wanted to say, he said. Things that felt important. It hit him hard when he saw my name, Livia, listed among the survivors.

I was still trying to breathe through the shock. Yes, I said. I am a survivor. I didn't ask, *What things?* I didn't say, *Too late for it to matter now.* I didn't tell him we could meet, or that we couldn't. Did not say, *I*

have a life, no thanks to you, and you mean nothing at all. Or, *I have been holding my breath for almost thirty years because you were all I ever wanted and then you did what you did*. I only wished him luck with his treatment. He could call me again in a few weeks or months or whatever it would be, when he'd finished up in Nashville. I would let him know.

But I'd misunderstood. This was only a consultation, and he was going back home afterward. If he drove over here to see me, it would have to be the next weekend, Monday at the latest. We settled on his calling again, to give me time to decide. I asked for a week.

Three days of preoccupation since then had gotten me nowhere. Risk boiling over at the sight of him. Risk hearing his confessions, whatever they were, his irresistible attentions. Let him do what he did before, suck the life out of what comfort I have, leaving a dry husk. Or turn my back and try to forget all over again. Too late for that. Just by threatening to come look at me, he left me looking at myself, this life I chose to save. A house built on the sand of thwarted ambitions. Which is overly dramatic—I can see my mother rolling her eyes. Building a life on low expectations was her religion, and maybe it was mine. If I'd settled for pupils with dirty fingernails and a marriage of simple comfort, it was a safe bet I could stick to. I didn't need anybody showing up to test how well my heart has bought into the plan.

I didn't need him here in my head either. Wednesday was meant to be the quiet island in my week, unscheduled until I did evening choir practice with the Presbyterians, then drove over to play for the Baptist service. (Mickie liked to say I was two-timing Jesus, but that was Mickie putting an exciting color of lipstick on a pig.) On all the other weekdays, I had students, but I kept this one for myself, ever since I started teaching. I must have hoped to get back some proficiency after the injury or find out, anyway, what was possible. And when dark weather passed through, I could have a morning with Beethoven's *Pathétique* or Ravel's *Pavane pour une Infante Défunte*, whose title suggests it was written for a dead baby. It hurt to play it, but if I needed to, I did.

Housecleaning and laundry crept into my free day, of course. So did students sometimes, rescheduled after missing a lesson for chicken pox or a track meet or a wedding dress fitting. And now my mother had gotten her hands on my Wednesdays. Since her death in June, I'd spent every one of them in her mausoleum, or else feeling guilty I wasn't. Getting it cleaned up

for sale was pretty urgent, for money reasons, and still yet, here we were in a mouse playground that drove Gaz to the end of his well-tempered wits. Mine also felt pretty far gone this morning as I stared down the hateful shoeboxes. I'd penetrated the bulwark of her bedroom now, and had to keep going. Lining up these boxes, opening their lids. Two were pictures of girls. All dressed up, coiffed, veiled. Brides, or engagement notices, mostly clipped from our local paper. I recognized some classmates. Girls taking vows of honor and obedience. Daughters she wished she'd had.

The rest of the stuff seemed to be the kinds of paperwork a normal person might hang onto. Only not for fifty years. I ran across a credit card application in her name, authorized by my father, required back then evidently. I trashed ancient financial records with a happy heart, but paused over a brittle bundle of letters held together by a rubber band that disintegrated in my hands. I fanned out envelopes, all addressed to my mother. From her mother, who lived in Bristol, just over the Virginia state line. I'd grown up thinking Virginia was a faraway land. Eventually learned it was only two counties away. Granny was widowed young, came to visit us rarely, died when I was in high school. We never went there. These letters might plead or scold. Either way, prickly territory that did not invite me in. I might read them some other day. Or not.

Another surprise stopped me then. Printed programs, a whole box full. Recitals. Gaz lifted his head, registering my distress and trembling hand as I leafed through them. I wasn't just repulsed by the paper laced with silverfish trails. I was shocked. Why did she keep these? How did she *have* them, for a lot of recitals and concerts she didn't even attend? They weren't in any order, except for a thick, stuck-together layer at the bottom that looked truly ancient: school music programs I didn't remember. The others I sure did: mimeographed one-page handouts for Miss Edna's recitals ("Livia Bohusz . . . . Fur Elise by Beethoven") mixed in with playbills for my fanciest performances. The prize of them all, the Knoxville Symphony Orchestra:

> **Edvard Grieg:** Piano Concerto in A Minor, Opus 16. Piano soloist, Livia Bohusz.

I stared, gobsmacked. Gaz's glacier-colored eyes didn't move from my hands, alert to whatever teeth in that box were set to bite me.

"It's okay, Gazzie. Just paper." I fanned out a hand of programs to prove it.

He laid his head down on his forepaws, and I leaned back on mine, trying to make sense of these programs tucked away like treasure. Artifacts of an enterprise that offended her. The lack of order did suggest some turmoil. Not tucked away by year, as keepsakes of my progress. I leafed through again. She didn't *go* to all these recitals. My early Miss Edna productions at the Baptist church, yes, she and my father both, where I labored to prove I wasn't wasting their seven dollars a week. But the Knoxville Symphony Orchestra? Not by a country mile. We'd had the worst fight of our lives over it. The battle that changed my strategy from fight to flight.

It was over a dress. With my mother, who was never, ever happy with the way I looked, and shamed me endlessly toward self-improvement according to her standards. On any big night, when I'd present myself after lengthy, anxious adolescent fussing over my hair and dress, she'd look up and ask, "Isn't it time you started getting ready?"

And for all that, the one time I needed to look perfect, she refused.

It's a pretty thing to picture, mothers and daughters shopping for a special dress. We weren't that picture. I didn't go to a prom, had no prospects or interest. The day Charlie and I got our marriage license, I can't remember what I wore to the courthouse. It didn't occur to us to take pictures. But the spring I turned seventeen, I needed my mother's help to acquire a proper concert dress.

Up to that point, I was always decked out for recitals just decently enough, starting with little-girl church dresses with sashes that tied in back. My look didn't change all that much as my performance arena expanded into regional competitions with sophisticated peers. I knew other girls looked sideways at my dresses and my hair, so weirdly long that I had to be careful not to clamp it under me when I sat on the piano bench. The boys tended to be as socially backward as I was, but they probably had their opinions too. Once, I overheard a tall, acne-pocked boy from Chattanooga refer to me as "the Amish chick," before he swaggered onstage and botched his Rachmaninoff. *Just wait until you hear me* was what I always thought, trusting the rush of competence to flood into my hands along with the passions that blazed through my body, vibrating out through the piano strings, pinning my listeners to the backs of their seats. That's how I pictured it, without looking up from the keys until it was over. But then I would see those faces. I have a satisfying memory of the pimple-faced Chattanooga boy, open-mouthed. Later that day, he asked me for my phone

number, to what end, I couldn't guess and didn't oblige. I had a much bigger love on my hands than any fifteen-year-old boy could hope to breach.

So that's how it was. Clothes were the least of it. I wore whatever best efforts my mother and I could agree on from the Sears girls' department, and as long as I fit into the old recital dress, she saw no need for a new one. One frock might see me through a nice wad of superior ratings before it had to retire. In high school, I was still built like a little girl but too tall for juniors, so we moved up to women's and took in the hips and bustlines on my mother's Singer sewing machine.

And then one spring, for a concerto competition that doubled as an audition for a guest appearance with the Knoxville Symphony, I needed to show up in orchestra attire: long, simple, entirely black. Not something you can buy off the rack at Sears. In the phone book, I found a formal wear shop in Kingsport, and my mother and I drove over there to discover a world of choices. I told the saleslady what I was aiming for, and she gushed that we'd come to the right place; some of her best customers were members of the Symphony. Everything in the store was beautifully made, with good seams and linings, priced in a different stratosphere from anything we'd ever touched. My mother kept asking if they had anything simpler. "For a girl, not a grown woman," she kept saying, as if the store might have something like a child's menu. I seethed, she fussed, and we found nothing for less than a hundred dollars. I told her I would pay for it myself. I'd won some cash prizes, and this competition offered a stipend to the winner who would ultimately perform with the orchestra. My mother objected on principle. I hadn't won yet. I should wait to see if a concert dress for that symphony business was really going to be necessary. "No point buying the uniform till you know you've got the job" was how she put it.

That wasn't an option. The entry form stated clearly, concert dress was required. A lot of my peers had been turning up in formal wear since we all left middle school. I could only imagine their city schools had whole orchestras of kids who owned long black dresses or tuxedoes. These competitions also had entry fees, which would have horrified my mother if she'd known. But the youth-artist organizations sponsoring them had waivers for hardship cases, and Dr. Leopold always got that worked out for me. He'd been pushing me lately to think about trying for a college music

scholarship, which was beyond me to think about. At present, I couldn't even scrounge up regulation wardrobe.

My mother wouldn't budge. She mentioned getting above myself. It all spooled out right next to a rack of satin-striped tuxedo pants, in plain earshot of the salesclerk: My mother had no intention of spending money on a pipe dream. "No good comes from parading yourself around."

"You don't get it," I told her. "I *will need* an orchestra dress because I'm going to win this competition."

Her right hand jerked up reflexively: My confidence and her slap were object and shadow. But I stared fire at that hand, stopping it dead. That meaty hand that found its way to my bleak center every time. With a belt, some days, but somehow worst of all just by itself, that flesh of hers on mine. I kept staring until it fluttered down to her side.

I heard the fluorescent lights over our heads. Then my own breath rushing from the tight drum of my chest. She rolled her eyes toward the saleslady, appealing for sympathy against this stuck-up daughter. My face felt hot with rage, and then embarrassment as I realized people were slinking into the dressing rooms. But I didn't back down. I felt heady and wrong and giddy and nauseated and in spite of all that, I felt right. I *was* right. I could play that Grieg like nobody's business, had practiced until my arms and even my chest muscles were sore. I knew every one of the pianists I would be competing against, including my would-be suitor who'd botched his Rachmaninoff, and not one of them could handle the technical demands of the cadenza the way I could. I planned on winning and taking my place onstage that summer with the Knoxville Symphony Orchestra as their guest youth soloist, and my mother could like it or not, but I was going to do it in a hundred-dollar dress.

And I did. On my own dime. My triumph in the preliminaries, and then onstage with all those exquisitely black-clad adults, heads cocked, bows tilted at the ready as I threw my whole upper body into the falling minor second, falling minor third of the opening motif, was the peak of my seventeen years. My quailing heart and steady hands cast a net over a giant hall and transfixed the audience until they stood on their feet applauding at the end. When the conductor's little daughter came onto the stage with a big bouquet of roses, I laughed and burst into tears at the same time, which made the applause louder. Outside in the parking lot afterward, I had to sit

in the car for half an hour, just me and my roses and pounding heart, before I trusted myself to drive home.

I came back to a dark, sleeping house that night and to school the next day, invisible as ever. Something had grown huge inside me that nobody around me could see. And they wouldn't, ever, not my parents or teachers or classmates. The hurt I felt was disorienting. I was used to solitude, I thought. I could blaze for other people when they showed up, but mostly I blazed alone with my piano in the little church, and that private joy had been my prized possession. Now, suddenly, it wasn't enough. Last night, a great hall of grown men and women had put on neckties and earrings and come together for love of something they craved. I reached across oceans and a century and gave them all of it, a story of lakes and snow-covered mountains and fiery folk dances and languid dreams. It was all of us together, the audience and the orchestra, but at the center of everything, it was me. I'd driven home from that to a different, bleaker loneliness than solitude.

After school, I took the school bus over to Cross Creek Methodist, like always, but instead of practicing in the empty church that day, I made myself into a person: somebody alive and noisy and visible, with or without any eyes or ears on me. I pounded out all the happiest pieces I knew, one after another, as loud as my hands could make them. Because happiness is there for the taking, and so is grief, tenderness, hope, the wonder of lakes and mountains. Reach into that bottomless music box and pull out whatever medicine your day is wanting. The composers have written scripts for every need. Mozart's "Rondo alla Turca" I played five times in a row for the flat-out joy of it. The Turkish march is all up and up, with its octave-wide, wobbly marches up the scales like a toddler pretending to be a king, and the laughing, trilled B-flat at the top, every single time. How could you hear that and not be happy? Mozart and me. We had a party all to ourselves.

After that fight in the dress store, my mother never hit me again. It changed something in her, and changed me too. For as long as I could remember, I'd been carrying around a freight of anger and obligation, with no idea where to put it down. I carried it into my performance with the Knoxville Symphony. To that applause, those roses. Afterward, during my ecstatic celebration in an empty church that made me feel real to myself, I felt anger and duty unraveling one from the other. I held onto the fire, let go

of the sticky strings of guilt. That week, I started making plans to audition for a college scholarship. I could leave her without looking back.

Everything else I'd ever worn in my youth was probably still in this house, if it existed at all, compressed in some closet. But not that beautiful long black cloak of outrage. I took it with me when I went, and racked up plenty more accolades in it before I was forced to agree with my mother, that wanting too much is a deadly choice, nobody loves a girl like that, and I left the dress behind.

A noise startled us: the back kitchen door opening. It always stuck in the summer damp, and you had to push so hard, it would fly back against the wall with a bang. I tucked away the Knoxville Symphony program. Gaz listened without getting up, knowing the intruder by sound. Somebody familiar, then. I brushed a dusting of disintegrated paper off my lap, steadied my shaky hands and heart. Steady hands used to be my pride. Which is what goes before the fall.

"Livvie? I brought you some lunch."

"Charlie?"

I got up and straightened my mother's dress. I'd taken this light blue summer housecoat as a habit. I could hear now that it was Charlie, the particular thump of his walk and the vigorous way he moved things around. I came into the kitchen and found him picking up a bundle of age-browned packets, clearing off a table. He'd used the same basket I always did to bring lunch to him out in the field when he was trying to get ahead of a rainstorm with the mowing or bush-hogging and didn't want to come in. He was like so many other farmers, men who worked themselves to the bone and thought it was nothing exceptional.

He set the envelopes on a chair and straightened the pile so it wouldn't topple over. Gave them another look. "What are these things?"

"Simplicity patterns. Like a blueprint, for a dress or something you sew."

The one on top pictured a child modeling three variations on the pattern's theme: shirtwaist, pinafore, overalls. The model looked like a ten-year-old Marilyn Monroe. It struck me as funny. My mother would have hated this poised, stagy child, with her haughty chin and turned-out toes.

Charlie looked at me, surprised. "Did she sew your all's clothes?"

"Not that I remember. Maybe when we were little?"

“How about this one?” Smirking, he held up a pattern as sexy as these cartoonish things could be: a woman in a sleek formal gown cut very high up one leg. Heels, updo, décolletage.

“How that came to be in my mother’s possession, I can’t tell you. I agree, it doesn’t seem like something she’d have put herself to making. But there you go.”

“If she made them . . .”

“Yeah. I’ll find them here eventually.”

“Can’t you just throw stuff like that away?”

“These patterns? I was going to. But I looked them up online, just in case, and found out some of the really old ones are a gold mine.”

“Shouldn’t have looked,” he said, giving me a sympathetic grimace as he set out things on the table, a thermos of sweet tea and meatloaf sandwiches wrapped in paper napkins. I’d made the tea this morning to send out with him to the field, the meatloaf last night. It was dear of him to do this, come over here to feed me. He hadn’t done it before.

“I know, I shouldn’t, but it’s hard not to be curious,” I said. “Same with the records. Mostly just junk, but some of them are worth a mint if you can find the buyer.”

“She’s got records?”

“Lord, yes. Stacks and stacks, mostly singers but *all* the singers. Elvis, Tennessee Ernie Ford, opera.”

“Did she play those? I can’t feature it.”

“Never. She just bought them. I remember being at Sears and Kmart, and she’d kind of sneak over to that section, slide a couple of records into the cart underneath the vacuum cleaner bags. Then here at the house she’d put them away somewhere, voices locked up in their jackets. She didn’t want us touching them either.” I had an awful flash of her battering Cy on his head and shoulders, big as he was then. Seventh or eighth grade. She’d found him with a pile of her records unsleeved around him on the floor.

“Well, I don’t know who’d want them now.”

I sat down at the table, slipped off my shoes, and tucked my bare feet under the soft cushion of dog on the floor. “You’d be surprised. It’s a big thing now, people getting old record players fixed up and paying good money for vinyl records. It’s kids mostly.”

“What for? They’ve got music in their darn phones.”

“To be different, I guess. That’s the hardest part of this. Sorting out what’s vintage and what’s just old.”

“Us,” he said, smiling. “You and me, we’re just old.” He sat down across from me, taking off his cap to run a hand over his short, damp hair. Nothing about his looks really agreed with what he’d just said. The crow’s feet when he smiled, yes. Also the way he refused to curse, while the world fell to swearing at the drop of a hat. Charlie had ways about him that made him *seem* old. But he was so full of energy, some part of him always vibrated—a knee under the table, a thumb tapping the table. It was up to me to see he didn’t overwork himself on a day like this.

“Hot out there?”

“Yes, ma’am. A scorcher.”

“How’s the baling going?”

“We might not get it all in the barn today, but we’ll get the worst of it.”

“Did James come over to help?”

“He did. Brought Ethan and two of his buddies. Those kids are full of vinegar, throwing bales like it’s a contest.”

“Shouldn’t they be in school? They started back last week.”

“James gave them leave to lay out today. Family emergency.”

“Mickie will have his hide for that. Both of your hides.”

Charlie chewed his sandwich, grinned. “Don’t I know it.”

“Well, you didn’t need to break up the party just to come over here and see to me.”

“I didn’t. Baler broke down. Pickup reel and twine cutter both went out this time. James went over to get his tools. But his trailer’s on a job site way up at Jackstown, so it’ll be a while.”

“Gosh. How many times can one baler break down?”

“As many times as we can fix it, I reckon.” He polished off the last of his sandwich before I’d even finished my first half. Wiped his hands on the napkin, ran his eyes around the ceiling behind my head. We were finding some leaks as my labors revealed parts of the house that hadn’t seen daylight since the ’90s. “Seems like a waste to overhaul that piece of junk again, but I’ve got no choice. Maybe I’ll look at a new one after this house gets sold.”

“Sorry. I’m doing my best here.”

“I know you are, hon. I hate this for you. Oh, did Mom call you?”

“No, why?”

“I saw she called three times while I was mowing. Can’t hear a blooming thing on the tractor.”

“Well, don’t worry. She’d call me if it was something serious.” Faye was as much a mother to me as to Charlie. I worried about her becoming a little untethered since her husband took his fall. Two broken hips seemed like excessive punishment. “We should drive over to Garden Hill to see Teddy. Maybe on the weekend?”

“Maybe.” Charlie hated the facility, hated seeing his father helpless. He looked up at me, seeming to notice my strange getup for the first time. “Nice dress there. Or what is that, a housecoat? One of hers?”

I nodded, and it rashly crossed my mind to mention what was underneath it—cotton nightgown, no underwear. For Charlie, that would just be information. We had our sex life, or did at one time, but had never been playful about it, even in the beginning. It was a matter of comfort, for both of us, I think. Like putting a heating pad on an aching muscle. We did not kiss, or hold hands in public, or anything like that. I was surprised to learn that some of my young piano students thought we were brother and sister.

He clasped his hands behind his head and leaned back in the wooden chair, which made a series of cracking sounds. Sprawled his long legs into the small cleared area beside the table.

“You okay?” I asked.

Only his eyes moved, but they jumped over to mine, surprised. “Sure. Why?”

“No reason. Long, hot day. What time did you all start?”

“I left the house right after you did. Around four thirty. I had to move the cattle and get all the equipment set before James and them came over.”

I was surprised he knew when I’d left. I thought I’d been slipping around pretty invisibly, but I might have been wrong. A man would need to be blind not to notice a wife as distracted as I’d been. Sleepless, fretful. I looked at the floor. And noticed his feet.

“Oh, Charlie. Don’t tell me you’ve been putting up hay in one of your good shoes.”

He looked down and shook his head, smiling at his unmatched feet: black leather shoe on the left, Red Wing boot on the right. He almost never changed the shoe on his prosthesis. It wore his work boot, day in, day out, and he always strapped them on as a unit: leg, foot, shoe. But I’d asked him take off both boots the previous evening and wear his good shoes around

the house. He'd been mucking the barn. I told him I would clean those boots for him, and if I'd done that, I'd have thought to put the left one back on his plastic-and-metal foot after he went to bed. But I forgot. And he wouldn't have seen the mismatched shoe when he strapped on his leg in the early morning dark.

If Charlie had grown up wearing a prosthesis, he might have learned to treat it more as a body part than an article of clothing. But he hadn't. All through childhood, I'd known him as the boy on crutches, next farm over from ours, two years ahead of me in school. The boy with one pants leg pinned closed at the bottom, in lieu of the foot he lost at age six when his grandmother backed over him with the riding mower. Everybody knew the story. High summer, big yard, a big chore for an older lady. Charlie was bringing out a Coca-Cola for his mammaw, as his mother had asked him to. Over the noise of the mower, she hadn't heard his little voice calling her.

He had no memory of the accident. He swore to that, and it makes sense, given the blood loss. He passed out right away and didn't wake up for more than a day. We should all sleep through our traumas, if that's how the shadow of tragedy bypassed this family, because it did seem that way. Charlie Cable was still and always a cheerful boy from a cheerful family, neither tormented or especially pitied in school as far as I'd seen, even as he sat out phys ed and sports and cars, all things that distinguished boys as valuable in our county. He was athletic in his own way—I had a particular memory of walking up the stairs behind him at school, noticing how he easily swung his crutches and lifted his whole body using his arms and shoulders. But no classmate would think to admire that special talent, any more than they were impressed by mine. I was mostly famous for having a dead brother. Charlie and I both nurtured our private gifts without complaint or expectation of praise. It was the opposite; we trusted invisibility, even as we moved meek and sexless into the showy circus of adolescence. Probably that's what brought us together so quickly, when the time came. The thirteen-year-old self is indelible.

Nowadays, to hear the TV and magazines tell it, an amputation that far below the knee needn't stand in the way of anything, driving race cars or running marathons or even climbing Mount Everest. But Charlie grew up with no idea he could be active and vigorous with the help of a good prosthesis. Maybe the technology has improved with the years and become more available, but in any event, the Cables didn't know of the possibility.

They weren’t told by our country doctors and rural hospital, or maybe ruled it out for financial reasons. Farmers, then or now, aren’t often able to afford insurance for their families, only for their barns and equipment. I know this from my father’s illness. The prospect of an artificial limb was never discussed with Charlie.

So I was as surprised as could be, coming back home after my disastrous failure at college, to see the one-legged neighbor boy walking around on two feet, as fit as any other young man. More so, in fact. He showed up eagerly for every haying and fence pulling and tobacco hanging in the neighborhood. He was a great help to my father when he fell ill, and that was fateful for us. It wasn’t just us either; he made himself useful everywhere he could, making up for lost time. The change happened in the three years I was away, prompted by a younger doctor who helped Charlie navigate the fittings and physical therapy that got him up and running. I arrived just in time to see the miraculous aftermath, which proved to be durable. Charlie still greeted every morning with fresh amazement at all the work he was going to be able to do.

He’d be eager to get back to work now, I knew, but was making himself stay with me for some reason. I hated that I’d been avoiding him since Sigurd’s call, afraid of letting him share any space with my sick preoccupations. Right now, his eyes kept going to something behind me. I turned around. The tops of the washer and dryer were covered with small household appliances, which I’d put there. I’d fairly well cleared this kitchen area and was using it to sort and stage goods for their various exits.

“What?” I asked.

“Is that our weather radio?”

An odd little thing, a radio with its own power source and satellite connection for scanning weather channels. Good to have in emergencies, my mother must have thought. She’d given us one for Christmas, years back. “That’s hers,” I said. “Ours is at home in the closet.”

“But, okay, is that not also our toaster? The one she gave us?”

“Ours is at home,” I told him. “And yes, that air fryer thing is exactly like the one she gave us last year. I’m thinking I’ll give it to one of my students as a wedding present. Edwina Moretown, you remember her.”

My mother clearly had no use for her air fryer either. It was still in the box, as were the weather radio and the toaster and all the rest. Charlie looked flummoxed.

“That’s just the appliances. Those big, soft bathrobes she gave us that time that you didn’t like? I found their twins in a closet here. Likewise the baby dolls and Lego sets and plastic dinosaurs she bought for the Christmas charity drive at her church.”

“How’d they end up back here?”

“No, the toys all went to the kids.”

“And she kept one of everything for herself?”

“Always. Every gift she gave. She’d buy two and keep one.”

“You’re kidding.”

“I never told you that? Ethan and Betts made it into a game, collecting up all the duplicate Christmas and birthday presents they recognize from our houses. The good thing is, it’s all in great shape to sell. None of it ever came out of the box.”

“Why would she *do* that?” Poor Charlie. He tried so hard to make it reasonable.

I gestured at the room, the dusty windows, the society of mice. “Why would she do *this*?”

“You’ve read those books about the . . .” His eyes darted away. After all this time, Charlie could still be bashful with me. “About people that like to collect.”

Mental illness is a hard thing to accept among people who were simply raised to work our way through our problems. Unmanageable problems mean you must not have worked hard enough. I’d been inclined, for so long, to see her hoarding as something crueler and more deliberate than a disease. Charlie was inclined the other way; he tried hard to see it as benign. Love thy neighbor, peculiarities and all. He didn’t have to grow up inside its chaos.

I crossed my arms. “You want my theory? She couldn’t stand to part with *anything*. Not even a gift she bought for a *child*, Charlie. Once the talking baby doll came in the house, she couldn’t let it leave. So she bought two of everything, as a way of still getting to keep it.”

I finished the last of my sandwich, folded the paper napkin in half, half again, then a triangle, like the flag they give dead soldiers. Charlie looked uncomfortable.

“Maybe it was the giving part she wanted to keep,” he said.

“How do you mean?”

“That feeling you get when you find something you want to give somebody. Thinking how it’s going to make them happy. What if she was trying to keep that?”

I had to smile. “Maybe.”

That was Charlie, believing she was holding onto her charities, where I saw only a failure of generosity. It was not the kind of conversation we ever went into, or needed to have, but right then, I wished we could: *We all accumulate*, I’d like to have told Charlie, and have him understand what I meant. That we hoard our wishes and our losses, hang onto them for dear life, even if it feels like it’s going to kill us. Even if it actually does.

I sat still while a train passed by, listening. I never could break the habit. Norfolk Southern. Which meant it was about ten minutes past noon.

I stood up and started putting things away in the basket. “You can leave all this here,” I told him. “I’ll take it back to the house. You need to go make hay.”

I truly did know my husband’s worth and goodness, the generosity of his spirit that would have to be called grace. I knew it was wrong for a person to want more than life gives them. Good people know this. I’d been settled on it forever, I thought.

The first time I saw Sigurd across the grass on that spring day, why did I think I recognized him? It’s impossible now to look back on our beginning without also seeing our end, and all the ruin I could have avoided. I’ve wondered if I was seeing the outlines of my own impending failure. Shouldn’t we know that when we see it, if we’ve been warned all our lives against some particular devil or weakness, whatever you want to call it? The vain and reckless craving that comes along when you already have what you need?

But what if *need* is a business that can never really settle itself? What if we can’t bar our doors against it because the beast is already inside the house? I know now what I didn’t know then: The treachery is the body. These sweet, soft creatures we call ourselves will not always answer to us, however we may think we can scold or train or coddle the flesh like a pet. The body is a wild, hungry animal hiding under the skin.

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Sarabande

We didn't make love in the cemetery. It's shocking enough that we did what we did on the moss between the gravestones, making out in the broad daylight with academic fuss carrying on around us. Shocking how *much* we did, what two people can manage while keeping all their clothes on, and a miracle of discipline that we stopped ourselves in time for him to go to work. Discipline, we knew. For both of us, it was something like our religion.

He told me he was about to go onto a new schedule. A change in the shop's workload was moving him to day shift, so he'd have evenings off. Could he see me tomorrow night?

With the last full measure of devotion to my pre-Sigurd life, I told him no, he couldn't. For the next week, I would be in a practice room for all the hours this rotating planet could give me. I told him I was working on the hardest piece I'd ever played, for the most important jury of my life. Then I had to explain what a jury was: an exam you take on a piano bench, performing.

"Why call that a jury? It sounds like you might go to *jail*," he said. His eyes still looked dilated from the intensity of our making out.

"It feels like that," I said. "You're sitting in front of music faculty judges and a jury of your peers, and your life is in the balance. I don't just get a grade for this performance, it's also about recommendations for musical

jobs I'll apply for in the future. And I'm not where I need to be with this piece yet. Do you know what muscle memory is?"

He had both my hands in his, looking at them as he stroked them. "I think so. Doing something until your body knows what to do without your brain having to think it out."

"Yep." I extracted one hand so I could pick bits of clover out of the dark thunderclouds of his hair. "There are hundreds of thousands of notes in this piece, and I have to memorize them with my brain, and then with my hands, and it has to be flawless. This piece is really, really hard. The composer that wrote it couldn't even play it himself."

Sigurd laughed. "Why would he do that?"

"To ruin my life."

He gently took my hand back from his hair and kissed it, and I didn't tell him I'd done this to myself, taking on a near-impossible piece to distract myself when I'd thought I was never going to see him again. I deeply regretted that now, but it was too late to change course.

"Can I go give that composer a piece of my mind?"

"Nope, he's quite dead. But this you'll love, he had a worse name than yours. *Maurice.*"

He thumped his chest. "Anybody would put their money on Sigurd in that fight."

"I wouldn't get too cocky. He was pretty hot, Maurice Ravel. This piece I'm playing, *Gaspard de la Nuit,* supposedly caused ladies in the audience to faint."

"You said he couldn't play it."

"Other people did. Only a few in the whole world, then or ever. And I'm trying to be one of them."

"You're amazing," he said, looking at me differently, rubbing his knuckle on one of my cheeks, then the other. "What's it called again?"

"*Gaspard de la Nuit,*" I said, self-conscious about the French words sounding snobbish. But he repeated them as best he could, several times.

"What does that mean in English?"

"'Spirit of the Night' is the way it's translated. It's based on a poem about this spirit creature that watches over treasures. But 'Treasure Keeper of the Night' sounds dumb."

He gently pushed my shoulders back into the moss and kissed me again. "It's keeping my treasure from me," he said, his mouth so close to my ear

that he barely whispered. “I want you tonight. And tomorrow night. All the nights I can think about.”

Oh, this, I thought, inhaling the scent of tobacco and moss and clean, damp granite, my body inhaling his body, believing whatever it wanted to tell me, taking in its nourishment. *This is what it feels like to be happy.*

The music annex where I practiced was an odd building shaped like a fat silo, with circular halls on each floor. All the way around each hallway, twenty-some doors opened into practice rooms, each one just big enough for a piano. If you weren’t used to the life of music, you might see it as several stories of weirdly furnished prison cells. I loved it. So many pianos in one place, my Lord. More than I’d touched in my lifetime of playing. I found this temple of practice rooms the day I arrived on campus, and I walked around its white-tiled hall, listening at every door, trying to peep into each little square window (mostly they’d been covered from the inside with sheets of paper) until I came back around to the first one. And that was just the first floor! So many pianists in so many rooms, like chambers of a giant heart. This was the luckiest strike of my life. A modest fee per semester gave me leave to play any of these pianos, so long as I reserved it in advance. I immediately signed up for every different piano on the first floor, one hour at a time, then moved on to the second, approaching this candy store in a businesslike manner until I found all my favorites.

I fell hard for one very old Steinway in particular, and then its blond first cousin, also old. (The best Steinways were built before 1940, I learned.) The former made me feel like I was playing in a forest, breathing pure oxygen. The blond had springier action and a resonant tone that gave me chills. From the sign-up sheets on their doors, I learned the names of other pianists who favored my pets, and I was jealous. I learned the exact time when the new dockets would be posted, and hung around trying to get my name on as many hour-long slots as I was allowed.

I knew I was the interloper, horning in on senior players who already had relationships with these instruments. But I was determined to be a new Livia here, with a muted accent and the confidence to claim something remarkable for myself. I would lead with my strengths, speaking up when I knew the answers, trying my hardest to let the whistle pull the train. That

was the plan, anyway. I succeeded mostly in this one place, hogging the good practice rooms.

It never stopped feeling like a miracle, sinking my hands into some of the best pianos ever built, after ten years of practicing on the Kohler & Campbell spinet at Cross Creek Methodist where the pastor had given me a key. I'd always had to make the jarring leap from that wet-noodle spinet to the firm action of Steinways and Yamahas in the auditoriums where I performed in competitions. The difference isn't just tonal; it's physical, like training for a weight lifting contest with throw pillows, then showing up to be handed barbells. In front of an audience. The shock always rattled me. I tried to prepare for the deeper resistance with all kinds of handicaps to build force: practicing in rubber gloves, in cotton gloves, deliberately practicing much too loudly, filling that empty little sanctuary with mezzo fortes and vibrating fortissimos in a piece whose dynamic markings directed me to be quiet. No easy trick for a girl like me.

In my music-school years, I had a running hum in my head that was hard to stop: *I will never deserve this place.* Only while I was practicing did that noise go quiet. I embraced the heaven of life inside those little rooms, with muffled arpeggios coming through the perforated acoustic-tile walls on either side, the more distant sound of a soprano somewhere coursing through *mee-mee-mee*s up and down her range. Once I got inside my own music, I tuned out the rest, but not really. In some way, I depended on this ambiance of beloved sound, like the crickets on a summer night that wrap you in a tonal blanket as you fall asleep, telling you where you are and who you are. A country girl. A pianist. A little room built for just one person and a piano? My ideal habitat. Sometimes I had to share with vocalists and instrumentalists, usually one at a time, when I worked as an accompanist. But that was for pay. On my own time, I couldn't have stood to share a practice room. Or so I'd have thought.

I'd told Sigurd I couldn't see him until Saturday night. It was a Tuesday when we fell into each other's arms in the cemetery, Saturday was an eternity away. It almost broke me to see him disappointed. But I wouldn't be able to relax with him until I'd solidly worked out the "Ondine." I had the "Scarbo" movement well in hand now, running on the batteries of sheer terror. I was stupidly ambitious to choose this piece. Dr. Betis hadn't said so; he just made a little cough and tapped his fingers twice on the fallboard and said, "Right. A stimulating choice." After three years, he'd finally

stopped hearing *Kohler & Campbell spinet* in my accent, taking note of my articulation and expressiveness instead. I surprised him regularly, and by some measures might have surpassed him. He'd never undertake *Gaspard de la Nuit* himself, and we both knew it.

Unfortunately, while obsessively practicing the third movement and taking good measure of the second, I'd neglected the first. And misjudged it. Now it was the "Ondine" movement keeping me awake at night, with all its shimmering thirty-second notes. My hands refused to even them out, I always leaned too hard one way, then the other. I fell apart on the impossible bar-twenty-two scalar run, every damn time. I trudged through the left-hand melody instead of making it float on a cloud of legato above the quavers. I was marching toward humiliation. To choose a piece like that for a jury and then blow it to shreds? That would be judged more harshly than punching below my weight with some unchallenging Mozart or Satie. Nobody likes hubris, I guess, but it's the particular duty of God and academic professors to strike it down. The respect I'd eked out of Dr. Betis through thousands of hours of practice could be shattered in one sitting. I'd put myself in this trap and meant to work my way out of it before I could go to Sigurd without feeling tangled up in guilt. If I'd betrayed Jon Link, who was leaving in another week and already felt gone, I didn't let that thought into my head. I opened the house of my conscience only to the specter of Dr. Betis, giving him full run of the place. Dr. Betis and Maurice Ravel.

Somewhere near midnight on Friday, I was into my third hour on my second favorite piano on the first floor, after using up all the hours I was allowed on other favorites. My upper arms were getting numb, and I couldn't feel any part of my back below my shoulder blades, but I wasn't thinking about that. "Ondine" and I had finally stopped wrestling and were merging into one creature. Over and over, I'd practiced the 1–2–3 groupings of the trembling opening phrases; over and over, I ran through the arpeggios of the middle melody in staccato to make the notes into droplets of water misting into moonlight, throwing rainbows. I was the keeper of treasures of the night, so lost to the present that I only vaguely registered a sound behind me. Then understood someone had come into the room, clicked the door closed.

“Sigurd!” My heart almost stopped along with my playing. His grin looked criminal.

“Am I allowed to be in here?”

“I guess, okay.” Seeing Sigurd here was like being startled out of a dream and still in the dream. “If we have a good reason. If I were your accompanist. Or I’m tutoring you.”

He slid onto the bench beside me. “Tutor me.”

“Okay,” I said, laughing. Nervous. “Let’s have a look. Ondine is a water spirit, a mermaid we’ll say. This piece is a musical impression of water, the sensuality and flow and all that. So first of all, in this opening bar, you’ll want to practice these groupings until they’re just flowing out of your hands.” I demonstrated the first few shimmering bars of the opening. “The hard part is to get out of the rhythmic pattern so you’re not even suggesting notes or chords, just a vague sense of floating sounds. Got that?”

He nodded. “Absolutely.”

“I’m not sure you do. This is not typesetting, good sir. You have to isolate the muscle groups to make the different voices work independently.” I reached across him—he was on my right side—to lift his right hand to the keys. His left hand was on my thigh, sliding between my legs. “You want your arm position high so your hand can rotate loosely from side to side. It took me a while to figure out this solution. The magic trick is to rotate your hand, pivoting around the middle figure. Like this.” I wobbled his hand side to side, then demonstrated it myself, with perfect control. “The rotation makes it sound relaxed. The whole point here is to avoid tension.”

“Is it?” His voice, his eyes, everything about him, his thin chambray shirt rolled back from his beautiful forearms, his perfect hands. I wanted it all for my own.

“Yes.” I dropped my hands onto my lap. “How did you even find me here?”

“By listening at the door of every practice room until I heard your piece. *Gaspard de la Nuit*.” His French was so un-French, the way people back home would say it. The way I would have, prior to my trials by fire, French I and II, and Dr. Betis. *Gaspared della nuite*. I adored it.

“A week ago, you’d never heard of it. Now you can pick it out of a lineup?”

“They have a music library here. I bet you knew that already. You can check out a record and go in a little booth with headphones and listen to it

until you know it by heart."

If he'd really done that, I was smitten beyond the pale. I sure hadn't seen him in there on my work-study shift, though. Also, there was another possibility. "My name's on that door," I pointed out. "Four times on four lines, where I signed into the last four hours in this room."

"Really?" He got up from the bench, stepped outside to look at the door. "So it is."

I didn't know if he was teasing or not. He clicked the door closed and came back to the bench, and we kissed for at least a minute before he pulled away. "You need to work."

"I do. Also, if somebody outside that door hears it's quiet in here, they'll think this piano is free. They'll come in to grab it."

"There are lots of other choices out there, believe me."

"Yeah, but we all like this one especially."

He looked at the piano, assessing its special charms. Then he looked at me, ran a finger down the side of my face. "And I like this one especially. Okay if I stay awhile?"

"Sure. But you have to let me keep playing."

"I want to watch you."

I started the "Ondine" from the top, feeling jittery. Not the ordinary nerves I'd learned to manage, but the pressure of giving something new to him. I wanted him to love it. To love me doing it. I'd spent the whole day working out hard phrases one at a time, breaking the murderous run into units of nine, nine, and eight, isolating sections of the melody, repeating each phrase dozens or hundreds of times. But that would be tedious for him. And it was high time for me to be putting the whole piece together, finding the music inside the notes and pulling it out of my heart, like those magicians pulling long strings of silk scarves from their sleeves. I wanted to make that magic for Sigurd. He sat perfectly still beside me, watching my hands.

"Can you keep telling me what you're doing? Explaining it? Or is that too distracting?"

"I don't know. I'll try." I've never had the knack for music and words both at once. I can't even sing hymns or Christmas carols while I play, though lots of people can, easily. I did my best. "The point . . . here . . ." I said, pulsing my offset hands through the asymmetric triplets of the opening tremolando, "is for it to feel . . . relaxed. Drifty. Not just a bunch of notes."

I was starting to settle in. “You want it to sound like it’s making itself up as it goes along.”

He got up and stood against the wall, taking me in. I wanted this. Wanted to bewitch him, as I’d done so many times before with so many people who didn’t matter to me at all when the recital was over. This one mattered. I resented the few feet of space between us. Then, as if he could feel my wanting, he quietly moved around behind me. I felt his hands resting lightly on my bare shoulders. Watching my hands from above. Amazed, maybe. I wanted to feel equal to his maturity, in possession of knowledge that was beyond him. Not just some girl.

“Here,” I pointed out, “where you bring in the melody with the left hand, it needs to float. You don’t exactly press down on the keys, you lift out of them. Like this. You stroke them.”

He was stroking my shoulders lightly, a perfect legato. Quick study. As I kept playing, I felt his hands edge forward, hovering so close above my skin, I could feel their soft graze against the little invisible hairs. All the numb parts of my body woke up. As I moved, his hands moved, following the slow rocking of my torso as I articulated the musical phrases. I felt naked under his hands. And nearly was, to tell the truth. I usually played without shoes, but we were having a May heat wave, so I wasn’t wearing much else either. A white cotton sundress, underpants, sandals I’d left just inside the door. I’d started the day with a cardigan, but dumped it with my music bag against the wall. These rooms could get really warm. I felt his hands slide under the wide neckline of my dress. My Ondine came out of the water.

“Do you need me to go?” he whispered.

“I need you *not* to go,” I whispered back.

I put my hands back on the keys, kept pushing forward, and, in short sentences that I hoped didn’t sound like gasps, tried to tell Sigurd the story behind this piece. It was inspired by a poem by Aloysius Bertrand about a water nymph who sings a beautiful song to seduce a man.

“She’s splashing . . . droplets of water against his . . . window. In the moonlight. You can hear the water, right?”

He said he could. I realized it must be dark outside. I’d been inside this windowless, timeless world all day. It seemed impossible that it was almost midnight. People were in bed.

“She’s trying to lure him into the lake. To live there with her forever.”

“You’re doing a lot of work with your feet too,” he said, as if he’d just noticed.

I told him playing the piano engages just about every muscle in the body. He moved away to stand with his back to the wall again, and my shoulders were very sorry to see him go. But the bewitching was underway. Out of the corner of my eye I could see him slowly melting, his back sliding down the wall until he was sitting on the floor, hands clasped in front of his knees, watching. I kept my focus and tried not to smile.

In another minute he moved closer to my bare feet under the keyboard, I suppose watching me kneading the sustain pedal on the right, dipping on and off of the una corda on the left. I felt the lightest of touches, almost reverent, on my ankle, then the top of my foot. Then nearly lost control of my pedal coordination as his fingers ran lightly from my ankle to my knee.

“None of this can be rushed,” I told him. “It needs to seem ethereal, and immortal. Like we have all the time in the world.”

I felt his lips meet the inside of my left knee. I let my legs spread apart, abandoning the una corda. I wasn’t positive they’d invented that pedal in Ravel’s time, anyway.

“Ravel was inspired by the poem’s eroticism,” I said, trying to control the thrill and panic that were running all over my body. “This is such a sexy piece. There’s general agreement on that. It has these wonderful moments of impulse that bubble up out of the texture. Quiet but intense. These waterfall climaxes.” I was having trouble breathing.

His lips left my skin. “Does that door lock?”

“That door does not lock. If it goes quiet in here, somebody wanting this piano will assume I’ve left for the night, and they’ll come in.”

“But if it’s not quiet?”

“As long as I keep playing, nobody will touch that door. That’s the law of this land.”

“Then you’ll have to keep playing,” his lips murmured against my skin.

I kept playing.

The lyrical melody in the “Ondine”—a falling third, rising back up in a melodic minor triad, then repeating the first two notes—I’ve always heard as Ondine’s voice, pleading: *See me, I know you see me.* She repeats her plaintive song, modulating from F-sharp minor to G-sharp major and on from there, getting more and more desperate. *Love me, why can’t you love me?*

His ease with my body would have taken my breath away, if I'd had any left to be taken. I played with my eyes closed, seeing colors and lights behind my eyelids. Sigurd paused in his explorations only one more time, to ask: "Does she succeed? In luring him into the lake?"

"Well, there's a problem. He already has a wife. When he tells her that, she cries a little, and then she laughs, and throws water against his window and dissolves back into the lake. If you stay, you'll get to hear the whole thing."

He stayed. No contest I've ever entered was harder to finish, but I kept my hands on the keys, even as my feet left both pedals entirely and my lower back arched and my head swam and I wanted to cry out and laugh and throw water on all the windows. Nobody else had ever explored me this way, finding this well of urgent want I didn't quite know about myself. Jon Link and I were self-taught, so we did what Adam and Eve would have done, I suppose, or touched one another efficiently like the good musicians we were, following standard key signatures and rhythms. Sigurd went outside the boundaries, holding back to make me want more, making me sigh and look up at the perforated-tile ceiling, making me lose my place completely. The "Ondine" is only supposed to be seven minutes long, but I must have started it over a dozen times. Surely at that hour nobody was listening outside the door to hear my outrageous rendition. Or the waterfall of my climax.

I showed up, barely, for what was left of the semester. My jury earned something close to a smile from Dr. Betis and praise all around for my unusually passionate interpretation of *Gaspard de la Nuit*. Jon Link packed his concert tuxedo and seven cases of instruments, left me instructions for how to pay the utility and phone bills while he was away, and we said goodbye with kisses on the cheek that felt forced and foolish. Without knowing any reason, he clearly understood I had regressed from girlfriend back to roommate. Our attachment had been the most important one in my adult life, and I let go of it now with no more care than you'd give an empty milk carton. I tried not to think very much about what kind of person would do that. One who trusted nothing as permanent, is all I can say. Not love or loyalty, not a mother's touch or a brother who makes a promise and then walks away to annihilate himself. I trusted myself alone, and the one thing I

was good at, mastering the hardest piano compositions ever written, outshining the competition, following the only safe path I knew. Jon Link and I were like friendly hikers who'd encountered each other along that trail and decided to keep company. Maybe I was looking to step off that path the day I met Sigurd. Or maybe I was blown off my feet one minute after, by a tempest I was defenseless to resist.

The lovemaking that started in a sweltering practice room was completed that same night in Sigurd's apartment. I have almost no memory of walking from one place to the other, in such a fever I forgot my music bag and sweater and had to go collect them the next day. I recall Sigurd carrying me part of the way to his car, because we'd also left my shoes behind and the street in front of the fraternity houses was sparkling with broken glass. Even before Jon Link was gone from our apartment, I'd spent that first torrid night in Sigurd's and, truth be told, several more.

His place was barely more than a bed. One tiny bedroom and sitting room–kitchen in a drab pea green apartment block on the northeast edge of town. It was far enough from campus that the rent was reasonable and the nightlife dull enough for families. I noticed strollers and toys parked on the long second-floor balcony, and tried to imagine the neighbors. Married people with sensible lives, waitresses and janitors and cashiers. Typesetters and revolutionaries.

I spent more time there after dark than in daylight, because of our schedules, and it took me a while to understand how fully Sigurd's daily life revolved around his Party. He made coffee in his kitchen, and not much else. His sad little sofa was buried under stacks of the newspapers I'd seen him selling on campus—all of this week's dire injustices, and last week's, much the same. His bookshelves slumped with the weight of Marx and Engels and Malcolm X and (mostly) people I'd never heard of, whose titles mentioned class or struggle or liberation or (mostly) all the above. I might have expected at least a poster of Lenin, or the iconic Che Guevara I'd seen in the room of my flautist friend Ina who smoked clove cigarettes and wore Doc Martens and, I suspected, just had the hots for Che. But Sigurd had no posters, or anything really at all you'd call decor, apart from a print of Van Gogh's famous almond blossoms that was curling and torn at the bottom, its aquamarine sky faded to overcast gray. I asked what he liked best about that painting, and he said he liked that it was already tacked to the wall when he moved in. I teased him about his austerity, told him he needed a pet or a

plant. He said he had a pet mermaid that had bewitched him, and pulled me back into his tangled sheets.

We tried to do other things, or talked about it anyway, but couldn't for the life of us think what those things might be. I'd spent my life as a citizen of this town inside a practice room, and he'd spent his in Party and union meetings. As far as other entertainments, what we knew between us wasn't enough to manufacture a proper date. I invited him to come to my jury. These graded performances were concerts, open to the public, and plenty of nonmusicians would be in the audience. Sigurd wasn't. My department scheduled it for an hour when he had to be at work.

What we did do was talk. He told me about his multitude of older siblings, mostly sisters, and I credited them with teaching Sigurd his unusual way with women, not just talking about himself all the time. They'd all gone into helping professions: two nurses, some teachers, one actual nun. (We didn't have Catholics in Steele County; I didn't know nunning was still a career option in modern times.) His two brothers both followed their father into the military, the eldest old enough to have gone to Vietnam and come home, as Sigurd put it, "pretty messed up." Their mother had passed away a few years back, leaving the family too disorganized and scattered around to see much of each other since her funeral. But he made phone calls that sounded enviably affectionate.

We didn't talk about previous lovers. Not that I wasn't curious. He had such ease with bodies, both his and mine, I suspected he'd been in the wooing business about as long as I'd been shutting myself up alone with pianos. It embarrassed me that I'd been with only one person, so uncreatively, and amazed me that Sigurd was unattached when I met him. Playing the field, I assumed, recalling the coed swarm around him at the South Africa rally. The people he talked about most were his Party comrades, especially a woman named Marisol, whom I hated for her exotic name and my hunch that something must have been going on there. I didn't want to know.

He still called me "Planets." But also *gorgeous*. *Beautiful.* Words I still heard with a reflexive urge to look over my shoulder to see who else was in the room. He loved my hair, the extraordinary length of it, and took it idly in his fingers when we talked in bed. He asked how it came to be so long. One day at a time, I told him, laughing, to stave back the memory of her hard grip on me, my head jarring back with every violent yank of the brush.

I was happier when he asked about dairy farming, even if my knowledge ran pretty thin. My brother was the one who got pulled into the daily work, while I played with the barn cats and tried to charm the big, jolly man named Mr. Picklar who came in the tank truck every day to pump our milk out of the steel bulk tank in the cold room and haul it away. My father said we had to keep on his good side, because Mr. Picklar tested our milk each day, and if we got a bad grade, he would pour it all down the drain. I did my best, bribing Mr. Picklar with four-leaf clovers and offers to let him pet one of the cats while I held it still.

Sigurd asked more questions about my family than I wanted to answer. Was anybody else in my family musical? They weren't. My brother, maybe, but we'd never know. He'd asked for piano lessons and got Boy Scouts. Talking about my mother felt humiliating. What would I say? That my brother and I measured our days, good or bad, based on which end of the belt she used against us? That my hair was long because of the day she came at me with scissors, and my piercing screams brought my father running up the stairs? She never touched my hair again, for any reason. I was six, and on my own. My school pictures would chart years of half-baked ponytails. I told Sigurd she wasn't a warm person.

He asked if my parents loved each other, and I rolled my eyes.

"My father's primary relationship is with a dog."

"Really? That was your model for romance?"

I leaned toward him, lolled out my tongue and panted.

He took hold of my ears, pulled me to him, and licked my forehead.

"Eww!" I cried, scrubbing at the dampness with the sheet.

"Would you rather I sniffed your butt?"

"Let me get back to you on that." I sat up against the wobbly headboard and stretched languidly, letting the sheet fall from my upper body. I was still trying to get used to the feeling of air on my skin. In my whole previous life combined, I hadn't spent this much time naked.

He reached across me for his cigarettes, lit one and passed it over to me. I was getting hooked here in all the ways. "Dad and his lady-dog," he mused, "you think they'll go the distance? Till death do they part?"

"That is actually my biggest family worry. I'm not kidding. We don't even know how old Dolly is, but she can't last forever."

"Child bride from the pound?"

“Worse. She showed up at the farm one day all torn up. Probably by feral dogs.”

“Does that happen a lot?”

“You’ve never lived in the country?”

He hadn’t. Of course. He’d told me about a childhood around military bases, mostly in big cities. But he was still yet so down-to-earth. I hadn’t known city people could be like that.

I told him it happened every day. “People get fed up with a pet, or accidental puppies, they drive out to the country and leave it on the side of the road thinking it’s going to seek its fortune. Hunt rabbits or whatever. But they starve, they gang up and start running in packs, and sooner or later, they’ll attack livestock. Canines always attack the same way, tearing into the throat and hindquarters, trying to get in for the soft parts. Ugh, you don’t want to hear this.”

“I do, though. This side of you, where you come from, I don’t really know.”

“Well, sorry if I’m not painting the prettiest picture. But people are sentimental about farms if they don’t know better. Poor Dolly turns up gashed and bleeding fore and aft, missing part of one ear, and that’s just kind of another day on the farm.”

“Not for your father, apparently.”

“God, no. My father—” I took another hit of nicotine. “He’s hard to account for. My mother’s easier to explain: She hates everything. The washing machine, the sun that rises, the deal she got. Like something was stolen from her, and it’s her job to be pissed off. Dad is cowed by that, I guess. Or he’s gotten worn down over time. But the way he nursed that dog was sweeter than I’ve seen any man or woman coddle anything, ever. They’ve not been out of each other’s sight since then.”

I took another drag and handed back his cigarette, feeling a warm rush. He always smelled like smoke, my father, when I rode his mail route with him, or in his truck when he drove me to my lessons. Dolly was always there too, of course. Dolly, the one of us he could protect and tousle and talk sweetly to without my mother taking it out on her later. He surely wanted to do the same for me but couldn’t, for how it would cost me. I must have known that. I felt sheltered in those sanctified passenger compartments, safe for the moment, inhaling his smoke like holy incense. As a child, I thought that was what good men smelled like. Still did, maybe.

“She’s a good dog, Dolly,” I said. “A good worker once she healed, pure border collie, valuable to somebody you’d think. But nobody ever came looking. My dad tried breeding her a few times with a proper stud, but it never took. The attack must have damaged the parts she needed for that.”

“Poor Dolly.”

“Nah. She’s the happiest member of our family.”

I was now running a close second, I thought. Nobody had ever reached for me the way Sigurd did, taking my hair between his fingertips, calling me “Planets,” as if I were a world he wanted to live in. He wanted to know about everything, even the torn-up dog of my youth. The best and worst parts of my working days. What my fingers were playing on his shoulder as we fell asleep. (It was Bach, always.) I explained why I loved Bach, because of balance. Not a flat-out symmetry of Question: Answer. That would be Mozart. Bach is more winsome, making his opening promise, then taking it out for a little walk around, which is called *fortspinnung*, and then, finally, inevitably, delivering heart-in-hands the conclusion he had you longing for. You could count on it.

Sigurd asked if I was hearing all this in my head as my fingers played, which I was, but didn’t usually realize until he asked. When I told him it was a partita, I had to explain then what that is, a composition made of a lot of parts with different paces and moods. A partita will never be all be happy rondos, or all andantes in a minor key. You’ll usually have a prelude, a thrilling allemande, maybe a slow, sexy sarabande—the contrast is the point. The parts are all different, and the artist’s work is to make them all add up to a something that feels whole.

He asked how much of the time I felt happy when I was alone with a piano. I found I had no easy answer. “Happy? I don’t know, zero? A hundred percent? I have no idea,” I confessed. “When I’m playing, I’m not me anymore. I go inside the music and disappear in there.” I tried to explain the strangeness, after hours of practice, of walking out of the building to see daylight had turned to darkness. A feeling of having been erased from the world for a while. As I talked about it, I realized I hadn’t had that feeling of complete absorption lately, and was missing it.

He said it sounded like being drugged. I agreed that it was. Not just high, bigger than that. The word I could think of, that seemed the right size, was *joy*. I told him he’d probably hit on the secret to why people like me kept doing it for such a lot of hours every day.

“A *preposterous* number of hours every day,” he said, rolling on top of me to kiss me. He had a wondrous knack for holding himself on his elbows so I never felt his weight, only the thrilling black fur of his chest, his hard abdomen against my softer one, his penis whose many dispositions held me in thrall. He was a magician with a condom, adept at making one appear the second it was needed, and vanish when it wasn’t. Even so, the first item I’d relocated from my apartment to Sigurd’s was the diaphragm I was assigned my freshman year, when I’d only gone into Student Health for a strep test. Apparently this is the universal mission of Student Health.

“A preposterous number of hours,” I confirmed, eventually.

Week by week, more of my possessions followed my diaphragm into Sigurd’s apartment. Clothes, toothbrush, a Teflon skillet for frying eggs. We bought groceries separately at first, then sometimes together like a normal couple, cooked and ate together, talked, slept. We never discussed my moving in, or the fact that I already had, but he always seemed delighted to wake up and find me in bed next to him or standing at his terrible little stove, boiling water to make coffee. He never once came to my apartment. I didn’t need Jon Link haunting us from the clutter of shoes and books and reed cutters he’d left behind.

I preferred getting to know Sigurd on his own turf. Not that I learned much from his sparse possessions, but he talked easily whenever I asked what he’d done with his day. Or what he was reading in his books. It was always to do with the world, and how things could be better, but in ways you wouldn’t necessarily think of on your own. That people didn’t always believe in private property, for example. He claimed this wasn’t really a natural thing, because we hadn’t started out that way in ancient times. Sigurd was reading an entire book about the idea of owning things, the history of it. He told me all this one evening when I came home from a rehearsal to find him sitting at the kitchen table reading, wearing nothing but his glasses. The man was completely comfortable in any state of dress or undress. I’d tried to do the same, with no success. I’d learned shame from a mother who expressed such strong opinions about women and bodies, I think I actually believed for a time that girls got pregnant from wearing tight dresses. Life had not prepared me to be around a body so beautiful I sometimes stared at him when he slept: at the crest of dark hair across his chest that narrowed into a line descending his smooth belly to the storm below. His back, with its rippled muscle like the surface of a lake.

The first time I laid eyes on him, I'd thought of Michelangelo's *David*. I could say now, there was no false advertising.

I leaned over to kiss him and cover his shame with a dish towel. Then got undressed myself, climbed into bed, and set about being jealous of his book. It was the size of a dictionary.

"How could anybody know that, about ancient times?" I asked.

"How do you know what your boyfriend Bach was doing nine hundred years ago?"

I laughed. "*Three* hundred. There were history books by then."

"There are history books now. I'm reading one."

He was aggravating me on purpose, I knew from his grin. I pestered him with questions. Why did people change, from sharing everything to owning? What made it happen? He said it came about after people figured out how to grow and store up more than they needed. Then they had to invent rules to make it seem okay for the rich ones to keep stuff they didn't actually need, and not share with the poor ones that did.

"It does seem kind of concocted," I conceded. "When you put it that way."

He said taming animals was the start of it. That having cows or what have you, animals that multiplied themselves, was the start of accumulating extra food. So, cows were the original wealth. I told him somebody should tell that to my mortgaged father. "Are you saying that's actually on the books, that cows are money?" I threw off the top sheet, trying to be distracting.

Sigurd said yes, it was the start of bookkeeping. All these clay tablets in places like Egypt and Mesopotamia were basically ledgers of who had how many sheep and cows. It was the men doing this, he said. They were in charge of the animals that became money. The ladies, meanwhile, were going around digging roots and such. Next thing they knew, some people had more food than they'd ever be able to eat, and they had to start making rules about why they should get to keep it to themselves anyway. His whole point, I think, was that people aren't naturally born to be grab-handed. And if they started out sharing everything and only learned later to be greedy, it was possible for us to unlearn it and go back at least some way in the other direction.

It sounded reasonable enough, to a girl who owned just about exactly nothing, lying naked in a bed with a warm breeze coming in the open

windows. It was June; anything seemed possible. I asked if it was a man who wrote his big fat book, which it was.

"That figures," I said.

He snapped the book shut and got into bed with me. "It figures, because this was the 1880s, and women weren't allowed to be educated or write books."

"They were in the kitchen cooking the philosophers' meals and tending their children. You wonder if the gentlemen ever thought to ask their wives about how people could learn not to be so grab-handed."

Sigurd laughed. "They weren't as bad as you think. Marx always said the revolution couldn't go forward without women."

"I bet. Revolution sounds messy, somebody's got to mop up."

He was amused by my resistance. "Let me read you something. Different book."

I was happy to let him, because it meant I could watch him get out of bed and stand at his bookshelf for a minute. Happier still when he turned around. He paged through the book, looking terribly pleased with himself. "This is from a letter Marx wrote to his friend Ludwig Kugelmann." He put his glasses back on. If there's anything sillier than a man wearing only socks, it's only glasses.

He read: "'Anybody who knows anything of history knows that great social changes are impossible without the feminine ferment . . .'"

"Feminine *ferment*," I shrieked. "What are we, *sauerkraut*?"

He shushed me. "They used different words back then. Just listen. 'Great social changes are impossible without the feminine . . .'" He looked up at me. ". . . *unrest*, let's say."

"Vomitous upheaval," I offered.

He read: "'Social progress can be measured exactly by the social position of the fair sex.' Which was the language of the time, you know that. He meant all women."

I vamped. "*Fair* maidens. Perhaps also the comelier brunettes."

"I was going to skip this next part, because you'd take it the wrong way. But look."

He came back to bed and handed me the book, marking the place with his finger:

> *Anybody who knows anything of history knows that great social changes are impossible without the feminine ferment. Social progress can be measured exactly by the social*

position of the fair sex (the plain ones included).

"Even the *ugly* ones!" I hooted.

He tried to use this as proof that Marx was broad-minded and ahead of his time. I felt that any question of female position could only be resolved with a wrestling match. We were hopeless at settling our scores any other way than this, getting rolled up in the sheets. Happy as bugs in a rug.

Music is made of tension. Little tense moments, one after another, each one a building block of tightness or unease that makes your body lean toward something, want it, even long for it, until that yearning is answered with release. Each of these pairs—statement and response, argument and counterargument—is a brief bridge of suspense moving right on to the next one, one after another, these small, satisfied hungers in succession. All of these beads of tension and release strung together make the whole piece of music.

It isn't just one kind of tension; there are so many. Dynamic tension: a great loud storm that finally quiets. Or the opposite, a stretch of soft notes singing to you from a distance, staying eerily quiet for so long you feel yourself getting impatient, aching for the thunderclap. And rhythmic tension: the stressed downbeat that pushes back against your heart's natural rest. The rubato that slows and stretches a moment until you start feeling robbed of the truth of the beat, almost righteous in your demand for the hurried catch-up that finally comes.

Mostly, though, the tension in music is harmonic. Every combination of notes has a particular agreement or disagreement inside itself, and wily composers use those elements to move you, laying out chords in progressions that rise, pressing on your throat, building your expectation for the resolution that feels like closure. I could play a few simple chords to show you: C major, G major, A minor, F major—that progression is so common, your ears know it by heart. You trust it. Others are trickier, the minor seventh easing down into the home base tonic. The augmented sixth chord surrendering into its dominant. These patterns drive your heartbeat, your mood, your trust in the world. You don't even have to think about it, can't learn or unlearn it; you just feel it in your body. Music is made the world over, and its makers might use different patterns and instruments, but

we're all the same in the way we're moved by it. Literally, moved. The tension pulls us forward into the unresolved strain and throws us back as we're released. Watch a pianist unself-consciously weaving at her keyboard, the bounce of an orchestra conductor with his arms up, the sliding hips of a jazz vocalist. Watch the listeners dance. Adults, children, babies scarcely old enough to stand, even blind people who haven't seen anybody dancing will naturally move their bodies to music. And all of them, even the youngest child, can tell if the song is happy or sad or scary. It's a language we're born knowing. To be blessed with its full fluency is a treasure.

It's important to my story to explain that making love with Sigurd was like this. Like music, in exactly this way. His body with mine, attending to mine, created moments of tension and release, over and over, building to resolutions within resolutions. Lips on my ear, my neck, my shoulders, fingers on my spine, my belly, my thighs. Lips on the insides of my elbows, my knees. Harmonic tension, dynamic tension, oh my dear Lord, the rubato, his movements slowing, slowing, robbing me of the truth of the beat until I begged for justice. Begged and laughed and cried out. Sometimes we both shed tears.

The beginnings, all of our beginnings, every time we put our bodies together, would put Chopin or Ravel or Satie into my head: playful notes, edgy, unruly push-and-pull, soft and hard by unpredictable turns. And always it was Beethoven at the end. Never the steady, unyielding beat of Bach, which is all I'd previously known of sex. Never Mozart. Making love with Sigurd was not a composition for church, or any king's court. But for me, it was almost like discovering music again, to find that lovemaking could also hold so much more tension and release than I'd imagined, longings inside of longings, answers of every possible making within more extended longings and resolutions. Every one of our times together had its own composition, so particular that I could memorize it and play it to myself afterward. I had never imagined lovemaking like this, made of so many movements, so many parts.

I've never known it since.

Almost nobody stayed on campus all summer. Those of us who did were very high-minded about it. Not ordinary students laboring to please adults, we were *musicians*, the chosen few who still belonged in these rehearsals

and concert halls after everybody else cleared out. I reveled in my sudden inheritance every June: all those pianos to myself! We didn't even sign up for practice rooms in summer. I could be promiscuous, jumping from one piano to another one to work through all the movements of Beethoven's *Hammerklavier* if I felt like it. For sure, it was the nearest I'd ever come to barhopping. At the finish of my first year, it was miracle enough not to go back to living under my mother's thumb, but by that summer's end, I had gained something more than freedom. I watched classmates coming back to the reopened dormitories with their boxes of stuff, climbing the stairs with pillows under their arms, starting something over again that I'd never looked away from. This was my home.

I had to be strategic about income, though, because my work-study at the music library lapsed in summer. Visiting artists were a gravy train. Their honoraria covered accompanists at their discretion, and Europeans tended to pay generously. They didn't seem to know about American student penury, and we kept our secrets. That's where I was headed now, to a lucrative rehearsal with my German Lieder singer in the borrowed studio of one of the voice professors.

I wasn't in that building very often, and was surprised to meet Stephania Schmidt coming down the stairs as I came up. She was another pianist who stayed for summers, and always complained it was hotter here than in Biarritz, which took me a few years to understand as a declaration of family money. Stephania used all the syllables of her name, every time, and made a bigger deal than I did about having perfect pitch—I hadn't quite realized I had it, before college (or, rather, I assumed everybody did). She was in my class, the sly informant who'd told me our first week that Dr. Betis intended to pass me off to a lesser instructor. *Don't take this the wrong way.* She might have endured a country mouse in the big leagues if I'd been a lesser pianist. But I did not oblige. She had to find other ways to win, asking me in front of her friends, "Livia, *where* do you get your hair cut?" (I literally never had) or "Where on *earth* did you find that interesting winter coat?" (thrift shop), enlisting a clique of Livia-haters that extended beyond bitter pianists to several non-contending woodwinds and a harpist, for crying out loud. The understanding of her as my enemy was fairly department-wide. Stephania was the only other one of us who might have been able to play the *Gaspard*, and now she never would, because it was mine.

On this summer day, she was impressively put together: skirt, button-up blouse, loafers with actual pennies in them. Lucky for me, wardrobe was not on the long list of things Herr Brockhaus was picky about. She smiled down the flight of stairs at me, not convincingly.

"Headed up to serve His Majesty?"

"Brockhaus the great and terrible," I said.

She made a little pity-frown, pretending she was glad it was me and not her. Herr Doctor Brockhaus was a huge star, famously particular about his accompanists, and performed the hardest pieces in the Lieder repertoire. Dr. Betis had recommended me for the job.

He opened the studio door at the top of the stairs before I could catch my breath.

"Livia, today we will have 'Der Erlkönig,'" he said, whisking me in, starting immediately into his new thoughts about pacing and dynamics. His English was excellent, only slightly shaded with German. Vocalists have to perform in a lot of languages.

I organized my pages at the piano and sat still, hands in my lap, while he ran through his vocal warm-ups. Vocal trills, bubbles, *eee*s all the way up three octaves like a siren, *oooh*s all the way down. (Brockhaus was renowned for his high notes.) *Puh-buh*, *puh-buh*, lip exercises to help with the overarticulated words that would make you back away fast from somebody at a party, but sound right in a German art song. Vocalists always do this, make the accompanist sit through the warm-up. The bigger the star, the longer the wait.

I watched his profile, trying to figure out what it was about him that *looked* famous, because he did. He was shorter than me, but seemed taller because of the regal bearing: chest out, shoulders back, hooked nose held somewhat aloft. A lot of well-tended dark hair, high forehead, eyebrows permanently raised in a way that made you think he was about to impart some crucial grain of knowledge. A lot of vocalists shared that look—the good posture, the eyebrows—but Herr Brockhaus was not run-of-the-mill. The knowledge he was about to impart might involve his bowel movements. He was gripped with their significance. Early-afternoon rehearsals weren't convenient for me, leaving an awkward gap after my two morning choir jobs, but we couldn't schedule them sooner because Herr Brockhaus would not sing before he'd had what he called "the motion of the day." Even at one o'clock in the afternoon, I'd come in a few times to

find our session canceled by a little note propped on the piano fallboard: “The Motion has not arrived.” Lord help the man if he got constipated on a performance day.

It probably didn’t help that he ate only white foods, or so I’d heard through the gossip channels. People also said he slept on a slanted board, crazy things I’d normally doubt, but I’d seen enough of him to put no absurdities off the table. His metal phobia, for instance. He claimed its presence pulled his voice off pitch. At his request, this borrowed office had been stripped down to books and wooden furniture, nary a competition medal or bronze bust in sight. In our first practice sessions, he’d met me at the door barking “Metal? Metal?” Checking my hands for rings or bracelets. The little silver loops I forgot to take out of my ears, I had to leave outside the room in my backpack, with its offending zippers. I’d heard he had special trousers made, with Velcro, which I had no wish to think about. I learned to bring my zipperless music bag and try to keep my mouth shut, but honestly. Concert halls would be gold and silver mines of ladies’ adornments. Here in this studio sat a piano whose innards held more brass and steel than a polka band. When I mentioned that, he said vocalist and piano are separate instruments in the Lieder. The piano may do as it pleases. But not its player, I understood. My job as an accompanist was to disappear. All sound, no self.

A year ago, I’d have been intimidated by this man whose musical brilliance gave him the right to make preposterous demands. Now he struck me as a big baby with the luck of a golden voice. Even if I knew it was more than luck. A Lied is like an opera in miniature, a special kind of art song that tells a whole story in five minutes. One singer has to embody the personalities and story lines of all the different characters. It’s considered one of the most challenging musical forms. And “Der Erlkönig” is best of the best. This Schubert masterpiece would be the capstone of his Visiting Master Concert in a few weeks. He told me this, when he finished his warm-ups and turned those eyebrows my way. As if I didn’t know. The auditorium would stand and stomp for Herr Brockhaus and nobody would notice me, reduced to a puddle by the piano accompaniment of this Lied that is every bit as technically demanding, if not harder, than the vocal star turn.

He gave me four curt nods to set the tempo, and I launched with both arms into the introduction, a fierce *moto perpetuo* of triplets representing

the hoofbeats of a horse, which do not slow down when the singer comes in to ask who is riding on this dark, windy night. Those insistent, relentless triplets keep pounding on and on, all the way to the end of the song. The *moto perpetuo* is what makes the piece thrilling, those powerful notes cannot come fast enough, they're the reason I was doing this today and not Stephania Schmidt or anybody else.

The "Erlkönig" is a *bitch*, I'd moaned that morning to Sigurd, who seemed to think I had some easy, servile gig here, like being a roadie for a band. I took his right hand, spread his fingers an octave wide, and beat them on the table in fast triplets: 123–123, 123–123.

"Do that fast," I said, and he did, a little ragged but good effort: *tadada-tadada.*

"Now," I said, "Double time. Twice as fast, six to a set, no pauses between, and *loud*."

I watched the muscles tense in his arms, watched his grimace as he watched his hand attacking the table. It tickled me that he was trying: *TADADADADADA TADADADADADA.*

"Don't stop," I said. "You're eight seconds in. Keep it up for four and a half minutes."

He fell back into his chair, mopping pretend sweat off his brow. "You are Iron Woman."

"Oh, well, that's only the right hand. There are also all these ominous left-hand melodies ripping around the whole time." I shrugged. "Day in the life of a superhero."

I didn't tell Sigurd I loved "Der Erlkönig" even more than I hated it. The first time I ever heard it was in a Romanticists class, and I had to go back to my room afterward to cry. Not the first nerdy girl, I'm sure, to shed tears over Franz Schubert, arguably the inventor of Romanticism, dying when he was only thirty-one, the gifted life cut short. But for me, that day, it was my brother I couldn't stop thinking about. Schubert was eighteen when he wrote "Der Erlkönig," the age I was then, that Cyrus almost was when he died. All three of us still young enough to have full grasp of the nightmare that childhood really is. The terrors that grown-ups refuse to see. Schubert's genius was to wrap that terror in a musical package so impressive, adults all over the world would have to sit up and take note.

It's a story about a father riding home with his son on horseback. The boy gets scared, Dad asks why, and the boy says, *Don't you see that horrible*

thing with a creepy crown and long tail? In the way of all parents, Dad says, *Nah, it's just fog. Think about nice things. Flowers, the beach.* But the creepy fog king, the Erlkönig, talks to the boy, *Come live with me, you'll love my place, I've got daughters*, and so on, until the poor kid is beside himself. *Don't you see him, Dad? Down in the dark under the willow trees, he is RIGHT THERE!* No, he doesn't. But the Erlkönig is stepping it up, not taking no for an answer. The boy at this point is practically frothing at the mouth, and finally Dad says okay, this is bad, he kicks the horse into high gear—I cannot tell you how exhausted the pianist's arms are by now, *tadada-tadada, TADADA-TADADA*—and when they finally get back to the farm, oh, shit. The boy is dead.

I executed my superhero task with Herr Brockhaus that day and many more, leading up to the night I executed it flawlessly on the big stage at the MAC. As I expected, after the finale, the audience roared, and I disappeared. I earned my paycheck and tried during all those days to remember the things "Der Erlkönig" had made me believe about music, once upon a time: It made me cry for my brother, because it told the truth of our helpless childhood so perfectly. Music could always help me find my feelings, had stood beside me at funerals, celebrated my joys, sat patiently with my loneliness. Not just mine, every person's. It could reach inside them to find what they needed to say or cry or yell into the ears of a hard old world.

But it wasn't the world in the audience that night. Sigurd, for one, had to work, and I didn't press him. I could play "Der Erlkönig" for him in a practice room anytime. Of course it would have been something else for Sigurd to see me perform for that huge crowd, up there in the spotlights in my long black concert dress. But it wasn't my show. It was all about the great Brockhaus, and I'd divulged so much about the man's egotistical acting out and bathroom habits, that's probably all Sigurd would have seen. Anyway, Sigurd had ants in his pants and important things to do. I couldn't ask him to sit through a two-hour program in German.

I doubt anybody from the town was there at all, just students and faculty from our music school and others nearby, maybe DePauw or Evansville. It was a free concert, but not really, for the tiny slice of humanity who had the expensive schooling to understand the point of Lieder, and could listen with worshipful respect to perfectly articulated high notes sung by a highbrowed,

turd-obsessed little man. Even on stage, I wasn't sure I still belonged in that camp.

Sometimes in the intimate darkness after our lovemaking, before sleep, I tried to tell Sigurd I was falling out of my life. I confessed to things I could hardly believe I'd done: The day after the Brockhaus recital, I skipped a rehearsal for one of the two choirs I was playing for. I chalked it up to exhaustion, but then skipped another one. The director called to find out if I was sick, and when I lied that I was, he didn't ask after my health, only if I needed to be replaced. Whatever had held me subservient to these duties for so many years was coming out of me in a slow leak. I had a block of free time every day between jobs, but could barely muster the enthusiasm to go to a practice room and learn a new piece.

Sigurd thought that was natural, after all the anxious work ahead of my jury in May. I'd been so focused on performing the *Gaspard*, and was so relieved to have it behind me now, it made sense I might be feeling a little unsprung. A body needs rest; my drive would come back as soon as I'd recovered. He said these things, but a month had passed since my jury, and something in me still felt different from before. Not just unsprung. Broken.

The truth was, I was scared of being ridiculous. I could see other music students coming up behind me, pushing everything out of the way of their ambition to be the best, and the ones up ahead of me, still pushing. Where was the goodness in our lives, what did we have, any of us, but a blind devotion to something that meant zip, basically, to the great scramble of humans out there on the green grass of the world? This "best" we were after, was it not just an elite society of the ridiculous? We went to our practice rooms like factory workers to the line, and at the end of our shift, our product was a piece of music played in a new way. It's been played already thousands of times. Recorded. If my interpretation was new, who in the world would recognize that but a handful of peers in our society of the ridiculous? If anybody else even came to hear me, it would sound the same to them as when other pianists played it. They could buy the record.

I didn't tell Sigurd my crisis was his doing, but I nursed a suspicion it was. Right from the beginning of us, I'd had this feeling of slipping out of my old skin. Crisis, or jailbreak. I took his hand and stepped off my little planet, and could look back at it now with a critical eye. As long as I'd stayed completely inside my pursuit of the next cadenza, the next performance, spending my life with nobody but other students and

professors doing the same, there'd been no chance to examine the project. You can't see the ground you're standing on. We had no inclination or even the time to ask, what are we doing here? What good is music?

Sigurd urged me bluntly not to duck my choir jobs. He asked for my rehearsal schedule and sometimes pushed me out of bed when the time came. He was sweet about it, but firm. However I felt about these gigs, I needed the money. Maybe he was uneasy to shoulder the burden of me as I rushed to abandon my own life, as if he'd begun an affair with a married woman who now decided hastily to leave her husband. I did not think this at the time, only later.

He did understand now what he hadn't at first, that I was exceptional. I'd invited him into more practice room recitals since that first "Ondine" we would never, ever forget. Chaste recitals, I mean. After he missed my jury, I played *Gaspard de la Nuit* just for Sigurd that spring, all three parts, and explained the story poems behind each one. First is "Ondine," the flirtatious water nymph, and last comes "Scarbo," a wiry goblin that comes out at night to terrify you, scrambling all around the bed and up the walls. The middle movement, "Le Gibet," is very slow and sad, with a B-flat octave tolling like a bell all the way through. Sigurd said he liked that one best, even after I filled in the picture for him: tolling death knell, red sunset, a man who had to hang for his crimes. A *gibet* is a gallows. No matter, Sigurd liked it. Sympathy for the damned, he said, and I played it for him many times. For better or worse, *Gaspard de la Nuit* was our song.

So he knew enough to mean it when he held my hands in the dark and told me that what I did was beautiful. I believed him, but it wasn't enough. I was not sure I could live by beauty alone. I wanted him to tell me this labor of my life and years was worth his respect. That I shouldn't give up music. That I wasn't allowed that choice.

I was love-struck. Taken with his attention and tenderness, and even the earnest way he gave himself over to the work that took him away from our bed. Sometimes he got up before first light to talk union with men at the end of their graveyard shift. At the other end of a day, Party meetings might keep him till midnight. He'd been put in charge of recruitment, and was planning projects for the student alliance in the fall semester, even though he claimed not to like being on campus that much. I thought of the buzz of

female acolytes at the South Africa rally. The Party knew what they were doing. Anybody would buy what Sigurd was selling.

This was no snake oil either. It was so real to him, the better world ahead. He trusted progress and fairness, even if the newspaper he hawked offered police brutality and criminal foreign interventions on every page. These setbacks and the anger they inflamed were the engine of forward motion. He talked about the revolution like a giant ball that couldn't stop rolling.

Like any red-blooded person, I'd grown up understanding all the -isms as dangers on par with too-tight dresses. When Sigurd questioned me, though, I had absolutely no grasp of specifics, only a vague idea of dictators and people in drab uniforms, which he laughed at. People in socialist countries elect their presidents and wear what they please, he said. It's about work and money, nothing more: who owns the factory, who's doing the producing.

I couldn't disagree with any of it in principle. How is it right for workers to do all the making, then have to accept whatever wage they're given? While the owners collect all the profits, just by being capitalists? That's the whole problem, he said. But there are lots more workers than owners—that's the solution. According to Sigurd, the proletariat will figure out they outnumber their bosses, and they'll get fed up, get control of the means of production through general strikes, and take over their industries. They will be more productive when they work for their own advancement, not just to make rich people richer. This canon was as solid for him as the ground under his feet. History would fold us all into its beautiful progress.

I could believe a fair amount of this when we didn't have clothes on. At other times, it sounded like fantasy. I told Sigurd, the idea of making a whole new better world out of this one is what my kind of people call "pie in the sky." But he said he *was* my kind of people, and this was his workaday life. His union, International Typographer's, was the oldest labor syndicate in the country but now was bleeding membership, losing jobs to mechanization. He'd just come from a meeting where they discussed a merger of his union with the Teamsters. It was a Saturday morning. I had no rehearsals and was cutting his hair, something I'd been itching to do since the first day we met. I'd learned barbering by trial and error, trimming up Jon Link every time he realized on the day of a concert that he'd grown shaggy. No improvements I'd made to Jon Link ever pleased me half so

much as the haircut I gave Sigurd. My skills advanced when client and barber were naked.

We finished up together in the shower, covered with soap and tiny hairs, our bodies slick against the tiles, reaching full agreement on the need for haircuts early and often. Afterward, we went back to bed, spent for the moment, and I remembered what I'd wanted to tell him earlier when he mentioned the Teamsters. I was easily distracted.

"I had two uncles who were Teamsters."

"Did you?" He rolled over onto his belly, propped on his elbows. I felt a little abashed. I didn't want to feel like a child working for his approval. The difference in our ages wasn't so much, but Sigurd was worldly and I wasn't, except in my own world. If he had come to my jury, he'd have seen men twice his age hanging on my every note, impressed by me.

Instead, I had Teamster uncles on offer. I told him how my father, oldest of three brothers, inherited the farm, because that's how it works. You can't keep dividing up farmland or you'll have no farm left. The two younger brothers went to work as freight drivers at a packing plant in Marionville. Everybody felt bad about it, as if my uncles got the short end of the stick.

Sigurd rolled onto his back with one arm crooked behind his head, smiling. "How'd that work out for the younger brothers?"

"The family would never say so, but they're the lucky ones. My dad has worked sunup to sundown all his life, plus his job as a mail carrier, and now he's crippled and mortgaged. His little brothers at the plant are getting salaries and benefits that seem over the moon to us. Health insurance, even. Retirement."

"Is that so hard for your family to see, that the younger brothers got the better deal?"

"What *you're* not seeing is it's not just money. There's more to a farm than land and cows and barns and profit margins. Dad used to tell me that, all the time."

"Oh really. What's the better-than-money part?"

Sigurd, with both hands cocked behind his head now, was making me feel bristly. Even if he did seem interested in what I might say. I called my father into my head, pictured him. The way he would open up, talking to me almost like another grown-up, when I rode with him on his mail route.

"Time and family. That's what he always said, those two things. Sometimes I argued with him, like you are now. I told him you couldn't see

those things. Not in our barn. And he'd say, 'Oh, yes, ma'am, you surely can.' That's why he painted the name of our dairy across the side of it."

"Which is what?"

"CyLee Dairy. 'Cy' was for Cyrus obviously, and 'Lee' was me, Dad said, because 'Cy-Livvie' might sound foreign to some people."

Sigurd looked amused, which shouldn't have surprised me; people didn't get this part of farming, or they mistook it for hayseed sentiment. I shrugged off my hurt feelings. "We just have to think the family farm is a God-given thing, that's all I can tell you," I said. "A privilege. Which it used to be. Before it got to be a hole you're digging to put yourself farther into the ground."

"The world changes," he said. "Faster than most people want to accept. It doesn't matter what line you're in, it all works the same way. How the labor is organized, who owns what. The mode of production always writes the story."

Sigurd could get to a place that was past any argument. A light came into his eyes that genuinely changed their color. At his happiest, they were aquamarine. The lost color of Van Gogh's sky. I reminded him he was an army brat, with no business telling me how farming works. But everything he said about it was true. That even if you use your animals past the point of kindness and treat the soil the same way, the money still doesn't quite pan out. The company that bought our milk—all the milk from all the farms around us—paid less every year. My father had to keep producing more to break even, and the equipment he needed for that put him in debt.

"What nobody talks about," Sigurd said, "is that the family doesn't really own the farm. You owe the bank for the land and equipment. The milk belongs to Carnation before your cows take a bite of mortgaged grass. Your private property is in illusion. All the machines and debts between a farmer and the land end up making the farm his enemy instead of his friend. That's alienation."

"Well, people still have to eat," I declared. I was starving. Our grocery habits ran from extravagant to hopeless while we stretched our days between love and obligation. A bouquet of grocery store roses drooped on the table, aging there since he brought them home the night of the Lieder concert he missed. (Which was sweet. I certainly got none on stage.) But I couldn't remember if we had the ingredients for grilled cheese sandwiches. I could see almost the whole kitchen from the bedroom, including the pool

of Sigurd's dark curls on the floor around the chair where all this started. I'd have to sweep that up before I could begin any other operation in there.

"If there was a better way of making food, somebody would have thought of it by now," I said, getting up and collecting the underwear and shorts and blouse I'd left in a pile.

"They have. But it's never going to work as long as every farmer wants to stay trapped in his own little sinking kingdom."

I looked up from buttoning my blouse. "Oh. You mean taking over the farms, like they did in Russia. Making them into giant communes or whatever? That's horrible."

"People get really sentimental about owning their land while they're digging a hole to put themselves under it."

I couldn't deny I'd said that, about digging the hole. Sigurd joined me in the kitchen, took up the broom, and started sweeping up his hair from the floor, still as naked as when he'd shed it.

"What you call alienation, I call adulthood," I said, staring into the refrigerator. It was a sad, needy, disorganized country in there. "That's everybody I ever knew, growing up. People working as hard as they can, as long as they can, with nothing to show for it."

"You're telling me you never knew a happy person?"

"No, and please go put some pants on, or you'll not be either. I'm about to fry some eggs, and we don't want the popping grease around your tender parts." I smacked a handsome buttock with my spatula to send him off. I thought about the question. The tired cashiers at the grocery. Old men at the feed co-op saying farmers had it worse now than anybody ever thought it could get. I wasn't hitting on any exceptions.

"Even if things are going well for somebody," I tried to explain, after Sigurd reappeared in his boxers, "like let's say they got a good price on their cattle sale, they wouldn't lord it over you. Maybe it's a country-person thing? But that would be bad manners. Tooting your own horn, my mother would say."

"Pride goes before the fall? That's Biblical codswallop."

"*Codswallop*?" I laughed, and he laughed.

"Who really doesn't want to be happy, at the end of the day? That's all I'm saying." He tipped his cloud of swept-up curls into our trash bin of food scraps and coffee grounds. It seemed like such a waste of beauty.

“I don’t think it’s about want. It’s about duty. This feeling of being downtrodden by The Man. That goes way past Biblical. It’s the glue that holds the place together.”

If I never could buy what Sigurd was selling, this was the reason. My kind of people weren’t going to take over anything. If they were at the bottom of life’s pile, they were mostly mad at themselves. I’m sure my father believed to his very bones, this is a free country and you get as much as you’ll work for. Or as little. Period. A man might rail his fist at God or drink himself blind, but his heart will go on telling him the same truth: If you hate what you’re reaping, you should have tended better to sowing the seed. Where I come from, that’s adulthood. The rock-solid belief you’re living the fate you’ve earned.

Richer, happier people believed this too, I’d come to understand, from my life on this campus. The deserving of good fortune, I’d felt even from Jon Link and his family, not that we talked about it. I just saw it dyed in their wool, the sense that having money was proof of their industry and cleverness. That wealth and education give you the right to be in charge of people who don’t have much of either. Not just in charge, possibly more favored by God.

I’d tried to find words for this before, but Sigurd would never have it. Class was not a prison. Workers only had to be convinced of their power. He was sure they craved a different story and would be galvanized by the prospect of better lives. Farmers too, he told me that morning, after we sat down in our tiny kitchen to eat fried-egg-and-tomato sandwiches. He was sympathetic when I talked about my parents’ fatalism. He apologized for disrespect, and confessed he didn’t know enough about farming. He just thought there had to be better ways to organize the work of people on their land. Not the giant Soviet communes—everybody agreed now that was a historical mistake. I could see him really thinking about it. Farmers weren’t the proletariat, and not capitalists either. They fit somewhere in the middle, he said, with shop owners, people whose wealth came from what they owned *and* what they did. Farmers were part of the petty bourgeoisie.

That one made me laugh. I *wanted* to believe him. I would have given anything for my father to have more light in his days. I repeated those words aloud, imagined telling my father he was the *petty bourgeoisie*. I could picture the two of them having a conversation. Sigurd wouldn’t just

tell my father what was what. He would ask questions, because that was Sigurd's way, making people feel like they mattered.

I don't know exactly when my mind started weaving a fabric of such things, but it did. My father and Sigurd in our old living room chairs, leaning toward each other in conversation, Dolly at Dad's feet watching them both. Trust growing like orchard grass between these men while my mother and I listened from the kitchen. Shredding cheese for her tomato pie, hearing the first bars of "Rock of Ages" hummed under her breath, over and over, and not despising her for it because it might not be so different from my fingers pressing a Bach partita into my lover's skin. Sigurd was somebody I could take home. To replace the beautiful boy they'd lost.

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Prelude IV

Thursday. My mind is made up. When he calls on the weekend, I'll say no. There's nothing left between us to talk about, and I'll tell him that, with the kindness he's due in his difficult situation, and the politeness I can't seem to help anyway. Half the time when I try to admonish my students, they mistake it for praise. Well, fine, there's no shame in good manners. I'll thank Sigurd for his offer to drive over from Nashville to pay me an afternoon's visit, but make it clear I've put him behind me. I have a life now and so does he, I'm sure. A wife, I assume. Children probably. It's a sore temptation to know for sure, but I won't ask, because how would that make me feel? After what happened to me?

Which he doesn't know about. Not even the half of it, the wreck of my hand or the size of the hole I've carried inside where some important parts should still be. Should he not hear about that? He said he'd been thinking of me, feeling like there might be important things unsaid. The man has no idea. It might do me a world of good to speak up, after all this time. Not with kindness either. To hell with his difficult situation, it was his choice to call me now, scaring the sleep out of my nights and lurking around my days. Like the Erlkönig, looming up out of the mist. He might as well hear the rest of it, the shocking parts I didn't tell him back then, and sent him to hell for instead, in my mind, for a long time after, as often as brushing my teeth. He wants to come around now like a dog wanting his ears rubbed?

This man and his snake-charming ways, who erased a decent, dependable man from my affections as fast as switching off a light. Just the proximity of him scares me. His voice on the phone. Knowing he's alive, a few hours down the road right now, asking to be closer, has knocked me off my rails, and I hate myself for it. For these hallucinations, if that's the right word, memories that keep knocking me sideways. How can he still be alive in the atoms of my body? His scent in the cemetery, damp moss and clean granite and tobacco. Naked in the sheets after his shower, the greenish whiff of soap and the darker undercurrent that was always there, like rain on fallow ground. His scent after we made love, same as before but more so. Fallow ground after a thunderstorm. The afterburn of electricity.

There's no having that back, no wanting it. But to say no to the sight of him, and whatever he still wants to offer, memory, apology, proof I was loved that much? To slam that door, *again*, when I could take one little step back through it, just the once? Life doesn't give you more than one drink of that water. If it gives you one at all.

We thought we were luckier than other people. We said that. Reaching across a table to touch fingers and feel the thunderclap, heaven reaching earth. God. Please tell me what to do. God in whom I don't really believe, except as inspiration for the kindest instincts and most torrid, passionate music ever mustered by humankind, please tell me. Because we're made of both things, kindness and craving. If you did make us, that's the complicated clay you used, those two ingredients in equal measure. So, you tell me. Which one is right?

Oh! God.

A deer in the road startled me from my head back into the world, and I slammed to a hard stop, gripping the steering wheel. Poor Gaz whined from the back, shaken as much as I was. We watched the doe amble out of the road and leap without any effort over a fence into a hay field. I hadn't been driving fast, thank goodness. But I knew there were two stop signs and the twenty-five-miles-per-hour speed zone of the elementary school behind me, between my house and here, and I had no memory of any of them. I eased off the brake and drove with acute attention toward the high school where I had a day of lessons scheduled. My heart was pounding.

I could have run over a child. One more casualty to add to the wreck.

I liked my Thursdays at the high school, especially this time of the fall with a new school year bringing a start-over feeling even to tired hearts. I wasn't employed by the school, but gave lessons there to students who had interest and parents willing to pay. The ones who came to my house on Fridays and Saturdays were mostly old enough to drive themselves. Otherwise, they left classrooms to sit with me on a piano bench in the same high school I attended, or on Mondays and Tuesdays, in the wood-paneled elementary school auditorium where I used to play Bellini's Grand March as my classmates shuffled in for assemblies. These schools extended an unconventional leniency to me, my livelihood, and my dog. Little country schools have to make their own rules. When their boiler inevitably broke down every winter, our elementary students took stints of their public education in the Sunday school rooms of the Baptist church.

At the high school, I gave lessons in a little auxiliary piano room attached to the main music space used for chorus and band practice. That band room was always a turmoil of half-dismantled instruments and overturned music stands, but my annex was an acoustic-tiled little hideaway that reminded me of practice rooms past. The piano was a decent Yamaha upright, and my Thursday students were all earnest in one way or another. The one I'd mentioned to Charlie, getting my mother's regift as her wedding present, was working on Elgar's "Salut d'Amour" to play for her husband as a surprise at their reception. When I told her Elgar composed it for his girlfriend when he proposed, she was sold. Edwina had taken lessons from me in elementary and high school, then for some years drove to my house. Now she worked as a secretary in the high school office, and it was handy for us to meet there. She intended to keep her job after she married, but had confided she wasn't sure how her husband would feel about the piano lessons. Maybe the surprise wedding piece was a tactical plea. I urged her to keep up her practice, no matter what. "Believe me," I told her, "these pieces you've learned will be your friends for life."

For the most part, my Thursday was a parade of high school girls of various abilities. One by one, they came during some free period in their block scheduling, with their surprising hair and clothes and little confessed exploits or grudges against certain teachers, which I officially discouraged but secretly enjoyed. They saw me as an ally, not part of the dour, unified wall of schoolteaching they resented on principle. I loved how they always bent down before taking the bench to ruffle Gazzie's nape and greet him

with pursed-lipped baby talk, which he bore with dignity. Some of these kids came to school altered, but if I recognized the skunky scent of marijuana, I didn't mention it. Sometimes anesthesia is survival. I ought to know. We pretended it was all about the little balls of gum these girls spit out and dropped in the trash can by the door as they ducked in, a ritual acknowledgment of this solemn hour that stood apart from their otherwise gum-cracking high school lives. I was flattered by their seriousness.

My favorite pupil was the last of the day, an eighth-grade boy who came over to take his lesson at the high school. My other younger pupils were allowed to leave class for a half hour on the days I gave lessons in their schools, but Deronne had started as a first-grader, with an alphabet-zealot teacher who begrudged him any absence for art or nonsense. I met with him and his parents at my house, watched his hungry little hands go after those keys, and knew right away a half hour wasn't going to do it anyway. We worked out an after-school bus-riding arrangement to the high school and had kept some form of it ever since.

Whatever I assigned Deronne, he devoured and wanted more. He used the computer at the library to find and print out sheet music, all on his own. Everything about him was different from my other pupils: his small stature, outsized discipline, and obvious feeling for every note he played. The color of his skin. Black families are fairly few in our county, Black piano students fewer. (None, until Deronne.) I've wondered if his family's sense of difference might partially account for their support of their son's choice. My other boys inevitably dropped piano as soon as they were sturdy enough to pick up a bat or ball or tackle another body on a field. I got used to this slow defeat as they woke up to male expectations, hastened along by cruel remarks. And by parents, who tended to pull for the athletic path, same as my parents did when Cy asked for piano lessons. Piano was for Livia, they said; Cyrus would find something that suited him better. A sport. They had to know he was tormented for being different—*sensitive* was what they called it. I'm sure they thought any good parents would do the same.

So Cyrus and I were sneaky about it. In the one year we had together after he got his driver's license, Cy always picked me up from practicing, and I'd let him play around on the keys in the empty church. I taught him the difference between major and minor scales, how two half steps of difference—such a small thing—turns a whole melody happy or sad. We worked out renditions of songs we heard on the radio. "I Just Called to Say

I Love You," by Stevie Wonder, is one I remember. I have thought and thought about those secret lessons, wondering how I could have tried harder, taken him more seriously, found the small alteration that could have shifted his mood from minor to major. The song that would have made him want to go on being my brother.

Now I worried about Deronne, but maybe that was guilt carried over from Cy. As far as I could tell, Deronne loved his life and did not much care what other boys thought. He was small for his age, dark-skinned, wore thick glasses; maybe piano playing was down the list of things a boy gets teased for. All I knew was that he leaned into his lessons like a thirsty boy gulping water. The intensity I recognized, a state that comes into you like new love. The feeling that you're not digging for the well of music because it's already there, bubbling up from inside you.

In good weather, Mickie and I liked to walk together after school on Thursdays. If no teams were on the track, we'd stroll around the asphalt oval. Otherwise, we could take a little trail from the end of the football field into the woods where kids went for the shenanigans they needed to keep out of the eyeline of teachers. Sometimes we'd find spent rubbers back there, and express our admiration for what young people can fit into a fifteen-minute break.

These walks had been Mickie's idea to begin with, back when her kids were little. She said we needed the exercise, but what we needed was time to talk without kids or husbands or the pretense of getting something done. We both came from families where physical work was a given, and leisure was putting your feet up, so exercising on purpose was not in our nature. Still, we took our walks. I waited today at our meeting spot by the bus drop-off, where Gaz tolerated a lot of slapdash petting and the sound of his name squealed out of bus windows. Could be worse. And was, at the elementary school. Mickie came out the door talking with the principal, a woman I'd only ever heard her call Bad News Beryl. When she spotted Gaz and me, her face lit and she walked toward us mugging exaggerated relief. Mickie favored her mother, Faye, same blond hair kept short, same magnetism. At just past forty, she was still what people call cute: short, curvy, good at dressing for her hourglass shape without overdoing it. More than a few high school boys crushed on Mrs. Barnes, I happened to know, even if they

thought her AP Lit class would unman them. Whether it's a boon or burden to be admired like that, I wouldn't know. I've always been the opposite of curvy, just a little thicker about it now. Like a two-by-four instead of a flagpole.

We were barely off the pavement before Mickie started talking about Betts. The tattoo was only the beginning; the confession floodgates had opened. Betts informed Mickie she wanted to be queer. "*Her* word," Mickie said. "Is there such a thing as getting child-splained? I told her I get it! Queer is a category now, not an insult."

"She wants to be, or she *is*?"

"She's working that out. I guess that's why all the swearing me to secrecy. I think she wanted to try it out on me first. To see how it bounced, as the kids say."

"And how did it?" I asked.

"With me? Fine. I think James will be too."

"And Faye and Teddy?"

"Grandpa's got bigger worries right now, but you know Mom. If Betts decided she was a fricking mermaid, Grandma would sew on a tail for her. I am not going to keep this from her. Or James. Betts doesn't need to know. Lord, I'm a damn double agent in my own home."

"Family life," I said, feeling the pinch of my secrets. I could talk to Mickie about anything except preoccupations with a man who wasn't her brother. We paused for a gaggle of boys running around the track in regular school clothes. Recreation or a punishment, hard to guess. We turned and crossed the brittle grass toward the football field.

"The thing about Betts is, she's always been kind of . . . what we *used* to call queer," Mickie said. "You know? Going her own way. I think this means she's decided to be happy about it. God knows, high school is hell. But she'll find her people when she goes away to college."

We stepped carefully over the freshly limed yard lines and so did Gaz, keeping pace at my left knee. "You sound sure that will happen for her."

Mickie looked at me, surprised. "Well, yeah. Didn't it for you?"

"In college, I was less of a freak, more a poor kid from the sticks. Pick your poison."

"At UT, we were *all* poor kids from the sticks. That was your mistake, being a genius scholarship prodigy."

I laughed. "Live and learn."

I saw her eyes drop for a second to my scarred hand. I never talked about my time in college. When I came back, my household was entirely taken up with my dying father. Mickie was in high school, Charlie's kid sister. A shiny penny. Too young to hear my secrets, so I heard hers: how she loved James, decided to have sex with him, was torn up about leaving him to go to college. Later on, we fell in as equals with that rare thing in common: We'd both been away.

"Did you ever think you might not come back here after college?" I hadn't asked her before, not in so many words. I wondered if I was trying to lead us into something as we stepped out of the end zone, literally into the woods.

She laughed. "Not for one minute. Mr. James Barnes would have come and fetched me home from Knoxville slung over his shoulder."

She held up a branch for me to duck under, onto the path. The woods were cooler inside. We fell into single file. "Here's some news," she said from behind me. "Your three Furies asked me if I'll sponsor them for a drama club this year. They want to put on a play."

"I don't know how they're *mine*," I said. "*You* had them for AP Lit last year."

"You started it. Seven years of piano recitals have turned them into exhibitionists. You watch, they'll pick some play that's a flamethrower aimed at the school board."

Our Furies—Bella, Cleo, and Rose—had a dozen visible piercings between them and covered the full hair-color spectrum on repeat every year. All three started piano in fifth grade. Nobody was headed in the scholarship-prodigy direction, but their persistence was impressive.

"Bella's mad at me. I thought she was going to drop lessons, but the three of them must have some kind of pact. She still shows up, but now she's got this shoulder hunch, like, *I am playing Bach under protest.*"

Mickie laughed. "I know the sulk. What did you do to her?"

"I wouldn't let her play 'Go Rest High on That Mountain' for her recital piece. Her pappaw died, and she wanted to do it as a tribute."

"Well, that's actually sweet. You know those grandparents are raising her, right?"

I did. Bella's father was doing time for selling heroin, and her mother was a hot mess. "I probably should have given her a pass. It's a hard row to hoe, Steele County."

“Harder than it was for us. Half these kids are dealing with so much stuff at home, they don’t have the bandwidth for school. The family’s getting evicted, or drunk Dad’s moving back in, whatever. They’re already pissed off before they get to my classroom. And if the president can act like a dick, why shouldn’t they? *Adulthood* is not on their radar.”

“I know. Our Furies have good cause for being furious.”

“And you didn’t let Bella play her country standard, because?”

“I told her she could play whatever she pleased at her pappaw’s funeral. But for recital, we were going with one of the European dead guys.”

“You let Deronne go with an American dead guy.”

“Also a great composer. I can’t believe you remember that.” Deronne had asked to play “The Single Petal of a Rose” for his last recital. Deronne’s father was a janitor at the truck plant, his mother was a cashier, and Duke Ellington evidently had a place at their table. “It’s a slippery slope, though. If you didn’t hold the line, wouldn’t your literature students all be reading Marvel Comics instead of *Wuthering Heights*?”

“No, they would be watching the Marvel Comics *movies*.”

“And my piano students want to play ‘Wagon Wheel’ or ‘Whiskey Lullaby.’”

The path was wider now and she stepped in beside me again. “And here we stand on the balcony, holding the universe together.” She made little air quotes to tell me this was from a book. I’d made her do that, ever since Wreck of the *Hesperus*. How else were we supposed to know when it was somebody famous versus the regular genius of Mickie?

“You know I’m right,” I protested. “It’s your job to teach them what a sonnet is, and mine to help them feel like Beethoven is just as welcome in their house as Vince Gill. Isn’t that part of getting adulthood on their radar? Learning about the best music people have made, not just last week but in our history? There’s no reason for them to think great art doesn’t belong to them.”

“Oh, Livvie. There are so many reasons.”

There were. At home, at school: *That stuck-up business is not for us.* “Who made that rule, though? Did *we* make it, or was it made to keep us out?”

“Who’s *we*?”

“People that like line dancing in a bar and going to baseball games. Your family, your students. The ones who don’t think they’d feel very welcome

in an art museum or a concert hall."

The path put us out of the woods onto a gravel road alongside a hayfield. We usually turned back there. Today we kept going. For the first time all week, I was seeing past the clutter in my head. Tall ironweeds bloomed in the hayfield, their flat purple flower heads stretching across it like a magic carpet levitating above the tall grass. The smells of late summer curled up in my rib cage. Early summer is Beethoven—overflowing. Late summer is a mix of happy and sad, like Shostakovich or Samuel Barber. An August hayfield smells like Barber's *Adagio for Strings*. "Maybe the Furies will adopt Betts, now that she's starting high school," I said.

Mickie gave me a side-eye. "I'm breaking my vow of silence here, but it was Cleo that gave her the homemade tattoo, at the sleepover. Cleo's sister Theresa and Betts are pretty tight." Mickie's hand went to her cheek. "Oh. Maybe tighter than I've been thinking."

"Betts will be okay," I said. As if I knew the first thing about it. Cleo was clean, I did know that. She hated Bella's messed-up parents on her friend's behalf.

"You know what? Betts will be. Honestly, it's Ethan I'm worried sick about."

"*Ethan*, the handsome prince? Seriously?" Football captain, pretty cheerleader girlfriend, spitting image of his father, James, who still smiled from old team photos in the school's hallway trophy cabinets.

Mickie didn't smile. "Maybe that's his problem. Everything's been too easy for him."

"*There's* a problem to have."

"I nagged him all summer to think about college. Senior year, he has decisions to make."

"Can you all afford it?"

"*Who* can afford it? Nobody! Do you know what it costs to go to UT now? It's like ten times what it was for me, and the scholarships we got aren't there anymore. It's insane. There'll be debt, but we could figure it out. I want them both to assume it's possible."

"Maybe he doesn't want to put that on you."

"You're crediting him with compassion for his parents. No, he told James yesterday, or whatever day it was when James let him skip school to put up hay . . ."

"Yeah, Charlie was in on that. Sorry."

“So”—Mickie looked at me, her lips pinched—“he’s *not* going. Flat-out no, doesn’t want to discuss it. Sees no reason for it.”

A silence stretched between us, letting a whine of cicadas into my ears. It was awful, like tinnitus. “You’re surprised,” I finally said.

She blew air between her lips. “Shouldn’t be, I guess. None of his friends will be going away. James didn’t. Nobody else from my graduating class did, as far as I remember. My friend Jeannie went to nursing school, but then she got pregnant and quit.”

“You and I were the oddballs, Mickie.”

“We were the *lucky* oddballs. We got to go see another little piece of the world, and learn things that let us come back here with livelihoods we’re glad to have.”

I felt a little bit chastened. If my livelihood wasn’t the one I’d planned, it was still our Thanksgiving turkey and our Farm Bureau health plan. Some years, it was what kept the lights on. “You drive a hard bargain, ma’am. Insisting on the decency of a person being thankful.”

“Right? He’s wasting his luck. It hurts to see it. Most of his friends don’t have a prayer of leaving this county or finding a decent job, and he has this opportunity he’s blowing off.”

“Maybe everything he wants is here.”

“I’m sure you’re right. He wants to work with James and take over the construction business and marry his high school sweetheart and just, you know. Be his father.”

“A happy man,” I pointed out.

“Do you know what Beryl was telling me when we came out of the building today?”

“Let me guess. Bad news?”

“She said the school board wants to redirect the funds for AP English.”

“Redirect? Do they mean your salary?”

“They won’t fire me. They’ll put me on freshman comp and more hours in the remedial lab for these ninth-graders reading at grade-five level.”

“Oh, Mickie. The stuff you tolerate so you can have your few happy hours of AP Lit.”

“She says she can’t justify it to the school board, with enrollment going down every year. How can I argue with that?”

We’d reached a fork where the gravel road gave way to rutted dirt. We never came this far. The cicada whine filled my head in an awful way.

Mickie took the right-hand fork and kept walking. “I wish we didn’t have to call it Advanced Placement,” she said. “Anything called *advanced* is toxic in high school. Especially for a boy. All fine and good to advance in state football championships. Just not in school. Poetry or music, God forbid.”

“Some kids don’t feel like they belong in college.” I offered. “I’m not sure I did.”

“Oh, Ethan feels entitled to go where he wants. I think it’s more about who he wants to be. Or *doesn’t*. It’s not that he says this exactly, but I almost think he doesn’t want to be the kind of person who *went* to college.”

“Which is who? People with decent-paying jobs?”

Mickie made a comical face. “You and me, lady. We’re pulling down the big bucks.”

“I mean theoretically. I guess I mean . . . men.”

“I’m saying CEOs and politicians and the people in charge that everybody thinks are screwing us over. God knows he hears that from James. *All they do is line their pockets and screw over the working man*.”

“And going to college would turn Ethan to the dark side?”

“Well, given what it costs, I think it’s safe to say most of the people there already came from lined pockets. But yes. The superior attitude derives from the fancy education, I believe that is the thinking.” She looked at me. “What? You don’t find that maddening?”

“It’s just not news to me, Mickie. My mother thought I’d go away and turn all high and mighty. She’d have tied me to the kitchen sink if she thought it would stop me.”

“Well, yeah, same. Not my parents, but James. He was sure I was going to meet some *rich guy* and never come back. That’s what he kept saying. Somebody more sophisticated.”

“Funny, my mother’s worry was that I’d get too educated to attract a husband.”

Mickie smiled. “She didn’t see Charlie coming.”

Most of us didn’t, of course. “It’s funny, I can remember you so well from back then. I have two completely different Mickies in my head, the girl and the grown-up friend.”

“Hoo boy. That little one was some kind of whoop-ass weird.”

“Were you? You loved to read, is all, the same way I loved music. Remember that weeping willow down by the creek between your farm and ours?”

“My reading room! I *loved* it in there. Like a green bell jar. Is that tree still standing?”

“It is. Waiting for the next time you run away from home.”

“Just let me go grab a good book. I am so there.”

Little-girl Mickie was independent, almost comically fierce, but I’d never thought of her as an oddball like me. Adolescence opened different doors. She was pretty, had a figure in middle school. James and Mickie were popular kids, sweethearts. The long complexity of a life hinges on such an early throw of the dice: timely puberty, athleticism. A mother who adores you.

“Maybe it was easier for your family to let their girl go because they had Charlie to run the farm.” I reconsidered. “Or did they? Think Charlie would be able to do that?”

“Maybe not at first, but by the time I went to college, yes. That was after he got his legs.”

They always said that, *when Charlie got his legs*, even though it’s just one expensive foot with a cup and straps to attach to the stump of his shin. Invisible under a shoe and sock. What people could see was a walking, cheerful, completely transformed boy, like the fairy-tale mermaid who cut some deal to get legs and live with the land folk. Charlie walked into the world where boys and men earned respect with their bodies—on the football field, or fields of hay and cattle. Why should anybody ask them to read *Hamlet* or play a sonata?

Mickie was churning similar thoughts. “How can I argue for AP Lit if I can’t get my own son’s ass to college? They’re right. It’s a waste of time and money.”

Mickie was so rarely defeated, I couldn’t stand to see it. “Or maybe it’s the opposite. High school might be their last chance to learn about literature. You’re not teaching Dickens so they can write novels. You’re teaching them how to broaden their lives with stories. They’ll have that forever.”

“Well, true. Just like you’re not training kids to be professional musicians.”

“Maybe Deronne. But for the most part, no.”

“So they’ll play Christmas carols for their families once a year, that’s the use of it?”

I thought of the Livia I was once, just before my future collapsed. The girl with the brilliantly gifted hands, making them into fists and shaking them at heaven, asking exactly that: *What good is music?* Anybody would say I deserved what I got.

"Mostly I think of it as my only marketable skill," I said.

"I'm not buying that. For the same money, you could be working in the school cafeteria, feeding those kids mashed potatoes. You're giving them music instead. Because you want to."

I thought about it. "Maybe I'm teaching them to hear better. To understand and feel what's inside whatever they're listening to."

"Fair," she said. "Some things just help you feel more alive. When I went to UT and enrolled in Russian lit, all I was thinking was how great it would feel. I'd only been dipping my toes in. Now I could get in there and swim around. I wanted to skinny-dip in Tolstoy!"

"That was me in my first music theory class. I was like a Holy Roller in church."

She nodded. "The point of art is to help you like your life better."

I felt a throb at my throat. This was all I needed, back then. Somebody to tell me this.

Our walk had gone on so long, it felt like we were getting away with something. Gaz kept looking up at me, to make sure this was all aboveboard. I touched his neck to reassure us both: *Yes, we can have this.* The tips of the tall grass in the field looked gilded where afternoon light fell across it. The cicada whine had quieted, giving over to birdsongs from the woods behind the pastures. I could hear their melodies joining and dividing, from little feathered bodies that couldn't hold in their love for the world's wealth of insects and seed heads. I felt a swell of happiness for birdsongs at daybreak and in the gloaming, tucking in the day on both sides. And for my sister-in-law. Life doesn't give you many friends like this, if it gives you any at all.

If it hadn't happened the way it did, if he'd not broken me to pieces, I'd not have come back to this.

I was so close to telling her. But something so big, held back for so long, was a kind of unfaithfulness to both of them. A thick coil of evasion I'd wound around myself, right from the beginning of our adult confidences. Pulling that apart now would leave holes in our family. I groped around for something else to talk about. Other secrets.

“You know those pictures I found? The shoeboxes of soldier boys?”

“Yeah?”

“There were girl boxes too. Brides. Hairstyles for brides, fresh looks for brides. I think it must have been a collection of make-believe children she could love, instead of us.”

Mickie nodded. “Sorry. That woman was very many fries short of a Happy Meal.”

“There’s personal stuff too. A bunch of letters to her, from her mother.”

“*That’s* interesting. Was it, like, the mean-mom chain of command?”

I blew out my breath. “Mickie, there’s so much stuff in that house, I feel swallowed.”

“You didn’t read the letters.”

“I can’t read any of it. There’s worse.”

“How do you mean, worse?”

“I found this big manila envelope labeled ‘Cyrus.’ Mostly clippings. Nothing that’s even about him. But tucked down in there . . .” I wasn’t sure I could say it. I hadn’t quite let myself believe what it was, had shoved it away like something that could burn my hands.

I said it: “There’s an envelope that says ‘Mom’ on the front. In his handwriting.”

“*What?*” Mickie stopped walking and stared at me. I had to stop too.

“I wasn’t supposed to see any of it. I feel sick just talking about it.”

She went on staring at me with her mouth open. Gaz lay down at my feet to wait this out.

“She hid all this stuff in her wedding dress box. It was a whole thing, that box under her bed. She lorded it over me that she saved her dress for me, and then I disappointed her with our non-wedding.”

Mickie shook her head, almost violently. “*Screw* the wedding dress. There’s a letter from your *brother*? And you haven’t *read* it?”

“It wasn’t meant for me.”

Christ almighty, did Mickie have a *don’t bullshit me* face. Before now, I’d only ever seen it aimed at her offspring.

“I know. But I’m scared.”

“Livia! Look in the envelopes! Read the letters! Whatever she was, it can’t be worse than the monster you think she was. And anything your brother had to say is yours to know.”

Gaz got up, alerting to something at the far end of the field. Mickie and I turned to see deer, all raising their heads at once. Three adults and four adolescent fawns, their graceful, red-brown bodies half submerged in the tall grass. They stood identically posed, gazing at us in the evening light with tall ears cocked, their stillness somehow vibrating with apprehension. And then they were gone, adults and young together jumping with perfect ease over barbed wire into the dark woods. I thought of the deer in the road that morning, and the phantom that was chasing me, causing me to go blind to this world.

Mickie touched my arm, registering what we'd witnessed. Then we turned back toward the school and our cars and home and all the rest. Our lives.

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Fugue

Jon Link left money in a bank account for our rent and bills that summer. It would cover his two-thirds, and the rest was up to me. This was a worry. Dr. Betis had recommended me to another visiting artist after Brockhaus left, but it was very short-term and lower paid, and I'd lost all interest in bowing down to another big personality. I passed. Stephania Schmidt could have him. I was still working with two choirs, but only one would last through the end of summer, when my work-study started again. It wouldn't be enough. Being the hardworking poor in this place was all the student life I'd known, but today I resented it.

I walked across campus trying to recast my mood. I was in love, happier than I ever thought I could be! Why should I be mad about the gum on the sidewalk that stuck to my sandal, the grumbling sky that threatened rain? But I was. Also, the fake campus flower beds transformed overnight, from yesterday's flagging spring tulips to bright summer swaths of marigolds and impatiens today. I doubted if one other person on campus noticed that gardeners did this in the off-hours, invisible men in coveralls kneeling to yank out the old and tuck in the new. It embarrassed me to think of them down in the dirt like that, laboring to preserve for us students the illusion of perfect flowers magically shape-shifting from spring to fall. Nothing ever struggling up out of the ground here, nothing allowed to go to seed.

I sorted through the bills in my head: rent by the first of July. Water and electricity, at least, would be low since I'd used none of either, to speak of. It was a waste to pretend I still lived in Jon Link's apartment, but it also seemed wrong to bail on him while he was in Munich. I needed to write and let him know I was continuing my demotion, from lover to roommate to getting myself moved out of his life completely before he came back in September. In the meantime, I would apply myself to becoming solvent. At worst, maybe Sigurd would help tide me over, but the thought of asking him made me uneasy. We ate and slept and washed dishes together, he brought home groceries and I made meals, but we'd never talked about money. Not the kind we used in our actual lives, anyway. As opposed to the wealth of nations and so forth, from each according to his means.

I opened all the windows in our sweltering, non-air-conditioned apartment when I got home. Then all the loose-hinged cabinets in that little kitchen, looking for neglected dinner possibilities. Sigurd wasn't home yet, so I applied myself to making spaghetti sauce while my solitude stretched itself thin. His meetings rarely ran this late. I had our supper simmering on the faintest possible glow of the gas ring when he finally came in, looking tired. I asked how the meeting went, but wasn't really listening for an answer as I stood in the open mouth of the fridge, taking my time breathing refrigerated air while I fetched ice for our glasses.

When I turned around, he was sitting at the table, looking at me with an expression I couldn't understand. Anxious. Excited.

"What?" I asked.

"I'm going to Arizona."

"Oh," I said. "For how long?"

"The Party needs me to move there."

I closed the fridge, set down the ice cube tray, turned off the gas ring, and sat down across from him. "What do you mean, they need you to move there? You live here."

He told me what he meant, in a voice too quiet for the size of what he was saying. The Party was moving their entire membership into the basic industrial unions. It wasn't a new idea, had been in the works for years, in fact, debated at their national conventions in Oberlin, Ohio. The chapters had agreed unanimously to make what they were calling the "turn to industry," but some turned more speedily than others. The Bloomington comrades had lagged. Apparently now they found it urgent to toe the line.

This chapter would fold, cutting ties with campus activism and shuttling out all its members to the higher calling.

"Railroad and steel and mining," he said, genuinely excited, as if I should be too. "Those are the most combative unions, and that's where we have to concentrate our base. Los Angeles and Phoenix already have a strong membership in the railroad workers' union."

"And you'll go there, to do that. You're acting like you don't have a choice."

"I do, Livia. I'm sure this seems sudden, because I haven't been talking about it. But there's nothing about this you didn't already know. I'm in the Party, and this is a requirement. So that's my choice."

"A *requirement*! What kind of organization tells you what to do and where to live?"

"How can you ask that? Your colleagues get jobs with symphony orchestras in New York or Munich or wherever, and off they go. You'll do the same one day."

"I have no idea if that's true. I might not be so lucky. But those are *jobs*."

"Organizing is my job. It's the work I care about. Our membership isn't that big yet, so we have to be strategic."

"I thought . . ." I shook my head, looked at the ceiling, wondering what the hell I did think. "I thought you were a typesetter."

"It was never the typesetting that mattered to me. You know that. Rail workers are affiliated with AFL-CIO. It's a better place to be, for recruitment."

I was struggling to believe this was real. "So, you infiltrate the unions and light the fire of revolution. That's how this goes down?"

He ignored the unkindness in my tone and said yes. That's how this would go down.

I got up and went to the window and looked down on some kids playing in the alley behind our building. I felt very strongly the urge to throw up. The window was open as wide as the sash could be shoved, but outside was the same as inside, muggy and hot. No escape. I pressed my face so hard against the screen I could feel the rasp of its wires on my nose, smell its metal and dust. It was late, but we'd come into those June days when the Indiana daylight hung around like it had no place else to go. The kids down below were throwing pieces of gravel at a dog that kept creeping out from behind a dumpster, then darting back behind it again. Three boys, two of

them old enough to know better, the younger one probably trying to get into the mean-boys club. The dog was a little white, short-haired cur I'd not seen before. I didn't recognize the kids either. I'd made no real effort to get to know the neighborhood.

I took a deep breath and swallowed, trying to shut a door on the queasiness that was shoving up from below.

"We don't even get to talk about this?" I asked.

He said we were talking now.

Talking was not the right word. We argued. I woke up every morning and went to bed every night with fresh resolve to stop asking, *What about me?* His answer wasn't going to change. We each had our own choices to make. His Party would soon cease to exist in this place, and he could erase himself with it, or follow. That's how he saw it. That band of believers was the only future he trusted, and the meaning that shaped his days. If I'd ever wanted to share this important part of his life, he said, it would have made him happy. He'd wished for it sometimes. But I never did. It made no sense for me to suggest he was deliberately shutting me out of it now.

I asked him point-blank, then: Was he asking me to go with him?

"I wish I could," he said, and seemed to mean it. "But you told me, you're not a joiner."

A bitter pill to swallow now. I'd been clear about that from our first or maybe second conversation, and he'd taken me at my word. He'd never asked me come to a single meeting after that first leaflet. Out of respect, he said. He had no right to impose his agenda on my ambitions. He'd seen my life, the hours, the practice and solitude, how I pushed everything else away to preserve my dedication. I could hardly remember that girl myself, but he was talking to her now. A serious musician.

What if it isn't important, isn't my future, I wanted to say. But I wasn't brave enough to ask those questions.

He referred to this complete wreckage and reconstruction of his life as a "transfer," and it was being sponsored by some people he called the Phoenix branch. Over the next two weeks, he was on the phone a lot as they worked on his behalf, helping to put in his applications to the railroad, sorting out where he would live when he got there. Southern Pacific was

hiring. Their simulator school was in Phoenix, so that's where he would spend his first months, training.

The railroad. He explained the hierarchy of jobs, fireman, brakeman, on up to engineer. I wanted to scream. A train. *Again.* Sigurd didn't seem to register that part of the misery for me. He didn't know I was still haunted by their whistles, or a track rumbling under car wheels. I hid my irrational fears. I'd wanted to be a certain kind of woman around Sigurd, serious, reasonable, maybe a little older or more worldly than I was. I was vague on historical materialism, but pretty sure Marxists did not truck with superstition.

Exams, certifications, on he talked, wanting me to be excited for him. After he was hired on a crew, he would work toward enough seniority to ask for a new location. The goal was Los Angeles, for some reason, but first Arizona, for a period of time nobody could predict, depending on how well he did in training and who transferred in or out. I couldn't stand to listen to these specifics. They felt like pieces of gravel he was throwing at me. I was the little stray cur, running behind the dumpster and then creeping back out to wonder again and again, *What about me?*

For a while, I tried to hurt him, going to bed before he came in at night and pretending to be asleep, as I'd done with Jon Link. With no success. His body beside me was like a planet with its gravity. I fell. I couldn't deny myself the comfort of his arms and affections, which still felt completely real. I did know, in some shut-away part of my brain, I ought to gather up my socks and hairbrush and sheet music into a laundry basket and march back to the empty apartment where I was still trying to keep the lights on. Any sane woman would. But sanity is hard to pin down where love is concerned, a concoction made of equal parts reality, hope, trust, and delusion. Or not equal parts, maybe not at all. I only knew this thing between Sigurd and me, our talk and our touch, still felt tangible to me, like a house. Something that couldn't just disappear.

I let myself cry sometimes, especially after we made love. He said he was sorry, a lot. He cared about me and wished things could be different. He didn't wish we were different people, he said. He wished the people we were could find a way to make this work. "But who would those people be?" I asked, truly wanting to know. We sat up in bed holding hands,

sometimes, playing fugues of fantasy in which I would fly away with him to the promised land of Phoenix.

I closed my eyes, imagining. “I’m picturing sand and date trees.”

He laughed. “I think that’s the Sahara.”

“Sorry. I don’t get out much. Maybe a little house somewhere, with cactus in the yard.”

“And a bed,” he said.

“In the yard?”

“Why not? It’s warm there, all year round. And never rains.”

I grabbed him gently by the soft parts. “We would scandalize the neighbors. And you would be excommunicated from the revolutionary faithful.”

“It’s not a religion,” he said, not amused, and from there our song fell into dissonant chords, every time. I couldn’t find the theme.

It didn’t look that different from religion, to me. A lot of people believing in some glorious thing that only existed because they all believed in it. But if I had to be honest, my tribe was just the same. If we all walked away from music, our god would fall without a sound. Recluse that I was, I’d never minded shutting myself up alone with a piano till the cows came home. But one swallow does not a spring make, as they say. Training myself toward performance, backing up other musicians, reaching the ears of our audiences—music really only existed as a collective endeavor. I wasn’t always charitable about my peers, but I did need them, as much as Sigurd needed his. Flying away from my life here wouldn’t just mean giving up the diploma I’d nearly earned and the career that was almost in sight. I would be abandoning my only real faith. He wasn’t going to ask me to do that.

If we’d ever wanted the same future, he said, this would be easier for us. A future in railroad work and revolution, I assumed he meant. He would have welcomed that. Only he said *we* would welcome it, and the *we* made me shudder. Even if Sigurd was one of them. I wanted other choices. Something between all of Sigurd and none of him.

If I wasn’t part of his revolution, I couldn’t expect it to take care of me. People of my kind aren’t brought up to be parasites. I might vaguely remember how to milk a cow, but hadn’t done anything most people would call *useful* since serving pizzas to fraternity boys at Gorgo’s my freshman year. Who would I be without music? Since my beginnings as a person, I’d

found home in the world I could make by touching a piano, among people who could listen. In the way of practical skills I might offer in this world that was calling to Sigurd, I had nothing. How could I trust his gravity and follow him with empty hands, now that I knew my position in his universe? I was not his North Star. I was leaveable.

Like many a foolish woman before me, I'd mistaken first-rate sex for love. Or maybe it's not that simple. If *love* meant affection and attention, he'd given me those things, causing me to bend like a plant to his light. But after I fell out of my trance, I could see he gave those things away wherever he went. He reveled in every satisfaction of being alive: the books he read, the food he ate, the love he made, the revolution on his horizon, the neighbor he met in the stairwell when he took out the trash. This struck me all at once, in a kind of crushing blow, one morning when I came out the door just behind him to drag myself to a rehearsal. He didn't know I was at the top of the stairs, watching as he set the trash bag down on the landing, turned his body, and aimed the full bore of his time and beautiful eyes toward Mrs. Robins. He asked how she was, and she delivered as if he'd slotted quarters into the newspaper box: her arthritis, her son about to be paroled, the water stain on her ceiling. She was a tiny Black lady with close-cropped white hair and pink rubber flip-flops on her bunioned feet, but she stood taller by degrees as he asked her more questions, agreeing that her son was sentenced too harshly for a drug offense, promising to call the apartment manager about the water leak. If he'd known how to relieve her arthritis pains, he'd have taken the time to do it. In a way, I'm sure he did. Mrs. Robins probably kept an eye out her window for the chance to run into Sigurd on the stairwell.

How had I not seen it? Every old lady in our building was in love with him, and so were the old men who sat on the fire stairs in their undershirts and commiserated about their pensions, and the rowdy kids with whom he'd shoot a couple of hoops as he passed by their parking lot court, and all of their young mothers. At my first sight of him, the married professor beside me declared she'd buy whatever that man was selling. I should have understood, I was only ever going to be one among so many. But that's the thing about irresistible people: They make you feel like you are *the* one among many. If Sigurd claimed to love, he meant *I'm here for you right now, all of me, body and soul, in this moment.* When I said it, I meant *stay.*

I came home from a morning choir rehearsal to find him packing his books into boxes. I went in the bedroom and slammed the door but found no comfort there, thanks to the pile of empty boxes on the bed. He must have collected a carload from the alley behind the liquor store. I swept the bed clear and kicked one box hard enough to bounce against the wall, leaving my toe throbbing as I lay face down on the bed. I tried to erase images of Sigurd from my head as I listened to his noises from the other room. The scrape of a chair leg against the linoleum floor. The refrigerator gasping open, grunting closed. An ice cube tray whacked against the sink. He drank coffee like a fiend, and now, in the hot days, he poured it over ice, in a glass. In other, happier times, I'd teased him about it, declaring iced coffee was not a privilege allowed to the working classes. He said I was confusing class with self-denial. I'd climbed onto his lap, then, and let him nuzzle into my neck some words about "what happens to a dream deferred," a poem he knew, about how you shouldn't have to wait for what you want. He'd recited it, and then had me right there on the kitchen chair. That memory now made every inch of my skin hurt, even my eyelids.

In a while, he came in and sat down on the edge of the bed.

"Livia. You know this is happening. Please don't act surprised."

"When?" I managed to ask the pillow I'd burrowed my face into. It smelled of Sigurd.

"By the end of the month. I told the landlord. There's no use paying another month here."

There is no use.

I couldn't make myself sit up and face him. I felt like a petulant child, but I could not. Surprised, no, I couldn't pretend to that. Not generally, but in the specifics. In principle. Did that declaration of uselessness include me? Was this not my home too? Maybe not by any exact agreement. He knew I was financially tied to another apartment, and maybe had been thinking of that as my home. But I'd long ago discarded any plans on living there again. It was only thanks to inertia and an ounce of guilt that I hadn't yet written Jon Link to disclose my full exit. *I know this is happening, yes, Sigurd, but? Maybe at the end of summer. Maybe after a period of time that could reasonably allow for changes of heart.*

He waited patiently until I managed to sit up. He was kind, I was miserable, we spun our wheels in the nonsense of our disconnected futures.

Our recent past also threatened to unravel. What had it meant? Was this just what men always did, using a woman for a good time?

He was taken aback by that. “I’m sorry, has anything happened here without your consent? Was it not a two-way street?”

I couldn’t explain the sense I had of promises made and broken. But it burned in my belly. Over the course of days, our voices rose. In our time together, Sigurd had never once questioned my detachment or shyness that kept me from being what I’d called “a joiner.” I assumed that meant he didn’t mind. Now, suddenly, it seemed that he did. When I accused him of being too busy saving the world to wash his own damn dishes, he countered that my apathy was a cop-out. To see the damages of injustice but ignore the work of changing it was perpetration. “If you’re not greasing the skids of this revolution, you’re a rock in its road.”

I was making our breakfast just then, and he was sloganeering. I handed him the spatula, grabbed my music bag, and slammed the door on my way out. Disapproval was so unlike him. This man who thoughtfully explained class struggle, who read Marx to me wearing nothing but his glasses and generosity, suddenly sounded like a recruitment poster. I wondered if he was using these fighting words to burn through doubts of his own. Maybe hearing them in his meetings, aimed at any comrades who might still be dragging their feet on the “turn to industry.”

We only ever argued with our clothes on now. The barbershop was closed for good; nobody would ever again call me by a celestial pet name. We were putting all that behind us. In my worst moments, I stabbed at his tenderest part, his conscience, by resurrecting my awful claim about men using women, until he finally snapped that he’d felt pretty used himself. Maybe it’s the way of all partings. We roll out anger as a bandage to stanch the bleeding of loss.

But my feelings for Jon Link had drained off so fast, back in April, any argument I’d had left in me was an empty husk. With Sigurd, it was a huge, writhing grub of a thing. Outrage at abandonment, dread of desertion, mortification at the size of my need. Shame. For so many things, I felt guilty. A few months earlier, I hadn’t even known this man, had no need of him, wasn’t looking. What right did I have to demand so much of him now? Who was I? A half-invisible person with clever hands, and not much more to show for a day’s work than a smooth scalar run. He wanted to liberate the workers of the world. You don’t scoff at a soldier going to war, no matter

what you may think of the opponents or the odds. You stand in awe of his sacrifice. And I did, insofar as it kept bringing me back to questions of my own uselessness.

Whatever I was choosing over Sigurd should feel precious beyond all measure. But in order to weigh it against a different future, I had to step out of my music-school world and look back at it. What if all my work and dedication, my sound and occasional fury, signified nothing? With Sigurd as an accomplice, I had laid myself bare and found soft, malignant patches of doubt I couldn't just stitch back up and ignore. Questions of purpose. Nothing I was learning here would make things any better for my crippled father, or the grocery cashiers or weary schoolteachers or the kids who wore them out, all these people I'd grown up with. The ones my mother accused me of wanting to leave behind. Sigurd had listened to my darkest speculations about my high-minded vocation. And now he agreed.

I asked him to meet me for lunch at Gorgo's between the end of my choir practice and the start of his shift. Maybe in those wooden booths, the smell of baking dough or *something* could pull us back to the place where we started. My wishful thinking. He looked at the menu, ordered quickly, and didn't bother to take off his glasses before looking across the table to ask me what was up. Nothing was up. Except that it was killing me to see him so impatient to leave. He'd always found the campus off-putting—I knew that. Now he seemed mad at it. Not my music school specifically, the ivory tower in general. The nerve of it, to stand in the center of this town, throwing its shade over typesetters and quarrymen. He spent our short lunch talking about the meeting he'd just come from, an internal Party session devoted to self-criticism. Discussing the flaws in their previous strategy, and why this branch had misdirected their efforts here for so long after the national priorities moved on. It was obvious the revolution wasn't going to happen on a campus.

I grabbed the bill and paid it, since it was me who'd dragged him here. Unfortunately, he'd parked his car over on Eagleson, and the quickest way back to it was to cut through the campus he suddenly viewed as pestilent. We skirted Showalter Plaza, where I'd once found him behind the giant banner and the African singers. The nervy girl who walked through the phalanx of helpers to hand him her phone number. Fool that she was.

He was remembering too, I guess, frowning at the plaza. “These kids yell anti-colonialist slogans for half an hour, then go get in their BMWs and think they’re absolved.”

From what crime, I wondered. Heat waves shimmered above the pavement, and a bronze lady frolicked nude in the fountain, permanently frozen in an odd, sideways balance on one thigh. “The Birth of Venus,” her plaque said. Little surprises like this were scattered all around the campus between the classroom buildings. One was a statue of Hoagy Carmichael, who grew up in this town and worked in construction and taxi-driving before the piano started paying his way. A kid from my side of the tracks. This place must have mattered to him, because he’d donated so much of his life’s work back here, they had a whole room for him now in the archive building. Maybe the campus was full of itself, but it offered something precious. A long recess between childhood and adulthood in a playground for our hopes.

Sigurd turned us toward Eagleson, tight-lipped.

“Seems to me those kids were earnest,” I said. “From what I saw at one meeting.”

“Sure. They tell each other they’d lay down their lives to level the playing field,” he said, in a flat voice that was breaking my heart. “Fair and equal for every color of the rainbow. With no idea of the mountaintop they’re standing on. Who do they think they are?”

“Hard to say. There’s thirty-some thousand of them.”

“And they all got here the same way. The meritocracy is so built in, they never questioned it. Their parents all bragged on their precocious children and ferreted out any track that would put them ahead, without ever owning up to what *ahead* means. Ahead of the kids from families that can’t. Starting from kindergarten.”

“Nobody did any ferreting to get me here. My mother tried six ways to Sunday to blow up my rise through the ranks.”

“You can’t really deny what I’m saying, Livia.”

“You’re saying I took advantage of a piano-playing field that wasn’t *level*. Because I was born with perfect pitch and good finger coordination. Sorry.”

“I’m saying most of these kids get here because they had material advantages on the way up. Better high schools, at the very least.”

He knew I couldn't argue. I'd told him how lost I was when I had to take classes that weren't music. My Bio 101 classmates yawning through "a quick review of the Krebs cycle" while I panicked in an unknown land. A beginning French class held entirely in French. Teenagers discussing *being in France*. On school trips. In high school.

Sigurd didn't need to hear it. He dug into our nonargument. "They're headed for livelihoods they think are *better*, just like their schools were. Better jobs for better people."

Was he forcing me to take sides, so he could be mad at me too? "A union welder or pipe fitter can make good money," I pointed out. As he'd told me many times.

"But how would you even know that, or have any respect for those jobs, if you've grown up without one friend whose parents are plumbers or janitors? These kids don't know what labor *is*, and they don't give a damn about the people doing it. Nobody calls that segregation, but it is."

I could add waitress. My well-heeled classmates used to look right through me when I served them. But I didn't want him to be so right about everything. "That might be a stretch," I said.

"Is it? If you live your whole life without ever knowing a shift worker, how is that different from never having a friend of another race?"

We'd stopped at the corner where we had to go different ways, he to his car and his shift. Where we would have kissed, in another life. I looked in his eyes for something in him I could still reach, that wanted me back, but came up empty. I'd be damned if I'd let him see my heart leaking out. I turned away from him, toward the side he'd chosen for me. The practice building.

Maybe if I could work on a new piece. Quit asking what's the good of it and just go do it. I was walking fast, closing in on the spot where I'd first seen him on the sidewalk, not far from the hulking red steel sculpture he always declared a waste of good welding. We musicians weren't very nice about it either. We called it "The Dinosaur." But knew the art students held it in high regard, as the last piece ever installed by the famous sculptor Alexander Calder. I paused to look up at it. One person's Calder is another person's Hoagy Carmichael, and if you scoured the campus long enough, you'd surely find Charles Darwin or Einstein or Mr. Krebs Cycle, whoever he was. All of them deserved their place at our table. I could see that much, surely anybody could. This place had good intentions.

My feet turned away from the music building toward the little woods. Not his side, or the other side, just dirt and the things that want to grow in it. I needed a minute alone on one of the benches down there. I knew them all: the oak-tree one, the tadpole-pond one. Other people hurried through there like cars on a highway, but I wanted to sit with the frogs and their songs. The mud that smelled like walking out to the school bus with my brother in early spring.

For one or two days at the end, with his books boxed up and phone service canceled and illusions hard to sustain, I talked myself into thinking I could go with him. Talked us both into that. I swore to him I understood what this meant. I would be giving up everything I was doing here, joining the Party if that's what I needed to do, applying for an industrial job.

Except that I can't stand the sight of a train. I went cold under the sheets while he waxed poetic on the Southern Pacific. This was making him so happy. He wanted me again, pulling me close, my skin against his bare chest, his fingers tracking my spine, his lips in my hair telling me how tormented he'd been by the thought of leaving me. *Tormented.* On plenty of other nights, he'd been kind enough while I asked questions like a broken child. But not passionate. Not making it any harder for us. Now he swore he loved me, and I believed him.

"Look at these hands," he said, kissing them. "We'll put them to work."

I took them back, studied them. Hid them under the sheet. "Don't bet the farm. They've been locked up in a little room for a long, long time."

"You told me you used to keep up with your older brother carrying the big milk cans."

"I said I *tried*. I was six years old! My father and brother always laughed at how hard I was trying. And we were all relieved when the milking machines came in."

"Doesn't matter. You were born to be a working girl."

I pulled my face away from his chest to look him in the eye. "I'm a worker *now*. I don't think you give me credit for that. I've probably worked longer hours than anybody you know, for the proficiency I have."

His eyes changed, and I felt a shift in his body, his hands on my skin. "But you're not like other pianists, you told me that."

"*When* did I tell you that?"

“Finicky about their hands, afraid of heavy lifting. When you were a waitress. You said you felt more at home with restaurant workers at Gorgo’s than on campus.”

“I did. Before I started finding my way as a musician and getting jobs in my field.”

“Your jobs back up other people, and you don’t get any credit. You’re an accompanist.”

“I’m more than that,” I said, frustrated. Where paychecks were concerned, I wasn’t more than that. Not yet, maybe not ever. I untangled myself from Sigurd and rolled onto my back. The bowl-shaped light fixture above us had collected a scrum of dead insects in its belly. Without taking my eyes off of it, I told Sigurd I was having doubts, but that was not the same as giving up on a commitment. “I’ve put so much of my life into music, I’m scared to throw it away. I don’t think I can.”

He was quiet for a long time. We couldn’t look at each other. Finally he said quietly, “I’ve never asked you to throw anything away.”

“No, you haven’t. But I think you somehow expect that I should. I think you believe you’re doing something really important for the world, and I’m not. And maybe that’s true. But I don’t think you understand the stakes for me.”

He didn’t say, one way or another.

“Since I was six years old, I’ve hardly ever gone more than one or two days without playing a piano. Once, in third grade. I had mumps and wasn’t allowed to leave the house for a week. But after that, I didn’t tell my mother when I was sick so she wouldn’t lock me in. Maybe there were a couple of days after my brother died. But I played at his funeral that Friday, so. That’s it. To stop cold would feel like . . .” I closed my eyes. “Walking off a cliff.”

He exhaled. “Then you don’t stop cold. We’ll find you a piano,” he said, in a charitable way, as if he were conceding the argument. He said more after that, but I mostly stopped listening. That I’d still have days off—that’s the point of a union job, along with the pay and benefits. Railroad work was strictly controlled on that score. If a crew member ends up running a train for more hours than it’s safe to work, the train stops, wherever it is, and waits for a fresh crew to be trucked out to take over. The tired crew gets driven home to rest. Union rules.

I tried to imagine the win he was seeing in this for me. The crew truck that would carry me back exhausted to our unpicturable house, where I

would sleep and eat and maybe once a week, in the nicer home of some friend of a friend we'd drummed up, go play a round of Bach preludes and fugues in their living room, "Für Elise" for an encore. Show off my hobby.

When I gave up on words that night and finally fell into his arms as I always, always did, I pressed myself against him through a veil of such hurt frustration, I wanted to beat my fists on his chest and cry. My heart was full of things he couldn't see or honor. How could he? In his whole life, he'd never known a pianist.

Sigurd could make you see what he believed in, clear as day—there's no denying that. I had teachers galore who made me feel small, but Sigurd wasn't one of them. He lifted people up. All the Mrs. Robinses on the stairs, the people he met on the sidewalk, his acolytes. Most things he explained or read to me, even from his philosophy books, I could understand perfectly well. One quote I loved especially: "Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world and the soul of soulless conditions." Oh, the truth of that. Everybody knows the quote about religion being the opiate of the masses, if they know one thing about Karl Marx, and they take that to mean he was looking down on the churchgoers. But that's only part of the paragraph. When you hear the rest, you understand he was saying the opposite. What a beautiful thing for people to be given: Heart in a heartless world. A soul to see them through it.

You have to remember that back in his day, religion wasn't just rules; it was ceremony. Religion and music were one and the same, and as far as I'm concerned, they still are. The man understood what we need from the bottom of our pain. Haydn's *Creation* to inspire us to heart-stopping wonder. The whole bundle of birth, death, and top-of-the-lungs hope for better things ahead, all packed into Handel's *Messiah*. Mozart's Requiem in D Minor is all that and more: the grind of life's misery, the flutter of possible joy, *please God make this all work out in the end*. From the opening heartbeat of strings and sorrowful horns, the Requiem holds out to you a double handful of the deepest sadness you ever felt. Then the voices come in, the standard liturgy but somehow with the music behind it he's applying these words exactly to what you were thinking: *Lacrimosa dies illa. Those tearful days, those tearful days. God spare us. Give us rest.* You're aching for some kind of answer, and then the soprano comes in to

deliver it straight: pure hope. She's heaven. And the marching beat of the men's choir underneath her is all about daily labors. *Do not forsake me on that day. Let not such toil be in vain*. The singing is in Latin, and maybe back then the congregation could translate it or maybe they couldn't, but nobody ever needed the words. That's what music is for. You don't have to know how to read or cipher, no need even to meet it halfway, music just hands it all over. Everything you were pining for. The finale of the Requiem stands with its angel hands on your shoulder blades, backing up all the weariness you were feeling, and promises you light at the end of the tunnel. Forever. Endless mercy. Eternal rest. It isn't for nothing. You will be thanked by a heavenly parent who saw the whole thing and hates that for you and wants to take you in his arms.

The first time Sigurd read me that passage about religion being heart for the downhearted, it struck me as a truth I can feel it to this day. When I play hymns for the Baptists, I'm not just there to hit the right notes and keep the tempo. I'm using my hands to spin soul from the straw of our hard conditions. It feels as useful as feeding hungry children. I'm grateful the Baptists pay me for it, but I think I'd still do it if they couldn't. Opium for the masses, or chicken soup, either way that famous quote is a statement of kindheartedness. If a whole crowd of people need a strong painkiller, they've suffered badly. You should care about them a lot.

But this other quote Sigurd was fond of never made sense to me, however he tried to explain it. Father Marx, again: "Only when the universal sun has set does the moth seek the lamp-light of privacy."

Is that a good thing, the moth waiting for sunset? Sigurd said no, it's the opposite. The moth seeking flame is like a bird that wants to be in a cage, not free. The universal sun is the dazzling light of the universal human collective. The moth is unwise to turn away from that, mistaking a simple candle as any kind of substitute for the sun. We can forgive our human impulses, sure. Sigurd allowed for that. We want our personal comforts. But they'll hardly matter to us anymore after we've felt the joy of total cooperation. Everybody looking out for everybody else, wanting for nothing, taking care of the hardship cases. All of us happy to go to work, now that we're in charge of the factories and the fruits of our labor aren't just for some rich boss.

Who could argue with that? No more children going hungry. Farmers walking their land without debt, nobody breaking their backs for a measly

wage. It's a bright, shiny picture. And maybe I'm missing something, but I never could find myself in it. I must be the moth, I thought, because I couldn't imagine any sun bright enough to make me forget the private bliss of a practice room, or the holy fire I could strike into the air, all by myself, from a bunch of hatch-marked lollipops on lined paper. Reaching into the past to pull out joyful noise from some man dead in the ground three hundred years. The pleasure is in the making. So lock me in that little room forever and a day, I don't care, I'll sing for anybody who'll listen. *Sorry*, I wanted to tell Sigurd, *I'm the bird that seeks the cage.*

That must have been all he could see of me over his shoulder, standing barefoot at the bottom of the apartment stair as he drove away: the bird that wouldn't fly. He had no use for her.

Scooped out and empty like the rind of a melon. Something to throw away. That car drove off with all the good I'd ever been and all I'd ever be. When the mind drills down into the dark center, it stops believing in light altogether. I would never be happy again. Not even music could save me now, I thought, and that dark forecast would bear out soon enough.

I moved like a sleepwalker around our apartment of nothingness. Telephone and electricity shut off, all accounts settled. I had to use daylight to see what was left for me to stuff into pillowcases and bedsheets tied up in bundles. The curled poster on the wall, Van Gogh's lusty almond blossoms, I tore down from its thumbtacks and wadded up. I found one of his old shirts he'd thrown away as he pared down and packed. I got it out of the trash and put it on.

Lacking other transportation, I hauled my things across town on foot to the apartment I'd hoped never to see again. Sigurd had offered to help me move, but I told him he needn't to bother. The walk was nearly a mile, and it took several trips. I was a public spectacle, no doubt inspiring passersby to pray for this sorry homeless girl in flip-flops and a ragged, oversized work shirt hauling her worldly goods in pillowcases down North Jefferson Street. I needed the prayers.

Jon Link's apartment smelled faintly of natural gas and stale bread, and felt like a place I'd never been. Or I couldn't quite claim the version of me that had lived there. I flung a sheet across the bare mattress and curled like an unborn thing on top of it and alternately sobbed and slept for some

number of hours I'd be ashamed to guess at. Light left the windows and came again. Eventually I lurched out to the corner convenience store and picked up whatever my eyes could focus on—a can of tomato soup, a bag of pretzels. A pack of cigarettes, but the price was staggering, so I handed it back to the cashier. In the two years since I'd bought cigarettes, the price of a pack had somehow run riot. If I'd been a drinker, I might have considered a bottle of bourbon, but there too the price would have saved me from the fall.

I ate the whole bag of pretzels at once, threw it right back up, and stared bitterly into the toilet, regretting the wasted calories. I felt myself growing skeletal, skin shrink-wrapping me to my own bones. Nothing agreed with my stomach. The second time I went out to the convenience mart, the kind gentleman at the counter looked at me through his thick glasses and asked if I needed him to call someone for me. I assured him I was well, thanked him, and accepted the possibility that I needed some other human contact.

Nearly all my friends had been Jon Link's friends first, or we'd met them together, and those people would hate me now, wouldn't they? Percussion and Bassoon were in Munich with Jon Link, no doubt listening over steins of beer to his tales of how cruelly I'd iced him out. I hated it myself, how I'd treated him before he left. I tried to put everything that reminded me of Jon Link into the closets, but then there was the furniture. I did have acquaintances of my own, or must have, at one time or another. A flautist named Ina, who wore army-surplus chic and growled like a wet cat about our music-student existence. She'd collected me, I think, as her first poor friend, but also seemed genuinely to like me. We'd bonded over a ridiculously impossible Fauré we played together for her sophomore jury. But like everybody else, she was gone for the summer.

I must have been anticipating the full disintegration, because I had a choir rehearsal on Friday and had marked that very firmly in my mental calendar, when Sigurd left: *I will need to pull myself together by ten a.m. Friday.* I hadn't counted on completely losing track of where I stood in relation to that landmark, and having to ask the nice man at the mini-mart what day it was. Which might be what led to his concern for my condition.

We did manage to coincide in place and time, myself and the Oratorio Chorus. I got myself to the rehearsal room exactly on the mark, which was worth some extra credit even in normal circumstances. Accompanists working for this director tended to arrive late because he was exasperatingly

yogic with his warm-up routines. Only it was a gamble—you never knew if it would be five minutes or fifteen with all the stretches, arms to the ceiling, the breathing from the core, *shoo-shoo-shoo-shoo-shoo* down the scale. I sat on my bench, staring at the floor, thinking how lovely it would be to lie down under the piano. The director took me by surprise when he abruptly asked me to bring us in on forty-eight with three measures of introduction. I hurriedly shuffled through pages and did as he asked, finding it a weird place to begin.

The choir did not come in.

"Not the *Carmina Burana,* Livia. The Britten please."

All four tiers of singers stared into my soul, judging the wreck, as I shuffled through other pages and found the correct measure forty-eight. The basses and tenors seemed sad for me. The sopranos appeared to want me dead.

"No. Three measures *before* forty-eight, if you would please, Livia."

I'd never allowed myself a complete revolt against the frustration of this work, not just accompaniment but accompanying a whole choir, where errors and needs for correction are multiplied and repetition is interminable. *Again, again, sopranos, please note it is "Ca-a-al-vary." Circle that with your pencils, and do not rush the calvary over the hill. Tenors, bring the corners in. Articulation! Livia, bring us in with the same three measures please. Livia. Livia.*

It wasn't just despair but the bald, sadistic tedium of the enterprise that kept me faltering and losing my place until I put my head on my arms on the keyboard and wept. At the rock bottom of my musical career, in front of all those ruthless sopranos, I cried like the baby I was.

The fermata is a musical symbol that looks like a glaring eye with a high, arched eyebrow. It tells the musician to hold a moment of silence. The shocked Oratorio Chorus sustained a very extended fermata, and then the director asked a piano minor in the alto section to come down from the risers and take my place on the bench. I was dismissed.

I should have thought of Amadeo sooner. Sigurd had brought me back around to Gorgo's as a regular, and I'd come back around to Amadeo's bear hugs. He always came out of the kitchen to talk to us and wink at Sigurd, solicitous of our courtship. I'd invited him to my jury to hear me play

Gaspard de la Nuit—the one that Sigurd hadn't attended. Amadeo did. He applauded so vigorously, several faculty members shook his hand and called him Mr. Bohusz, assuming he was my father. The man was in my corner. He was also the only person who'd really been aware of Sigurd and me as a couple, so he'd appreciate my calamity. Also, he might give me a job. Amadeo was the daytime manager at Gorgo's now, and I was flat broke.

He took me back to the little office behind the kitchen that was used by staff for smoke breaks and gossip. Shooed out a couple of servers, sat me at the little desk, brought me a glass of water and asked if I'd eaten anything today. I'd come straight there from my choir disaster and had made myself stop crying on the walk over, but was still in that shuddery gasping phase that happens when your body refuses to get over it.

I told him everything: that he'd left me, I was forced to choose between Sigurd and my life of music, but now I was such a mess I hadn't touched a piano for a week except to screw up my summer job, so now I didn't have rent money either, and no, I hadn't eaten today and couldn't remember if I had yesterday. That was the first sentence. I didn't have the stamina for many more, but Amadeo didn't need them.

"He made you choose? *You*, Livia? The figlio di puttana doesn't deserve you!" Here was a side of Amadeo I'd never seen: the full mettle of an offended Sicilian. I wasn't sure how old he was, maybe forty, with four or five children, and now he added me to the brood. With touching solemnity, he made me vow that nobody would ever make me waste these beautiful hands. He said we have to take care of the body first and then the heart. When he stood up and left, I was nervous that number three involved going after the figlio di puttana with a butcher cleaver, but no, he came back with a margherita pizza hot from the oven and a very cold beer.

I surely needed them, and to be swaddled in the comforting scent of baking pizza crust while this huge, sweet man fussed over me. I started crying again. But by the end of the hour, Amadeo had me in an apron and on my feet. He said he didn't think I was ready just then for the front of the house, but he needed me in the kitchen.

We were still on the early side for the lunch crowd, so he took some time to introduce me around, making sure the kitchen and waitstaff understood I was "our own Maria Tipo," which I'm sure meant nothing to them, and instructing them not to let me carry anything too heavy, which they

absolutely would. But the feeling of refuge I used to find here came back, even if the staff was mostly new. The only holdovers from two years ago, besides Amadeo, were an older waitress named Marjorie and a guy named Leon who ran the deep fryer and famously did not talk to anybody, ever. Turnover was high. Luckily for me, a line cook had quit that morning. The empty slots refilled with a certain type, and I could be one of them. A working girl.

He put me on the pantry station. I hadn't worked in the kitchen before, but who can't make a salad? It made perfect sense, even scaled up: opening the produce boxes, cutting the vegetables, making the house dressing and Caesar dressing, boiling eggs for twelve minutes, grating the cheddar and the Parmesan. I was supposed to coordinate with the fry cook on making the croutons, but Leon sensed my nerves about hot oil and did those for me. Otherwise, the only special protection I got was an order from the head chef to get myself a hat or a hairnet. "If that Rapunzel rope gets caught in a dough mixer or something, aagghh." He made a choking motion with both hands on his throat. I found a roomy newsboy cap at Goodwill and made it my signature kitchen look.

I pulled my weight, coming in early to prepare my mise and my station in the quiet hour before pots and pans and tempers started flying. I had a lot of practice with poise under pressure and applied it here with my hands on the cool stainless steel of tongs and colanders, ingredients all lined up on their shallow trays of ice. For the first time in a while, I looked forward to coming to work. For many reasons, I needed to keep my mind on this job and do it well, and I did, even with the notorious midday crush. Gorgo's success involved rapid mass production. It was as mechanized as any factory, with powerful slicing machines, dough mixers of a size you could take a cozy bath in. A dough-rolling machine turning out pizza crusts of exact thickness as fast as three people could slap on ingredients, with a fourth person sliding them in and out of the wide-mouthed oven on a long paddle. The sandwich station, Jesus. If you closed your eyes at noon and listened for twenty seconds, you'd believe people were getting shot over there.

Up-tempo was home territory for me. I snapped on my gloves and ran orders through my well-tempered station like a Bach invention. Rhythm is everything. Downbeat—bang—goes the head lettuce on the cutting board, knocking loose its core, then two beats under cold water, set upside down in

the colander for a whole rest to drain. Tomatoes cut like notes: half, quarter, eighth. Onions falling away from my knife in a glissando of even sixteenths. The work of a line cook suited me fine. Better than the front of the house. Amadeo was right; I wasn't ready to face the public. If somebody from the Oratorio Chorus had come in that first day and remarked on my demotion, tears or knives might have come out.

The clientele here was mostly students, and if I'd forgotten what they were like, it drifted back to me now through the order window. Loud with each other, mute to the staff. Snapping their fingers to get your attention. Not really looking at you when they ordered. I remembered waiting on students I knew by sight from my first-year classes, who didn't seem to recognize me when I stood over them with my order pad and pencil. Even my biology lab partner once! I stared at him hard for an extra few seconds after he ordered, but no. I even said his name quietly when I delivered his burger: "There you go, Garret." One of his friends glanced up, but Garret was telling a story and never noticed. I was trying not to think about Sigurd, but he'd surely hit the mark on these kids who'd grown up with no friends from the side of town where people did shift work. No practice with viewing us as human. Evidently it was too late for them to start now.

Back in the kitchen, I found it easy to relax into the rhythm of making salads and let the rest of my life fade to soft static. Sigurd wasn't wrong about this campus where my avocado-soft heart had gotten bruised by years of judgment. In my hours of reducing lettuce heads to shrapnel, I made my accounts of the monsters out there. Slowly, over the days, I understood that *Gaspard de la Nuit* wasn't one of them. "Ondine" could have pulled me under and drowned me, but I'd loved the wrestle. Loved it so much I forgot time and space and my own life, knew in my bones I could win her over. It was always in my power. I was that kind of working girl.

Amadeo wasn't going to let me forget it, either. He left me to my pouting and scullery for a few days, but after that, he was more of a taskmaster than Dr. Betis. At the end of my shift, he'd pull me out of the kitchen by my apron strings and point me toward the practice building, asking what I was working on. I was embarrassed to tell him my summerlong breakup had ravaged my discipline, so I made up one thing and another. He put in requests: the Clementi and Scarlatti that won Maria Tipo her biggest audiences. Lord, the man was smitten. I promised to learn them, and to keep myself from backing out, I promised to organize a special concert for him

and his family before fall classes started. The MAC had rooms that were easy enough to reserve, in the student-vacuum of summer.

Amadeo always felt he'd failed his opera-loving mother, who'd been so invested in his musical future, evidently from his christening. Now he meant to make good as my musical guardian and conscience until mine kicked in. I wasn't quite fooling him. He remembered the pianist I used to be, always bubbling over with a movement I'd conquered, itching to get back to my practice. He could tell I'd lost hold of some important part of myself, a big enough love to outlive the one that had extravagantly deranged me for a couple of months. I could still feel it, but not inside me. It was just hanging around me, like weather. Blowing hot and cold. I had no heart for the high-wire act I'd been carrying off, to so much applause. Maybe that artist had fallen to her death.

Still, for Amadeo if not for myself, I had to try. Practice rooms felt safer than being alone in the apartment with my grief. I played tender nocturnes to remember, and furious agility practices to forget. As self-comfort goes, an hour pounding through Hanon exercises is not that different from a fifth of bourbon. I kept my promise to look into Maria Tipo's repertoire, and had a torrid rebound affair with Scarlatti's Sonata in E-flat Major.

But as summer oozed past, I kept putting off registration for fall classes. The thought of facing Jon Link appalled me. His parents would come to see him, Ma-*ma* in her big scarves with gold chains printed on them, Father in his boating shoes, asking whatever became of poor little Livia. I had to find someplace else to live, pronto. But it was worse than that. I needed to find somebody else to *be*. Sigurd had somehow unleashed my grievances against Dr. Betis and all the other people I'd been reinventing myself to please. Now I balked at bending myself back into their routines, putting my old skin back on, climbing up into that tower that threw its shade on a town of typesetters and quarrymen. One of those typesetters had punctured my detachment. After three years spent swallowing my accent and trying to pass, the ground had moved under me, and I could see the mountains people were standing on, insisting this was all on the level. After a thing like that, you have to learn to walk again. I didn't know how to do it without him.

Every night, I curled up in a tight ball of misery and wished I could just hate him instead of missing him. Looking back across weeks of being too upset or distracted to apply myself, the last thing I could see that I'd handled well, as my fully intact self, was the *Gaspard*. In May. He'd spent

more time pulling away from me than believing in me. I had to get up from here, wrap my wounded core in the bindings of rage, and go hunting for the new apartment I wouldn't have needed, go chop lettuce in a kitchen I would never have walked back into, if he'd loved me enough to stay.

Amadeo will blame himself until the end of his days, but I don't. He wasn't even there.

The rest of us didn't want to be. Everybody was in a mood that night. It was mid-August, and students were taking over the town again. Our summers stayed plenty busy because so many other places shut down or cut back their hours and shunted their business to Gorgo's. But it was possible to forget in a few months what it was like when the hungry locusts turned up again, hell-bent on recouping a summer's worth of lost beer buzzes and pizzas. We were under siege.

I was still there after eleven because I was working double shifts, with the idea of putting down first and last month's rent on a tiny apartment I'd found on the west side of town. I planned to be sensible this time, and arranged with Amadeo to help me move before Jon Link got back, which wouldn't be until September. Grad students were on their own schedule of performance credits and such, so I still had a month. I'd mustered the decency to write and tell him my plan, but not quite the bank balance to execute.

Double shifts were serious business, maybe illegal if anybody was paying attention, and when Amadeo went home to his family at four o'clock, the light of the place always went out for me. I guess he'd been protecting me more than I knew, or else the second-shift manager just liked me a lot less. Wyman was his name. And it probably wasn't personal. Wyman favored the older workers over students, whom he saw as unreliable, likely to leave at the drop of a hat, not worth coddling. I tried to carry the heaviest boxes I could lift and keep an eye out for anybody else who might need an extra hand. I was still on pantry, which the other cooks considered to be junior varsity. I wanted them to know I wasn't a lightweight.

Wyman wore a backwards baseball cap like a comic book bully and drank on the job. The more of it we smelled on him, the more we braced for his escalations over the stupidest things, an avocado cut wrong or anchovies that were not laid out like the hands of a clock. We were already having that

kind of night, and then Wyman picked the wrong fight. A sober manager would know better. Our chef walked off, two hours before the kitchen closed.

Wyman stepping in to run things was worse than nobody in charge at all. He didn't know the shorthand between us that made things flow, and tried to cover his ignorance with nit-picking. Along with his useless instructions, he threw down cooking equipment in prep areas, left handles over the gas flame and spoons in boiling liquids, yanked orders off the rail and somehow sent them into the ether. It was hard to believe one person could so capably obstruct the work of ten. We all held our breath to keep from telling him to get the hell out of the kitchen. Orders should have been winding down at that point, but students weren't in classes yet and needed to celebrate that fact with binge drinking and ordering food they'd leave on the table with their measly tips.

I was keeping my head down, cutting cucumbers for salads that definitely would be left on the plate. (Nobody eats anything healthy after eleven at night.) But Wyman was standing so close to me I could feel his body heat, and he was literally screaming that the pizza crusts were a mess. One of the pizza-prep guys had left already, but the other two both pointed at the dough roller. It was sticky and needed to be cleaned.

Kitchen jobs have a pecking order nobody likes to cross. The porter who cleans the equipment is junior-junior varsity, expected to stay until after closing, and not paid enough to really count on him doing that. Ours had slipped out already. The only job below porter is the dishwasher, who is not supposed to mess with the equipment, and in any case was barricaded behind so many stacked dishes, nobody could see him. I put down my knife and told Wyman I would clean the dough roller. I'd never done it, but cleaning is cleaning. Grab a fresh rag and have at it.

I became aware of people yelling. I remember pushing the rag onto the steel plate, and then a lot of screaming and people crowding around me saying *reverse, reverse* and *drop the plate,* and then I was curled up on the floor holding my right hand to my chest. There was still a lot of yelling about why the cord was duct-taped to the outlet and things like that. I felt a dampness on my chest that confused me, and when I looked down to figure out why, what I saw must have made me stop remembering, because that's where the scene goes dark for me.

Anybody who's moved through the world with visible battle scars will know this already: Every single person is going to ask what happened to you. Or worse, *What did you do?* Friends, strangers, all of one mind to ask this painful question. You might like to hear *Sorry, that must feel like hell* or *Let me get the door for you.* No. They want a story. Live it over again, just for them this time. Your awfullest moment. Walk them through it.

Maybe they mean to help you get it behind you. Roll that land mine around your brain till it's worn down to a smooth pebble. I don't think so. What did you do—*you*, in the business of hurting yourself—is a question they're pulling on like a protective shell: *Whatever* your *story is, I want to pin it down at a safe distance. I need to know it was nothing I would ever do to myself.*

I can pretty much promise that what happened to me is never going to happen to you. I've had a lot of practice delivering this good news. I tried to wipe down an industrial dough roller that was set to start pulling when pressure was sensed on the steel dough plate. The machine had its cool heart set on making fifty pizzas an hour. It pulled my hand into the roller and did its best to even out bones and flesh to a uniform thickness of five-sixteenths of an inch.

The permission form for my surgery listed more external fixations and arthrodeses and nerve, blood vessel, tendon, and ligament repair and reconstruction for more phalanges and metacarpals and DIP and PIP joints than any one person has a right to. I saw the paperwork later, have no memory of signing it. I remember that night in short, ragged scenes like movie clips, all out of order. A kind man with a beautifully bald, ebony-brown head in the X-ray room, saying "Breathe in big for me, dear, breathe in like you want to holler, 'cause I know you do." In my fuzzy recall, he comes before other things that had to have preceded him, like the ambulance. Somebody applying a device that swallowed my hand and inflated with so much pressure, the pain turned into freezing. Realizing I had no feeling in my right arm, couldn't even tell it was there unless I looked. I'd had a nerve block by then, but I would have sworn that came later, in a crowded little room with everybody's eyes glued to what looked like hazy cirrus clouds on a black-and-white screen, while nobody else but me watched the actual whopping needle going into my flesh.

Somehow, then, winding up on my back rolling down a hallway with a doctor walking beside me explaining things fast-tempo. The man was entirely covered up—light blue scrubs and mask, green bonnet like a shower cap, blue eyes behind a clear face shield that made me wonder hazily if he expected a lot of blood spraying around. A drip line in my left arm was spreading a hot, metallic fuzziness through my whole body and starting to hit my brain. He said something about nerve damage and getting some function back and being optimistic. He said I'd be able to hold a pencil, and made some joke about my golf game. Thumb and index finger were spared, how lucky was that, the outside of that right hand took it for the team. Probably no chance of saving the pinkie, but you really don't need that one. Oh. *Oh.* For a pianist, the little finger is a workhorse, much more important than its middle neighbors. Thumb and pinkie together own the octave, and without that, you might as well go home. I wanted to say this out loud. My mouth tasted of pennies and stuffy cotton and wouldn't open.

I don't know who called Amadeo, but there he was. A set of double doors opened wide with a clunk and I rolled through them. Just me and the person pushing my stretcher. The doctor had stopped behind us like he'd hit a rock. The doors closed, and then I heard Amadeo on the other side. The doctor's talk was muffled, but Amadeo was animated. I remember thinking that if the words "our own Maria Tipo" came through those heavy doors, it would be God's way of telling me I'd entered the kingdom of heaven. The drug tide was rolling.

I was redirected. Back through the double doors and down the hall, trailing my IV rack on one side, Amadeo on the other. We waited together in a tiny curtained-off room with machines beeping off-key all around us and a boa constrictor of blood pressure cuff intermittently squeezing the living daylights out of my right calf. We were there for some period of time that I kept sliding in and out of. Then there was a lot of hubbub, with two nurses saying doctor somebody was in the building, and I was rolled again into surgery and finally got the sleep I deserved.

Bassoon came back from Munich while I was still in the hospital. I'd always liked him a lot. He was short and shy and funny and, unlike Jon Link and Percussion, an undergraduate who had to be back on campus in time for classes. There had been talk of him replacing me as Jon Link's

roommate, but those plans were up in the air. I got the scuttlebutt from Bassoon when he came to see me in the hospital, bringing flowers he'd picked from a sorority house yard on his walk over. He admired my gigantic mitten of bandages and protruding pins attached to a thing called a fixator, with the whole business elevated in a sling that held my arm up in an unfortunate kind of salute. We couldn't see an iota of human hand under all that, which was concerning, but the painkillers kept me dazed enough to resist ripping into the packaging. Bassoon was impressed. He said I'd probably set a school record in getting my money's worth out of student health insurance.

I don't think he knew—hoped he didn't know—how starved I was for company. He brought me a trove of funny stories from Munich and asked how my summer had gone before it went to shit and whether he could bring me anything, and eventually I started to drift off, but Bassoon didn't leave. He sat quietly, looking at me. He had perfectly straight blond hair that kind of stood out from his head as if overwhelmed by static electricity, and in my current state, I found it mesmerizing. It dawned on me that he was tapping his thumb on his knee, needing to say something else. So I asked him what, and he told me. Over the summer in Munich, Percussion and Bassoon had become a couple. Or rather, they had been a couple for a while without telling anybody, and somehow, in the atmosphere of beer gardens and artsy European permissiveness, they decided to come out. The only person who took it a little hard was Jon Link. Not that he disapproved, he was just used to thinking of them in a different way. I could see how it might hit Jon Link as another loss after my defection, his two best pals making him into a third wheel. Also, he'd be out a roommate if they came back to Bloomington and shacked up, which was the plan.

But since he was still in Munich, we took the liberty of being squatters in Jon Link's apartment. It was a huge stroke of luck to have Bassoon there after the hospital sent me packing, which they did the minute I could detach my giant mitten from its sling and wobble myself to the bathroom. (No malingering on Student Health.) He drummed up a friend to drive us home, then tucked me in and brought me hydrating liquids and toast and ice packs and entertained me with incontrovertible proof that any major bassoon solo ever written could be made to sound like cartoon theme music. In the evenings, we shared a bottle of Münchener Kümmel he'd brought back as a souvenir, knocking back such tiny shots, it took us over a week to make

much of a dent. It's hard to overdo it on booze that tastes like coleslaw. Plus, we were both lightweights, in physical build and experience.

Bassoon was a sweet, weepy drunk. He told me the German name for the bassoon is *fagott*, referring to the double reed, which in practical terms is sticks tied together. Which in more horrible practical terms is what they used to do when publicly burning men who loved each other. I told him, in that case, he'd picked a hell of an orchestra to come out to, but he said no, everybody was so great, and then he lay down on the bed exactly the way my brother used to, me under the covers and him on top of them beside me, and we talked and talked until tears slid down the sides of our faces. He said he was happier than he'd ever been in his life, which was plainly true. He looked and acted like a new person since he'd been back. I told him I could see it right from the first. Those flowers in the hospital! "Stealing Kappa Kappa Gamma roses, who even does that?" I asked him. "You're a prince among men."

He said he was still the same person, but with fortissimo marks where everything used to be pianissimo. He told me he'd spent his whole life thinking he was never going to get to be in love like other people, and now he was. He'd found his heart's companion.

I told him I was so happy for him, my smile might break my face. Which was true. But I was also a little spooked, because this made me think of my brother too. Of all the nights we used to lie side by side and whisper the same conviction, that we didn't think we'd grow up and get married like other people. That nobody would ever find us that perfect. Maybe I was just agreeing with my older brother, who would have entered adolescence by then, with more formed thoughts on the subject. But it felt true back then, when I said it. I listened while Bassoon's breathing turned into a soft snore, and kept these thoughts to myself.

After the first go-round of follow-ups and dressing checks, I was starting to get up and at it. I relied on Bassoon for help with a hundred things I couldn't do one-handed, including embarrassing ones like zipping my jeans, which, again, he did in the most brotherly way imaginable. And my hair! Dear God, my superfluous hair. One brave nurse at the hospital had washed and tamed it, but now I was on my own. I tried to cut it off, but discovered that scissors in a left hand are rendered bizarrely toothless. What conspiracy

was *that*? I begged Bassoon, but he refused. When people see hair that long, they act like it's the constitution of some country, not to be overthrown. I ignored my scalp until I couldn't stand it, and then, with Münchener Kümmel under our belts, we'd get in the shower in our swimsuits, my hand in a plastic bag, and he'd hose down my mane as if I were a draft horse. Then braided it wet. He said it was sort of like tying a bassoon reed.

Slowly, slowly, I got myself back in the game. Pianists are trained to ambidexterity as our second nature, so that was lucky. I discovered I could make a left-handed signature the first time I tried, even if it looked like an amateur forgery. I figured out that with patience and strategy, everything in life worth doing can be done one-handed. Twist-off lids are ridiculously everywhere, and do require a pair of grips, but the body offers more vises than you might think. The crook of an elbow, a forearm against a table. Teeth do nicely on the ridged cap of a medicine bottle. If it's one of those tough child-proof ones, you grimace and use the molars. Patience and one hand can make an overhand knot; repeating that will secure it. Tying anything up with a tidy bow is not in the category of "things in life worth doing." Ditto for shaving: I couldn't reach the good-side underarm, so it seemed best to let them both go. I'd have to resign myself to the same for flossing, I thought. But! The drugstore sells teeny bottlebrushes in fifty-packs, for the dental hygiene of one-handed people everywhere.

A few days before Jon Link was due back, I felt brave enough to try going solo. Bassoon helped me move into my new apartment, which Amadeo had held for me by putting down the deposit. Just under the wire, I'd made a quick job of registration and the paperwork to carry my scholarship into fall classes, on behalf of my new relationship with Student Health. Nobody needed to know I wouldn't be showing up for a single class, and was now less qualified for a piano scholarship than the trained parrot my father used to make us all come watch when it performed on *The Carol Burnett Show*. All my life I'd tended toward invisibility, even when I was fully participating. It might be a while before anybody reported me missing.

On moving day, as he'd promised me back in another lifetime, Amadeo transported my stuff and me in his station wagon. He brought his whole family along to help. His wife was small and dark-haired and very beautiful. The daughters looked exactly like her and seemed impossibly close in age, between thirteen and fifteen, and were named Tosca, Elektra,

Minnie, and Carmen. That family's hopes for a musical legacy ran as high as Amadeo's generosity. They all offered to help unpack my embarrassingly few possessions, which mostly ended up staying in cardboard boxes because there wasn't exactly a closet. The little, austerely furnished apartment had been partitioned out of the back of a big white Victorian house so the landlady could collect extra cash. I've heard people call these "bereaved apartments," where a dwelling is made by subtracting space from a whole house, because every addition to one is the other's loss.

We guessed that my new home had mainly bereaved the grand house of a sunporch, because it had windows all the way across the one long room, more glass than wall. I could look forward to freezing here, in a month or two. But I had my own entrance that opened onto a little backyard where the rotting boards of a raised garden bed bore a standing crop of dead weeds. I had a hot plate and dorm-sized fridge presenting themselves as a kitchen, and a bathroom with a tub that would serve for washing dishes. Bassoon and Amadeo's family settled me in, and we ate the lasagna they brought, all eight of us chatting while some of us sat at the small kitchen table and some of us sat on the single bed. Amadeo kept waving away my thanks. He said the money for the apartment deposit came out of my workers' comp, which I knew was untrue, and I felt teary because all these people were being so nice to me.

The night before, Bassoon had given me a stern talk about my duty to our art and my career. We both knew he wouldn't be seeing much of me once he reentered the all-devouring worlds of orchestra and true love. His lecture had the feel of an inspirational send-off. Music is a calling, my years of discipline had prepared me to work hard now for a full recovery, et cetera. He wasn't that convincing on the "full" part, because he also brought up the concert repertoire for one-handed pianists that Ravel wrote for Paul Wittgenstein after he got his right arm shot off in World War I. Poor Bassoon was miserably earnest, so I put on a good false front. That's all it was. We still hadn't really had a good look—either one of us—at what was left inside my giant mitten of bandages and steel pins. But I'd seen the mess that went into it, and I was coming to terms with what that meant. Nothing was like it was before. I wasn't going to learn Wittgenstein's one-hand repertoire either. I hate to say it, but that felt like aspiring to be a performing parrot, and I had no heart for it. Not after the pianist I'd been.

What lay ahead of me was a great emptiness. Namely, the rest of my life. As I weaned myself off the painkillers, I gently pushed my thoughts into that wilderness and it seemed best to leave false hopes at the door.

In late September, I graduated to smaller bandaging that liberated my undamaged thumb and index finger. I might as well have been the world's first human, for the delight I took in my opposable thumb. Potato chip bags, milk cartons. I bought things at the grocery for no better reason than the tricky packaging I could tear into all by myself. I got out my Keds and tied their laces, threw off my stretched-out tees and wore nice button-ups for the occasion of a walk around the block. I found my one brassiere, hooked all the little clasps, and put it on, because I could.

But the charms of becoming a near-competent human being wore pretty thin by the end of a day. The solitude in this apartment was deeper than any I'd known. People my age in that town had all rushed back to the self-congratulating society of busyness. I idled on a great plain of nothingness. No roommate, no classes, not even the camaraderie of a restaurant kitchen. No lover in my bed. I still woke up out of cloudy sleep every day to the tension of decision—what did I need to train my hands to that day?—before I opened my eyes and watched that question dissolve into the dull roar of lethargy. Nights were excruciating. Pain was a constant, even when I'd had the best medicine at my beck and call. Those drugs do a funny thing to your brain, not really removing the shrieking doorbell of pain, just telling you not to answer it. Now I'd used up my allotment of those and was down to the discount-drugstore arsenal. In case I'd forgotten, now I remembered what's so special about hands: They have more nerve endings than most of the rest of you put together.

The physical pain was all of a piece with my bereavement. I still missed Sigurd with the ache of a muscle spasm. I'd passed through nausea and howling into furious, pathetic blame. Him, myself, it was all tangled. He shouldn't have left. I should have gone. I would never have crossed paths with that hellacious dough roller if I hadn't unraveled. Thanks to him. If I hadn't thrown away everything we could have had, in favor of the pious, fragile self-importance of a fantasy career. Over that beautiful, brilliant man, I chose *this*. The nothing I was now.

He’d given me the address of the people he’d be staying with in Phoenix, if I wanted to keep in touch, and I’d thrown it away in a fit of performative pique. Still refusing to believe he’d really go. Refusing until I watched his taillights turn the corner, and one minute after that, I started writing him letters in my head. Angry, accusing, beseeching, penitent, the full scrambled omelet of tempers known to every woman scorned. Fortunately, I never wrote any of it down.

But the oratorio in my head was still a connection to him. Now even that was dying down. After the accident, I did consider telling him this news that seemed big enough to share, and I could have. I knew the address. Memorizing the three thousand or so notes of a sonata is one thing; it’s nothing at all to memorize in one glance the common surname of his host, a four-digit number, and a street name that defied expectation (Water), in Phoenix, AZ. I didn’t get past a left-handed “Dear Sigurd” before I crumpled under the burden of truth. If he didn’t want me whole, he wouldn’t want me maimed. I would only be casting a net for sympathy or guilt, and I wanted to be better than that. But the accident was my whole life now. It left me without anything more to say to him, on paper or in my head. The quiet inside me was terrifying.

Music abhors a vacuum. Partitas and inventions slipped back into me through the cracks, without invitation. Without my knowing it, really. I just caught it in the act sometimes. Lying in bed or looking out the window, thinking of nothing, I’d become aware of the fingers of my right hand. The pain would draw my attention, and I would realize they’d been moving inside their swaddling clothes. Pressing the notes into nobody’s skin, just playing for themselves.

For a lot of weeks, my future was mapped in appointments: dressings changed, stitches out, therapists who cajoled motion out of the joints that weren’t permanently fixed in place now with internal steel pins. We were about fifty-fifty on that: Many of my knuckles would never move again; they would stay in the semi-flex my surgeon had chosen for me while I slept through this whole remodeling of my future. I was regularly told I was lucky to have what I had. If I was inclined to lose my temper, I could still count to ten first, on my fingers.

The possibility of another surgery hung over everything. I had months of work still yet to do to recover any real function, I was told, but my wounds had healed, and the bones and tendons inside were supposed to follow suit. We'd have to see what my next X-rays looked like. Confidentially, I was told I might not need more surgery. My confidante was a physician's assistant named Ladawna who saw me practically every other day. She wore maroon scrubs and had a huge contralto laugh and a magnificent crown of black curls, with tiny white coils as fine as watch springs at her temples. She took over for Bassoon as my bosom friend of convenience, and I'm sure she was that nice to all her other patients. I appreciated her nonetheless. She asked how I was doing, if I was eating properly, if I had a boyfriend looking after me. (Emphatic *no* on the boyfriend. So much *no*, she backed up a step, laughed, and said, "I hear *that*.") She passed on compliments from the more taciturn members of the care team, telling me how I'd impressed them all with my progress. Extraordinary musculature had helped protect my bones, was the surgeon's theory, and my youthful metacarpals were knitting up a storm. Therapy felt like a pianist's home ground, although it wasn't just about training movement, but also reeducating the nerves in that drear five-fingered bag of meat my brain was trying to disown. I had to touch things in an ordered way: soft things, rough things, vibrating things. I'd always been one to lead with my hands, so I did that now, even at home. Cotton sheets, warm running water, my sandpapery emery board. Trying not to think of touching Sigurd in the shower and in the bed. All of it hurt, every time. Even so, the occupational therapist bragged on me as her only patient who followed through on these exercises. I'd gotten nowhere on sorting out the rest of my life, so I settled on being the wunderkind of the ortho clinic. I was making straight A's in flexion and bone generation.

And all this progress could backslide, depending on my next round of X-rays. I found myself thinking of them as an upcoming jury, except there was nothing I could do to prepare. Anxiety used to be a kind of engine that kept me in a practice room for all those hours. Now, with nowhere to go, the worry-engine spun my wheels without mercy. I'd hardly slept the night before I reported to the clinic to face my internal judgment.

Ladawna gave me a hug and brought me a juice box, for no good reason other than wanting to mother me. I'd be giving up some blood today; that was her excuse. She'd gone back through all my paperwork and found a lot

of things that were understandably missed the night I was first admitted to the hospital. She gave me pages to read and sign, pointing out the great improvement since then in my lefty signature. She was left-handed herself, and joked about my wanting to join her team. She pointed out questions I'd failed to answer while marginally conscious. Family history, previous injuries, allergies, date of last period. She frowned at the last one, because I'd written "can't remember," which was true. Sometime before the semester ended? I told her I'd always been extremely irregular. I didn't even start until I was sixteen, and still sometimes had only four or five in a year. She looked from the clipboard to me.

"Oh, you skinny girls. Y'all skip like a scratched record. After you have kids, you'll be regular as a clock, and then you'll see how lucky you were all this time."

Ladawna made some notes on the clipboard and then sent a nurse in to draw my blood. The nurse tied the rubber tourniquet on my upper arm, asked me to make a fist, and remarked that I had really good veins. I felt ridiculously proud.

She told me to wait in the exam room for the X-ray technician to come and get me, and that it might be a minute because they were backed up this morning.

It was more than a minute. Maybe half an hour. And when somebody finally came, it wasn't the technician; it was Ladawna. She looked like a different person than the Ladawna who'd given me the juice box and laughed about my signature. She pulled a stool close to my chair and sat down on it and looked me very directly in the eyes. I noticed pale, bluish crescents at the edges of her dark brown irises.

"Honey, I don't know how you're going to feel about this. But it's what it is."

I was confused. I hadn't had my X-rays yet. "What *what* is?"

She gave me a sad smile. "You're pregnant."

UNCORRECTED E-PROOF—NOT FOR SALE
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Prelude V

Friday, I woke up thinking about my hands. I usually don't, not anymore, unless something hurts. Which is the thankless custom of human creatures I guess, to walk around inside these marvelous instruments with full expectation they'll carry on being marvelous. I should know better, though. Marvels come in kinds, and mine was this hand I held out in front of me in the dim morning light. Crooked and faintly scarred, pinned together inside with metal bits and bobs that howl when I walk outside on a cold day. It will never touch the "Ondine" again. But it can carry its weight in a working life, cooking a meal, greeting a friend, demonstrating technique for students of any level. I was born with ten fingers, like most, but it's no ordinary miracle that I'll be buried with the same.

I have Amadeo to thank for that. Also, of course, the famous surgeon who rushed to the University Hospital from Indianapolis. His work exceeded expectations. All the nerves grew back except for the outside heel of my hand that can feel touch but not heat or cold. I have to mind that when I'm cooking. Several joints in my fingers are fused into slight, rigid curves, including everything in the little finger, which shortened it. But the span from its tip to my thumb is unusually wide for a reconstructed hand—almost seven inches. That measurement wouldn't mean a thing to a hand surgeon unless he knew the width of a piano octave. That was Amadeo.

I still send him a Christmas card every year. Everybody else from that time, I left behind, even dear Bassoon, when I shut the door hard and cast that part of my life away like the broken thing it was. But I kept up with Amadeo. He stayed in Bloomington, contentedly retired, lost his wife a while back from a sudden illness, but enjoys frequent visits from his daughters, none of whom turned out to be the least bit musical. At first, I wondered if I was keeping Amadeo in my life because he'd known Sigurd and me together, walking into Gorgo's with that blaze burning between us. It was real, I thought, if somebody else remembered it. But Amadeo probably didn't. I'm sure he saw me as a girl doing what girls do: fall head over heels, get dashed to pieces, get back up and swear next time to keep a better grip on our hearts and our panties. In a household of four daughters, he'd have been through all that on a schedule as regular as laundry days. I remember him saying one time that young men were like buses; another one comes along every hour. So no, he wasn't a keeper of my flame.

Amadeo got a call in the middle of the night. He could have waited until morning to come see me in the hospital. It's all anybody would expect. He wasn't my father. What made him get out of bed and tell his wife, *I am going right now*? An impulse. The temperature of his heart. That's what I was thinking about on Friday morning, not just my hand. Though I did make a special point of admiring it some more while I cooked breakfast for Charlie and washed up after, while I sat at the piano for an hour to calm my heart and brace it for this day, and then drove to my mother's house to open envelopes, as I'd promised I would do. Today. Even if it meant letting that hand of hers sting me one more time, delivering the sum of her losses. I was thinking about Amadeo. How a fortune can turn on a dime. How I still have what I have.

If angels and devils dance on our tempers, my grandmother had the devil in hers. The spelling unsettled me, but the message was clear: "Maik your bed now missy and you wil lay in it evermore" and "I pity the day you are learnt you was naut but a ordanary canairy." Good God. "Parrading yourself up and down lik a paintd woman." Lacking other choices back then, I guess people used to yell at each other on paper, and that's what she did, in these handwritten screeds that reshaped my mother's life. It took me most of the morning to work that out, sitting on the floor with brittle, age-mottled

envelopes laid out around me like puzzle pieces. I had only half the conversation to work with. Whatever my mother wrote back was only here by reflection. I studied postmark dates, put them in order, and saw they'd been mailed to two different addresses. The later ones came to this house where my mother raised me and lived until she died. Earlier ones went to an apartment, I had to guess—a number and building on Charlotte Pike, Nashville—which surprised me greatly. *Nashville.* My mother never talked about any such thing. I always assumed she'd lived under no other roofs than her father's and her husband's.

It's a wonder she even let her mother know her whereabouts, given the level of abuse in these letters. Anybody would guess my mother had gone off to revel in a life of crime. While living with some number of other girls in her rented rooms, which seemed to amplify the offense. My mother was "having a hie old time" with these women, also painted, no doubt. *Ordanary canairies.* Every letter mentioned my father in threatening terms: her duty to Willard, this good young man of a good family and his own farm, what a fool my mother was to make him wait ("maik him wate"), while she ran off chasing "the pie in yore sky." "Prettir girls then you aplenty here abouts wood marry Willard to morro. You will be sorry then and a shaim on yore pore mommy."

I struggled to make out these reproaches and square them with any possible image of my mother as rash and merry, chasing a selfish dream. Whatever on earth it was. Something to do with singing, if that's what *canairy* meant, but I had to smile at the unlikeliness in both directions: my mother's capacity for any kind of musical joy, my granny's conviction it would rend the fabric of her civilization. Then I swallowed that smile. This chain I'd uncovered had its links to me, my mother on the phone, the offense I could never quite decipher. Leaving home was part of it, and immodesty, poor attachment to kith and kin and duty. But mostly, chasing that "hie old time." Walking to the front of the line in a fancy dress, onto a spotlit stage, dissolving happily into music. Joy was boastful. It broke the rules.

The Nashville screeds, six in all, were sent to my mother over a period of about two months. Then the address changed and the hatefulness ended. The letters sent to this house were stuffed with the minutiae of domestic life: Cousin Lemuel getting along tolerable, beans no good this year. All was well, now that my mother had straightened up and done her duty to

Willard. She would soon see how marriage was better than the “quairing” she was leaving behind. Children would come along, to be what my grandmother called “the eggs in yore dear basket.” That would be my brother and me. Born to the task of compensation.

I couldn’t make myself read all the letters to my married mother. Scanning their tedium, I felt her tiredness creeping over me. The reassurances were somehow worse than the scoldings. I put all the letters back in the box where they’d spent most of a century under bundles of canceled checks. She’d kept this venom. She kept everything, sure, but not from that far back in her youth, I didn’t think. Kept them *here,* as part of her life’s squirreled ledger of accounts, a few feet from where she slept every night. Maybe lying on her side, looking at the box with these letters inside.

I lay back on the floor, causing Gaz to lift his head in concern.

“It’s okay.”

He settled back into his passive vigilance, head on paws, in the doorway.

I stared at the ceiling, assembling what I knew of my parents’ lives. They met at a dance in Bristol—that’s the story my uncles always told at family dinners. My father drove over there with his brothers to hear Lester Flatt and Earl Scruggs at the Glen Ballroom. My mother caught his eye for some reason, he danced with nobody else all night, then . . . what? A quick courtship was usual at the time; there wasn’t any hurry-up scandal. My brother didn’t come along for several years. Marriage sealed my father’s inheritance of the farm. His brothers went off to seek their unionized fortunes at the Marionville plant, the younger one dropping out of high school to do it. My mother met my father, they married and established themselves in this house as a farming couple, that’s what I knew. Now their love story had a shocking hole in it.

For the first time I could remember, I wished for my mother. Only conditionally. I wanted her back here just long enough to sit through my interrogation: *Nashville?* There wasn’t a soul alive anymore who could tell me. I touched the phone in my pocket in a rueful way. Like everybody in the world, I’d gotten used to finding the answer to any question with a quick search. No tolerance for speculation. I felt frustrated that I could never know. What in the ever-loving hell was the pie in my mother’s sky?

I lay blinking at the ceiling a while longer before I thought of something I’d seen in another box. There was too much stuff here to process as it passed in front of my eyes. I sat up and checked other shoeboxes like a shell

game, lifting lids one by one until I found the box of recital programs I'd run across earlier. Here was the record of my own "hie old times," showing off my talents in student recitals and competitions and, most grandly, the Knoxville Symphony, where my inspection had ended, the first time I'd poked into this box. Now I kept going. At the bottom was an ancient, stuck-together layer I'd glanced at before without recognition. Now I teased the pages apart like pastry layers, revealing titles I'd never played, or heard of. "Bobbie Shaftoe's Gone to Sea" and "The Wraggle Taggle Gypsies-O." These programs were not from my little school concerts. They were from hers. Handwritten, mimeographed, marching up the years to the Virginia High School Glee Club. I'd guessed right; this was about singing. She'd been special, like me. In every one of these handbills she'd saved, my mother was listed as a soloist. With her well-pitched voice I'd only ever heard in church, or else raggedly humming under her breath, my mother had charmed audiences with "Catch a Falling Star" and "For the Beauty of the Earth" and "Long Black Veil," and Patsy Cline's "Walkin' After Midnight."

Another curious thought came to me. Under Gaz's nervous watch, I got up and rifled through the clothes in my mother's closet. But it wasn't here I'd seen them; it was upstairs. She kept her very oldest clothes in what used to be Cy's room. I'd looked through these sometimes, long before they came to be my problem, because I used to find an eerie magic in that closet. It was like a fairy tale, seeing these dresses she must have worn as a happy woman. Unlike the other junk, this sentimental trove made a kind of sense: youthful colors, full round skirts that swirled when she danced with my father. Anybody might hold on to such things, well past any hope of fitting into them again. Delicate buttons, tiny waists, she must have been thin as a rail back then, like me. A physicality completely vanquished by the body I'd always known her in.

I hated going in Cy's room, but I was on a mission now, marching upstairs with Gaz on my heels, leaving him to watch from another doorway while I burrowed into that closet. Here they were, long dresses in slinky fabrics. A teal-colored cowgirl type of thing with pearl buttons and white fringe along the sleeves. Good Lord. Nashville. If I looked back through her hoard of vinyl records, would I find her name in a fine-print list of backup singers? Or a box of tapes from a studio session, autographed with thanks from the day's recording star—Stringbean Akeman or Kitty Wells or

whoever the heck? Earl Scruggs? Maybe she'd stepped in as a backup singer at the Glen Ballroom. Was that how she captivated my father? As a *siren*?

I felt something close to panic. My family story could not be this complete contradiction of the one I'd lived through, with a mother who despised not just the idea of chasing happiness, but *music*. We could not be these people. A mother who loved music, like her daughter. A keeper of secrets, even her biggest and most crushing one, even from her own family. Like her daughter.

Not possible. I couldn't put on those shoes and walk in them. How could she have gotten anywhere close to session musician or backup singer in just a few months? Maybe there was an invitation, a band, or talk of one. Then she came back home, to be the person I knew her to be. Whatever she'd briefly hoped for had blown away, and all the chaff fell here. I worked the cowgirl dress out from its neighbors for a better look. And the long, low-cut dress next to it, shimmery blue fabric, slit to the thigh on one side. Did she have to fight with her mother to get these dresses she thought were beautiful? That she needed "for parading herself around"?

I had a flash of recognition, and we ran down to the kitchen, Gaz's feet galloping a cadence behind me on the stairs. I'd lost the morning to this goose chase, and here I went, still chasing. Mickie had made me promise I would read the grandmother letters this morning *and* whatever was in the envelope about my brother, *and* she was holding me to it. Was calling me on her break at 12:45 because, in her opinion, I should not be dealing with the shit in that freaking horror house all by myself. She was also dying of curiosity. After Mickie's call, I would have to go home for an afternoon of scheduled lessons. My assignment was still mostly undone, I already had too much to report, and now I was sidetracked, pawing through the pile of Simplicity patterns Charlie had moved off the table the day he brought me lunch. The low-cut gown he'd held up with a laugh. My mother, and *that*. Hilarious. The cowgirl dress was here too. I held them up like winning cards. "Look!"

Gaz did as I commanded, then went back to staring through the glass storm door at the backyard. He didn't mind the kitchen so much. I pulled the paper patterns out of their envelopes. They were stuck full of holes where she'd pinned the light brown tissue to her satiny fabrics and cut out pieces to stitch together. For a glee club concert, or whatever shiny future

she imagined she'd find in Nashville. Most of the other patterns were for children's clothes, all in original condition, never used. Probably her mother sent these, knowing she was a whiz with her sewing machine. For the eggs in her dear basket, a new project for the new life my mother could never make herself take up. Oh, my heart. We all cracked together.

The fat manila envelope labeled "Cyrus" was a cache of news more baffling than my grandmother's letters, if it even pertained to our family: newspaper pages and clippings that seemed random. I had to wonder if my brother's name on this package might be accidental. But it wouldn't be in the wedding dress box unless it mattered. Also, tucked down among the clippings, there was that envelope I'd been holding my breath not to think about since I first ran across it. The one addressed to "Mom" in his handwriting. I leafed through the clippings instead, trying to pin anything to Cyrus. All from our local paper. I carefully unfolded a whole front page. Did Cy care about the county board's rejection of a zoning change? The wrap-up of youth summer baseball season? I moved on to other clippings: columns of court reports; others detailing what they used to call "society notices," which mostly proved the absence of any real news in our county. Mr. and Mrs. So-and-so's daughter getting engaged, somebody visiting from out of town, some young scion enlisting in the US Marines. A name caught my eye, and I backtracked to the court reports, then the front page again. All of them mentioned a Marshall Sterling, eighteen years of age. In the front-page account, he was picked up by the police with three other boys at two a.m. on Monday night in the back storage room of the Western Auto store. Of the three unnamed boys, one was local; the other two were residents of a nearby town. The article suggested all four were involved in whatever was going on, but three were minors, so their identities could not be disclosed. In this town, I thought, that was a joke; all names would be known far and wide before any ink hit this paper. But I couldn't rule out the local one being my brother. He never made it to eighteen. I checked the date on the masthead. A couple of months before he died.

Along with the unnamed minors and Marshall Sterling, the incident involved the owner of the Western Auto store, Wesley Summits. He wasn't present at the time of the so-called raid, but was awakened at his home and taken into custody the same morning. He insisted he was innocent of any

wrongdoing and so were the boys, “just some fellows visiting with each other.” Mr. Summits vouched for them all as good boys with decent grades and Boy Scout merit badges among them. They had his permission to be in his store. He’d made it available after hours as a place for these young people to socialize, since they had no other reasonable place to gather. Mr. Summits didn’t have a lawyer, I was guessing, because he was very wordy for a man accused. He also stated: “Parents won’t like me saying this, but most of their kids are out drinking and getting up to mischief and doing their carousing in cars. These boys needed an alternative to that.” I read the article three times, start to finish, and found no reason why the policemen should have given up their sleep over four boys with no larcenous intentions in a warehouse room full of car parts and unsold bicycles. Or the man who’d given them the key. Alcohol didn’t seem to be a factor. There was mention of “confiscated materials,” but no other damning evidence.

Again, I wished for somebody left alive to fill in the holes. If this really was a piece of our family history, which I still couldn’t believe. I suppose I could have slept through a late phone call sending one of my parents to the police station to pick up Cyrus. I was eleven, with even less than the average schoolchild’s interest in local affairs. Definitely not a reader of newspapers. After the front-page splash, the incident regressed to inside pages, the court reports and social columns. Mr. Summits had to see his name run up the flagpole several times, but no charges were brought against him. On the society-column side of things, Marshall Sterling’s parents were proud to announce his enlistment with the United States Marine Corps. The Western Auto affliction that rang our town’s alarm bells would evidently be cured by the Marines.

I knew my parents had wanted the same for Cy, military service. Not looking to get him out of trouble, though, surely. They just said it would be good for him. I read every word of the clippings again, looking for an outline of my brother that wasn’t there. If he’d been pulled by accident into some kind of hot water, he’d have told me. Or it would have come up after he died, gossip at school or a side-glanced remark from some adult at church. There was nothing like that. They all just steered clear, as if we’d been infected with the death we failed to prevent. Cy was a troubled person but not a maker of trouble. Anything but. He was our family saint.

Only once did I ever hear otherwise. Racking my brain now for some shadow on my brother’s reputation, it’s the only hint I could recall. It came

up in a fight, after I told my mother I'd been accepted to IU on a music scholarship. My piano teacher had arranged a remote audition for me in Knoxville, which my parents thought was just one of my competitions, and they never asked another thing about it. So this was a blindside, sudden news I was going away to college. They'd seen no planning, and probably assumed my lack of resources would keep me out of the running. I allowed for the element of surprise, but didn't expect a screaming match. She did, and then I did, while my father sat in his chair looking back and forth between us. I think he was afraid of us. Of our undisguised hatred and our energy for the attack.

I was a terrible person. This was her position, and it grew tentacles faster than I could swat them off: I'd lied to my parents about my plans. I was an ungrateful sneak. People like me didn't care about home or other people or the commandment to honor thy father and mother. They moved away and didn't come home again. What I screamed back at her were probably variations on the theme of her never having cared anyway. If she wanted to keep me around, she should have acted like it. When she held her position that only bad people leave home, I threw Cyrus in her face. They'd wanted *him* to go away. They badgered him to enlist.

I'd said it without a thought, and was startled by the dark shift his name brought into the room. She went quiet. My father held the arms of his chair as if it were tipping backward. He looked at her, not me, and for a long minute, none of us said anything. Then, almost whispering, she said that was different. The military didn't teach you to put yourself above other people. It taught young men to have good values.

I looked from one of them to the other and asked a question I thought my parents would find ridiculous. Did Cy need better values? And my mother said yes. Yes, he did.

Mickie called at 12:45 on the nose, asking for the down-low. I told her I didn't think it would fit in her half-hour break. I didn't say my down-low was what her husband liked to call "ten pounds of shit in a five-pound bag." I sat on the floor running my fingers through the fur of Gaz's nape over and over to calm myself down, and told Mickie about my one discovery that felt like a proper story: My mother had gone to Nashville for a few months, before she married. Evidently she loved to sing, was locally admired for it.

She tried to make something bigger out of that, against her mother's extremely cruel objections. I quoted some of the awfullest ones. True to these brutal predictions, my mother failed and came back home to begin her life of domestic drudgery.

Mickie was quiet.

"And they all lived miserably ever after," I added.

"There you go," she said. "There's you and your mother in a fortune cookie."

"Really?" I asked. "Because I've been sitting with it all morning, and I can't make it work. She hated everything about me and music. If you had a passion for something that passed down to your kids, would you not cheer for them to take it and run with it?"

"Not if it felt like a bank robbery," she said.

"I *stole* music from her?"

"Livia, I have everything I could ask for in life. It's easy for me to want my kids to have the same. But she got punished for her dreams, it sounds like."

"Thank you, says the punishing, thieving daughter."

She didn't laugh. "You're giving yourself credit for things you had nothing to do with."

"As self-centered children do."

She did laugh that time. But wasn't letting it go. "There's this famous poem by Langston Hughes that asks what happens to a dream that gets deferred."

I felt dizzy. Sigurd. In a tiny, sun-filled kitchen pouring his coffee over ice. I realized I'd gone hours without thinking of him. "I've heard of that poem," I told Mickie.

"Then you know the answer."

"It was a long time ago, and I wasn't really paying attention. So no, maybe not."

"Well, I won't spoil the whole thing for you, but it doesn't go well. It festers like a sore, and stinks, and sags like a heavy load. There's an explosion at the end."

"Damn," I said.

"Damn."

They'd already lost one of us. I was all the future my parents had left. That's the story I thought I'd been written into. She was unhappy because we didn't turn out the way she wanted. Cyrus, for tragic reasons, didn't turn out at all. With so much now at stake, I was never going to be up to snuff. That's what I heard in those phone calls. Nothing I accomplished would make good on the family debt. Or if so, that was risky too, the permanent trap of growing up. It's a reflex for a parent to disapprove of change, to dread being judged and coming up short in the eyes of one's child. Even my vowels were shifting away from her. She had ears. I was becoming the high-and-mighty kind of person she saw too much of on television. Whatever it was—shame or dread or disapproval—she was papering it over with indifference. I thought.

But envy? I had no inkling. Every spectacular concert, all the praise and applause, the joy that made everything else disappear, that even let *me* disappear, out of the house into my own world. All stolen treasure. From her. I felt something move inside me, the way a bunch of rocks will settle down in a jar when you shake it.

I didn't do it to hurt her. I just didn't get a choice. She didn't either.

I sat for several minutes with the envelope on my lap. Not in that dismal bedroom—I had to do this outside. The front porch was far and away the best part of the house, if you ignored the big flowerpots full of dead geraniums and a messy rabble of sparrows' nests. The porch swing never accumulated piles, even when she was alive, because it got rained on in a high wind. (She took some care to guard her rubbish from harm.) So there I sat, swinging gently forward and back, toes on the floorboards, a small breeze in my hair, heart thumping, trying to make myself open and read a suicide note. I tried to send Gaz out on a look back, but he was wise to me and settled on the porch floor at my feet.

If I didn't do it now, I might not ever. I had to go home soon. Today's students were my adults, who came after their various workdays to take their lessons in my living room. I'd be at the piano all afternoon into early evening, and then with Charlie, and this strange space that had opened up inside me would close again, and maybe I'd have no more heart for her secrets. From my precarious perch of compassion, I could easily fall back

into the satisfaction of rage I'd carried all these years, striking imaginary matches and burning my mother to the ground.

"Mom," it said on the envelope, in his handwriting. On a reused junk mail envelope addressed to "Resident." He'd scratched that out and revised it, not *To my family*, not *Mom and Dad*. Just her. I worked a finger under the tape that had resealed it, and it gave up easily.

When you read this I'll be gone. I have to show you I am not something you can make into what you want. You can't. I'm free. Livia will understand, I wrote to her. Just think about this when you try to make her stop doing what she wants. I am not yours, and she isn't either. —Cyrus

"What in the everloving hell," I said aloud. To Cyrus, I guess. Otherwise, it was just me and Gaz and the sparrows. A lifetime of guessing couldn't have gotten me to this. For *me* he erased himself? To set me free? I refused that with my whole body. Damn it, Cyrus. God *damn*. Livia did not understand. He did *not* write anything to me. Oh Christ.

"Stay here," I commanded, in a voice so harsh it hurt us both.

I had almost no time for this, but back I went into that horrible lair, took hold of the accursed box and dumped out everything on the bare mattress. The fat packet of clippings, the satiny loops of dress and tissue paper, the gray rime and dust of silverfish. An envelope with my name on it. Still sealed. *Jesus.*

This one was square, pale yellow, from a box of unused stationery in his desk that matched the set I had in pink, gifts from our aunt who imagined children had correspondences. Where did he leave this note he meant for me to find? Instead of our mother, who obviously did. I had no hesitation on this one. I tore it open as I walked back through the house and out to the porch. Unfolded the letter with shaky hands as I stood on the front steps with the afternoon sun trying to blind me.

Dear Livia,

I'm really sorry. I know you will be okay. I can't be any more. The thing is, I love Marshall Sterling and he loves me. He thinks I'm perfect. They made him go away in the Marines, maybe you knew about that, but not why. It's because of him and me. I never thought I would get to be with somebody in love, but we are, and I'm so happy. I want to finish it up here, and not do all the rest of the stupid days from here on out where there's no Marshall and me again, ever. That's like being dead, only worse. Screw that.

I'm sorry I didn't tell you before. I know you'll be mad. I want to say something nice, like have a good life. I don't have to tell you to practice because nobody could make you stop. Music is your total everything like Marshall is for me, only it won't disappear on you

or join the Marines. Hang tight sister, you are the righteous champion in our wasted family so don't ever look back. When you're famous I will tell everybody in heaven I'm your brother and we used to play chopsticks together, ha ha.

Love, Cy

I called the first of my afternoon students to tell him I would be a little late, so he should go on in the house and run through his pieces until I got there. I had to tell him it wouldn't be locked; people here generally don't lock our doors. This young man—Gerald was his name—moved here for a job with the County Extension Service and was still learning our ways. He'd taken up the piano for his thirtieth birthday, he said, because it's something he'd always wanted to do. Which is touching. Most people set themselves pretty hard against trying anything new after they've reached adult size, for fear of appearing childish. I hated being late, but he didn't seem to mind. I told him I was having car trouble.

My trouble with my car was, I didn't want to get in it. I needed to walk. It would take me about twenty minutes, which seemed long enough for the good cry I needed before sitting down with Gerald. Instead of taking the road, Gaz and I cut across on a cow path I knew from childhood. It ran along a pasture edge overgrown with tall arcs of blackberry bramble and honeysuckle and every kind of thing that wants to live in a wild thicket like that. Cy and I used to see foxes down in this glade sometimes, groundhogs by the score, black snakes we chased with sticks. One time, a mother skunk with her children following in a line like kindergartners on a field trip. In the afternoon heat today, it was dead silent. I let myself picture Cy on this path, carrying the pocked metal bucket we used for whatever we would pick or try to catch. Following behind him with exactly the same devotion as the four-footed shadow that followed me now. I could see him so plainly: the ragged white hems of his blue jeans, the pale soles of his tennis shoes lifting and setting down ahead of me on the path. He could have been playing with older kids, but mostly he chose me. We could still be here on this dirt track with its animal smells and leaf breath in our lungs, holding together these memories, that motherless house, the all of it. If he'd chosen more time. Tears came finally in a sobbing free fall, blurring my eyesight and running down my face and out my nose, which I wiped with the back of my wrist. I'd have to wash up some before I saw Gerald. I had planned to change out

of the work clothes I wore for excavating that wreck of a house, but Gerald worked outdoors and wouldn't mind my dungarees. At least today it wasn't my nightgown. I'd got past that business some way.

I was glad I'd come down into the woods to fall apart, instead of out on the road where anybody could see me. These steep fields, the land between my childhood home and the one where Charlie and Mickie grew up, were all worked by Charlie now. The house where Mickie now lived with James was his family house, across the road. We'd lived our lives in this place, Gaz's kin too for that matter, without any idea how we'd lose and then find each other again differently—the boy on crutches; his kid sister; the rowdy squad of tomboys across the road who railed against their little monarch and only brother, James. Almost every tree here held some scrap of our past, every ditch and fencerow and the fields we ran all over, seeking each other out or else hiding. Where the Barnes sisters tied Mickie to a sycamore and gathered up kindling to burn her. Charlie and Cyrus rescued her together, little Charlie Cable flailing at those long-legged girls with one of his crutches. Mickie was so little. Their reasoning against her, probably about the same as for any witch ever burned. Maybe they foresaw she'd grow up to enchant their brother. These families on adjacent farms supplied each other with childhood playmates who became adult mates: Mickie and James, Charlie and me. Like the Land of Nod in Genesis that was just magically *there* to pony up wives for Adam and Eve's sons the minute they needed them. Good Lord, did Cyrus make trouble over that one, standing up to our Sunday school teacher. If there was only the Garden and these two people God created, what is up with these wives all the sudden? The Sunday School lady was unprepared to defend her sources and waved us all outside to play on the grassy riverbank. But Cy was so mad. *There is more to the story than anybody's telling us* was his complaint, and there surely was. Oh, Cyrus, so much more. Marshall Sterling, the happiness he never saw coming. If he'd known that another world lay outside of the one little garden we knew, could he have gotten through his inconsolable hour? To trust that his huge new feelings belonged to a bigger life that could come to him again? *Cyrus.*

Tears felt good, but brought on a flush of anger that surprised me. Not the familiar burn of abandonment, but of fresh impatience. Everybody loses love! You kick a box, howl into your pillow, then make yourself go meet the rest of it. The boys that come along every hour like buses, as Amadeo put it.

How I'd scorned his ignorance. I would never be happy again. I fell into darkness and stopped believing in light. I could reach inside myself right now and find what Cyrus must have felt, *and not do all the rest of the stupid days from here on out where there's no him and me again.* We were the all-or-nothing kind, Cy and me. As Mickie's counselor friend had once kindly hinted, this bright dangerous stream runs in families, tipping us toward the extremes, filling up a house to suffocation, handwashing down to raw knuckles. Loving so hard in a moment, the only possible choices are to be fully loved or be nothing.

I was twenty when my turn came to face the impossible. Almost three years older than Cy. Maybe that's all it took, that many more days, and the chance to make my small life just enough bigger to be worth holding onto. I thought of Bassoon, the happiness he didn't expect that had taken him by surprise. I had more of the world and time, and I had music, my "total everything"—Cy wasn't wrong to think so, even if my everything was soon to take a hard turn. Cy had nothing. He could have stayed for me, I always thought. But he was nearly a man. I was an eleven-year-old child, down at the church all hours, hunched over the piano with my heart pressed flat against key signatures and quarter notes.

Did he tell our mother he was doing it for me? Or was he asking for some pledge, from both of us, that no cage would be clamped around my heart, so I could live as a whole person? If he'd come in my room that night and made me promise, what would be different? I did what I loved, wanted ferociously and took freely, even when no taking was granted, and it cost me a lot. Everything, I'd have said at the time. Survived it in patched-up parts that don't quite work the way they did, but I do think, Cyrus, I took the better path. I've not said so to anybody, ever, and now it's too late, but I wish I could.

I might have been talking aloud to myself when those thoughts passed through me. Quietly, under my breath, which is a thing I do sometimes, the same way I press mute notes into somebody else's skin, that nobody hears. When I was a girl, they told us only crazy folk talked to themselves. Fair enough.

Through the soles of my shoes I could feel acorns rolling like marbles underfoot. This summer would die soon. The goldenrod would bow down and acorns would cover the ground and a golden time would fold into itself

again like a tablecloth waiting for the next banquet. I could feel all the life in this little place passing through us and right on past.

The peaked roof of our farmhouse was visible as I crested the hill, and then Gerald's white truck parked in the drive. I would go in and wash my face and sit down with this young man who gets up before dawn every day to go talk with farmers about fencing their cattle to help the creeks on all our farms run clear. After that, he comes to me, for the piano lessons he's wanted since he was a boy and finally gave himself as a man. I help him put his hands on the keys and find what he's been missing.

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Pathétique

Ladawna shut the exam room door and shot her day's appointment schedule to hell. She probably spent over an hour with me. Under her gentle questions, I laid out prospects so awful they even made me wonder myself how a person could get herself in such a mess. No, the father was not in my life. Gone, I would never see him again. No, I said, looking down at my tennis shoes, dirty white against the black floor, I had no family who would support me through this. They hadn't spoken to me in many months. I had no income since the accident, and no employable skills in my new condition. Not now, maybe not ever. Not even health insurance, starting any day now when the university discovered I was freeloading. Yes, I was one hundred percent sure I did not want to keep this baby. At least ninety percent of me didn't even believe in this so-called baby. Was Ladawna really sure? Because a few minutes ago, I was just a person waiting to get X-rays. The only things in my belly were a lack of breakfast and a monthslong bout of nausea I'd chalked up to the convoy of godawful surprises barreling through my life.

"Umm-hmm," said Ladawna. "Could be the convoy just got longer."

After moving her stethoscope around under my T-shirt with a neutral listening face, she said, "Stay right here," went away for a little while, then came back with an ultrasound cart she'd rounded up from somewhere. She wheeled it into the room and wasted no time slathering my flat tummy with

Vaseline. I was sure there was nobody in there. Ladawna tried to show me something on the screen, but to me, it just looked like the same cirrus clouds that had wafted across the scene of the nerve-block needle on my big night in the emergency room. This felt continuous, all part of the same long nightmare. Then Ladawna said something that woke me right up. She said, "About nineteen weeks."

I told her that was impossible. Her eyes widened, and she waited while I counted backward to May, Sigurd's sweltering little apartment. Well, yes, sex was happening then, plenty of it. I had to confess to Ladawna that in a biological sense, it was possible.

She blinked a couple of times and hesitated slightly before telling me the "biological sense" of pregnancy was kind of the whole thing.

I tried to laugh, without quite getting there, and assured her I did know about the birds and the bees. We had used protection. By *impossible*, I meant that an almost-five-months-pregnant person would look nothing like me. She would be rubbing her round belly, lumbering around in maternity tops and painting her stupid nursery.

Ladawna said pregnant ladies look all kinds of ways. I looked like one that had almost no body fat to begin with, and had barely eaten enough to keep herself going, never mind a passenger. She said the fetus was very small for its term, and considering all it had been through with me—anesthesia, surgery, pain medicine, and all that throwing up—it must be a scrapper. But she was pretty solid on how far along we were, despite what she called a low rump-to-crown measurement. She could see things like spine development that wouldn't show up earlier.

She was in the bone-doctoring business, of course, not the pregnancy business. She said I should follow up with the OB-GYN down the hall if I wanted more information. "But honey, I'm just going to tell you. He *is* going to find a baby in there. It's been hiding real well, but we are ollie-ollie-in-free now."

I did laugh then, but it chucked out of my throat more like a sob and I blinked to keep from tearing up. Ladawna set down the wand she'd been sliding around on my belly, peeled the blue gloves off her dark brown hands, and gave me a hug. I wanted to stay right there. But I'd already used up way more than my fair share of Ladawna.

She wrote down the name and address of a clinic that helped young ladies in my situation. She said there was a women's group on campus that

could round up a ride for me if I needed it. I looked at what she'd written and said I wouldn't need a ride. This was my first lucky break in a lot of months. The clinic was two blocks from my apartment.

I'd walked past that building just about any time I'd stepped out. To my ortho clinic appointments, mostly, or the mini-mart for string cheese and ginger ale and potato chips. To campus, but no farther than the southwest gate where I could see the tops of the trees in Dunn's Woods, and I wasn't even sure why I did that. I felt the pull of the practice building all the time, like the pain of a phantom limb. Another home that would never have me back. And just once, I'd gone to Gorgo's. The kitchen gave me a hero's cheer, and Amadeo said he'd hire me again the minute I was back on my feet, technically meaning two-handed. I thanked him.

Now I would pass the building again, coming home from my surprising appointment. The X-rays eventually did come to pass, after some awkward fuss about finding a lead apron to cover my middle parts. Just like that, the news I'd been waiting for so anxiously turned into a feathery thing that flew away without landing. I would not need another hand surgery. From here on out, it was up to the OT ladies to urge me through stretches and bends and the fist I clenched in spirit but still couldn't muster. All the bones had knit themselves, a little hodgepodge in the manner of survivors, and the jury was in. The hand I had now was the hand I was going to live with. I could hold a pen, and with patience could relearn to write my name. *Piano* was a word I didn't say anymore. The X-ray gave me cause to be glad and also terribly sad, and if I'd gotten a minute to catch up to myself, I might have felt something, but I didn't. I had another fish to fry.

I slowed down to check out the women's health clinic as I approached it. Three protestors today, two women and a man, all three ignoring a young woman who sat at a table just outside the glass doors, presumably there to help get customers inside. The building was beige stucco with a shallow parking lot across its full width like a modest storefront, minus any plate glass windows to show off the goods. A blue sign over the entrance identified it as a clinic in a serene font that seemed designed to be overlooked. I couldn't count how many times I'd passed it by without thinking the place was of any consequence to me, now or ever.

The little team of protestors came to life and wobbled their placards when they saw me looking. “Please don’t murder your baby,” requested both the women’s signs, because women say please, even when it’s murder we’re discussing. They were nondescript, but the man was dressed to be seen, all in white, even his shoes, with a big head of hair swept back like a disco rooster. He hoisted an image of a fetus entirely unlike anything I’d seen on Ladawna’s screen, with red paint smeared across it, which he probably thought was terrifying. He should have seen my right hand two months ago. Helpful of him to advertise the services here, since there were no other hints on the premises. I was tempted to flash him a thumbs-up: *Count me in!*

But first I had to go home and curl up on my narrow bed and pull myself together: the emptiness inside me that wasn’t, the goneness of what I’d had in my hands, the future I’d meant to make, the man who was gone and also still here as a red bull’s-eye on my body. In the department of pulling a self together, it was a lot.

I wasn’t sure whether abortion was a walk-in or an appointment type of endeavor, but either way, I told myself I’d go over there on Friday. It was a Tuesday when I found out. Hooray for Fridays, then, that sleeve-tugging nag that moves procrastinators to act. On both Wednesday and Thursday, I practiced, walking out to the mini-mart in spite of a graham cracker supply that could easily have gotten me through the weekend. I needed to view the situation. Wednesday was slow, two different women and that same man, who seemed to be in charge of protesting. The crowd was bigger on Thursday, men and women of various ages, including some young mothers with kids in tow. I had to wonder how they explained the baby-murdering thing to their offspring. The crowd looked miserable in the biting wind, moms and kids especially. A toddler straitjacketed into a big puffy coat stood howling next to his stroller-bundled sibling, his pink face all shiny with snot. I wondered what part of this show they thought was going to change my plans.

I spent most of Thursday night awake with anticipation, and some of Friday morning wondering what people usually wear to an abortion. I finally stepped outside, to shocking cold. The temperature had plummeted overnight. Ovals of frost salted the windshields of all the cars parked on the

street. I went straight back in to strategize about wardrobe. In my new life with a stiff, swollen hand, I'd gotten by since August in short sleeves. Now I rooted through my boxes to find a heavy sweater or coat with enough forgiveness in its sleeve to admit my painful extremity all the way through. That, or wear a blanket like a homeless lady. I finally managed to get into a sweater by bunching the sleeve inside out and rolling it onto my arm like a condom.

Protestors were just trickling in when I got there, huddled in a little clump, blowing on Styrofoam cups of coffee. I walked straight past them, making eye contact with the friendly girl staffing the table a few feet outside the doorway. A student volunteer, I guessed from the red-and-white IU jacket and makeup that seemed more than equal to the circumstances. Blue eye shadow and everything. Maybe a sorority pledge doing her public service. She was friendly and efficient, taking down my name and phone number and asking for my driver's license, which I hadn't used in over three years but had brought with me just in case. My aching hand was useless in the cold, so it took me a minute to dig it out. She studied it for a long time, then flicked her blond ponytail over her shoulder and looked up at me.

"I assume you know about the twenty-four-hour waiting period? But we've got a problem, you're still under twenty-one."

"Yes, ma'am," I said. Nerves short-circuiting me back to childhood.

"So. You'll need a parent's permission."

"I'm sorry, what?"

"It's Indiana law. I see your birthday's not till November."

"I don't think you . . . I'm not financially dependent on my parents." I just looked at her, flummoxed. Younger than me, this willowy girl, falsely bulked out by the stiff white leather sleeves of her boyfriend's letter jacket. She stared up at me, perfectly patient. "No," I finally said. "That's not going to work."

She handed back my driver's license with a little shrug of her righteous armor. "We're not in a position to break the law. I'm sorry. You might be able to get a court order or something, I guess. Good luck!"

I walked back to my apartment, lay down on the bed, and stayed there for several hours eating graham crackers in my heavy sweater. I had no control over my apartment's heat—the thermostat was in the main house—and my little apartment had become a hothouse. When the crackers were gone, I ran

the fingers of my left hand around the inside corners of the waxy paper and licked sweet grit from my fingertips. My right hand was a bulb that never went out, wired from the inside to generate its glow of pain. I pictured taking off the sweater: first reversing it off my torso, then rolling it back from my arm inside out and finally over the tender hand, like a snake shedding its skin. But the energy for that was beyond my making. I lay sweltering on a pillow that smelled like a brackish creek. Life had defeated me. I had no next moves.

I stewed for a week, long enough to consider every single escape route I couldn't take. Calling my parents didn't even make the list. Talking to Ladawna was possible, but unlikely to yield helpful results. I called the ortho clinic anyway and booked myself into her first available. I told the receptionist it was a follow-up on my X-rays. "She found something she didn't like the looks of," I said, making my voice very solemn. The receptionist said she would pray for me.

I considered writing Sigurd, but only got as far as addressing an envelope. I didn't have a stamp, or any words. Sigurd was finished with me; that had been settled months ago. Changes on my end of our equation did not signify changes on his. After another day of deliberation, I wrote a quick note explaining that I had a new phone number and would appreciate a call, when he got a chance. Then I wrote "yours truly" and then drew a line through that, because I wasn't. Just Livia.

Bassoon and Percussion stopped by that week to check on my recovery and drop off some work for me, as we'd previously arranged. It was their first visit since Percussion got back from Munich, and before they were even inside the door, still stomping wet brown leaves off their boots, it struck me: *Of course* these two were together. Percussion lifted his sunglasses and looked at my hand before he bent to give me a hug. Then shucked off his leather jacket and declared my apartment was as hot as the hinges of hell.

"Sorry," I said. "I don't pay enough rent to get my own thermostat."

They sat on the bed, which I'd made for the occasion, because my rickety chairs were iffy for full-grown men. They sat slightly apart, honoring the invisible boundary that would have been habit, even with friends like me who'd be glad to see them hold hands. I tried not to stare at how much

Europe had changed them. Percussion seemed even taller and thinner, if that was possible, with a new spiky haircut and little round glasses like black quarters in front of his eyes, now pushed up on his bristly red head. I apologized for the state of my apartment, which hadn't changed much since Bassoon helped me move in my boxes. The empty milk quarts lined up like chubby plastic soldiers on the counter, those were new. Also, the dishes in the bathtub.

They asked about my hand, and I showed off my pitiful, hard-earned range of motion. Most of that hand was a whole different color from the rest of me, the livid pink of a hot dog. Bassoon insisted it looked better, told Percussion he should have seen it a month ago, and nobody brought up Ravel's repertoire for one-handed pianists. Bassoon opened his satchel and pulled out a pile of student-written four-part chorales, which he was outsourcing to me. He'd scored a teaching assistantship in the huge freshman theory class, but was scared of grading the chorales, which had traumatized him when he took that class himself. For me, they'd been the second easiest assignment, after dictation. (With perfect pitch, hearing a teacher play notes and writing them on a staff is about like reading an eye chart.) What's hard about grading chorales? Grab a red pen, circle wrong stem directions, parallel fifths and octaves, any note outside its vocal range. Make sure chord progressions move through sensible cadences, dominant to tonic and so on. No creativity is allowed in Theory I. Music is made of rules!

But poor Bassoon, on our Münchener Kümmel nights, had confessed he had treble clef anxiety. Its lines went wavy and crossed when he tried to read it. All the orchestra's deep voices—bassoonists, double bassists, trombonists, euphonium players—use only the bass clef. Other instrumentalists use only the treble. Pianists are fluent in both clefs from our childhood days, training our hands to cover the whole map and many notes at once. We pity the lodgers restricted to only one floor of the grand staff. I'd told Bassoon before and reminded him now, grading chorales would be good practice. "It's not too late to learn. There's a whole mansion up here, and you're living in the basement." We laughed, and the sides of my mouth felt strange. Aloneness had fossilized my face.

"Basement is good. We have our own amusements down here," Bassoon declared.

“Oh, right,” I said. “Five-note ostinatos. You know all the fun stuff happens upstairs.”

Percussion clucked his tongue. “Once a bottom, always a bottom.”

Bassoon gave his partner a look of mock horror and smacked his shoulder. “Polite company, dude!” It was the first I’d seen them touch, and from Bassoon’s pink flush, I got the joke. I wasn’t worldly, but sexually speaking, I’d learned my way around the block.

I was always going to take Bassoon’s side. “Let’s talk about percussionists then. Unpitched staves? That is not the top floor, sir.”

“Right?” said Bassoon. “Illiterates. I don’t think we even let them in the house.”

Percussion lightly shoved him back. “Excuse me, who played xylophone on the *Peer Gynt* in Munich?”

I’d heard that he was handling difficult xylophone parts. I’d also heard he got a pianist to run through the parts for him once or twice, then played them by ear, from memory. It’s an open secret that drummers can’t read music, but there’s more than one way to skin a cat.

“You guys are low-key hilarious,” Bassoon groused happily. “The point is chorales are a pox, and Livia needs the money.”

Livia did. In exchange for this favor, he was diverting some of his TA stipend my way. If a one-handed pianist could still make rent as a musician, I would skin that cat.

The telephone rang from the wall, and we all watched it until it went quiet. I explained I wasn’t supposed to pick up because it was an extension of the phone line in the main house. Just like my overactive heating duct. My landlady did some kind of business from home and got a lot of calls. If one was ever for me, which it never was, she would bang on the wall and I’d pick up. My guests admired my crafty evasion of exorbitant phone and utility bills.

I asked about Jon Link, only because I thought I should. These two were his closest friends. They glanced at each other in a way that told me what they didn’t want to tell me.

“He’s dating somebody. That’s *good*. It makes me feel less guilty for leaving him.”

They looked relieved. “She’s not as fun as you,” Bassoon said.

“*Not* as fun as you,” Percussion agreed.

“Aww, guys. I’m fun? I had no idea.”

“It’s relative,” Bassoon explained. “She registers on the fun scale with . . .” He thought about this for a second. “Flossing.”

“Exactly,” Percussion agreed. “She’s flossing. You’re an absolute Water Pik.”

I laughed. “You can like her. You have my permission. As long as she’s not a pianist.”

They exchanged the look again.

“Okay. Just tell me it’s not Stephania Schmidt.”

They burst open simultaneously with embarrassed laughter. Stephania, my archrival in penny loafers. I wondered with a blank sort of ache if she knew how washed-up I was now.

“Credit the man with good taste,” I said.

“No, it’s an overreach,” Bassoon complained. “She already made him buy a new tux and a stupid fancy coffee maker thing that farts foam. We’re worried the couch will go next.”

“I *love* that couch,” Percussion said, and I didn’t doubt it. He’d slept on it enough.

They steered us into more neutral gossip. Some dethroning of first chairs, post-Munich. The flautist—it was *always* a flautist—alleged to be sleeping with the visiting orchestra conductor. I took the stack of chorales from Bassoon. Grading these would give me some distraction from my loneliness after they’d gone. For at least half an hour, I’d forgotten I was pregnant. I didn’t feel pregnant, didn’t look it, could see no way to bring it into the room with these two happy fellows. I couldn’t, and didn’t.

My appointment at ortho got off on the wrong foot. The receptionist asked how I would be paying for this visit, as my student insurance was no longer valid. She tried several times, but my matriculation number no longer registered in her computer. I told her it wasn’t her fault, I just wasn’t a student anymore. I’d known it would happen but wasn’t ready for it today, in this place that had been the anchor of my recovery and also my social life, if I had to be honest. I was in limbo at the check-in desk when Ladawna stepped out of an exam room and saw me, probably very visibly trying not to cry. If weepiness was a symptom of pregnancy, it’s the main one I had.

She hurried over and told the receptionist not to bother checking me in; this was just a quick consult. Then she steered me out the door into the hallway that connected this clinic with the rest of the University Hospital's warren of departments. Ladawna looked me in the eye and asked what was up. I was surprised that we were the same height. Up to now, we'd only spoken while I was sitting or lying down. I reported what they'd told me at the abortion clinic: that I needed a parent's permission because I was still a minor. Which was a problem.

"*Who* told you that?"

"A receptionist?"

"Well, that is misinformation. The age of consent is eighteen, and even that's not watertight. Was this someone you spoke with in person down there, or on the phone?"

"In person. It was the person that sits at the table outside, checking people in."

"Out*side*? You mean a *protestor* told you that."

"No, the protestors were ignoring her."

Ladawna pulled her head back on her neck and gave me a look that stretched her face—eyebrows up, mouth pulled down.

"Oh," I said. "I'm an idiot. She was one of them."

"Honey, that was not misinformation, it was a goddamn lie. Those sneaking *assholes*."

I must have looked a little startled, glancing up the hallway.

"Don't worry, that's why we're out here. I'm on my break, and I can call anybody on God's green earth an asshole if I so choose. So look, you've lost a little time, but you get back down there tomorrow. Do not talk to anybody till you get inside the door. Take somebody with you. If you need an escort, fullback, whatever, call that number I gave you, and they will get you a person. You're in need of immediate medical attention, and nobody has any business standing in the way of that. Do you hear me?"

I promised Ladawna I did.

"All right, dear. You let me know how it goes."

She gave me a quick hug and disappeared back into the clinic. I longed to follow her back in there, wait for the end of her shift, go home with her, curl up on her sofa and pet her dog if she had one. I knew she had teenage kids because she'd spoken of them. She wouldn't have to cook for me or anything like that. I just wanted to be near somebody who would kick down

doors for me, move a mountain without the slightest doubt that sucker was standing in the wrong place and I was in the right. I'd known love, had *been* loved, I thought. And it was nothing like that.

I didn't call for an escort because I'm a farm girl from Tennessee. I've gone head-to-head with horned beasts in a pasture, and with my mother, who was scarier than any Jersey bull. Back when my brother and I used to do early barn chores, our father always gave us the same advice when we left him to head out for school: Don't take any wooden nickels. Apparently I had done just that. It wouldn't happen again.

The clinic's parking lot was empty when I got there. No protestors, no table out front, a handwritten sign on the door that said "Closed." I stood with my forehead against the glass door and looked at the emptiness inside—a proper front desk with a computer and a plant, not a card table with a tablecloth and a sorority girl. (I was an idiot.) An empty waiting room ringed with plastic chairs. My breath made clouds against the glass while my head refused to believe I couldn't go in there and sit in one of those chairs. The hours listed on the door, in permanent paint, said "Open Monday through Saturday, 9 a.m. to 6 p.m." The "Closed" sign was written in ballpoint pen on lined paper, taped from the inside. In smaller writing, it explained this was an emergency closure and gave a phone number, which I didn't write down.

Saturday was the same. Nobody inside the building or out. Same sign on the door.

I wanted to bang the glass door with my one good fist. What I didn't want to do, didn't think I could, was spend another night lying in bed with my hands on my stomach, saying *Goodbye, good riddance, how dare you* and *Please go away if you are in there at all* to this spark that Sigurd had struck without our consent inside my body. Not *I'm sorry*. I had no apologies to make after faithfully erecting every practical barrier to this outcome. I couldn't think of it as a person or creature of any kind. For most of its life, it had gone by the name of Heartburn.

I memorized the telephone number on the sign and went home to call it.

I got a recorded message. Someone would call me back if I left my number, which I only did because of the kindness in the recorded voice. "We want to help you," it said. "We're taking extra care right now to keep

everybody safe, so you've connected with a switchboard. I promise you'll hear back from us right away."

She called me back in less than ten minutes. I'd waited for my phone-guarding landlady to leave, on the chance a callback might come. I picked up instantly and felt my luck turning around as that same wondrous voice told me her name was Pam, one of the patient coordinators at the clinic, and apologized for the circumstances. I asked what kind of danger anybody might be in. "Just out of curiosity, is it the white-shoes guy with the cock-a-doodle hairdo?"

I could tell Pam thought that was funny, but she kept her tone serious. My mind was trying hard to picture her: old or young, what kind of face. I couldn't pin down her age, but saw blond hair like a Christmas tree angel. Not from around here. She said that guy was not likely to hurt anybody in person, but he was the local head of a group that was trying to get an abortion ban passed.

"I thought we got that worked out already," I said. "Like, ten years ago."

"Closer to twenty, yes, we did. But some states are trying to backslide, and unfortunately, we live in one of them. We're doing our best to work around all that ugliness in the parking lot, but we had a threat on Friday morning that we didn't think we ought to ignore."

I was going to tip her off about the fake doorkeeper, but suddenly understood we were in deeper waters. "Are you saying somebody called in a bomb threat?"

"I'm afraid so."

"You're kidding," I said. Obviously she wasn't. I'd had my head up in music for a lot of years while stuff was happening on the ground. "Is that real, do you think? Or just somebody trying to scare you?"

"We'd like to think they're bluffing, to cause inconvenience. Excuse me a sec." I heard the sound you get from a hand on the phone, muffled voices. I was seeing Pam as maybe in her thirties. From the South. Not Tennessee but Southern, where women sound a little older or more formal because we've grown up polite. I used the short pause to wiggle out of my shirt. Ever since my apartment settled into the hinges-of-hell range, I'd been living mostly in my underwear. I stared at my belly. A little puffy, maybe, but it truly looked innocent of any wrongdoing.

Pam was back. "Sorry, we're taking a lot of things as they come. I don't want to scare you, but clinics like ours have been firebombed. Three in the

last couple of months. We can't take any risks with the safety of our patients, so we made the decision to close while we wait for the police to come search the building."

"Waiting since Friday morning?"

"Yes." She sighed. Probably there was more to say on that subject, but she didn't. "Okay," she said, in a different voice. "How can I help you?"

"I just found out I'm pregnant, and I want to get unpregnant. That's about it."

"Of course. We're expecting to be open Monday, but just in case we aren't, would you like me to refer you to a different clinic that might be able to get you in?"

I thought about that. "No, it's okay, I can wait a few more days. I've gotten my head around this clinic being the one. It's two blocks from my apartment."

"Well, no bad news without some good, right? Let me take down your information, and I'll see when we can schedule you. We're operating right now on the plan of reopening Monday, and it'll be a little bit of a madhouse. I'll need to do a bunch of rescheduling, but we'll get you in, I promise. Next week probably, the week after at the latest. I'm sorry, I'd normally do your intake in person, but we've got to do some triage over the phone, so, do you have a pretty good idea of how many weeks along you are?

I counted back to my X-ray day, the sonogram. "Maybe twenty-one or two?"

Pam made a little throat sound. "I'm sorry, did you say one or two? You might as well wait a little longer to see if your period comes."

"No. I'm sorry, it's *twenty*-one or two. Since May."

I waited. Three, four, five seconds, before she said, "Since May."

"Yeah. I had kind of a bad summer. I almost lost my hand in an accident, so there were surgeries and a lot of pain meds and, you know, metal things sticking out of my hand. I thought throwing up every day was just part of the deal. We probably should have caught the pregnancy sooner, but it only came up before my last X-rays."

"Good Lord, it never rains, but it pours!" Pam said, and then I knew who she was exactly. My mother's age. But a mother you'd want to have.

Everything she told me after that was bad news, but I could tell she felt really awful about it. After twenty weeks, it was too late for the kind of

abortion they did in Pam's clinic. It would be more of a surgical procedure. Not the cutting-you-open kind, but some anesthesia was needed.

I knew it was useless to argue, but I told her my orthopedics doctor had specifically sent me to this clinic. Pam said she was really sorry, they used to do those kinds of abortions in smaller clinics, before all of this pushback. But now, for legal reasons, they had to be done in a hospital or more specialized clinic. The University Hospital would be able to schedule me quickly, she was sure. The procedure was outpatient, and I'd be able to go home right after. She could give me the number of the appointment desk there, and any other help I wanted.

"How much does that cost?" I asked.

"Oh, gosh. You step in the door of a hospital these days, you're already at least five hundred dollars in. But it's covered by insurance. It sounds like you're already in their system."

"Okay," I said.

"Don't tarry, hon," she said, and in my mental picture, Pam's hair turned a beautiful silver. "A pregnancy won't wait for you, it keeps moving along its track. You know that already."

"Yes, ma'am," I said.

"If you go much longer, they won't be in a position to terminate, even at the hospital."

I could tell she didn't want to hang up on me, and I didn't want that either, but my landlady was back from the grocery. Through my wall I could hear her slamming kitchen cabinets, putting away her cans of soup, her cooking oil, whatever it is people have when their lives are their own and they pick up the keys to the car, the purse, the things they need. This telephone line that connected me to Pam, even that wasn't mine. I told her she'd been really helpful. I wished her luck with the bomb-scare thing. And told her I had to go.

It's not real, I remember him whispering. *Not nickels made out of wood. He means don't let somebody tell you something is good when it's not good.*

But she does that. *For your own good*, she says. *Hurts me more than it hurts you.*

Listen, he says then, because we can hear them again. Bobcats or runaways screaming from the woods, the way a person screams. The way

we want to. Outside, shivering in our pajamas under the dead October trees with their black twig fingers trying to cover the moon's crying face. No other light but the blue glow from the house where they're inside watching TV. We practice screaming without any sound. *I'm running away from home*, he says, and I tell him I'm running away too. Where will we go? Cy says, *You're too little, it wouldn't be safe*, and I know he won't go either because he won't leave me alone.

The wildcats cry their long, sad, wailing howls in the dark that make us want to cry too, make us push air quietly through our throats, dry howling at the crying moon. The smallest tightening in that tunnel of throat would make a dry scream catch and come alive, and we want to do that, always. Cry out full-blood loud the way the cats do, hunting mice in their tunnels, fighting over blood. We want to do it every time she hurts us, to see who will hear. No more hiding from her, she told us this time. No more playing in our secret milking stall, velveted white with cobwebs and the dusty crate for our checkers and sitting on cold cement and old straw telling each other stories. He's too old to play with a little sister, she said; a young man has to stop being a child. I tell him, *Then I will stop being a child too*, and we both scream out loud. Finally we're brave, we try, and the end of our story is nobody comes to save us. We can go on screaming, child and not-child, until he runs away by himself and the only scream is metal dragging on rails and nobody remembers hearing that but me.

Is this how it was? No place to go or person to be, not even a body to house you the way you need it to stay alive, no keys to pick up, no door to open. What injury could make you run away without me? *Why didn't you say?*

In the backyard of the bereaved house under the crying moon, I open my mind's eye like a window to let in the people I know, one at a time. Any person I could tell about this wreck that has got me trapped inside. One by one, I let them in, then let them go. They have better places to be, homes dogs teenagers orchestra practices shared beds beloved cocoons. Here under the dead October trees, I let my eyes make friends with the dark and the night gives up everything to me, all its useless things. Uneven squares of pavement breaking a path out of this yard. A wire fence, brushstrokes of moonlight. A coffin garden of straw pale weeds. Nothing here is mine. I am this close to being nothing myself. With these night sounds coming in my ears without my asking. A high steady trill of crickets, a world of crickets

all singing their one high note together. And the contrapuntal rasping triplet, *rachrachrach, rachrachrach*. The same triplet answering back from behind the fence and trees. Every question has its answer, the insect pathétique and the hushed human sounds of tires moving on streets I can't see, going their own places.

In my mind's ear, I make the night noise into a train. The clang-clang overture that lets you know, then almost below hearing, gradually growing, the dry-throated howl that catches to a pitched scream rising on the approach, carried on a low ostinato of round-wheel rumble.

I hear it, but it doesn't belong to me. Survival is the price you're willing to pay for it.

Dear Sigurd,

I have surprising news. When you moved away, you left something here in the oven. It's about half cooked at this point, and I'm as unhappy about it as you will be now. I didn't want to make it your problem, but it has turned into a sticky one. My life got totaled this past summer, is the best way to put it, and without going into to the rest of it, I'll just tell you I tried very hard to get an abortion. No success so far. It's not as easy as you probably think. If your revolution really does care about the fair sex (even ugly ones), please think about abortion clinics with welcome mats instead of asshole protestors and firebombers. And birth control that fucking works.

Sorry, I am mad, not at you necessarily. Mainly because I just found out I will need five hundred dollars to finish this business, and due to the disaster I mentioned, I have no job, scholarship, or health insurance now. It never rains, but it pours.

I tried to handle this myself because I really don't want to need your help. There's this thing my mother used to say about some neighbors that lived in a horrible run-down house on our road: They're too poor to paint and too proud to whitewash. I guess that's me. But without other options, I am requesting cash.

I hope this finds you well.

Livia

I had nightmare after nightmare. Rolling in the overheated darkness, scrolled in sweaty sheets, the familiar throb in my hand and a new sharp pain above my hip bones kept me tethered loosely to wakefulness while I wallowed in a shallow marsh of dreams. Sigurd came in sometimes and spoke kindly, as himself, but then he would be skull and bones holding up his skeleton hand to keep me away. In these dreams, I always had my two beloved hands, and that was terrible too. Dancing over a keyboard, chords and arpeggios I knew and could hear, or sometimes playing pieces I didn't recognize. I understood I should be afraid of these hands with powers outside my knowing. I wanted to trust them, but even inside my dreams, I knew I couldn't.

Awake, I could only think about the whereabouts of my letter. The little truck with the right-side drive would have picked it up by now from the blue helmeted box where I mailed it. Inside a canvas bag, it would ride to the main Bloomington station, maybe from there to Indianapolis. I invented a route, day by day across the plains of corn and soybeans and then the deserts. To Phoenix. I dragged out the journey as long as I could, to postpone the next stage of waiting for the phone to ring. The pounding on the wall that would tell me this was it.

Waiting was poison. Vapors leaked in through the cracks. He might come back. Or want me there with him to raise our child. However awful we'd finally been, Sigurd would still be the man he was. The opposite of selfish. I couldn't imagine carrying the burden of this impending life, had no idea what to do about it, but maybe the duty of knowing wasn't only mine. Maybe it was his too. The temptation of these thoughts was worse than despair. I had to know better. In the end, he didn't love me enough to stay. Full stop. I wasn't enough.

What if his own child might be?

I lay on my back in the swelter and begged the black air above me to swallow me whole: *Please please let me sleep.*

The ringing and pounding fused with my dream. Something breaking or falling, trees, a scene that made sense until I swam up into wakefulness and lost the taste of it in my mouth. Dark, or darkish, but not night. Afternoon.

Raining. I struggled to understand the hour and the day and the self I was supposed to be, the banging on the wall. Oh. I got up so fast I felt woozy and almost tilted over. Held my hands out like a sleepwalker, feeling myself through the daylight toward the telephone on the wall. I picked up, held the receiver to my ear.

My landlady checked to make sure I was there, then hung up. I listened to my own breathing against the receiver. Sat down on the floor with my back to the wall, knees drawn up to my chin. "Hello?"

"Livia, it's Sigurd. Who was that? What's up?"

"That was my landlady. What do you mean, what's up?"

"Why do I need to be calling you?"

Grappling my way into wakefulness, I absorbed his voice and these questions that felt like parts of the dream I'd left over there in the bed. It might make sense if I could crawl back into that bubble where I'd left myself.

"Did you get my letter?" I thought to ask.

"No. She just said it was urgent, there was a phone number, and I should call you."

"*Who* said that?"

"Betsy. The branch organizer. She and Baird are the people I stayed with in Phoenix. Your letter came there."

"That's the address you gave me." I could not grasp what conversation he was having.

"It is, but I'm in Los Angeles now. My transfer came through about two weeks ago. I passed through training faster than most people do." He was proud of himself. Everything going according to plan. *That* was the conversation. I needed to start over.

"I sent a letter to Phoenix, and you're in Los Angeles. So, how did you . . ." I had a sickening thought. "Did somebody else read the letter I sent you?"

"Yes. And told me I should call you as soon as I could. That's all she said."

"*God*, Sigurd. It was personal! This is how it is now? Your private communications have to be screened by Betsy the goddamn organizer?"

"Calm down."

If any two words from a man will sooner blow up a woman's composure, I've not heard them. "I hate you," I said, calmly.

He took a deep, slow breath and let it out. I could see his face, all of him, so clearly. His voice brought the whole package right into my head again, welcome or not. “I’m sorry things with us didn’t end well,” he said. “But it’s been what, three months? Our lives have to go on.”

“Twenty-three weeks,” I said.

“What?”

“That’s how pregnant I am now.”

The rain had picked up, making long, angled streaks down the windows. Exactly the same angle on all the windows, upper left to lower right. The rain had its shit together.

“What?” he finally said.

“I’m pregnant. It was in the letter. I guess Betsy didn’t mention it.”

“She, no. . . . Livia, that’s not possible. We were careful, we always used . . .”

“Birth control, that’s right. And still, here we are.”

“I’m trying to understand. You said how many weeks?”

“Twenty-three, more or less.”

I could hear him doing math or something, turning the calendar back under his breath. “That’s over five months. Since May.”

“Correct.”

“You’re not making sense. If it’s really been that long, why didn’t you say before I left?”

“I didn’t know before you left. And it really has been that long, and yes, it’s yours. I haven’t been with anybody else. Not because . . . that’s not about you, don’t worry. My summer went to hell and I’ve been dealing with a lot of other things.”

“Sorry, I’m just having trouble believing this.”

Not *What other things, Livia?* Just this trouble with believing. I felt ice riming my heart like frost on a windshield. “I had the same problem for a while,” I said. “Wasn’t helpful. So let’s move on to the practicalities.”

“Of course. Get an abortion, you have my blessing on that.”

I laughed.

“What?”

“Your *blessing*. I’ve been trying to get an abortion for a month. I explained all this in the letter. Maybe you should powwow with Betsy and she can fill you in.”

“Livia, I’m sorry she read my mail. I gave her permission to do that when I moved, to forward anything important. I wasn’t expecting anything very . . . You’re right, this is extremely personal. I feel badly for everybody involved.”

“I think the person you need to feel badly for is me.”

“Okay. That’s fair.”

“I’ve been trying hard to get out of this mess, believe me. I didn’t want to involve you. But it got to the point of costing money I don’t have.”

“Okay,” he said. “How much are we talking about?”

It was my turn to take a slow breath. “I think it’s actually too late now,” I said.

“What do you mean?”

“After twenty weeks, it’s more of a surgical procedure, in a hospital. Which is where the thing got out of my price range. I didn’t think it would take this long to hear back from you. Unfortunately, now I’ve timed out.”

“Out of what?”

“Options. It’s not legal at this point for me to get an abortion in this state.”

“How is that possible?”

A wave of exhaustion hit me. I was just trying to tell him the truth. I’d called the hospital as Pam advised, and the nurse I spoke with was clear on the numbers. While I was waiting for Sigurd to come through with the cash, the price of my predicament bumped up drastically.

Our predicament. Anger seemed to be the only tool in my kit right now, so I went with it.

“I’m not interested in debating realities with you, Sigurd. I’m carrying around your fetus, which I didn’t ask for and do not want.”

“I’m sorry, obviously.”

“I’ve had a rotten few months trying to terminate this hell and get back to my own life.”

“I’m sorry,” he said again.

“Yeah, me too. But that fixes nothing. I’m out of ideas, so it’s your turn.”

He sighed, probably to stop himself from saying he was sorry. “I need some time for this to sink in. I have to think about it. Let me call you back in a couple of days.”

“No.”

“What do you mean, no?”

“I can’t do this anymore. We’re not hanging up this phone till we have a plan of action.”

“I can’t come there, if that’s what you’re thinking.”

Is that what *he* thought? That I’d cooked up some old-fashioned trap to get him back? I’d already said I hated him. But a person of Sigurd’s charm might have trouble believing it.

“Let me be blunt. You being here would be of no use to me whatsoever.”

“Right. Livia, this is hard. You’ve had a lot of time to be mad at me about this, and I’m just trying to catch up on the facts.”

I couldn’t stop myself from seeing him, so vividly. The color of his eyes. I said nothing to make him feel better.

“We’ll figure this out, okay?” he said, in a kinder voice. “I think the best thing might be for you to come to Phoenix.”

“Where you’re not.”

“No, I’m not. But I know a lot of people there.”

“*Betsy.* The mail spy.”

“You’re going to have to get past that, it was my fault. Listen, the branch in Phoenix is a solid group. They do a lot of work around abortion rights, they’re well-connected and will know how to help you.”

“And if not?”

“Then they connect you with somebody who wants to adopt. There might even be somebody in the Party. It’s a national network. What I’m saying is, it’s a good community. Our people take care of each other, and if I ask them to, they’ll look after you. It’s a safe place for you to go. I promise.”

“Phoenix,” I said. “Where I don’t know anybody. That would be so weird, Sigurd. Strangers getting involved in this, with you not even around.”

“The timing is bad for me. I just got to LA and I don’t know anybody here, other than the three comrades I’m living with in a two-bedroom apartment. I’m still on probation, working the worst hours because I have the lowest seniority, no PTO yet, not even sick leave. I spent all summer working up to this job, and I just . . . I’m really sorry. But I can’t screw it up right now.”

“Of course. No time for a sad little ruined life like mine.”

“Jesus, Livia. You’re acting like this is my fault.”

I let him sit with those words.

“I guess you can’t go home,” he said finally. “To your family.”

“I don’t have a family.”

“Then I think the best thing is for you to come out West. The Phoenix branch has been like family for me. You’ll like them, I promise. Can you get yourself to Phoenix?”

“You mean, in a car? No, I don’t have transportation. I don’t have anything, if you want to know the truth. A one-room apartment I might lose at the end of the month because I haven’t been able to work and don’t have the rent.”

“I can send you money for a bus ticket. Would that be okay?”

“Greyhound? I guess. I know where the station is. That’s how I got here from Tennessee.”

“It’s a long trip to Phoenix, maybe a couple of days. Are you comfortable doing that? I’m sorry, I should have asked this before, how are you feeling? Are you . . .”

Funny how I could hear his thoughts as he connected the dots, one by one. Livia. Pregnant. Very.

“As big as a house? No. I look the same. Maybe a little puffy or something, but I’ve never at any time felt pregnant. That’s why it took so long to catch.”

“But you definitely are?”

“Blood test, sonogram. Vertebrae, stuff like that. I’m housing an invader.”

“Okay. I’ll talk to our friends, they’re actually in Tempe, which is part of the same city, anyway that doesn’t matter. I’ll send you bus fare. They’ll be prepared to meet you and take it from there. I’ll send them money to help cover your expenses, and if I can get a couple of days off, I’ll come over and see you.”

“No,” I said.

“No to which part?”

I thought about it. Wave around that anger tool long enough, and it starts to take.

“If you’re prepared to swear on your life these people can get rid of this problem for me one way or another, then I will go. But I don’t want to see you.”

“Ever?” He sounded so surprised.

“Ever. I don’t think we should talk again. We’re done here. You have my address, send money for the bus fare, and you’ll be free of any further

obligation. Goodbye, Sigurd."

I hung up quickly. I never even had a chance to tell him about my hand.

I sat a while longer on the floor with my knees to my chest, watching the rain stripe the windows. My right claw was curled against my chest, just under my heart, where it always went if I wasn't thinking about it. My two wrecked parts seemed to need each other's company.

For almost five days, I was Jane Doe.

Maybe I started it myself by treating my body like a nameless, unwelcome drifter. I drank water from a glass by the bed if I woke up parched, but that's about it. If I ate anything, I don't remember it. The body was a burden I despised. Once or twice, I sat on the edge of the bed and tried to imagine packing whatever mattered to me in a pillowcase or two, getting on a bus, handing myself over to the care of insurrectionist strangers. In my mind's eye, they wore brown coveralls and scornful expressions. Worst of the lot, *Betsy*, shaking my intimate letter at me like a page ripped out of a porn magazine. I looked around this room I'd shrunk myself into, the sheaves of piano music in a pile, my thrift-shop skillet at a tilt on the hot plate, my long black concert dress folded on a shelf. My other clothes were still piled in the open moving boxes: summer dresses, socks, underwear, jeans, and sweaters all jumbled together in reckless disregard of any calendar. Time had gone from me, along with music and all appetites. I couldn't think of a thing that mattered enough to put into a pillowcase.

My walk to the hospital was just another dream, I could have sworn. But it was real enough to make a lurid trail on the sidewalk, found the next morning by several blocks of children on their way to school, inciting a frantic summoning of mothers, then the police. No victim or perpetrator was found. I was both. Bloody to my bare feet, in my underwear and T-shirt, I'd passed like a specter through the dark neighborhood, retracing the route I'd walked so many times for X-rays and hand therapy—I really did know it in my sleep, or whatever medical term is more appropriate. I wasn't conscious in any normal way. I collapsed in the hospital entrance with no pocketbook or pockets and was wheeled right up to surgery with a white plastic bracelet on my wrist identifying me as Jane Doe. What is the good of a bracelet like that, I can't say.

The complications of a placental abruption, like the fine print on a smashed hand, are another long list that was given to me as a keepsake to read after the fact. Obstetric hemorrhage, disseminated intravascular coagulopathy, renal failure, and preterm delivery of a nonviable fetus. My presenting symptoms were copious vaginal bleeding and bloody amniotic fluid. The fetus was dead on arrival, but the offended uterus was not ready to let this business go. I received multiple units of A-positive blood while surgeons tried to stop the speedy departure of all the other A-positive I'd brought with me. My hemorrhage refused to surrender under what they called "extensive pelvic packing." I was moved to a different operating room without my consent, due to my unresponsive disposition, for a total abdominal hysterectomy and ligation of blood vessels to achieve homeostasis. I received twenty units of PRBCs with five bags of plasma. While all this was going on, my heart tried three different times to clock out of the disaster. I don't blame it. In the end, I was wheeled to the ICU with four rubber drainpipes sticking out of my abdomen and the bonus of a thrice-recovered pulse.

Waking up was a gradual development. Overwhelming sights and sounds kept directing me back to the somewhat more reliable land of nod. Yellow tubes coming out of my belly, for example. Garish, surreal appendages to my familiar flesh, each one draining blood into its personal bag. Translucent lines running various broths of saline and morphine into both arms, trying to make good on my losses. Cacophonous beeps and clicks at my head and feet like soulless crickets singing into the permanent, artificial dusk. The light never came up or down, making it hard to distinguish living from dreaming. I only began to be sure when doctors came through to look under my sheets and ask questions. Dreams don't interrogate your urine output. Slowly these white-coated figures gave me to know this was a real place on earth, and I belonged in it. My life had been saved in a heroic exchange. I traded it for my uterus.

Nurses circled like angels in their pastel scrubs and revolving shifts, merging together, dreamlike, except for the one who came every night to bend over me smelling of something awful I couldn't place, mothballs and bitterness. In my mind, I called her the sour-milk fairy, always waking me up roughly, jerking the sheets with smug satisfaction, bringing me to tears.

She was no dream. I knew that from the beginning, when she came for my heart monitor and ripped away the electrodes glued to my chest. Each one came off with a bright stinging flash inside my eyelids and a sound like tearing paper, leaving behind livid rectangles that wouldn't heal for a fortnight. Only life can hurt you like that. Night after night, she turned me over with rough hands and scolded steadily under her breath: *What you did to your baby.*

It wasn't until later on that I learned the most common cause of an abruption as serious as mine. Alcohol and drug abuse, especially cocaine. The sour-milk nurse was punishing me for a failure of maternal love. I knew that crime by heart, and hadn't really thought I was guilty of it. But I wasn't really innocent either.

Several days into my intensive care venture, I woke up and identified myself to the man who pushed in the tinkling breakfast cart. No, I wasn't allowed solids, and no, I was not Good Morning Jane; I was Livia Bohusz. Evidently they'd all been asking. The morning-shift nurse was almost giddy as she replaced my Jane Doe bracelet. "It's about time we put a John Henry on you, young lady!" The whole ICU staff was celebratory, popping in to congratulate me: *Our Jane Doe has a name!* As if I'd produced a baby after all, and it was me. Hospital records promptly connected me with the other poor unfortunate who'd nearly lost a hand, back in August, and some of the nurses who'd tended me in a different wing came up to say hello. I let myself feel touched by these attentions, even if I knew, at some level, the main victory here was the securing of a billing address.

My clarity came and went, but I remained steadfastly Livia, and after a few more days was moved from my mechanized crib to a more relaxed floor. Bassoon came as soon as they let me have visitors, not with stolen flowers this time but with my friend Ina, the army-surplus flute player I'd bonded with over the crazy Fauré. I hadn't seen Ina in an age, but you'd never have guessed that from her enthusiasm at my bedside.

"We thought you were *murdered*," she cried, her dark eyes wide. She was wearing parachute pants and heavy boots and a child's sequined My Little Pony T-shirt.

Bassoon agreed; there was an awful lot of blood.

“Oh,” I said, staring at Ina. Her short hair in two upstanding ponytails made me think of the knobby horns of a giraffe. Murdered? “Where was this blood exactly?”

In my apartment. They’d gone there a few days after I left it. They were both on their way to orchestra, and Bassoon needed to pick up the chorales I’d graded for him. He mentioned it to Ina, and she was keen to pop in with him to say hi. I was horribly embarrassed by the scene they described, bloody footprints all over the floor tiles, sheets and mattress so soaked they looked black. I didn’t know yet about the sidewalk trail and the police.

I promised my friends there was no foul play. But hedged on a full explanation. It was way too late to start from the beginning. “Nobody here told you what happened to me?”

“We asked the nurse at the desk,” Bassoon said.

“We were *so worried*,” Ina gushed, talking over him. “We said, ‘Just tell us she didn’t get shot or whatever,’ and the nurse is like, ‘We are not legally able to give you that information.’” Ina waggled her head in a haughty way to mimic the nurse. “Some kind of bureaucracy bullshit.”

I made a *yeah, bureaucracy bullshit* face, and waved a hand at the lower part of me under the sheet. “Nothing that exciting, just woman stuff. Something kind of blew out down there. Sorry if that’s gross.”

Bassoon went a little unfocused, but Ina nodded forcefully. “Right? That’s exactly how it feels sometimes, like you’re just going to *blow*. I mean, like a freaking water balloon. You don’t know how lucky you are, Greg. You’ll never have to deal with all this female shit.”

I’d forgotten Bassoon’s name was Greg, and wondered how many other people besides Jon Link, myself, and his lover called him Bassoon. I also wondered if Ina knew how entirely he would not have to deal with female shit, in the way of a wife or girlfriend’s below-the-belt calamities. In that moment, as I fiddled with my IV drip and tried to ignore the ravenous itching that came on after my pelvic drains came out, I envied Bassoon a whole lot.

I asked how they’d found me here. They said they ran straight from the horror scene to fetch my landlady. She had no idea I wasn’t home (I was always that quiet) or where I’d gone, and after coming around back to have a look, was probably fixated on my damage deposit. Anyway, together they’d made enough calls to track me down. The hospital was their first guess.

“Why didn’t you call me?” Bassoon asked, and Ina looked at me with the same question in her eyes. Ina, who didn’t even know about my hand until she heard it through the department grapevine. We hadn’t spoken in months. *After* people realize they should have been paying attention, they ask you this, *Why didn’t you say something?* Not before.

I was discharged eventually with so many instructions, it seemed pretty clear I shouldn’t be going anywhere yet. But I was on thin ice financially, and no keener than the hospital was to keep me there racking up bills I couldn’t pay. The discharge nurse spent half an hour going over every point, asking if I had help at home (I lied), asking if I understood, and assuming I didn’t because at the end of all this she gave me the whole list in writing. Then sat and watched me leaf through these pages of things I must not do for the next six to eight weeks, involving pretty much every aspect of living, including not lifting any item heavier than a cup of coffee and not having sex. *That* was fine, for the next eight weeks or ever. Not a fan of the consequences.

All the rest would be a test of ingenuity. I wasn’t even allowed to walk home. My one car-owning friend was Amadeo, and I couldn’t call him. As a full adult, he would want an explanation and would not be defeated by a simple wave of a hand toward my nether regions. The man had a wife and daughters. He’d saved me once already because he believed I was worth saving. I thought about this for most of a morning and decided to leave things with Amadeo where they were.

It took some doing, but we persuaded the discharge nurse to let us borrow a wheelchair for an hour, and Bassoon pushed me the eight blocks back to my apartment, marveling at the quantity of stains I’d left on the sidewalk. We joked about my macabre breadcrumb trail, and I held my breath against the pain as I bounced along with a green plastic bag on my lap full of antibiotic wound-care creams and giant sanitary pads and a mammoth water bottle with an accordion plastic straw, plus the pages of instructions for my further survival. The bag was marked “Patient Possessions,” but I’d come into the hospital with nothing but underpants and a T-shirt, neither of which could be salvaged. Bassoon had rifled my boxes and brought me what he could find, sweatpants and an old wool poncho, so I wouldn’t have to go home in a disposable paper gown.

I was so embarrassed by the mess of my eruption, I couldn't watch Bassoon pull off the horrible sheets, turn over the mattress, and make up the bed again. We got me seated on it, and I gingerly changed into a T-shirt while he ran out to the drugstore to procure an essential powder I was supposed to mix into my giant cup of water and consume completely every two hours. The nurse had gone over this with an intensity that scared me. Like an officer sending a soldier to battle, with electrolytes as my artillery and Hydration, our castle on the hill.

Bassoon came back with a jumble of soft, edible things and the crucial red powder, which, mixed with lukewarm tap water, tasted exactly like blood. I smacked my lips and vowed to do my duty. He arranged white-capped antibiotic and painkiller bottles like chess pieces on my bedside table, along with snacks and a pen and paper for keeping track of my medications, and even after I'd promised a dozen times that I would be fine, he stood shifting from foot to foot, looking at me. Afternoon sun blazed in the window behind him, causing his fine blond hair to glow like a halo around his head. Poor Bassoon, he'd already served his time as my right-hand man. I knew he was crossing some precarious straits of loyalty now, between Jon Link and Stephania and the circle of friends who surely all hated me. Percussion supposedly sent his best regards, but never came to see me again after the one visit.

"You need to go," I told Bassoon. "I'm sure you're late for something. And if you don't get that wheelchair back to the hospital, they'll charge me for it."

"Are you *sure* sure? You'll be okay here alone?"

"I'm so ready to be alone," I lied.

As soon as he was gone, I carefully worked myself into a face-down position on my pillow and wept. For the pain and fear and relief and everything that used to be inside me that must be curdling in dark clots in some medical furnace now, wherever lost human pieces go to be cremated. I'd never wanted to be pregnant, never even quite believed it, but must have, since I felt its weight lifted now from the version of me it had flattened like a dead thing in the road. "Good riddance good riddance good riddance," I murmured against my wet forearms, but grief and emancipation made messy company inside me. I hadn't planned on saying goodbye to every future possibility. I soaked my pillow with tears and snot for the children who might have been waiting for me in the future. They would

have wanted a different kind of Livia. I couldn't be their mother. I told myself they were lucky, and I was glad for them.

It was a few hours before I thought to look through the mail Bassoon left on the table beside me. Circulars advertising grocery sales and campus events. I dropped these on the floor, offended by the stupid preoccupations of the lucky. Halloween spooktacular sales, costume parties come and gone. I almost missed the envelope from Sigurd, but there it was after all. Without tearing it open, I tried to remember what I'd asked him for exactly. Money for the abortion, *that* was the wheel I'd had my shoulder to, all that time I was waiting for him to call. But that plan timed out. Bus fare. This would be the travel money to get me to Phoenix. They must be expecting me by now.

Lying on my stomach had been a bad idea. Everything between my knees and shoulders was a wilderness of pain, all the worse with my belly against the mattress, and moving any muscle in that territory caused me to yelp out loud. I eased myself back around on my narrow bed, terrified of the damage I might do to myself by rolling out of it. Lying on my back, I held up Sigurd's envelope to the last of the windows' light and tried to see inside it. The envelope was so thin, it could have been empty. No long letter, just a check-shaped rectangle inside. I felt like throwing it on the floor with the advertisements. A few hundred dollars from Sigurd wouldn't touch the mess I was in now. Old fury boiled up from whatever entrails I still had down there. I reached for the pen and scrawled hard black lines through my name —maybe the only time he'd ever written it—and wrote "RETURN TO SENDER." He'd printed his Los Angeles address in the upper corner, so this would go straight back to him, not the despicable Betsy. After some thought, I added in smaller writing on the other side of the envelope, just under the unbroken seal: "You're off the hook. Have a nice revolution."

I didn't worry right then about getting it to a mailbox; I just tried to taste the victory of being done with Sigurd. Anger shook through me in a visceral, shocking current. I wished I could use it to burn something. To hurt him. Sigurd, who should be here now, should have been here before, not Bassoon or Amadeo or anybody else. I'd nearly died for Sigurd, and his answer to that was bus fare. I lay with one hand on my scarred, bandaged abdomen and said out loud: "Sigurd, you can go to hell." It wasn't the first

time I'd said it, but the first time I meant it with unreserved loathing. No fishing him back out of that incinerator.

Lying in bed, running my fingertips up and down what felt like a badly installed zipper below my navel, looking back over the shambles, it was plain as day. I'd lost my mind when I met Sigurd. As people do sometimes, a lapse of reason that should come and go quickly. But I would never again be the person I was that day I first saw him across the grass.

Darkness came on, complete and suffocating. I couldn't turn on any lights or move an inch one way or another, no edging out of the mire of hate I'd given myself to lie in. What if I'd made this bed myself? I tried to fly too close to the sun. And failed. As she said I would.

If I'd lost my knack for tallying time, it came back to me now with the cruelty of a metronome. Seconds, minutes, hours. I know how long it was before I called, and how long before I was fetched. One day each, twenty-four hours of watching shadows inch across the room. Surveying the distance across the floor to the kitchen tap, to the bathroom. Touching the stitched, puckered, stapled geography of my belly. It could all tear open again, they said, if I tried to walk or even sit up without help. Feeding myself from the bottle of painkillers poised like a pistol ten inches from my head, plenty more medicine in there that could finish this story so easily. I contemplated the plastic bedpan that came home with me in the green bag, which I would not be able to carry away and empty. Once, then twice, I oozed out of bed and across the floor like an inchworm, to the bathroom. Filled my mammoth bottle from the bathtub tap. This was the bottom a person could reach, the outermost edge of risk. No farther to fall. I inched across the floor, edged my back up the wall, reached gingerly above my head to the telephone.

I braced for her cold jubilation. But my mother wasn't the one to answer the phone; it was our neighbor Faye Cable. Mickie and Charlie's mother. She sounded surprised when I asked her why she was there at the house. Helping out, she said, and I still didn't understand. Why would my mother be at the end of her rope? *Poor thing, needing more help than she's ready to ask for. People don't know what they're getting into, with a medical situation like this.* Faye sounded dismayed at my questions. "Your *father*," she insisted. Then a sudden dawning. "Has she not told you?"

I explained we hadn’t spoken in a while. I’d moved over the summer, and they didn’t have my new address or telephone number. So no, I didn’t know anything.

Faye sighed. “Well, it’s not my place to tell you, honey. But she’ll have to, pretty soon.”

This conversation was so far from what I’d expected, I nearly gave up. I had to force myself to interrupt Faye and tell her I was in a medical situation too. A dire one. I needed to be fetched home from college.

She redirected. “Oh, goodness, hon. You can’t drive yourself home, then?”

“No, ma’am. I’ve had abdominal surgery and I’m not even supposed to be sitting up yet. Also, I don’t have a car. And I’m not in any shape to take the bus. I don’t know what else to do.”

“Surgery? Lord, child.” She paused. Her breaths sounded like panting. “That’s going to put you back in your studies,” she finally said.

“I had to withdraw from school.”

She put her hand over the phone and through the muffle I heard her tell somebody it was me. That I’d had an operation. She came back to me then, thankfully not to ask for more details. She only asked if I was still in the hospital.

“I got out yesterday. I was in intensive care for over a week. They told me I almost died on the operating table,” I added for good measure.

“Good night! Do you need us to send somebody up there to fetch you home?”

“I think so,” I said. “Yes. As soon as you can.”

Faye took down my address and said she would talk to my mother, to see what they could organize. She seemed to understand it was urgent. She thought to ask if I could pack up myself, or if I would need help with that. I decided I wouldn’t need to exit this place with anything that weighed more than a cup of coffee. I told her I could handle it.

“All right then,” she said. “We’ll get somebody up there to you by afternoon tomorrow.”

They did. It was Charlie.

UNCORRECTED E-PROOF—NOT FOR SALE
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Prelude VI

Saturday morning, I went over to have it out with my brother. You don't stop talking to people just because they're dead. When you miss them, you have things to say. If you're mad or hurt, you have more. Cyrus and I barely had ten years to talk while we were both alive, and I'd been carrying on my side of things for so much longer than that, with no help from his end. Now I had this letter in my pocket and his words loud in my ears. Through all my hours with students at the piano yesterday and then with Charlie at supper, I felt shut up inside a jar of time, just me and my old bereavements in there. I couldn't see how to break the jar. And, if I didn't, how to go on living with all these good people who could see me through the glass but not quite touch me with their kindness. My piano, lifelong rescue and medicine, had failed me all week. However I tried to play my way through this, I still had to look across a table at Charlie with secrets packed tight around me, making me feel deaf and suffocated. The loneliness wasn't new, but newly unbearable. Being alone in a room didn't offer salvation anymore. I needed people in there with me.

I couldn't think where else to start, so I came to the house to sit with Cy's letter and listen. *Goodbye*, he said. *Have a good life, I'm stopping mine right here because this is the best there could ever be for me.* We hated our mother's demand that he turn away from childishness, meaning me, but he'd stepped over anyway into manhood. *He thinks I'm perfect.* And she

was having none of it. They meant to make him live as a child again, a soldier boy, whatever it took to keep him unloved and untouched. Forever, as he saw it. He couldn't do it.

You should have said something, I told him. As we do after it's too late.

Gazzie raised his head, faintly jingling his collar. I met his pale-eyed stare through the low, open dormer window between us, ears up, head at a tilt.

"Not you, friend," I said. "*You* are the righteous champion of our wasted family." I patted the spot beside to me, a rough surface of tar shingles. "Come on out here."

His eyes jumped from my hand to my face, back to my hand. He leaned his chin forward over the low sill, leaking the faintest whine of internal struggle. This was the rare command he could not execute. Poor Gaz. Some binding law of dogness informed him there's no such thing as walking out through a window onto the roof of a house. He'd lain down just inside it instead, as close as possible to where I was sitting outside the window of Cy's old room.

I'd started this inside, but couldn't find my brother under the sediments of my mother's keeping. She'd stowed cardboard boxes in there, piles of them, some still fully fleshed with their Styrofoam packing that had cradled some fragile purchase of yesteryear. The bed was covered with purple Raisin Bran boxes flattened in tall stacks, the product of many years. I'd bet their inner wax envelopes were also rolled and stashed somewhere. A huge box the size of a chest freezer over in the corner was crammed with hundreds of spent paper towel rolls. Lately I'd been having dreams of carrying some impossible burden around this house—a sofa, a tall ladder, a limp body. No matter what it was, I walked from room to room with rising panic, finding no empty space to put the thing down.

I'd felt that same dread this morning when I came into Cy's room carrying nothing but his letter. On impulse, I pulled open the dormer window, stepped over the low sill onto the shingled roof, and felt my brother's presence immediately. We used to do this a lot, climb out our adjacent bedroom windows and meet out here. We called it "Over the Rainbow," away from everything that could hurt us, not counting a serious fall to the ground. We were children, too taken with our phantom dreads to think about physical ones.

Border collies being more practical, Gaz was keeping a nervous eye. My panic drained off little by little as I sat outside watching the sun sift its fresh light across the fields, highlighting the different angled shapes and hedged borders that fit them together to make a whole farm, and bigger things beyond it. A county. Mountains. *Where would you be, he asked me now, without all our shadows that fell across your path? If we'd let you stay whole, could you have climbed to any place higher than this?* It was hard to think so. I watched a green patch of sunlight creep across our back field like a pool of rising water, then jump up into some broken panes in the old milking barn, glazing them with the color of fire. The fencerow trees stirred with their own breeze, the way trees do when morning light first touches them. A crowd of blackbirds wheeled up from inside the branches, as if light could also give birth to birds. It took me aback, all of it. Even though there was nothing new here under the sun.

It wasn't that early, almost nine o'clock, but thanks to the steep hills on the east side of my mother's house, morning was slow to break here. I remembered that. Cy and I would walk out to the bus feeling like orphans in the half dark, then roll down out of the hollows onto the open school grounds, where we'd be struck by the sight of children playing loudly in broad daylight, their games underway. Somehow the whole world always ran ahead of us.

I rubbed the single yellow page of Cy's letter, thinking of his fingers there, the last ones to touch it before mine. Almost the last. How did she find it, when he'd meant it for me? I thought about that night, the two dismayed men in our living room with their officer's hats on their laps, saying what they said. His empty room upstairs, where I quietly went to find him, his unmade bed where I lay down, not believing, willing him back. Where I fell asleep. He would have put this letter in my dark bedroom when he slipped out, not thinking my mother would be first to go there in the morning, looking for me.

My whole life ago. I was a child, clingy as a fresh-weaned calf, with about that much sense of what grown-up love was about. What would have changed if I'd read this? Only the unanswered question made of equal parts anger and sadness: *How could you leave me? Why am I leaveable?* The center of his universe wasn't me, it turns out. And who wants to hear that from the one you love best? He commanded me to follow my heart, for both of us, because he couldn't. Music was my everything, he said, which it was,

until it wasn't, and none of that was a choice. I couldn't have made heads or tails of these words.

But they were still mine to have, and she kept them from me. More fuel to this fire I couldn't seem to put out.

At the back of the overgrown yard behind the house, I could make out a rectangle of concrete blocks Cy and I built together. We'd hefted the blocks from a pile we found in the barn to construct a ramshackle incinerator, because it was our chore to burn the family's trash every week. Weeds stood tall inside it now, fed by the ash pile of a thousand Saturdays. Before she started keeping, it was all ours: newspapers, cartons, plastic milk jugs we melted to blue-flaming torches and hoisted on sticks so we could watch the fiery droplets fall. *The leaking faucets of hell!* we screamed, inhaling diabolical fumes. Empty spray cans we positioned strategically near the flames, then ran away to hide from the explosions. Modern parents would go pale to hear such things, and more's the pity. Incinerating our family's trash was the best fun of our week.

My phone buzzed in my pocket, startling me.

"Planets."

I could swear my heart stopped, started again. Old habit.

"Have I caught you at a bad time?"

"You've caught me on the roof, actually. So, here you are."

"The roof of what? Are you . . ." He paused. "Working?"

"I'm not a roofer, no. My dead mother's house. I've been thinking of burning it down."

"Oh. Some vendetta there?"

"Just the usual. Feminine ferment."

He laughed softly. "Wow. I can't believe you remember that."

"I do."

"Sounds like we have a lot to catch up on."

Gaz was watching me so closely, I could see the judgments ticking behind his blue eyes: *Not the one she laughs with. Not safe out there. Nothing to be trusted here.*

"Is this your idea of a friendship?" I asked. "Check in every two or three decades?"

"You were pretty mad at me. I thought I'd give you some time to cool down."

His laugh, his voice, all of it was still exactly Sigurd. I could so plainly see his hair falling in his eyes, the set of his shoulders in a flannel shirt. So young in my mind's eye, it was jarring. I knew that couldn't be right, but couldn't find my own place in time. I felt my limbs filling up with the greedy, unbalanced fury of a very young woman.

"I had reason" was all I said.

He exhaled slowly. "I'm not proud of the way I handled things, and I don't just mean the, the pregnancy. I've had a lot of time to think about that."

"And you've come around to apologize?" I had a thought. "Is this a twelve-step thing, where you make amends?" Two of James's sisters were in NA now, and their amends were wearing us out. It seemed likely they'd get all the way back to Mickie's witch-burning.

"It isn't," he said. "But is there any harm in apologies, where they're needed?"

Gaz's eyes burned ice at me. I looked away, out at the saw-toothed mountains on the horizon, their dark, fuzzed pelt of trees that touched the sky. "Honestly," I finally said, "there's so much you don't know, you wouldn't know where to start. And I'm so far past it now."

That's a moving target.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

I considered this. "Not over the telephone, no."

"Then you'd like me to drive over tomorrow and do this in person? You said you wanted a week to decide."

"It's only Saturday morning."

"Didn't I say I'd call back Saturday?"

"Maybe you did. I was thinking you'd said Monday at the latest. Sorry. Tell me about your medical thing. How'd that go?"

"It went okay. Looks like I get to stick around."

"I'm sure your family will be happy to hear it. Tell me who that is. Wife, kids?"

He paused for a long beat. "I'm not sure how to do this."

"You started it."

"I did. No, I'm not married at this time. I have a lady friend, is that what we say now?"

"You can. The kids say GF. Or LTR. Unless she's just your booty call."

I was trying to sound cold, but he laughed. “Sounds like you’ve got teenagers.”

“A dozen of them, more or less,” I said. “You?”

“No kids. I was married, a long time back. To somebody in the Party, which was predictable, I guess, considering how single-minded we all were. She and I were on the same path, but then the path fell apart, and so did we.”

“Your revolution,” I said. “Sorry for your loss. Must have been quite a shock.”

“That’s another conversation.”

“Is it, though? Because I hated your revolution, after you left. I guess I should tell you that. I felt like it was the woman you left me for, and I wished her the worst.”

“Wow,” he said.

“I know, it’s stupid. We were kids, Sigurd. Childish minds.”

“We were. But that’s not how it was. I left because I didn’t want to be in your way. I had big dreams, maybe, but you had *everything*. Right in front of you. I’ve been looking for your name for more than twenty years.”

I was baffled. Had he called the wrong jilted lover? “Looking where?”

“I don’t know, on TV? Public radio? Wherever you hear about famous pianists. I don’t *know* where, obviously. Because I never could find you. Till now.”

“Oh, Sigurd.” I had a strong impulse to hang up before something broke inside me.

“What?”

“We’re like strangers on a train. If we’re going to do this, I think we should stick to small talk. So you’re in California. No kids.” I tucked Cy’s letter back into my pocket.

“No kids. California, yes. I like it here. I grew up all over, but I guess I finally found out I appreciate sticking to one place. And you’re Livia Cable now.”

“Right, not Bohusz. One small step in the alphabet, one giant leap for getting my name pronounced at the doctor’s office.”

He laughed, but it was an old joke. I was feeling too rattled to be clever. “And you’re in Tennessee,” he said. “Back where you started from, am I right?”

“On the farm next over from where I grew up, as a matter of fact. My husband, Charlie, and I have been friends since we were little children.”

Gaz was as close to me as he could get without violating natural laws, resting his chin on the windowsill. Only his eyes moved.

“Gosh. That sounds idyllic,” Sigurd said.

Was it? Charlie and I were still children with each other, in some ways. No grand romance. No complications or duplicity, at least on Charlie’s end. None of this did I wish to tell Sigurd. “So your medical problem was a false alarm? You came a long way to hear that.”

“Not exactly. The doctors figured out some things, started me on new medications, and basically said I can live with what I have for a long time. It’s not curable, but it’s manageable, and it won’t be the thing that kills me.”

“Well. Not the best way to put it, but the best news, I guess.”

I listened to him being quiet, thinking, before he spoke again. “Livia, I’m going to tell you something weird. If you find it uncomfortable, we can drop it.”

Hearing my name in his voice made my heart miss one beat. “Okay.”

“I was disappointed. Which doesn’t make any sense, I’m really not a suicidal person, I think I do want to live, so I should have felt like celebrating. High five the doctor, go have a beer, whatever, but instead I just felt this weight I would have to go on dragging. All the things I gave up for some wonderful future that’s never going to happen.”

Me. You gave up me, did that to me, blew open my doors and windows and made me think there was more to want than I’d ever had. My hands were shaking. I’d still hardly slept since his first call, and this one was not going to help.

“You were so sure how it was going to play out,” I said as calmly as I could. “The workers and the factories and everything. You were kind of cocky, to tell the truth.”

He exhaled a small sound, as if he’d been lightly punched.

“Sorry,” I said. “That was uncalled for. I can see how that would be hard, to give your life over to something and never see it succeed. To see the opposite, I guess. As far as rich people learning to be less grabby, looking after the needy. Aren’t we kind of going backwards?”

“Backwards over a cliff,” he said, and I could hear sadness in his whole body. But the body I’d seen him in last, not the one he must have now. I was

so lost in time, it felt like walking through deep water, trying to catch up with my proper age.

“You really were sure, Sigurd. I never read the books you did, obviously. But when you quoted those revolution guys, you were pretty convincing.”

“Yeah. There’s a lot those revolution guys never saw coming.”

“Like?”

“Robots, outsourcing. The knowledge economy taking over, making free trade policies that sent all the unionized jobs overseas, because people like us didn’t matter to the managerial class. We made our turn to industry just in time to watch them kill manufacturing and redirect the whole economy into finance and consulting.”

“I see. Those college kids that grew up without any janitor or waitress friends. You’re *surprised*, Sigurd? You *told* me this, a hundred years ago. You wouldn’t shut up about how they were all about ‘Free South Africa’ but didn’t give a damn about the campus maintenance crew.”

“Did you not agree with me?”

I leaned back on the windowsill. “I was kind of between a rock and a hard place, at the time. I’m not sure you cared a whole lot what I thought.”

“I guess I never saw it going as far as it has. To being a whole segregated country now, the college-anointed versus the roofers and plumbers.”

“Are we? Who’s winning?”

“I think you know.”

“Workers of the world, have at it.”

“Yeah, well. They’re so pissed off and suspicious of the suits in charge, any kind of abstract strategy is going to be target practice. They think ‘socialism’ is some fantasy game cooked up by college kids. Subsidized health care and food stamps sound like handouts, which are the opposite of respect for labor. They’d rather set fire to their backyards right now than listen to theories about the peaceful transition of power.”

My eyes kept going back to the little pile of blocks where my brother and I spent our finest hours together, burning things. The memories were strangely calming.

“You should talk to my nephew, Ethan. He’s not going to set fire to a hayfield, let’s hope. But to hear his mother tell it, he’d sooner walk over hot coals than go to college.”

“With a bunch of spoiled brats that care more about some theoretical person’s freedom than farmers that can’t afford to put gas in their cars.”

“That’s got it. Only the gas is for our tractors.”

“Everybody’s mad, everybody’s broke. But I bet his heroes wear a lot of big gold chains.”

“Or big shiny pro football contracts.”

“It’s not just kids. I try to talk with these guys about the billionaires getting rich off the sweat off their backs, and it’s like, ‘*That* dude, he’s good at the game. I want to be *him*.’ How do you get anywhere with that?”

“Depends on where you want to go. What if loyalty just comes down to the biggest feelings? Who makes us feel ashamed, who makes us feel important?” I stood up and stepped over the windowsill, back inside Cy’s room. Gaz backed up and watched me as I grabbed an empty cardboard carton by its earflap, then stepped back outside.

Sigurd let out a long sigh. “Yeah. What if it’s just that, and every good intention comes down the pipe as arrogance? What if I’ve been playing my heart out to empty stands, my whole life? I think that’s what hit me so hard this week, when I found out I might have decades more to go.”

He sounded genuinely miserable. It wasn’t my job to make him feel better. Under scrupulous canine supervision, I took a few careful steps toward the edge of the roof and flung the box down into the backyard.

“Still working for the railroad?” I sat back down near the window.

“I retired from that.”

“You did not! You’re not old enough.”

“They let you. They’re always trying to shrink the work force, so they pay you to quit. I took my buyout and went to work for a nonprofit in San Jose. I’m sorry, can we talk about you being on the roof?”

He must have heard me moving around. “Of my mother’s house, yes.”

“She died, back in the summer.”

“She did. And do you know, I still want to kill her.”

He didn’t laugh. “I’m remembering now, you didn’t have much of a connection.”

“You could say that.”

And if we didn’t, what was I still doing in her house? I lifted my feet over the windowsill and sat facing in, staring down the nightmare of that cluttered room. I’d come here this morning to apologize. To Cy, mainly, but anything was possible. Yesterday, with that cowgirl dress and her hopes in my hand, I’d been so close. My mother, Sigurd, how sweet would it be to

lay down my hackles and let these ghosts rest? But they weren't lining up for my charity at the moment.

"Tell me about your dozen kids," he was saying.

"Maybe later. Tell me about your job. Not for profit."

"A nonprofit, yeah. We try to connect people in minimum-wage jobs with secure housing. Ten years I've been doing this, and that many years of watching people's lives fall apart. They're not healthy, they die young, they're single parents watching their kids die of overdose. And they're *lonely*. Half these people, if you ask them for emergency contacts, they can't name one friend they could call in the middle of the night."

"Sounds like a rough neighborhood."

"It's a pretty typical American neighborhood, unfortunately."

"So. Why did we call this meeting?"

"I'm sorry. This is an intrusion. I'm somebody you knew for ten minutes a long time ago. I wasn't sure you'd remember me."

"Sigurd." I felt a hardness collecting in my throat, as if it might close altogether if I didn't say something more. Gaz was giving me a pleading look: *Don't die out there on the roof.* "It was an important ten minutes," I finally managed to say. "Not for you, but for me."

He was quiet for a long enough time, I thought this might be it. Over and out.

"You got pregnant," he finally said. "*We* got pregnant, and I wasn't responsible about it, and I'm so sorry about that."

"And that's what this is about."

"Partly, yes. I never heard back. Basically just 'Drop dead, Sigurd.' It's what I deserved, but I hope you can understand, I still wondered. It's a big thing not to know whether you have a kid walking around in the world. Especially since I don't have any others."

"Well, you don't. Not even the one. You can take that off your worry list."

"Is it fair to ask how it ended? Because the way you put it, this baby was so far along, it was going to happen."

I stepped back into the room and began tossing out big boxes one-handed while I kept hold of the phone with my left hand. Gaz stared at me with the sympathy of a cop watching a bank robber. One by one, out the window and onto the roof they flew. A couple of them landed cornerwise, bounced, and rolled down to the edge of the eave.

“Livia?”

I paused my efforts and looked at my watch. “I’ve got to go soon. In half an hour or so, just to let you know. I’ve got a whole slew of Saturday students coming to the house at noon.”

“Is this the house you’re wanting to burn down? What kind of students?”

“No. My house, down the road. It’s seven kids from two families that get homeschooled together. Their dads are brothers, they share the farm they inherited that used to be a dairy like ours, but they’ve gone into smaller commodities. They literally pay me in butter and eggs.”

“Your keep dropping these hints about living in fantasyland. What kind of students?”

“*Fantasyland?* They don’t have butter and eggs in California?”

“Not like the ones you’re getting, I’m sure. From children growing up in a commune with a barter economy.”

I looked around the crammed room for more things to pitch out. I considered the stacks of flattened Raisin Bran boxes, but rejected them as loose change. Gaz stood frozen, following my gaze as it pinged from corner to corner.

“I should mention that the oldest daughter in this happy commune has some kind of autoimmune thing that makes her miserable, but they don’t have insurance. They’re trying to get her to a specialist in Nashville with a GoFundMe. Probably the same hospital where you are.”

“Wow. Sorry to hear that.”

“I just don’t want you thinking it’s all roses out here in the country. I mean, *loneliness* is not our problem. Everybody I know has lots of people they’d call any hour of the day or night.”

“And you hope they don’t?”

“Depends. I love the Callisters. All the kids have their own little businesses they’re in charge of, honeybees or chickens or something. They’re disciplined. Also, they know how to handle firearms, even the seven-year-old. Just in case that warms your revolutionary heart.”

“Not really. Now they sound like preppers.”

“Do they?” I thought about it. “The rifles are for deer hunting. I guess most rural people are preppers, one way or another. I preserve jam and tomatoes. My husband’s putting up hay right now, for next year’s cattle.”

“Prepping for winter is not the same as prepping for the end of the world.”

“Only a matter of degree, I’d say. It’s all discipline. That’s all I was trying to say about these kids, they practice their Mozart and Beethoven. I have a lot of favorites, but the Callisters are high on that list.”

“So Old MacDonald’s farm will have Mozart and Beethoven after the apocalypse?”

“I’m sorry, Sigurd. Are you making fun of the—what are we? The proletarians?”

“The petty bourgeoisie. No offense, it just sounded funny.”

The petty bourgeoisie, how could I forget. I felt prickly. Still standing in that box-stuffed room, dying to throw the heaviest things I could lift. “Why does anybody want beauty in their lives? You tell me. The Callister dads are both fiddlers, some of the kids are picking that up too. Music is a big deal around here, and for whatever reason, some people want to learn to read music and play the classics.”

“You teach piano,” he said quietly. “That’s what you meant about the dozen teenagers.”

“More than a dozen, yeah. Even more in elementary school. Plus all kinds of adults. I’ve got a librarian, a County Extension agent, couple of retirees. The gamut.”

“You’re a school music teacher? Like . . . oh, man, what was her name? The one that made us listen to that *Planets* thing for a whole year.”

“Miss Vormelker.”

“Shit. Your memory’s scary.”

“I’m not her. I’m a private piano instructor.”

“You teach kids to play the piano.”

“Sigurd, yes. That is what I do.”

“And you also . . .”

“I’m not a concert pianist.”

“That’s where you were headed. I didn’t know much, but I knew to get out of your way.”

“Bullshit.” I punted a couple of trash bags out the window, but was really hankering for something that could shatter.

“What do you mean, bullshit?”

“Sigurd, you left me to go work on the goddamn railroad. You didn’t care if I came or went. Whatever else you’ve been telling yourself for twenty-seven years, it’s bullshit.”

“I did care. I wanted you to come with me, and that scared me. I know everything moved fast that summer. You saw me rushing the decision. But it’s because I was scared.”

“*Seriously.* Scared I would give up music to follow you.”

“We talked about it, Livia. Maybe you don’t remember, but we did. I didn’t want to be responsible for taking you away from your purpose in life. That was too much weight to carry.”

“Hang on a minute.”

I set down my phone outside on the roof so it wouldn’t get lost, and got my arms around the giant box packed with hundreds of paper towel rolls and all the empty air inside them. Unwieldy but light. I had to distort its cube shape to get it through the window. Then walked it down the slope, corner by corner, and gave it a heave. Paper towel rolls exploded in a starburst across the grass. I stared back at my phone for a second, not sure whether to pick it up or not.

Then I did. Perched on the windowsill, with a dog head in my lap.

“Are you still there?” he asked.

“Sorry. Something I had to do.”

“I can tell you don’t believe what I’m saying. But it’s the truth, I was overwhelmed by you. In awe, honestly.”

“Well, you didn’t miss my meteoric rise to fame. My career went to shit, about three weeks after you left.”

“How’s that?”

“I was in serious money trouble because I had to get a new apartment, after you shut ours down. So I took a kitchen job at Gordo’s. And got my right hand crushed in a dough roller.”

I heard his sharp inhale. As if I’d stuck him with a knife.

“That’s why it took so long to know I was pregnant. I was on painkillers, in surgeries and casts and skin grafts and whatever else the hero doctors could pull together to try and save my hand. Nobody was looking at any other part of me. I sure wasn’t.”

“My God. Did they? Save your hand?”

I held it up, looked it over front and back. “They saved something. It’s not the hand I started out with, I can tell you that.”

“But you still went back to your playing and everything.”

“No. I had to drop out of school. It was what they call a career-ending injury.”

“Jesus,” he said slowly. “You were going through all that *and* trying to get an abortion. *Jesus*. Why didn’t you tell me?”

“You weren’t there.”

“But if I’d known. You could have . . .”

“Could have what? Begged you to come back? You offered me *bus fare*. To Phoenix. To go be a pregnant stranger in some revolutionary homeless shelter.”

I listened to him breathing for a little while. Listened to some shameful business in the house of my conscience, like tunneling mice. I could still feel the satisfaction of not telling him, back then. Greedy and unbalanced. Withholding was the only power I knew.

“I did warn you, Sigurd. We should stick to small talk.”

“Livia, I’m so sorry. This is more than I . . . My God. I’m so sorry. When you get older, you look back on things and see your immaturity. I wasn’t a credit to my sex. We split up in an unkind way. I was thinking if I came over there to see you . . .”

“We could have a nice chat and put our bygones behind us.”

“For you, it was a pregnancy. I understand for a woman that’s a different thing to put behind you. But your hand. I mean, this is . . .”

“A hornet’s nest you’ve stepped on. Yes, sir. There’s more and worse I haven’t even told you. When you called last Sunday, I was so taken aback, I couldn’t think. I asked you for a week to decide, but I still don’t know what I’m deciding. If it’s just a matter of telling you what I think of you, we can do that now. Save you a long drive.”

“And what is that?”

“You know? It’s kind of a lot. Twenty-year-old Livia wanted to see you turning on the rotisseries of hell. Obviously I should be a better person than that now. Maybe the grown-up version is just that I wish I’d never met you. My life would have gone a really different way.”

“I hear that,” he said, and was quiet, long enough for me to believe he did. “If that’s what you need to say, and it’s enough, I’ll take it and we’re done. Your call.”

“I’m still thinking.”

“There is more I’d like to talk about,” he said gently. “Sounds like there’s also more I need to hear.”

“Brave man.”

“Can I just say, I understand some things better now? Maybe I was a jerk. But it’s true what I said before, I was overwhelmed by you. You were a star there, accomplished and brilliant and on your way. My own life was something I was still trying to figure out.”

“That’s not how it was. You were very sure of yourself. And then you ran away.”

“Running was all I knew back then. I’m sure I told you, I went to ten different schools, growing up, and as an adult, I’d probably lived in ten other towns before Bloomington. Doing different kinds of work, never settling in. Always chasing a different future because I hated being stuck where we were. As a society, I mean. I wasn’t running away from *you*. I’m sure you know that much. It’s not that you didn’t deserve to be loved. I was just bad at it.”

“Are you crazy? You were *so* good at it, Sigurd. You loved *everybody*. All the oppressed of the world and their grandmothers and their dogs.”

“Loving everybody is easy. Close up, it gets hard. You deserved a lot better.”

I didn’t say anything. I wasn’t sure I could, without letting him know I was crying.

“I hoped I didn’t matter to you that much,” he said. “I guess that’s why I was keeping an eye out for your rise to fame. I wanted to be sure. Then this opportunity came up, and I thought, maybe I’ll go see Livia, all grown up and happy. See for myself I didn’t make the smallest dent.”

“You made a dent.” I wiped my face with my shirtsleeve.

“I am so sorry.”

“Can you tell me what you look like?”

“What?” He laughed, a little nervously. “You don’t remember?”

“I do, is the trouble. All I can see in my mind’s eye right now is who you were then. Which is really not helping. I need you to be different.”

“I’m a totally different person. A veritable troll.” He laughed. “So sad and old and hideous, I don’t think the devil even wants me on his rotisserie.”

I laughed too. Gaz finally relaxed a little, resting his chin on the windowsill. Interesting. If he didn’t think I was in trouble, I must not be.

“Tell the truth,” I said. “Gray and grizzled, at least? Gone soft around the middle?”

“Grizzled as a bear. Soft as vanilla pudding. You?”

“Exactly the same as I always was.” I checked my watch. “We really do have to wind this up. My Callisters are coming.”

“Your Callisters come as a unit?”

“Yep. One of the grandparents drives them all in together. They watch each other’s lessons all afternoon, starting with the youngest and working up. If the little ones get restless, my assistant takes them outside to play.”

“You have an assistant.”

I reached over to rub behind his ears, “Yes. My students are crazy about him. He can chase a Frisbee for two hours without a break.”

“A dog. Lucky you. What’s his name?”

I swallowed. *Gaspard, treasure keeper of the night.* That Sigurd would remember, even if he’d forgotten everything else. “His name is Keeper.”

“So where are we leaving things? As far as my driving over.”

I thought about it. We had visitors sometimes, relatives, old friends. We always put them in the little apartment over the garage. Having enough room was not the sticking point.

“When would you get here? I’m not saying yes, I’m saying *if*.”

“I don’t know, midday?”

A plan was coming to me. Several plans. “Could you make it later? Monday afternoon or evening? We have room at the house. You could stay over and leave the next morning.”

“The house you’re planning to burn down.”

“Not that one. Cross my heart.”

“I could do that.”

“Okay. I’m still thinking. I want to be sure you understand, you’re not the hero of this story. You say you gave me up so I could go have my brilliant career. Which never happened. But I gave you up first. So you could go make your brilliant revolution.”

“Which never happened. Can we say we did both those things at once?”

“Were we like ‘The Gift of the Magi,’ then?”

“Gold, frankincense, and whatnot?”

“No, that Christmas story about giving presents. The girl cuts off her long hair and sells it to buy a chain for her boyfriend’s watch. And he sells his watch to buy fancy combs for her hair.”

“Oh, right.” He thought about it. “No. They ended up with each other because they understood love was more important than material things. They were grown-ups.”

“What we gave up each other for wasn’t material. Dreams and ambitions. That’s not childish.”

“No. We were just unlucky. You a lot more than me.”

“Well, let’s not make this about poor Livia either.”

“Seems like we need to see for ourselves we both did okay.”

I took a breath, checked the Gaspard pain index. Was I okay? I asked Sigurd, “Can I walk back my statement about still looking exactly the same?”

He laughed. We both did. Again, I checked my watch. “Jesus, Sigurd! We’ve been talking almost half an hour. If we can do this by phone, why do we need to see each other?”

“You tell me. Do we? That’s why I called in the first place.”

Because in my mind’s eye he was still the ghost of another time? Because I needed physical proof of something? Why do people need to see the body at a funeral? I didn’t think Sigurd would care for my line of reasoning. I just told him I would text him directions.

“Great. Tomorrow, then,” he said.

“No! Monday. I have a lot of things to do here first.”

“Sorry. Sounds like you’re a busy person. Monday then.”

I signed off, pocketed my phone, and found an empty box I could stuff full of the loose change of cereal boxes, clothes, anything. Not now—I would come back to this tomorrow. Busy person, yes, I was. With a lot to get behind me.

UNCORRECTED E-PROOF—NOT FOR SALE
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Da Capo

My father was dying. He'd had the cough forever, but men like him don't go to the doctor unless stitches are called for. A heifer's hoof to a cheekbone or a hammer to a thumb is about what it takes. A malignancy in his lungs could make itself at home there, stretching into spleen and liver and bones until the night my mother couldn't understand what was keeping him, and went out to find him collapsed on the muddy cement floor of the milking barn. He was conscious but not able to get up, or explain why he couldn't. And so came the ambulance with its rude commotion, rushing them both into a new life nobody ever wanted. This was the news Faye couldn't tell me on the phone, thinking my mother surely would have already.

I knew about life after that ambulance trip. The humiliations of nakedness under a paper gown, a body divided into measured parts, heartbeat, blood count, urine output. Most humiliating of all, the bills, outside the stratosphere of any known paycheck. I held with my father on keeping those wolves at bay as long as possible. I wondered, as I bounced out of Bloomington, laid out across the backseat of Charlie's Pontiac, how long it would take them to find me.

All I could see of Charlie were the bristles of short brown hair on the back of his head below his cap and the sunlight caught in the red cups of his ears. Twice we went over railroad tracks while he told me the sad news from home, and both times he apologized for the bad shocks on his car. He

meant to replace them when he could afford it. I watched the telephone lines and billboards go by as I lay on my back trying to breathe through the stray sobs that kept hiccupping their knives into the bottom of my lungs.

I don't know what his mother sent him up here expecting, but Charlie was plainly shocked by the sight of me. I'd lost any acquaintance with a hairbrush, and I'd lost enough blood to qualify as a ghost. I was no less shocked by the sight of Charlie Cable, for opposite reasons. For a half second, I didn't recognize the young man who knocked lightly and walked into my apartment on two legs, taking the situation in hand. My stuff was still mostly in the cardboard moving boxes, so he asked if he should take those out first and put them in the trunk of his car. *His car.* Charlie drove now; he owned a 1976 Pontiac he'd bought from a guy at the gas station where he worked. Charlie had a job, at a gas station. I tried to picture him loping around the pumps, crutchless, both hands free to check tire pressures and drag the squeegee across windshields. He was so quietly at home in this new version of himself, there wasn't any way I could ask, *Where is the crippled boy I grew up with?*

He didn't seem eager to poke into my new condition either. After he went around to tell the landlady I was leaving, he came back and sat down to drink a glass of water before we set off, and I felt like something had to be said, to make me worth all his trouble. I told him I was sorry to put him out like this. That I'd had an accident in a restaurant kitchen that almost took off my hand, and in the middle of all the doctoring they'd found a dangerous growth in my insides that had to come out. I parsed out these half-truths with no idea how long this rope of evasion would grow, or how it would come to bind me. Charlie just said how sorry he was for me going through that, and hoped my piano playing wouldn't be too much the worse for it. In my months of facing people with my new damage, he was the first one not to ask, *What did you do?*

When nothing was left to pack up, he stood over my bedside looking helpless, his hands open at his sides. He was nervous. Maybe he'd never touched a woman he wasn't related to. I apologized, but told him if I tried to stand up or walk, I would tear up my stitches, so we just had to do this some way, get me from here to there. He looked horrified. By my fragility, I hoped, rather than the thought of contact. But he lifted me under my shoulders and thighs and carried me to his car. I had a powerful memory of

following him up the stairs of our elementary school, watching him grip his crutches and lift his own full weight without a thought.

The car's door stood open to beautiful white nest of sheets and pillows waiting for me in the backseat. The white linens gave me pause. I was still bleeding a lot. But I shuddered with relief at my deliverance. It was probably Faye who'd fitted out the backseat of her son's car for me, but even still, it was Charlie who delivered the gift. I would think about that practical, comfy nest in the back of his car in the years to come.

A road atlas lay open on the seat beside him. He'd traced the route to my address in pencil, and I could see him looking over to check it at every intersection. This might have been his first long driving trip. I wondered whether he'd volunteered or if Faye had sent him. And if she was nervous about him doing this, either way. Only after we got out of town onto the interstate did he relax enough to talk again. I asked how long they'd known my father was sick.

He thought this over. "Since April."

"*April!*" I felt tricked by false history. All these months, my father had walked sturdy and upright through my mind, milking, hauling grain to the barn. "Are you sure?"

He was sure. It was a little before Easter when he collapsed. They'd prayed for him at Easter services, not only at Cross Creek Methodist but at other churches too. According to Charlie, the surgeons cut him open, shook their heads, sewed him back up, and sent him home to die. They doubted he'd last through the summer, and now here it was, almost Thanksgiving. I knew this was supposed to be a victory for my father, but knew enough of pain myself to wonder.

Easter. I thought of the last phone call to my mother and the strange plea she'd forced out. *If you loved your family, you'd come home.*

If she'd told me the truth, I would have. In possession now of the facts, I thought it all through: I was finished with classes by then. I could have taken compassionate leave on all my other duties except the jury. Could have found some decent piano to practice on back at home, to finish working up the *Gaspard*. Then found a car to borrow, to drive back up to Bloomington in May, just for the day or overnight, to perform my jury. After that, I could have spent these last months with my father. Instead of with Sigurd. Instead of this chain of calamities that fell one from another

almost from his first touch. These losses I hadn't told him about when he called.

Why didn't she? *If you loved your family, you'd come*, simple as that. If Sigurd had loved me enough. It's a dubious power, like a knife in the hand. These truths we keep to ourselves.

Poor old Dolly. It had been a family joke, our worry over how Dad would get through his days after outliving his beloved companion. It never occurred to us it might go the other way. Dolly herself had no intention. If ever any vigilance was fierce enough to scare off death, Dolly was keeping it, on the floor beside his bed. Just watching her unsettled me.

They set me up in the den with my father, our two beds flanking the TV. It was a cramped, dreary room, even before throwing a pair of invalids into the mix. Windowless, lit by one wobbly floor lamp, crowded by my parents' ancient recliners. Hers was threadbare brocade; his was wrinkled fake leather, tan with thin gray patches bearing witness to his bottom and arms. The living room was brighter and bigger and would have made a happier setting if it weren't a warehouse of nonsense, but alas, it was, completely. So it was the den for us, keeping close company with our nagging needs and faint odors of medicine and urine. The doctor who gave me my childhood shots, Dr. Paisley, visibly pretty similar now to my father's pleather recliner, came to the house now and again to check on both patients at once. My mother made some noise about having cleared out my old room upstairs, thinking she'd put me up there, but then I turned up pale and eviscerated, no more able to take a flight of stairs than take flight, period. My father had a proper hospital bed with up-and-down moving parts, pushed against a wall where it could be plugged in. I got my old twin bed hauled down the stairs, pushed against the bookcase, and fitted with pillows to prop me as necessary. When Mickie came over and sized us up, she said, "Okay. He's electric, you're acoustic."

My father was on oxygen and labored to breathe, let alone talk. We sent signals across the room. With my left hand, I could push the unbending fingers of my right into an approximate, questioning thumbs-up? His shaky, work-rusted fingers would reply with the thumb-finger circle: *Okay!* The oxygen machine was an overbearing third party in our sickroom, pulsing its

rhythm into the floor, shuddering the house day and night with its constant, percussive thrum.

Solidest of all of us was Dolly, curled up snug against the oxygen pump as if she were also part of the machinery keeping him alive. She would not leave his bedside, and never paused her vigilant glare at the doorway, leaving no doubt as to the anticipated entry gate for the reaper. At night, I could still see the white of her unmoving nose and crossed forepaws. My mother or Faye let her outside every morning to do her business, and that was it.

Dolly's devotion was no surprise, but I did wonder a little at Faye's. We didn't see a whole lot of the Cables when I was growing up, beyond the usual neighborly things, my mother sharing a ride to a funeral of a mutual acquaintance, or a pie when she or Faye had overbaked. Cy and I weren't the type for hayfield softball games, nor was Charlie, obviously, so we didn't have normal things like that in common. Mickie was so much younger, and James's savage sisters scared the living daylights out of us. We didn't drum up the kind of alliances that neighboring mothers often form through their kids. Faye did drive me to a piano lesson once, called in by my mother as a last resort, and I never forgot her kindness. She'd asked real questions about my music, my friendships at school, things I had no idea an adult might want to know. Whether I needed a snack or a bathroom stop on the way. For weeks afterward, I envied Charlie and Mickie with an ache like a bone bruise on my chest. A mother like that.

Now Faye was pretty much running our household, cooking and fielding phone calls, checking with Charlie and her husband, Teddy, and other neighbors on the rotation with our farm's animal chores. She worked as a home health aide, and it was our good luck that her latest client had recently passed away. Sometimes Faye spent the night to give my mother a rest. She knew how to do things like crush a morphine pill into water and put it on my father's tongue with a dropper. His needs were constant, his cannula forever dropping off his face, dangling and hissing into the room like a snake while I yelled for somebody to come save him. And then there was the heartbreaking businesses of an incontinent adult. I was careful to turn away from that, making myself one with the bookcase, wishing I could reach past the demoralizing wall of *Reader's Digest* Condensed Books. Faye had a manner that let you know she wasn't afraid of sickness, talking to my father in a loud, cheerful voice as she plumped his pillows and

refilled his water glass and checked the little monitor pinched on his finger. She also did those things for me, minus the pulse monitor, but offering other pluses, like reaching a decent book. I'd have settled for the dictionary, honestly, but she got down a paperback called *The Name of the Rose* that I guessed was my brother's, and found "Cyrus Bohusz" penciled on the inside cover, sure enough. Faye brushed my ridiculous hair and tried to get a smile out of me, teasing me about the ratty T-shirts I wore as pajamas. She fed us tirelessly, cooking golden-smelling soups slick with chicken fat that she brought me in bright, unfamiliar mugs that must have come from her house. My mother favored small, old-fashioned coffee cups devoid of rainbows or Backstreet Boys.

Mickie came over on weekends if Faye had to be elsewhere, or even if not. Their talk in the kitchen was a steady, easy ramble about anything, when to put in the salt, some unkindness at school. I always closed my book and listened, marveling at their fondness. Sometimes Mickie carried a kitchen chair into the den and sat by my bed, perceiving my desperate boredom. She liked braiding my hair and admiring my hair, the longest she'd ever seen. I felt a keen wish to cut it all off, and told her so, but she wouldn't do it. She said the long braid down my back made me look serious. If that meant joyless, she wasn't wrong. I might as well keep it.

She asked if *The Name of the Rose* was any good. I showed her my brother's name inside and told her that was my favorite part, not counting the scene where a monk gets drowned in a vat of pig's blood. She wanted to borrow it when I finished. She loved telling me about books she'd discovered, always with a secretive enthusiasm as if nobody else knew about this author yet. Even if it was Charles Dickens. She was florid and sincere and every inch a teenager, but I recognized something grown-up in the way she could love something so abstract, even something created a long time ago, and own it as part of herself. The way I did with music. Used to do.

Thanksgiving came and went with the minimum of gratitude. Faye had Teddy's big family to cook for at her house, but brought us a bounty of leftovers on the weekend, and we tried to count our blessings. My mother and I told each other we were thankful my father was still alive, but I'm not sure he joined us in that. He'd lived with various pains for years, but now

he was down to bones and yellowish-tinted skin, and he looked away from Dr. Paisley or anybody else when they spoke to him, as if he felt ashamed. He *was* ashamed. I was coming to terms with membership in the damaged caste, and could see self-blame hanging around my father with the medicine smells. A strong man reduced to weakness, failing to provide. He'd had that smoker's cough forever, so there was that too: *What did you do?* Let things go too far, is what, till it was too late for the doctors to do anything. I knew my mother would be mad at him later, when she had time for it. And so would other people, taking care to set Willard Bohusz's fortune apart from theirs, for they were reasonable people and went to get their checkups.

Once or twice, I heard my mother and Faye talking in the kitchen about treatments that were discussed when they first found out, back in the spring. My mother rehashed gruesome details, an operation that would take out half his insides and leave him to sit in a wheelchair with bags of his own excretions. "Over two hundred thousand dollars," they always repeated at the end of the conversation. "Can you imagine?"

You couldn't. Farmers like my father couldn't carry insurance on their bodies, only their livestock and barns. They hoped they'd reach Medicare age before anything needed much repair, but my father fell far short of the goal. Hundreds of thousands of dollars would be out of reach even with mortgages on everything. It would take selling outright. This would be my father's one point of pride in all this dismal business. He got to make that choice, to save the farm rather than his life. Even without a son to work it.

I had one lucky strike of my own: My ludicrous hospital bills, try as they might, would fail to strike me down. I'd left a forwarding address with my former landlady, and she sent me a note saying, "Please God call this woman." Ladawna. She'd taken it on herself to follow up on the case of the disappearing Livia, and was horrified to learn what happened to me. Also righteously pissed that some numbskull in the registrar's office had cut off my insurance mid-semester. She'd gone straight to the hospital's top brass with barrels blazing: Trying to collect these charges would be unlawful, costs incurred during the prepaid grace period, the patient's pain and suffering caused by this error, potential lawsuit, et cetera. If there were outstanding deductibles, I expect the gentlemen in that room quietly chewed and swallowed the invoice, and God help the numbskull registrar if Ladawna ever found him. She asked me a lot of questions about my recovery, both my hand and the hysterectomy, and offered to be in touch

with my current caretaking team. She wanted to know where the hospital could forward my medical records. My choice would have been the same disposal site where they'd sent my stricken uterus, but what would Ladawna say to my pregnancy shame and secrecy? I was scared to hear it. I gave her Faye's address. Mickie could keep an eye out for this top-secret info and deliver it to me discreetly. She'd like the intrigue.

Other than relief at escaping a lifetime of debt, I was having trouble locating my feelings. Less pain now, more emptiness, as I lay half propped up in my holey T-shirt with my worthless hands resting on the husk of my middle. I remembered what I was supposed to do to teach my nerves how to feel again, and asked Mickie to bring me things to touch: sandpaper, a silk scarf, ice. But mostly what I felt was hollow. I had no substance for resisting whatever poured in from the outside, soup or disapproval or the music my mind's ear kept spinning out of the oxygen machine's constant pummel. Day and night, the symphony in my head was Beethoven's Seventh, second movement, with its relentless rhythmic drive that fills you up with a sense of the imminent. *You are going somewhere*, it says. And me with no plans past my next walk to the bathroom, supported under each armpit by a woman more than twice my age.

My hand was still the overly pink shade of some body part that shouldn't be made public. My abdomen was healing into a rumpled mess of scars. Dr. Paisley renewed our prescriptions, upping the morphine and backing off the therapeutics for my father, doing the reverse for me. Supposedly our trains were running on opposite tracks.

Mickie was the only one who ever asked me, delicately but directly, what happened. She delivered my medical records in a gargantuan yellow envelope and hid them in my room upstairs, but that's not when she asked. It was later, after supper one evening when she came over to show me her dress before she went to a dance at the high school. I'd heard every chapter of Mickie's Winter Formal story: In which we hope James asks. In which he does. In which we wonder if this is true love, and also, can we look at these pictures of dresses in *Seventeen* magazine? I made her promise to show me the dress she finally chose, though I didn't expect I'd be part of the evening itself. But late that night, after Dad was asleep and everybody else gone, Mickie swanned into the room in her sparkly dress, lit up from the inside. It hurt a little to recognize that glow, so far behind me now. She twirled in her dress and talked about the decorations in the gym, and thought to ask if I'd

gone to dances at the high school. I told her the big nights I got dressed up for were piano competitions. She got quiet then, and asked if she could see my hand. I let her hold it, showing her where to feel for the metal parts inside. I told her it didn't hurt so much anymore, which in the physical sense was not untrue.

She asked if the other surgery was part of the same accident. I told her it wasn't, but it felt that way because of how things happened. My hand getting crushed by a machine at work, then the hand surgery, the X-rays, the growth in my uterus discovered, already advanced and then suddenly so problematic they ended up having to take out my whole uterus. She understood that meant I couldn't have children. I told her I was still getting used to everything. It was a strange confessional, Mickie in her hairspray and sequined dress holding my hand in the dark, quiet house. I said "growth," not pregnancy, giving the truth a very wide berth, but still told her more details than I'd ever planned to speak of. My three deaths on the operating table, for instance. She listened, her wide eyes shining in the dark.

"And three new lives, then," she said. "That's way more than the rest of us get."

Never in those days did my mother ask me anything. I assumed Charlie passed on to Faye the slim version of things I'd told him. Now Mickie would do the same, Faye would tell my mother, and I wouldn't have to. We hardly spoke at all, really. My mother was kind enough if I needed something, as she'd probably be with an unfortunate stranger. At the end of a day, when she took off her shoes and put her feet up in her recliner and put on the closed captions so my father and I wouldn't have to hear about hostages in the Middle East or a twenty-car accident on I-75, I'd sometimes catch her looking at me. Thinking what, I'd never know.

If it satisfied her to be right about me, the failure that crawled home with my tail between my legs, there was nothing said of it. And no need. She was right. Even about the black dress we'd had such a row over. After the Knoxville Symphony, that dress saw me through so many more triumphs, it turned into my lucky charm. Slipping it over my skin before a performance gave me the feeling I could sit down at a piano and do no wrong. When I moved into my little apartment after I got hurt, I hated seeing it jumbled in a box with underwear and T-shirts, so I folded it and tucked it on a shelf above the refrigerator. I didn't think of it again until Charlie and I were halfway back from Bloomington. Now I thought of it all the time. An empty

dress for somebody to find and get rid of, a story they'd never know. The talisman whose luck ran out.

I'd missed a lot, growing up with my nose to my own grindstone. Now I watched economies of need and service fall into place through discreet phone calls, among families that didn't begrudge the loan of a mother or son. Charlie had quit his job at the filling station so he could take over all our dairy chores, allowing his father and other men to get back to their own concerns. The Cables were mostly tobacco, which was hard work, and summer work. Teddy had always relied on a platoon of nephews and hired help, not his disabled son. It dawned on me that Charlie had a freedom these other men and boys didn't. He was a new participant here without a history of obligation, due to his being only a year or so into being able-bodied.

I wasn't sure my preoccupied mother appreciated the sacrifices our neighbors were making, and asked Faye outright if it was a burden on her or Charlie to be doing so much for us. She waved me off. For her part, it was nothing, she said. She wouldn't deny, Charlie was going over and above, but he wasn't a volunteer. She was surprised my mother hadn't told me this. My father always hired extra hands for the spring months when the work of calving and freshening and everything else ran around the clock. That spring he'd hired Charlie, and he took to it so well that he stayed on, gradually picking up what Willard couldn't do until that came to be everything. I didn't ask how this was meant to go on past my father's life, but I did wonder.

I always heard Charlie come up the drive at daybreak to do the first milking. Then he'd let the cattle into the bunker with the silage feeder and do whatever else was to be done, meeting the tanker driver three days a week when he came for pickup and testing. (Sadly, not Mr. Picklar.) Around nine, Faye would have arrived, and he'd come in to have a cup of coffee. Their gentle talk in the kitchen was different from the girl chatter with Mickie. She'd ask if he was warm enough, if he wanted some eggs, if the hinges were doing better after the last adjustment, and if the cup was still hurting his shin. I understood this was about his prosthesis. Nobody ever mentioned it to me. I was still getting used to the sight of Charlie as a man and not a boy. Without crutches, he was tall, and noticeably broad-

shouldered, from years of carrying himself in his own arms. I remembered him so differently. A vague boy, almost transparent. He and Mickie were both towheaded children, and Mickie had helped herself to keeping that. Charlie was also blue-eyed, with the tender kind of skin that's easily burnished red by sun or wind, but his short hair was dark now and bristled like a cactus from being mashed the wrong way under a cap.

After his second breakfast, he always came in to give my father a report on the morning, and for that half hour, my father would rouse out of his near-constant sleep. He talked to Charlie about herd health records and feed ratios, when to irrigate and when to cut the corn for silage, so many things I knew little about. This kind of information was the roof over our heads and I always knew it, but never thought it was meant for me. Nobody else thought so either. Now I eavesdropped, learning things that surprised me as my father leaned close to Charlie, detailing careful calculations in his earnest, nearly inaudible voice. Operations he'd invested in, other things he'd had to let go, even before he got sick or knew that he was, because the physical end of it was too much. How he'd managed to make it pay out with a smaller operation. I had the impulse to turn and face the bookshelves as he tendered out these confidences, the same as I did when my mother washed his privates. But the men didn't seem to notice me.

I'd never seen my father read anything but market reports and extension pamphlets and *Dairyman Magazine*, but he read those like sacred texts. And treated his giant ledger books with the care of a Bible, studying their columns, even now wanting them near his bed. He was cautious about change, because a gamble on one year's production could cost a farmer everything. Somehow my father kept his dairy going while almost every other in the county sold its equipment and transitioned to feeder calves, or went under. As a child, I thought everybody waved at my daddy because he brought their mail. He knew every household for miles around and more than a little of their business, and I had to grow up in order to see the respect in the contract. My father was never a talker, and he wasn't a gossip. A working man, was how people saw him and how he wanted to be seen. Until he ended up crippled in a chair and then a bed, ashamed of himself in a way I could feel across the room. In these morning conferences, though, when Charlie drew up a chair, the lights seemed to come on inside his dark house. I had no idea he could still sit up and speak his thoughts so clearly, but he did, keeping the fingers of one hand on the cannula under his nose as

he leaned toward Charlie, passing over all he knew into this boy who'd lately gone from sitting to standing to running a dairy operation. Maybe my father and Charlie were also trains on opposite tracks.

Two days before Christmas, I let Dolly out in the morning and she didn't come back.

I was the culprit. I was up and walking by then, at Dr. Paisley's urging. I'd mastered solo bathroom excursions, then climbed the stairs one day to see if I could. My mother took that as the go-ahead to move my bed back up to my old bedroom. It was lonely up there, and far from "cleared out," as she put it. The bed had a little walking space around it but was walled in by furniture odds and ends, dressers, even the old den sofa that got replaced eons ago by the two recliners. There was barely room for my boxes I'd moved from Bloomington. The closet was crammed with everything I wore in high school, plus a bunch of old coats, plus so much stuff piled on the floor, the hanger-ups didn't have room to dangle. I idled in bed trying to tune out the pandemonium, but my eye kept picking out bizarre little still-lifes that no human reason could account for. A glass ashtray on the dormer windowsill, holding a clutch of petrified cough drops, rusty paper clips, one folded napkin, and a chicken feather. It made me want to sob.

Sleeping through a night was a skill I'd lost completely. I dipped in and out of light napping, day and night. They teach you this in the hospital and send it home with you along with your stitches and the giant water cup. I couldn't find any comfortable position lying down, and now I was off the meds that had helped me look at this whole business as a TV show I didn't have to get all that invested in. I was itchy and restless and took to moving around the house like a ghost in a robe and slippers, coming downstairs at eleven at night to see if anybody was still up, at three a.m. to check my father's oxygen, at the first crack of daylight to turn on the coffeepot and let out Dolly for her one quick frisk of the day. She never took more than half a minute to come running back to her spot under my father's bed, and then I'd wait around the kitchen for Faye or Mickie or Charlie or anybody whatsoever. Mormon missionaries, God willing.

That morning, it had snowed, the first accumulation we'd had so far, and I welcomed it. I'd had too much of chill winds in Bloomington, not enough of this whitefall that could slip in overnight to turn the barn and fields into a

Christmas card. I watched Dolly stitch out her narrow line of tracks to the front hedge and paint the scene with one small, round patch of color on the snow. Then, in an odd, abrupt way, she lifted her head and took off, past the front walk and driveway and parked cars, making a wide right-hand arc toward the barn. She wasn't trotting but running fast, as if she'd caught the need to herd or chase. The cattle were all in the barn or a paddock on the other side of it, and no other life was about. This dawn didn't have a deer or fox or rabbit to its name. The snow was trackless.

I waited on the front porch, admiring the snow humped up like rising dough on each of the geranium pots and the boxwoods. Every fencepost had its own personal white pouf. Dolly didn't come back. I stared at the one yellow spot she'd left at the foot of the hedge, telling myself I wasn't dreaming I'd let her out here. I called and called. I stuck my fingers into my mouth and tried to whistle, the way Cy taught me when I was ten. Dolly did not come back.

Charlie heard me and came out of the barn to see what was up. I was freezing out there in my bathrobe. He said not to worry; after he finished up, he would fetch Dolly in. She couldn't go anywhere without leaving tracks, he pointed out, and waved his arm to shoo me back inside.

My mother was up by then, trying to get a spoonful of watered-down oatmeal into my uncooperative father. We were unsettled by the strange light. Snow sets a kind of blue mood into a house that you feel before you've even looked out the windows. She put down the bowl and came into the front hallway to stand with me looking outside. We watched cows poke out of the barn looking freshly offended by this winter business. Waiting for Charlie to let them over to the silage feeder, they stood around the near pasture all facing the same direction like toys set out by a fussy child. Unperturbed. Any sign of Dolly would have pushed them into a nervous clump.

It was probably close to an hour before Charlie came in, shaking the snow off his heavy chore coat and stomping his boots, betraying the slightest limp. No Dolly. He was flummoxed. Her tracks led into the barn, so he'd called and called in there, looked high and low, even up into the haymow. No trace. Nor any other tracks to show she'd gone back out of the barn.

He took a cup of coffee from me to warm up, then went back out to keep trying. I wondered if his metal parts hurt him in the cold the same way mine

did. Faye and Mickie came over later to help look. Mickie was out of school for the holiday and they were headed into town on some last Christmas errands but stopped by first, to hunt for Dolly. “Men can’t find anything to save their souls,” Mickie said, laughing, and I saw a flash of the woman she was just about to be. But the women had no better luck.

A few minutes past noon, while we had our faces pressed to the front windows looking for a speck of black-and-white motion in the far white fields, my father left us without a sound.

People assumed I would play for the service. I had always played for the services. My brother’s, of course, as young as I was, and my uncle Leonard’s the next year, but it wasn’t only relatives. I’d been called on to play for retired schoolteachers, members of Cross Creek Methodist, members of other churches. The families usually paid me for it, at least a little something. Along with their chosen hymns, they often asked for the third movement of Chopin’s Sonata in B-flat Minor, which they knew only as “the funeral song.”

When my father died, I hadn’t touched a piano in more than four months. Literally had not touched one, or looked at one if I could help it. Since a day in the middle of August when I spent a couple of early hours in the practice building before going to work, playing I don’t know what, probably the Scarlatti I was working on to please Amadeo. It grieved me now that I didn’t know. My right hand had touched and loved something without knowing it was the last time, before I pulled it away to a kitchen to meet its maker.

When I realized what she was thinking, I explained to my mother I wasn’t a piano player anymore and never would be. We were sitting at the kitchen table with the telephone ringing and ringing between us, people asking what they could do, stepping outside their holiday plans to help organize food for the fellowship supper, while my mother and I tried to plan a funeral and think how to make my father’s whole, quiet life into something fit for a newspaper obituary.

She stared at my hand in a way that made me want to hide it. “It won’t heal up, then?”

I made myself look at it too, a foreign thing holding a pen, resting on a yellow pad. It made letters like a kindergartner, careful and round, nothing

like my old handwriting.

"This is about as good as it's going to get," I told her. "Hopefully it won't always be this ugly when the skin isn't so raw. The nails might straighten up some. But yeah, this is it."

"All of it's still *there*," she argued. I was baffled. Whose side was she on now?

"Not on the inside, it's not. A bunch of the knuckles are missing, they're just solid wires now. I don't have the flexibility, or the control. To play the piano you need . . ." I didn't know how to begin. I just looked at her, looking at my hand. That mug of permanent resentment I knew so well, like she'd been cheated out of something, muddled now with grief and confusion.

"You can put on a wool sweater, Mom, but that doesn't make you a sheep."

"All right," she said, clapping her two hands down on the table. "We'll do hymns."

We settled on "I'll Fly Away" and "Abide with Me," plus a few others. She surprised me by also suggesting "Give Me My Flowers While I'm Livin'," by Lester Flatt and Earl Scruggs. I'd forgotten that's how she and my father first met, at a dance hall in Bristol where one or both of those men were playing. I thought about bringing that up, but decided to stick to the task at hand. She had a museum of records collecting dust in the living room, surely including a recording of "Give Me My Flowers," but she dismissed that. Somebody at church had offered to organize all the music, the recordings and the sound system. We only had to give them our list.

We put off the funeral almost a week so people could enjoy their Christmas without having to bring out sad faces for us. The chapel was still a stuffy riot of poinsettias and Nativity, which felt wrong, but I was moved by the turnout. Every person in our county who ever had good news delivered in the mail was packed into that church, from the looks of it. My father said so little but mattered to so many. I didn't yet have the stamina for standing with my mother by the coffin to greet the endless visitation line, but felt proud to have accomplished the full complement of underwear, slip, nylons, shoes, and decent outerwear for the first time in many a month. I sat through the service with her on the front pew and gripped her hand—her right with my good left—and we passed a cellophane packet of

Kleenexes between us that finally gave up the ghost on “Give Me My Flowers While I’m Livin’.” Because nobody really did that for my father.

The recorded music made me desolate, beyond the normal grief. I was sad that I couldn’t play for him, sad that not one other person in this multitude could stand up among us to play or sing real music, one breathing soul to another. It’s as different as baking a loaf of bread for somebody or handing them a sheaf of limp slices in a bag. Probably nobody else thought much about the music, or felt we deserved better, but I did. I’d gotten spoiled on so much ready beauty, away at school. Piano concerts, chamber concerts, arias any day of the week, Handel’s whole darn *Messiah* with full choir and orchestra, timpani and trumpets and all, for no greater price than walking over to the MAC. I’d feasted without giving thanks. The scratchy recordings felt cheap, and got mixed up in my bereaved insides with all kinds of other sadness for a man who should have gotten more from his life than this.

My mother stayed long into the evening, of course, what with all the food and fellowship in the basement, but after a point, I’d had my fill of both and went back up to the empty chapel. For some reason, I thought my father would still be there, which was silly; we’d all watched the pallbearers take him out and that was goodbye. It was too cold to do anything graveside.

I stood at the empty spot where he’d been, then went over and sat down at the piano. The same one I’d learned on. Back to my very beginning. Da Capo. I touched the keys without making any sound. A little dusty. They must not have anybody playing here at all now. I closed my eyes and imagined being six. Spread my hands on the keys, listened inside my head. Touched a middle C with my unspoiled index finger. Then walked a little stepladder up and more slowly back down, C-D-E—D—C— with that one finger, the way a child picks out a melody. The first five notes of “Give Me My Flowers.” My left hand moved automatically to brace it from underneath with the C major chord, easing into the G dominant seventh. Poor left hand, able and bored all this time. I played the one-finger melody and left-hand chords all the way through the verse, then called my stiff middle and ring fingers into service on the chorus. It was something a child would do, and I was embarrassed for her. I reached into the pocket of my dress for a crumpled Kleenex and blew my nose. I heard slow clapping.

“*Char*lie! *Jesus!*”

He was in one of the back pews. I'd shouted his name (and the Lord's) like an accusation, more angrily than I meant to. He looked stricken.

"I didn't know anybody was in here. I'm sorry I hurt your ears with that mess."

"It's something," he said. "You have to start back somewhere."

"No, it's not!" I burst into ugly tears on the piano bench. I'm sure Charlie was mortified, thinking he'd intruded on my grief. My father, this long day, everything. He slipped out quietly.

It was nothing, nowhere to start. And even if it was, or might be, I couldn't get back what I wanted. Not in this life. I would never have "Ondine."

With the funeral behind us, Faye left us to ourselves, and I understood her main work in the house hadn't really been the cooking or moral support. She was there to clear space for sickness and dying. Literal space. Uncluttered kitchen counters for preparing food, room for a caretaker to move around my father's bed to wash and tend him, a place for a chair beside it. A clear floor underneath for Dolly, for God's sake. Even that was a luxury. I hadn't realized.

And had no idea how Faye got away with it, because I sure didn't. My mother watched me like a hawk, intercepting anything I tried to throw away. My father's empty medicine bottles, for starters. I went to clear a little clutch of them off his bedside table, and she shrieked from the doorway: *Don't.* She fetched a black garbage bag that was already nearly full, *all* his empty medicine bottles, and toted it back to the living room. Sickness creates a lot of waste. I felt a spike of horror in my gut, looking at all the other garbage bags piled in there. It was the day after the funeral, and two church volunteers were coming to take back the borrowed bed and oxygen machine. I'd hoped to clean up a little to make it easier for them. Nothing doing. It pained her even to see that equipment leave the house. We stood in the hall watching them tip the bed sideways out the front door, and the anguish on her face was not very different from when she'd watched the EMTs carry out the zipped black bag containing my father.

In my weeks of convalescence, I'd seen little of the house outside of the den and my room upstairs. Once I started my ghostwalking through other rooms in the dim hours, it came back to me. But felt different now, the

monstrosity of it. It's an unrelieved pressure, like noise or a toothache, to live in a house that wants to crowd you out of it. In childhood, before I went away, I lost sight of any notion that kitchen tables were for dining instead of piles, or that people actually set down coffee cups on a coffee table. You can't see chaos for what it is until you've lived outside of it. And then you do. My college friends always joked that I might as well be a nun, for how few possessions I kept around. For me, that was freedom.

In the kitchen, I set her off constantly, just trying to clear a countertop or throw out an empty jam jar. "We don't waste those," she'd snap, digging into it with a sponge under the faucet, chasing me out of the kitchen with her bulldog glare. I offered to take over some of the meals, which my mother took to mean I didn't like her cooking, so I backed off. I tried instead to help out with slicing or peeling, telling her I'd worked as a professional and knew how to take orders. Which caused her to set down her stirring spoon and walk out of the kitchen. I'd forgotten it was always this way, my mother and me in this house. As early as I could recall knowing grown-ups had their own feelings, I recalled the sense of this loathing of hers like a pressure against my skin. She hated cooking, laundering, serving. And I'd still yet grown up watching her do all those things with her broad back turned to me like a "No Trespassing" sign.

As soon as I felt brave enough and had mastered showering and dressing myself in less than an hour, I asked her if I could borrow the car. I said I needed to fill a prescription, though I didn't, and offered to pick up anything she needed in town, though she didn't. But she gave over her weather-beaten Buick Regal by way of the keys she kept in her apron pocket all day long and maybe wore to bed, to keep tabs on their location. She bought reading glasses by the dozen, because anything you set down in the crannies of piled-up tabletops, you had slim chance of finding again. My marbles were going that same route. I had to get out.

By the grace of deserted county roads and mountains stippled with barren trees and the rust skies of early-winter sunsets, I would get myself through January. Every few days, for an hour or two in the afternoon, I put my hands on the fake-woodgrain steering wheel of the car I'd first learned to drive, trying to call back the old thrill of driving myself out of here to lessons and competitions. Now I took over the grocery shopping. While I was at it, I also took to smuggling out things to deliver to a trash bin in town, starting with the goddamn glass ashtray nursing its weird contents on

the windowsill of my bedroom. I slipped the whole mess into my coat pocket, petrified cough drops and all, and walked out of the house whistling. It gave my life a purpose. I had wild delusions of clearing the whole room, one coat pocket at a time.

Sometimes I'd meet Charlie coming in for the second milking as I headed out, so I'd wait for him to get out of his truck to say hello. We'd stand red-cheeked in the windbreak between our vehicles with frozen hands shoved in our pockets, his hunting cap pulled low on his forehead, breath puffing out in clouds, while he told me what kind of week we were having. Gallons I understood, somatic cell counts I didn't. Lower is better, basically. He was frugal with his talk but explained anything I asked about, and my interest pleased him. His reddened face would relax to a smile as he thought over a question and fit the answer into a very few just-right words. I remembered this now about Charlie Cable, even as a boy. His sentences were like pieces of music with a lot more thought in the composition than notes on the page. I assumed my mother would keep him on till she could go about selling the livestock and equipment. Poor Charlie, he'd given so much here and must miss my father as much as any of us did. Our talks in the driveway felt like acts of consolation. I told him how I used to bribe the tank truck driver, as a little girl, to make sure our test results stayed in the clear. We commiserated on the sore lack of barn cats now, but Charlie said he'd remember the four-leaf clovers, if worst came to worst.

Grocery shopping in town was awkward because of the people I always ran into and the questions I had to answer about the future I didn't have. I stuck to a script. *Got in an accident, home for a little while, got to spend time with my father; yes, he was, thank you.* If they'd heard I was in a car accident, I said that was right. If they asked if I was going back to school, I said eventually. With any luck, these things would get onto the books and I'd be able to buy my margarine and lettuce in peace. I always took the longest possible way home, driving around a lot of loosely joined county roads I'd never really learned in my teens.

One day, I found myself in the gravel parking lot of my mother's church. It wasn't a Sunday or Wednesday, so nobody was there. I still had the key the minister had given me more than ten years earlier, when I first started practicing there and playing for services. I'd kept it in my wallet with my money and identification cards, even when I was away at college. Which might be on par with hoarding jam jars, but it always felt to me like a

precious object. The most valuable thing I'd ever had, honestly. I decided to see if they'd changed the lock.

They hadn't. I went in and sat down at the piano, like old times. They hadn't changed that either—I already knew from the day of my father's funeral. I looked around the empty chapel. The Nativity animals and Holy Family had gone back to their storage crates, the lusty poinsettias banished to wherever they all go to be out of season and wither from embarrassment. I was safely alone. I ran a C major scale all the way from bottom to top with my left hand. Then a D major scale, then some arpeggios and just silly running around, octave intervals, some quartal descending patterns, noodling. I let that hand have a romp. It felt so strange, as if I'd forgotten all about this stuff, but poor lefty still had business of its own to go see about.

I let my right hand touch down tentatively. It went to a simple B minor chord, inverted. Repeated. Slow, slow, very quiet, until I understood what it was, and my left hand picked up the melody from underground. Chopin's B Minor Prelude, the saddest song in this world. It's not the hair-tearing heartbreak of the Raindrop Prelude he wrote when he thought his lover was dead. This one is quiet, his testament to the never-ending ways of grief. It's the one piece I wished somebody could have played for my father's funeral, that I did play for my brother's. The sadness is all in the melody line the left hand keeps bringing up from below, a slow arpeggio trying to climb up out of the dark, but after a few notes of rising, it falls back down. It happens over and over, the melody slowly climbing again and falling. It presses your chest with this awful hope that you're going to get up into the light, and at one point, you almost do; the melody hovers around a major chord. But no. It slides back to the minor, and finally, softly creeps away. It's the God's honest truth of grief. It doesn't resolve; it will always be there. It's going to walk with you.

I came to the end and let the notes die and sat with myself in the quiet. A little bit shocked, to tell the truth. I hadn't thought I could do that. The B Minor Prelude is a simple piece on the face of it, just twenty-six measures long, never fast or complicated. An advanced middle schooler could probably handle it technically, but they wouldn't find what makes it what it is. A child wouldn't know where to look for those feelings. It struck me, there on that bench, I wasn't young anymore. Didn't feel so. It struck me also how much of music isn't in the hands but in the mind, the memories of a life survived. Musicianship, I still had. Buckets of it, probably enough to

drown in. Too bad a pianist still needs hands to curry it up and set it out on the table.

Even still, I'd managed the B Minor Prelude, to my own surprise. The treble side never gets any harder than a slow, repeated minor triad, and I'd dropped a few notes when my hand wouldn't stretch that far. It was complaining about it too. Just those few minutes of work sent a new kind of muscle cramp running up my palm. I massaged it with my left thumb and thanked it for its service, a proper funeral song played for my father. Same as I did for his son, years ago, directing all our thoughts toward our past with Cyrus, our future without him, and away from whatever awful version of him was under the hood of that closed casket at the front of this church. It wasn't where I'd wanted him. I wanted him still here. Then and now and tomorrow.

Strange fortune, in my own life, to hit that colossal Da Capo mark and get sent back to my beginning. I was in the right place for it. But wasn't the same person. It's never the same music the second time through, and maybe that is the point. If only I had the heart for starting over.

I stuck out my two index fingers like a pair of sticks—realizing for the first time, stupid me, this is why they call it that!—and played "Chopsticks." With the mighty enthusiasm of a child, I banged through those sextuplets to the end. It was the first thing I ever taught Cyrus, and like all children in the world who know how to play "Chopsticks" and nothing else, he covered any deficits with speed and volume. Now I did that too, racing him through it, feeling him laughing at my elbow. Then I noodled around some more with my left hand, giving it some air. And then with two hands I played "I Just Called to Say I Love You," another one I taught Cyrus, not long before he died. It was on the radio that year. I wasn't sure whose funeral this was anymore. Just a family outing.

My mother once in a while had duties in town related to my father's death. She was the executor of his will, which I took to mean the execution of selling the assets to settle the debts, and I didn't envy her. She came home from one of these appointments and laid a big manila envelope on top of the washing machine, where we'd got used to putting anything important because that space always had to stay clear. It was a top-loading washer.

"That's for you to look at," she said.

I turned around and got a little jolt, thinking she'd found my medical records. But no, this envelope was nowhere near that thick. "I'll look later," I said. I'd started dinner while she was out, a pale business of baked chicken and potatoes, aiming for neutrality but still ready to flee at the first sign of hostile takeover.

"No, you better look now. Take it on in the den and read it."

Hostile takeover, then. I did not take it into the den, because I didn't like her telling me where to go and couldn't stand that room anymore. Minus Dad, Dolly, and the oxygen machine, it was a sad blank canvas filling in with what some hectic modern artist might paint if his medium was junk mail and gewgaws. I put on my coat and went out to the front porch. The big swing out there being subject to wind and weather, it stayed uncluttered.

The envelope wasn't sealed. I pulled out my father's will. I'd never seen one before, but it looked like what it was, with "Last Will and Testament of Willard Bohusz" across the top, followed by oddly offset margins and words like *whereas*. I was a little surprised he needed to have one of these at all, assuming his wishes and the letter of the law would agree on just rolling everything over to Mom. I didn't understand what she wanted me to see here.

The property was laid out simply. Willard Bohusz owned a house as joint property with his wife, eighty-four acres in trust inherited from his father, and an LLC with livestock and other material assets listed in a separate document, all belonging to the business incorporated under the name CyLee Dairy. *"Cy" for Cyrus, and "Lee" for you.* I could picture him telling me this, plain as day, while we drove his mail route. *Because "Cy-Livvie" might sound foreign to some people. A farm is more than land and cows and barns.*

He left the house and four acres surrounding it to my mother. The dairy business and remaining property to me.

I slammed back into the kitchen. "Why would he do that?" I demanded.

She shrugged without turning around. "It's what he wanted."

"So you knew? All along?"

She did. Or so she said. Later it dawned on me to wonder if this might have been a shock to her too. Could be she was wanting to save her pride.

The next morning, I put on Dad's big galoshes and his barn coat over my own coat and clomped out to the barn. Charlie looked up, surprised. He gave me a shy wave from the little rolling stool he sat on, but didn't interrupt his attention to the undercarriage of a cow.

"Looking for Dolly?" he asked. I still did sometimes, though the effort felt foolish now. She was as gone as my father. I told Charlie no, just looking in general.

He said I was welcome to be there, but now that he had the cows in their tie stalls, he needed to work fast to get them all attached to the milking pipeline. I stood at a decent distance watching his practiced hands pull the green stopper from one padded steel cup after another, gently attaching one to each of four long pink teats and positioning the milk claw properly under the udder, then giving the lady a sweet pat on the flank and rolling his stool to the next animal. I'd seen my father do this, how many times, but you can watch a thing without seeing a thing. This milking system was a world of its own. The big vacuum pump thumped a steady beat that made me remember Dad's oxygen machine, except this was the opposite, pulling instead of pushing, making the whole spaghetti jumble of long silicon tubes tremble in unison with its beat, and all those veins flow white with their harvest from forty-two unbothered cows with unfocused eyes, chewing their cuds. The barn was a throbbing circulatory system of milk, with Charlie at its center, moving around with deliberate speed. It took me aback to watch him, the little boy on crutches who grew up to be a cow-dancer, never frantic, all gentleness and grace. Anything else would upset the girls and shut down their easy flow. It had taken him much too long to get legs, but he was born to work like this. Gentle Charlie, without a mean bone in his body.

I stayed out of his way, noticing parts of the work I'd never thought about. The timing, for one thing. He seemed to know exactly how long every cow needed before he could go back and detach her, stripping out each teat and swabbing it with iodine before he untied her. The cows were in no hurry to get away from him. Some milked out in under five minutes; others took longer. *This is my dairy*, I kept telling myself. And kept failing to believe it.

After he ran cleaning solution through the pipelines and freed his charges to wait outside, I followed Charlie into the milk room. It was cold in there, a different cold from outside. I rubbed my hands together and wondered if I could talk to him now. I couldn't tell if he'd rather I wasn't there, or was

just tremendously shy. I'd wondered the same when he came to see Dad in our sickroom, never saying much to me. Or that first day he came to Bloomington to fetch me home. What an imposition that was, more than I'd realized, when he had all this to do. I took a deep breath. He was standing still now, running the milk through the chiller into the big holding tank.

I gestured vaguely at the building around us. "What's going to happen now?"

He looked up at the stainless steel drum. "Pickup tomorrow. SCC tests are running a little blue this month. Keep your lucky clovers on standby."

"I will. Because that's the sum total of what I know about running a dairy."

"You'll be wanting to know more."

"I guess so." I looked at him, kept staring until he looked up from the temperature dials back to me. His gaze was level, unsurprised, maybe a little pleased.

"You knew, then?" I asked.

He nodded.

"Dad told you?"

"It's what he wanted." Charlie flushed slightly, looked away, then back at me. "*Half* of what he wanted."

A whole lot less than half, I thought. He'd have wanted Cy to take it over.

"I'll show you whatever you want," Charlie said, seeing my despair. "The work in the barn, you've just seen the better part of. The equipment, milk handling. The animals are the other part, heifers and the dry herd both. And there's the reckoning. Ledger books, herd health records." He paused to turn a valve, rubbed his hands to warm them up. "There's a lot to it."

"Yeah. I can't do this."

"It doesn't take a thing you haven't got. Good head, a pair of hands, enough gentleness so the animals want to have you back. You and the cows, you all just have to love the doing of it."

I didn't have the heart say aloud that's what I lacked. Whether the cows did or not.

After he moved the milkers onto their feed, he looked after the dry herd, all the pregnant ladies who were enjoying some months off before they calved and started producing again. They mooed hot clouds of breath into the air, grumpy and peckish, jostling each other's bulging sides at the

feeder. Charlie said he would show me how to put the day's notes into the ledgers.

In the house, I self-consciously cleared things off the coffee table in the den so we could spread out the big book. That table, Jesus. In the span of a few weeks, we'd surpassed the standard armload of magazines into the realm of the godawful: A framed, childish picture of a llama in a bathtub. A plastic donkey that dispensed cigarettes from its rear end when you clicked up its tail. Charlie and I side-eyed each other, trying not to laugh as I set each of these treasures on the floor. My mother was humming under her breath in the kitchen and I was nine years old.

"If it ever gets too much, Mom says she'd be tickled to have you over at the house, anytime," he said quietly.

"Tell Faye to be careful what she wishes for."

I spent a lot more mornings in the barn with Charlie. His shyness persisted everywhere outside the barn but dropped away when he was my teacher. I learned how to run SCC test strips, check temperatures, and hose things down. I skittishly let the livestock from one paddock into another, accepting the contemptuous regard in the giant brown marbles of their eyes. They only had eyes for Charlie. Same with the tanker driver, boringly named Jimmy Jones, who was introduced to me but never looked at me again during any of his long chats with Charlie. I felt like a kid sister following Charlie around, through no fault of his. He had the patience of Job. But oh my Lord, attaching the teat cup to the cow while the pipeline is running? That is harder than it looks. The trick is pinching off the suction until you've got it attached so you don't suck air into the line. One of the tricks, I ought to say, for there were more than I'd know how to tell. All related to a cow's faint interest in having clumsy, nervous hands on her underparts. Charlie said I wasn't doing too bad, which I disbelieved, and never on any day did I love the doing of it.

We talked more, once he got used to me. He told me things I should have known already about my father's business. What a smart move he'd made ten years ago, for instance, when he cut the size of his herd, changed their diet, and dropped out the antibiotics and hormones in order to contract with a small company that paid more for the higher grade. Other dairymen thought my father was foolish to follow a fad, catering to tastes that farmers can find a little bit precious. This milk company made a big deal of the small-family-farm thing, going so far as to put pictures of their contracted

farms on their cartons. My father did well by his contract, we were still getting by on it, but he never consented to having his picture on a milk carton. Charlie laughed and shook his head when he told me this. A man's got to draw the line.

I was still depending on my afternoon drives to escape the house and reclaim some order in my head. Sometimes, if Charlie and I drove out together, I'd follow him and stop in at Faye and Teddy's house to say hello. It shocked me to see with adult eyes how close our houses were. Less than a mile apart. On any day of my childhood, I could have walked over there for an hour with this woman who pulled square pans of blondies out of the oven and asked after your hurts and worries. She did those things for me now, with a pot of coffee and an adult slant on the hurts and worries. After Charlie went upstairs to get out of his barn clothes, she took surprising ease with my personal situation: Did I have a boyfriend at school? Was I thinking of going back? I told her I didn't, I wasn't, I couldn't. Honestly, I didn't even want to leave her kitchen.

She seemed to understand what my mother didn't, as far as the wool sweater and the sheep: Even if my hand looked half decent, my prospects were shot. A piano scholarship, and only that, had gotten me to college. Then a restaurant kitchen chewed up my golden hand. Faye wasn't a nurse, but as a home care worker, she knew things. She asked me about the fused joints and pins in my hand. And about the other surgery, how things were healing up down there. How I was feeling about it. When I shrugged that off, she looked at me over the rim of her coffee cup for a quiet minute and said I wasn't being fair to myself. It was a sad thing to lose so much at a young age. Of all the people who'd tended or consoled me, ever urging me to look on the bright side, Faye was the only one to say this. *Not* that I was lucky to be alive. She seemed to think I had every right to be alive. What I got was a rotten deal.

I fell apart that day, cried through half a box of Kleenex and apologized for the mess. "Honey, Kleenex is cheap," she said. "Tears held in are what costs you."

Mickie would regularly breeze into the kitchen to say hello, always with her arms full of books, sometimes with an extra bloom on her cheeks. James was bringing her home from school every day now, and I recognized

the signs of urgent making out. So did Faye. After Mickie checked in with me on what she was reading, grabbed a blondie and wafted upstairs, Faye would cluck softly: “In the front seat of a Ford Fairlane at four in the afternoon.” But she smiled when she said it. Maybe a little envious.

My father’s plan for the dairy and me was not news to the Cables. Faye said Charlie had told them. Teddy had talked about it with some of the neighbors. Half the damn county knew, then. I was more than a little peeved he hadn’t mentioned it to me. Yes, I’d been away for three years, but he could have told me over the phone. In one of my Sunday calls. From the mysterious castle where I’d gone away to turn myself into a music princess. I tried to imagine what he feared I would say to his proposition. What I *would* have said. Tears stung my eyes to think about it. His loss of Cy was as desperate as mine was. We needed to say this. And I’d been so far away.

Now I was here. As I’d watched Charlie apprenticing himself to my father in our sickroom, it had dawned on me that Charlie had a rare freedom by coming into a new body. Whatever expectations he’d grown up with, he had to shuck them off now, for he was a new kind of worker, clicking into the labors of our neighborhood in a new way. The same might be true of me. For the same reason. Without the hands I’d expected to have, I didn’t know what I was. Nor did I know yet what I wasn’t. I owned a dairy. The last thing I wanted. But maybe the loving of the doing mattered less than Charlie suggested. You get what you get.

As far as my plan to clear out my mother’s house one coat pocket at a time: I was not going to win that war. God knows where the crap came from; she didn’t even go out all that often. She didn’t need to. It came to her. Catalogues, newspapers, junk in the mail, groceries overly decked out in salvageable packaging. Other people’s castoffs followed her home from church, jumble sale or no jumble sale. I was coming to see that throwing things away, having them vanish, is a privilege for which all of us should prostrate ourselves in gratitude, if not guilt. In that horror house, I saw the human endeavor for what it is: a giant caterpillar chewing up leaves and grass and minerals, excreting its truckloads of frass into our households.

I made myself at home at Faye’s, stopping in to visit several times a week. If she invited me to stay for dinner, I stayed. She gladly let me chop and peel. If we asked, she’d let Mickie and me do the whole thing together

while she sat down and worked her crosswords. At their supper table, I disclosed details about my mother's hoard that were probably unforgivable, but entertaining. A fat manila envelope stuffed with the tags that say "Do not remove under penalty of law." If the others thought I was making things up, Charlie could vouch: Yes, there did dwell in that house a donkey that shat cigarettes out its butthole.

I didn't quite know it, but maybe I was fishing for rescue. One afternoon in February, Faye told me she and Teddy had an idea. They wondered if I'd want to move into what they called Mammaw's house. It wasn't a house, just a little apartment they'd built over their garage years ago for Faye's mother to move into after her husband died. It had stood empty now for a long time. Faye and Teddy had talked on and off about renting it out, but there weren't that many single folk looking to rent way out here in the country. It was real small, Faye said. But at least till I got on my feet, she thought I might not mind it. We could go take a look.

The whole thing seemed magical to me because I'd never known this apartment existed. I knew Charlie's mammaw lived with the Cables the whole time I was growing up, but children don't give a thought to where the various adults are sleeping. Nor had I ever had reason to go in their garage and see the staircase that ran upstairs to a perfect, life-sized dollhouse with gingham curtains on the gable window and a braided rug on the floor. I told Faye I didn't feel right taking this place without paying rent for it, a sentiment she shushed completely. She kept apologizing that it was so small. She had no idea. It had a bathroom behind a door that closed, a kitchen with a proper sink and stove, cabinets above it with heavy white plates and mugs. Mammaw's house was exactly what it sounded like, as whole and appealing as oatmeal. Unlike my bereaved apartment in Bloomington, nothing here had been stolen from the garage downstairs.

Everything I owned, other than a dairy, was still in three cardboard boxes. My move was accomplished within the hour. If my mother had feelings about it, she didn't say so. It turned out Faye had already discussed this possibility with her before she invited me, out of concern for her widowed neighbor being left all alone in the house, but my mother had expressed no objections. Probably was eyeing the closet space before I was out the door.

I loved my new little home, the cozy angles of its dormer ceilings, the morning light through blue-checked curtains, the antique wooden bed. I

could be a mammaw with the best of them. I sometimes took meals with the Cables, more often cooked something simple for myself. I read from the pile of books that grew taller every time Mickie stomped up the staircase to show me her new platform shoes or the bangs she'd cut herself, or just to see what I was up to. She looked around enviously and agreed, a girl needs a place of her own. Mine lacked for nothing.

What I missed was my mother's Buick Regal. I could ride over to the dairy with Charlie, and I did that, not every morning but several times a week. I was still making my stab at learning the ropes, and trying to force a little eye contact out of the tanker driver Jimmy Jones, as well as my mother. I always went in to chat and get her grocery lists. Charlie could run me into town after he finished the morning milking. And still I missed those long, solitary afternoon drives that had turned into my new life, small as it was. A stand-in for other things I didn't have, like a vocation or social life. Over the weeks, I'd driven past various landmarks I loved or hated. Once, I drove the forty minutes to the next town to see if I could remember where my middle school piano teacher Mrs. Sagraves lived. I got myself excited at the thought of maybe knocking on the door and seeing her again, if she was still there. Mrs. Sagraves, who taught me focus and posture and discipline and set me onto a lifelong pursuit of perfection. I found the house. Two little kids in grubby snowsuits were in the front yard jumping up and down, up and down, in a mud puddle, screaming, "You're a snotbooger. *You're* a snotbooger." I didn't get out of the car.

Now and again, and maybe more often than that, my drives took me back to the piano at Cross Creek Methodist. I pressed my grumpy right hand a little further out of lazy retirement, week by week. It complained bitterly. I channeled Mrs. Sagraves: *Pain is gain.* I dug into my boxes for the music I'd played when this was all new to me. Not hymns, but the first proper classical pieces I ever mastered. Bach's Two-Part Inventions were completely doable, I reasoned. No big octave stretches, not even a lot of right-hand chords; it was more about the contrapuntal melodies, fingers taking their little walks up and down and all around the town, *fortspinnung.* Fingers passing over fingers in the scale. Dexterity, coordination. Ugh. *Pain is gain.*

I was careful never to come to the church on Sundays or Wednesdays or any other day I spotted even a single car in the parking lot. I wanted no audience for my pitiful practices. Nor did I want to bother anybody, but

didn’t think I was trespassing, since I had a legitimate key. Even so, it felt like an illicit life I was carrying on here. Nobody needed to know.

After moving out on Mom and her wheels, though, I was missing my secret life, a lot. Finally I gave myself away to Charlie. After morning chores one day, he asked if I needed to go into town for anything, and I told him no, but would he mind dropping me off at the church for an hour. He didn’t mind, and he didn’t ask why, but when he dropped me off in the vacant lot and watched me go into the place with a key of my own, he guessed. After that, he asked almost every day, with the slightest twitch of a wink, did I need to go for my prayer meeting.

We took to driving around the backroads together, Charlie and me. It started as practical errands but turned into something else. He’d recently traded in his Pontiac for a slightly less antique pickup truck, and he let me drive it sometimes. Unlike every male in the county, I’d never driven a pickup and loved how it felt on the road. The height, the power in the engine, the way people waved at us as they passed. I was a citizen of my place, in a pickup truck. He told me he’d chosen his first car with an eye to its automatic transmission, which was easier for him to learn to drive. His Silverado was the real thing, though, stick shift and clutch, and unlike other males in the county, for Charlie that was a mountain to climb. Without any feeling in his prosthetic foot, he got frustrated trying to coordinate the opposing clutch and gas pedals. I told him I knew the feeling. My fingers and Charlie’s feet. Dexterity, coordination. Ugh. *Pain is gain.*

We covered a lot of territory, driving around just for the hell of it. I didn’t have anything else to do. He did, but still managed to work my vast uncharted wilderness of a life into his busy schedule. I was embarrassed to realize how poorly I knew the map of my own home county. Surprised, time and again, by turns he would take and the places we’d end up. They weren’t always short cuts, he said. Just a lot of different ways to skin the same old cat.

“I never learned any of these roads in high school,” I confessed. “I was always either practicing at the church or hightailing it out of here to some piano thing.”

“I didn’t either. It’s only here lately I’ve gotten to know them.”

“Our classmates sure did. A country kid’s whole universe is gravel roads and cars.”

“Love and war,” he agreed, surprising me with his choice of words.

“That’s the truth. Backseat sex and drag racing. Six-packs and bonfires.”

Charlie smiled. “I’ve heard of such things.”

“Me too.”

We had the windows rolled down a crack because it was a rare sunny day for late February, not really warm but sneakily thawing things out underneath the damp ground. The kind of day you wanted to smell. “What were you doing instead?”

He shook his head, still smiling. “I read a calculus book. Twice.”

It was during another one of those drives, with Charlie at the wheel, me staring out at brown fields, thinking, that I broached my biggest worry about the dairy: whether or not, or how, he was still getting paid. And he broached the subject of these things being all up to me now. Along with other decisions and whatever profits might be coming out of the operation. I needed to go into town to sign some papers transferring ownership.

I told him, not for the first time, I wasn’t ready to do that. Could hardly even stand to think about it. “I don’t know what’s scaring me most. Taking on the responsibility, putting the last nail in Dad’s coffin? The fact that I hate paperwork? I don’t know *why*, I just can’t. It’s worrying me to death. I’m sorry, you’ve heard all this already.”

Too many times, evidently. Charlie stopped the truck at an intersection of two empty dirt roads and turned to face me.

“You know what I like to do, when something’s eating at me that bad?”

I stared back at him. Long drives? Shot of whiskey? Calculus? His interior life was still pretty much a mystery. “No, Charlie. What do you like to do?”

“Do it right now. And it worries me no more.”

I kept staring at him. Hands draped on top of the wheel. Winter sun streaming bright and low through his bristle-brush hair, lighting his eyes. I understood I’d just learned the secret to being Charlie Cable. That, and remembering at all times: God gave us two ears, only one mouth.

We drove into town before the courthouse offices closed and did the transfer paperwork. It was tedious, and the notary public stayed with us almost an hour after they locked up. She was a good friend of Faye Cable’s, naturally. She said Faye was the one to “sit with” her grandmother in the months she was dying at home. We promised we’d pass on her love to Faye. From the courthouse, we drove straight back to my mother’s house to fetch

down the ledger books and health records while they still could be found, and brought them to my apartment.

After that, Charlie would come up for a little while most evenings to show me how to keep the books. We moved the little kitchen table and its two chairs over to the window so we could spread things out, and called it my office. CyLee world headquarters. I never really took over keeping the accounts, at all, and the herd records even less, but I got some understanding. Milking in ten-month cycles, pulling out the breeders for calving at two different times of year, since under our contract we could never go dry all at once. How to buy quality semen—that was an eye-opener. My father had requested a small stipend set aside to help support my mother, which of course I would keep up. Charlie and I agreed on hiring two workers before spring calving started, with plowing and planting the silage fields also to come. One full-time hand to cover one of the milkings, and maybe a high school kid part-time to clean stalls and equipment. My father had let some of the silage fields stand fallow last summer, and even at that, the work was a lot more than Charlie should have been handling alone. I also figured out he wasn't getting paid half enough, so that was my first act as dairy queen. I gave my sole subject a raise.

Sometimes I sat at that window by myself, trying to decipher the week's numbers, distracted by the view. From the peak of my little gable, I could see most of the silage field that lay between the Cables' house and my family's, with the long, narrow woods at its edge where Cyrus and I used to spend Saturdays poking at things with sticks. Such a team we were. So I thought. Until he quit on me. I thought about what Charlie had said, that my taking over the dairy was only half of what my father wanted. I tried to picture Cyrus and me doing this together, but neither one of us really fit the mold. Cy was drafted into barn chores as soon as he was big enough to pull on galoshes, and he did it without complaint, but it was all chore to him, not a calling. I was too young to think about how that was for him, this vocation closing around him like a hard shell. Not the life he'd have chosen. He never loved the doing of it either.

Faye saw me carrying a box to Charlie's truck one day and thought I was moving out.

“Oh, Faye.” I laughed. “You’ll be lucky to get rid of me. This is the best place I’ve ever lived.”

She eyed the box in my arms.

“This is my laundry. I always do it at Mom’s while we’re over at the dairy.”

“Does she like you to be doing it over there?”

I had no ready answer for that. The lid of the washing machine was still unencumbered, available for my use. In the way of a mother’s love, I took what I could get.

Faye saw my hesitation and took the box out of my arms. I made her promise not to do it for me while I was at the dairy. Which she did, but argued she’d just thrown my things in with her white load, and waited for me to help sort it out. We did that together, pulling staticky shirts and socks stuck together out of the warm dryer, talking and folding. The sunny mudroom, with its jumble of men’s boots and coats, was homier than most living rooms, and Faye was dear, but I cringed at the exposure. She’d seen the ratty things I slept in as a convalescent. Now she was seeing the rest. My T-shirts had holes; my underpants had holes. I still had some jokey T-shirts from my music-nerd days that she wanted me to explain. (What happens when C, E-flat, and G walk into a bar? Nothing. They don’t serve minors.) She said a little bird told her I was playing piano again, on the regular. I said that little bird was in big trouble if he told anybody else.

She folded a towel without saying anything and then turned to face me. “It would kill me to see that boy broken. I want you to know that.”

“You’re on safe ground there, Faye. If somebody asked him to, I expect your boy could throw a heifer over his shoulder like Hercules.”

“If you asked him to, he would. That’s what I’m saying. He’s strong on the outside, but in the middle, he’s not but a puddle of butter.”

I stared at her. I’d never seen Faye quite so serious. Or fragile. She looked up at the ceiling and ran a finger along each of her lower eyelids. “Oh Lord. He’d skin me alive for telling you this, but I’m going to anyway. He’s had his eye on you ever since middle school.”

I laughed. “You’ve misremembered. I went years and years in that school without one person noticing I was there. Not even the teachers. Ever hear of Livia Bohusz?” I mugged a broad shrug.

“So you think.”

“So I know.” I folded one of her towels for her, trying to do it the way she did. In half, turn, then in thirds.

“I could tell you things, Livia Bohusz. But he’d not want me to.”

“Like what?” I truly didn’t believe her.

She looked up at the ceiling again, heaved a breath. “Remember your brother’s funeral, how you played the music? You weren’t but the littlest thing, with that long hair down your back, sitting up straight and doing that. Everybody in town was a mess over that business, throwing stones or getting thrown at. But you played the piano for your brother. In front of everybody.”

“I had to. That’s all I could do for him, and that’s how I got through the day.”

“Well, see, that’s what *he* said. We all thought your parents shouldn’t have put you through it. Maybe you shouldn’t have even been there, considering. But Charlie stood up against us on that. He said you were the only one there with a backbone. Charlie wasn’t but, what, twelve or thirteen then? But I thought, my goodness, he’s looking at that girl. And I wasn’t wrong. There’s more, but I won’t tell it. You know what you need to.”

“I hear your words,” I said, after a minute. “You’re too good to me, and so is Charlie. I’d sooner smash my own hand again than cause any of you grief.”

“Lord, child. Don’t do *that*.” She set my neatly stacked, holey apparel into my hands and sent me on my way.

I didn’t believe her. I was the string-bean invisible girl, hiding from everything and everybody, revealing myself body and soul to naught but a church piano. There really was nothing else for Charlie to see. If he did, he never said so. It didn’t change the story. But after that talk with Faye, some tender spot was picked open, and I fretted overly about things I might have said or done to Charlie. Transgressions past or present. I’d been feeling so easy around him lately, and now I was nervous. He’d been underpaid and overworked, but I’d fixed that as soon as I could. Did he know how awful I felt, that he’d been devalued? I was clumsy and useless in the barn, in every way a poor excuse for an overseer, for which I could only apologize, and I did. Practically every day. I couldn’t remember ever raising my voice or being careless with Charlie. It was hard to imagine.

Oh, except the once. The day of my father’s funeral. I’d blown up at him in the empty chapel when I caught him listening in on my first little mess-

makings on the piano. Now that I remembered, I couldn't forget. The incident kept coming back into my head, crazily magnifying itself. I was a harpy, screaming him out of the church. The next time he offered to take me over there to practice, I saw myself screaming at him. The awful scene replayed as we drove, was still going when we pulled into the gravel lot. I could see only one way out of this.

"Would you like to come in for a little while and listen?"

He looked very surprised. "You sure?"

"I mean. You don't have to. I'm just saying you'd be welcome, if you ever wanted to."

"Well, I've got a minute now."

Oh. I thought he'd decline, that the welcome would be enough to clear our slate. "I don't have anything all that exciting to offer," I warned. "Just some Bach inventions."

"Hard to turn down a good invention," he said, and followed me in.

He stayed the whole hour. I was nervous at first and kept tripping up, apologizing, and tripping up again. He then apologized to *me*, asking if I'd rather he left me alone, but no, I insisted I wanted him there. And I did calm down, pretty quickly. I was starting to understand things I hadn't much thought about before my losses. That different parts of a person go into making music: What comes from your hands, everybody's looking at that. What's coming out of your soul, they can't see, but they can hear. And finally some of the music is just your way of being you, after a few thousand hours of practice. I could hold my insides as steady as a prayer. That was me. No matter who was looking on, even if they wished me ill, I could forget there was ever any Livia and turn into a liquid being of notes and rests. I might be a welded-together mess now, with limited resale value. But some of my parts were still the original.

This got to be a regular gig. Every couple of weeks or so, I organized a little recital for my jury of one. I think it was a deal I made with myself against giving up, as I wanted to do, always. Now, if I quit, Charlie would know. He was patient and forbearing, generous with praise, did not mind or notice the short rotation of my repertoire, and only a couple of times fell asleep. Which he had every right to do, given the hours he worked. I gave it my best, and my best got better by microscopic increments I almost couldn't credit, and I apologized after almost everything I played. No matter *what* I played, or tried to play, or didn't, frustration was a constant.

The cramp in my right palm was a constant. Anger at what I'd lost and would never get back, that was just life now, mine to live. I never cried in front of Charlie, but sometimes he asked me what was the matter, and I told him every time: "I'll never have 'Ondine' again."

After inviting Charlie into my music, it wasn't a very big step from there to invite him into my bed. This is not to say the latter sanctuary wasn't a private and precious one. It's that the former was so much the same.

He'd already spent a lot of time in my bedroom, it being also Cy-Lee world headquarters. We'd put our heads together on a lot of big decisions. Hiring Manuel and his son Eddie we did not regret, only wished we'd done it sooner. Investing in new silage baling equipment was a scary risk we hoped would pay out. I was still hopeless as a dairywoman, but I was getting the hang of Charlie. One night, we closed the ledger after pushing a lot of numbers around, and I put my hand on his hand and asked him if he wanted to come to bed.

He sat up tall in surprise. "With you?"

I laughed. And he laughed.

I'd been thinking about it awhile, but was stymied by the shower question. I figured if I asked, he'd want to shower first, as people do. And I didn't think mine was very handy for a man who had to do the whole thing standing on one foot. That night, he'd come upstairs after his supper with still-damp hair and an overarching scent of Prell. I made my move.

I turned off the lights, undressed, and got in bed. I looked the other way while he unstrapped his prosthesis and laid it on the floor with a little thump. We lay under the covers for a while holding hands, not talking. He was shivering a little. He said he was shy about the stump of his leg. He'd never let anybody see it since he was little. I told him I was shy about the scars all over my stomach, which nobody had seen at all. Not since I left the hospital. We agreed we wouldn't look, but that it might be okay to touch. We turned to face each other, finding ourselves very close, because it was a really narrow bed. I don't think Mammaw ever had visitors.

I stroked his face, but then waited for him to lead the way. I didn't want to come across as any kind of expert because I was pretty sure this was Charlie's first time. I didn't want him to feel ashamed of that. I was touched by it. I was used to being out of my depth with other people, and very often

I still was, but not here, not now. Charlie kissed me. I think he had done that before; he wasn't bad at it at all. We kissed for a long time and held each other's bodies, and I shuddered and felt a sob in my chest for how good it felt to be touched. To hold another person. It had been many, many months. I would have been happy to stay just there all night, holding and being held. But our fronts were pressed together and began getting their own ideas, one thing leading to another as it does.

He paused once, when we were getting a little momentum. "I don't . . ."

"Don't what?"

"Do we need to use something?"

"Oh. No. It's weird, right? But no, I can't get pregnant."

He smiled and pulled me to him. "Well, aren't you wonderful."

This became a regular gig too. More often than the piano recitals, with less frustration and no apologies. I had no mixed feelings about the smell of Prell shampoo coming up the stairs. Charlie was just easy. We always kept the lights off, but tried to get less shy with each other. We talked, and often fell asleep together, but Charlie never stayed the night. He was careful with his comings and goings, quiet about slipping back into his own house. I never said anything to Faye, even though we talked about everything else under the sun. Charlie seemed worried about what she would think, and I guess I was too. She was his protector. I'd been warned.

The work of springtime soon came over us in hectic, never-ending waves. Charlie would have to be up all night with calving, and out all day with planting. I told him to give himself rest. We saw less of each other. When he did come to me, he was weary and would fall into a hard sleep after we'd made love, from "good night" to softly snoring in ten seconds, literally. I've never seen a body so tired. But he insisted I wake him up so he could sneak back into the house. We got through April with our secret intact. We thought. Till I came upstairs one afternoon to find a filmy negligee laid across my bed, and a note from Faye: "I've seen what you wear to bed. I'd put on this instead."

I loved the gesture, but was too embarrassed to wear it. She didn't understand; this was something we did with our eyes closed. There was never any extravagance in our coupling. We just touched each other in a way that felt like falling into a featherbed. Being with Charlie was as

natural as gravity. I'd come back to this place broken, in some ways past repair. I had no more use for passion. Reaching for the stars had torn open a gash of loneliness in me that nothing would ever put right. But I was holding myself together and didn't want to test those stitches. Comfort was safe. With a deeply kind man who thought I was wonderful.

He knew I couldn't get pregnant. It was just an odd surprise for us both, in that first awkward moment, to realize the convenience. He knew my uterus had to be taken out of me in a terrible operation, and that I'd almost died. He didn't know its removal was in some ways the least of it, relief and resolution of a nightmare I'd been trapped into. From the first day Charlie came to fetch me, I'd bound myself into a coil of untold truth, and it only pulled tighter with time. Sometimes I wished I could see my way to telling more, but I couldn't. Not to Faye or Mickie, and now, especially, not to Charlie. These were unsayable things. That I'd walked the line of madness, isolated and hated and half starved myself as penance for being unlovable. That I'd borne a man's child nearly to full term, after falling into a kind of love I would never get back from. So much more than physical stuff had been cut out of me. Future hopes, and the last malignant shreds of romantic illusion.

I kept all that from Charlie because I had to. I didn't need to be in love again, ever, if I could have something else so solid and safe. Any riskier, deeper feelings I vowed to keep far away from both of us, in our little bed under the angled beams of our dormer ceiling. And even so, a risky kind of remembering seeped back into my head. I knew it to be poison, didn't want it, hated myself for breaking the most civil human contract, but couldn't stop it. He eased in behind my eyelids and the secret caverns behind my nose and tongue, into my fingertips. The sight of his body, his smell, his hair curled in my fists. I held onto Charlie for dear life, but when I pushed up against the edge of happiness and hovered there close to completion, it was Sigurd who pulled me over. Every time.

May was eventful. Mickie took her PSATs, got the highest scores in the county, went to prom, and swore me to secrecy on the matter of what happened afterward with James. I tried to be helpful at the dairy and even pulled my first calf, which is another kind of virginity to lose. I was scared to pieces and did it solely to prove to the guys I wasn't a lightweight.

Manny and Eddie always called me “Fingers” because they knew I played the piano. Now they congratulated me and nailed my shoulder-length disposable plastic glove to the wall of the barn as my badge of honor. It was a boy. We were coming up boys all over. Charlie got more upset than I’d ever seen him because the semen we’d paid top dollar for was supposed to deliver us a high percentage of heifers. He spent a lot of time on the phone, and had to keep tracking me down over at the church to sign paperwork I didn’t understand, and didn’t really want him to explain. Calf pull or not, I felt like a tin god. It made no sense for me to own this business when Charlie was running it.

We argued about it all through summer. Not unkindly but persistently. He saw no problem with the way we were doing things. It’s what my father wanted. When I pushed, he suggested I discuss it with my mother. If anybody was getting a bad deal, it might be the wife who didn’t inherit. I had to agree with him on that, but I waited to go see her until the weather was warm enough to sit on the front porch. I’d stopped going inside. She’d gotten reclusive and didn’t really like anybody in there. We sat on the porch and drank iced tea and calmly discussed the inheritance. She said she was fine, money-wise, with or without the stipend I intended to keep giving her. She had his Social Security, they owned the house outright, she didn’t need much money to live on. I rolled my eyes toward her domestic pandemonium and suggested that if she ever did, she could organize a yard sale.

“That’s it, I’m done,” she said, clapping her hands on her knees. She was wearing old khaki pants and had a scarf around her head like Rosie the Riveter. I did not want to think what she was up to in there. Constructing a blimp out of bread wrappers.

“I’m sorry, Mom. I just worry. That you miss Dad. And I’ve abandoned you. If you feel like you should be part owner, we can fix the paperwork. Full owner. Whatever you want.”

She looked out at the barn for a really long time. I could never say what color her eyes were. Probably because she never really looked at me.

“I never wanted any of it,” she said finally. “I told him that, from day one.”

“On your wedding day. You told him that.”

“January sixth. The day I slit my throat.”

This was supposed to be a joke. Every year. He would say “Happy anniversary!” and she would say *that*. “Excuse me if I don’t find that funny anymore, Mom. He was a good man. He never said an unkind word to you, or any of us.”

“Am I saying he did?”

I wanted to throw something at her. “So that was always the plan. It would go to us kids.”

“He named it for you, did he not?”

“But that was before . . .” It was too awful, this. Almost ten years, still at this impasse. “He didn’t know he’d end up without a son to work it.”

Then she looked at me. Right at me. Brown. Light, almost grayish-brown eyes. Exactly the same as Cy’s and the same as mine. How could I not know that?

“Could be yes, could be no,” she finally said. “He wanted that to be your decision.”

I walked away from her in a buzz of incomprehension. Wanted me to decide *what*? I waited for Charlie to finish checking all the calf hutches. Manny would finish out the day, and Charlie was going home to sleep. There was no night and no day at calving time; this operation ran like a hospital. I was headed over to the church to practice, and I did that, but my head was still a beehive. It stayed that way for several days. Without a son to work it. Up to me. What in the everloving hell did she mean?

Without a son to work it until Charlie. It was Monday afternoon, he was snoring quietly in my bed while I sat looking out the window, and that’s what I thought. I woke him up.

“Dad told you he was leaving me the dairy. We’ve talked about this, you knew. But you didn’t say *how long* you’ve known.”

Poor sweet Charlie. He always napped in all his clothes, and his foot. Ready to spring into any kind of rescue. He blinked. Ran a hand over his bristle-brush hair. “I don’t know, two years? I started coming over there to help him in the fall. Right soon after I got my legs. Willard was my first real job.”

“Your first boss, and he tells you what’s in his will.”

“Well. We talked, I guess. Willard was a man with things to say.”

“*Was* he?”

“To me he was. Don’t be mad at me for another man’s talk, I just listened. What he wanted more than life was for that farm to stay in his

family. And he wanted me to look after it the right way. And that I have done."

"That you have. Over and above. To the point of—I don't know, Charlie. Insanity?"

"No." Charlie shook his head, smiling, looking to the side, like he'd been caught in some small, forgivable crime. "I don't know what to say, Livvie. He wanted me to promise the deal was locked in."

"The deal."

He looked at me, eyes wide, eyebrows raised. The fermata. Commanding a silent pause.

"You and me? *You and me* are the deal? What the *fuck*, Charlie Cable." He grimaced. "I'm sorry, what in the everloving. He wanted us to get *married*?"

It made perfect sense except it didn't. I listed every reason. We were so young. We were pawns in a game. We'd only really known each other a few months. Or our whole lives, depending on how you looked at it. But the main thing was, I couldn't have children.

"You know this. I've told you, and you understand, I can't have babies. Ever."

Charlie saw no merit to any of these objections. He said I was pretty much perfect as just myself. All the wife anybody could wish for.

"*Plus*, I come with a dairy," I pointed out. Which I understood to be either a dowry or a pox, depending on the day. Charlie confessed, then, to what Faye had already told me. He'd loved me a long time before he knew I had a single dairy to my name.

I couldn't deny, it was a perfect solution. It felt like we would be getting away with something. But then. I couldn't hold the thought in my head for one minute before I started worrying about my mother. "If we get actually *married*, oh God. How does that work? What will she expect, or not expect? Nobody can go in that house, but it's not even that. It's me. She's told me so many times I'm not fit for any man to marry, I don't know if she'd be happy or mad to find out she's wrong, but she keeps her own wedding dress in a box *under the goddamn bed*, Charlie, sorry for cursing, but she does, she's talked about it all these years, and I never can tell, is it her prized possession or the noose around her neck? She's saving it for me, and I'm not fit for it, and oh my God, Charlie. The word *wedding* makes me feel sick to my stomach."

Charlie sat patiently observing my distress until I had to stop for a breather.

"Know what I like to do, when something's eating me that bad?"

I stared at him. "As a matter of fact, yes," I said. "I do."

We got ourselves to the courthouse that same afternoon. Our witness was the sweet friend of Faye's who'd stayed late for us back in February when we signed all the dairy paperwork. She emptied out a little handful of white paper confetti from her hole puncher and tossed it over us at the end. We walked out laughing. And it worried us no more.

Charlie and I lived almost two years in Mammaw's house. Faye kept threatening to get a bigger bed hauled up those stairs, but we really didn't mind. And as far as possessions, Charlie was on the austerity plan, like me. We felt like children playing house, which I guess we were. Apart from running a business with employees, impossible hours, and a tight bottom line. Charlie had no fear of any of it. We both relaxed into his co-ownership, and he didn't just love the doing; he did it shrewdly. My father had a good eye. He picked the right son.

Of everybody, Mickie I think was the most gleeful about the marriage. Faye clucked over us like a gloating hen, but Mickie gushed. "You *guys*!" She couldn't decide if we were like a Charlotte Brontë novel or a Thomas Hardy novel. Definitely a novel. I said I wanted to be the one where nobody dies. Charlie said he'd vote for the one where the silage baling equipment pays off. Mickie looked at us across the supper table with starry eyes. She'd bagged a sister.

We took almost all our meals with Faye and Teddy and Mickie, and did our laundry there, and while we insisted we didn't want any bigger life than the one tucked up under the garage gables, we did kind of ooze into every room of the Cable house. We took over a corner of their living room to shelve all the herd records and use the computer Charlie had helped them set up, now devoted mostly to our spreadsheets. We'd fitted out my tiny shower with a plastic stool for Charlie, but it wasn't great, and he still used the one they'd modified for him with grab bars and a bench. Faye confided she worried about him on those stairs. I was surprised to hear it. He was as able a man as any I knew. She meant at night. If there was to be an

emergency, she said. Like a fire. It took him time to get his foot on—obviously I knew that. I told her I'd think about it.

What I *thought* I was thinking about was the two of us moving into Charlie's boyhood room, an idea he rejected with un-Charlie-like intensity. I understood. It's a squeamish proposition to be an adult in the room that coddled your childhood. Maybe more so, for a man so physically transformed. But it was also his shyness. He couldn't abide the thought of having sex under the same roof with his parents. So that was that. Our move was out of the question.

I took over the cooking because Faye had a new client: a rich lady in Marionville, a hundred and one years of age, who'd outlived four husbands and, sadly, all of her children. The last husband was a bigwig at the chemical company over there; before him was a high-ranking officer in the army, and they'd lived in Europe. For this or possibly other reasons, she had a big house full of fine and surprising things that Faye tried to describe to us, and we are not talking cigarette-shitting donkeys. This lady liked Faye the best of all her care aides, and wanted her every night of the week. Marionville is a long drive. She got Faye for four.

I bought a very used Chevy Nova so I could get myself around without begging rides for household errands and going to the church for piano practice. I was there four or five days a week now and, under some pressure, opened up my little recitals to Mickie and Faye, then a few others. Manny from the dairy, surprisingly. Who still called me Fingers. Well. He had this niece, Cookie, who "sang as good as Selena," he earnestly swore, and was dying to learn to play piano. I let her come and listen to some romantic Villa-Lobos, but apologized that I couldn't teach her. I didn't have a piano. Nobody even knew I was using this one.

This turned out to be untrue. I was a subject of much discussion for Cross Creek Methodist members and the Methodist-adjacent. There are no secrets in a place like ours. My vehicle had been observed almost from the beginning by passersby, and by one poor soul who came to dust the pews every Tuesday night but ran away the first time she saw somebody was there, in case a burglary was in progress. No church in our county had ever been burgled, to anybody's knowledge, but times being what they are, et cetera. She reported it to the minister and turned in her dust rags and Pledge, but he took a careful inventory and found not one single item moved or taken. Just a bunch of extra Kleenexes in the trash. A wistful

ghost was haunting his sanctuary, ferried by a truck he recognized eventually as the Cable boy's, and later by the Chevy Nova driven by the daughter-in-law. He told his parishioners, on the quiet, to let me be.

I don't know how long my presence was known before he stopped in one evening and sat in the back to listen. I didn't notice until he gave himself away with a quiet cough at the end of a little tussle I was having with Scriabin. This was the minister who'd given me the key when I was eight years old. Even so, I panicked, not sure whether to apologize, give myself up for arrest, or what. He smiled from the back pew and gave me an *okay* sign, like my father used to.

I still felt rattled, or guilty. My mother attended that church, but I hadn't in a long time. Not since my days of playing for the Sunday services. I asked him if he was sure none of his proper churchgoers minded.

"They've been advised to think of you as part of our flock," he said. "I told them salvation moves in mysterious ways."

So he knew. I was taking only what I needed.

Mickie got engaged to James at Christmastime. She was a senior, and her teachers were pushing her about college. She didn't want to let anybody down, but understood she was going to do that either way, staying or leaving. I told her she might as well send out applications and see how she felt when the time came. On Christmas Day, I went over to see my mother. The kitchen barely had room for us both, but she shifted piles so we could set our coffee cups on the table, and we talked about my father. She said she missed him; it was too quiet. That made me laugh. My father, who hardly said a word in her presence. I told her it was a pretty common failing, not taking proper regard of what's around us all the time. She allowed that could be true.

Afterward, I walked out to the barn, even though I knew nobody was there. Charlie had finished the first milking early, and set the cows out to pasture with their calves instead of being held in for the second milking. He felt everybody deserved the day off, man or beast. I'd never seen the place so empty. No restless swishing tails, no thumping vacuum pump, not even the usual sweetness of manure and silage and cud all mixed together on the air. It smelled cold and vacant. I walked down the row of milking stalls all the way to the last one, where Cy and I used to hide from our mother and

play cards. I couldn't shake off the crazy idea she would be in here somewhere, someday. Dolly.

What Faye had in mind was not Charlie and me moving into his old room. It turned out, she was suggesting we swap altogether: We'd move into the big house; Faye and Teddy would take the apartment over the garage. I wouldn't hear of it, but she still brought it up, all through winter into the spring. She said she would need a bigger bed up there, that was for darn sure, but otherwise, it made no sense for them to keep the whole house when Charlie and I were the ones using it most. Mickie was moving out in the fall. She'd made her decision. I remained neutral as pea soup on the subject while she talked herself into college. Then told James it was all my idea.

This proposal of Faye's was not unheard of. We'd known farm families whose elder parents retired to smaller quarters in town as the younger family took over the farm. But Charlie and I weren't going to be a family. I felt self-conscious about that. I could offer the Cables no future that required very much space. Over the summer, the subject of our moving died out because everybody was too busy to think past tomorrow. Teddy had acquired more tobacco allotments and was growing more acreage now than anybody in the county. At cutting time in the fall, the horde of nephews and cousins that showed up at our table at a workday's end put me in mind of Gordo's when the students came back to town. Except the Cable boys looked you in the eye when you passed them the potatoes, and they said thank you.

In the fall, Faye brought it up again. Mickie was off to UT in a happy flush of nerves and color-coordinated dorm room decor. Faye complained that she and Teddy were just rattling around in that big old house by themselves now. I pointed out that Mickie would certainly be back if Mr. James Barnes had any say about it. Faye said, "Yes, but not as my little girl." She'd not be moving back into her old bedroom. Again, true. Not if James had a say.

In time, both Faye and Teddy lobbied for the move and got Charlie in on it too. There was something they weren't telling me. Then, leading up to the holidays, they got insufferable. For the last two days before Christmas, they made me stay out of the big house. I was banished to my attic, not allowed

back until Christmas morning. Charlie led me into the living room with my eyes closed and then had to catch me because I almost fainted from shock. What in the ever-loving—*where* did this come from? Because I know what they cost, and it's a fortune.

It came from Faye's hundred-and-one-year-old lady, was where. She still refused to die, but could no longer put off the move to a nursing home and was saying goodbye to all her beautiful things. No children, she lamented, and you can't take it with you. She told Faye to take her pick of anything in the house.

Faye chose the Steinway Model M studio grand. It was in dire need of tuning, but the action was gorgeously sturdy, as perfect as anything I'd ever had my hands on. For the first time in my life, I was invited to live under the same roof with a piano. I swore I would never leave it.

Faye and Teddy called Mammaw's house their honeymoon house, but they didn't even last the winter. It was cold up there. The steep stairs were not the best thing in the world for Teddy's knees, and Faye needed to spread out. They'd probably never meant to stay; it was just a half step toward turning over the keys to the kingdom. I could see that now, and had a hunch they'd already had their eyes out for some little place nearby. Charlie was already more or less in charge of the farm. Teddy had barely cleared expenses the previous summer, even with the heroics of the expanded acreage. Tobacco was falling through the floor as price supports phased out, and dairy wasn't looking much better. Charlie and Teddy together laid out a long-term plan to transition the dairy to a cow-calf operation using both farms combined. With that kind of acreage, they'd be producing hay and silage to spare, and could sell it for extra income. Charlie meant to make good on that baling equipment or be buried with it.

Teddy and Faye found a sweet place not five miles down the road from us. Like every rural county, I guess, most young people were moving away—all those who weren't lucky or unlucky enough to be born to a family farm. It made for too many houses standing around empty, and these could be had for a song, especially if they were small, had no land attached, and needed some repairs. This they found, and secured it with the lump sum Teddy got from selling all his tobacco allotments back to the state. Faye and Teddy still came over to see us all the time, and nothing felt too different

except for an ache that started following me around. I tried to ignore it. My wounds had long healed over, my hands worked well enough. I could play my own piano anytime, and had taken a few paying students, starting with Manny's ambitious niece, who had a good ear and a stage name already picked out. Many bright sides to look on.

Maybe I was getting used to being married, the permanence of it. Life wasn't something I could look forward to now, but something that *was*. And had been, for long enough now that women were stopping Faye in the grocery to ask with coy faces if we had any *news* yet. Faye would answer, *Oh, my, yes*, then tell these nosy Nellies about equipment we'd purchased for the dairy, our output and somatic cell counts, the baler that cuts and wraps the silage all in one go so it ferments in the big white plastic wrapper right there in the field. The ladies stopped asking.

I didn't think I could be missing something I'd never wanted. I had only to look at my own mother to know I wasn't cut out for that. Charlie swore he didn't mind, and Faye was plainly on our side. The absences weighing on me were nothing they could see. It was the other possible Livia I was carrying around, like a heavy ghost. She'd almost come to life, and then she was nothing. Pure loneliness, standing under dark trees screaming at a wall of impossibility. If a little door opened in the wall one day, why would I not walk through into something else? This family, this bright little life I never even asked to visit. How could this not be salvation?

I recalled asking Charlie one time what was hurting him, because I could see something was, and he told me it was his missing foot. He knew how that sounded, but truth to tell, it happened all the time. Real pain, as if the foot was still right there. When he'd lost it as a little boy, the doctor explained this pain was from all the nerves he still had connecting his brain to emptiness at the end of his leg. It was their whole job to wait for feeling. If they weren't getting what they expected, they just hollered instead. The name of it was phantom limb pain. I supposed I was feeling something like that, from parts of my life that were gone. And I supposed if Charlie had suffered most of his days without talking about it, I could do the same.

In April, I had another surprise gift from the family, as far outside anything I'd expected as the first one was. It felt like something they'd all conspired on, though they couldn't have. It was a miracle, and they were just

bystanders. Or the deliverers of great news, like that angel that dropped in one day on Mary and left her gobsmacked.

They found Dolly. At first, Manny thought it was a cat, curled up so tight in its black and white fur, he couldn't see head nor tail, way back in a corner behind the milk room where dust and lost tools accumulated. Manny could only tell it was a dog after she lifted her head. Poor old thing, gray in the muzzle, one ear almost missing. *Come look here,* he yelled at Charlie over the beat of the milk pump. Manny said it was the first time he'd ever seen Charlie Cable shocked enough to cuss. The second time came right after, when she got up to her feet. She had a pup.

Charlie called Faye, and Faye called Mickie, who was home for Easter break and over at James's. Faye went deaf in one ear for several days from the scream over the phone. This was a miracle beyond the return after a long absence. Dolly couldn't have pups, we thought. My father had tried to breed her more than once. Maybe she hadn't cared for the stud. For here she was now, licking her own offspring at the age of at least twelve years that anybody knew of, probably more. A litter of one is small but, given her age and the all-around circumstances, respectable.

Charlie and Mickie had the same idea at the same time, but it was Mickie who named her. I was in the kitchen starting supper when they came in. I'm sure I swore a few oaths of my own when they told me Dolly was back, and again when they showed me what they'd brought me, all wrapped up in a towel. Mickie told me I had to name her Ondine.

I was confused. This sweet fuzz ball. "Why?"

"*Because*," Mickie said, exasperated.

"You always say that," Charlie said.

"You *do*," Mickie insisted, pretend crying, grinding fists in front of her eyes and wailing, *"I'll never have 'Ondine.'"*

"I say that? Out loud?"

I did. And I'd have to be done with it, they said, because whatever it was, I had one now.

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Prelude VII

On Sunday, I meant to burn everything that was reasonable to burn. And given my history with Cyrus and our incinerations, my sense of reasonable surpasses the usual.

Even if I'd lost my mind, I could still yet see the good of having calmer wits on hand, so I asked Charlie to come over later. For safety's sake, but I think too I wanted a witness. What kind of ceremony this was to be, I didn't know. Something between spring cleaning and witch-burning. As soon as I got home from the Presbyterians, I changed into old clothes, came over to the house with a box of matches, and started on the hail of boxes I'd thrown down yesterday from above. The demise of cardboard is hypnotizing, all those corrugated layers turning slowly red and curling back from each other in the way of a flower or sea creature. Then the whole mess blackening into huge, weightless flakes. It's also quick. I soon moved on to the furniture.

You can learn a lot about your belongings from throwing them off the roof. Little of the furniture was made of wood all the way through. Good, solid chairs or dressers would come apart at the joints, but these things splintered open at their widest parts, revealing weak hearts of glued-together sawdust. It all burned hot and fast from the inside out, exploding into a spectacle of admirable colors and evil smells. Gaspard and I kept our distance. I threw another armload of magazines into the furnace, then backed up to sit down with him on the grass. He'd stayed right with me

whenever I ran out of fuel and went inside to collect more, but was dispirited each time I came back out to the hot-mouthed devil around the back. He never did come around yesterday to my throwing things out the windows, and he thought even less of what I had going today.

I sat rubbing the bony shoulder blades under his soft pelt as I watched the flames. Poor Gazzie was trembling. It was wrong to be so near a conflagration, more wrong to abandon me to one, so here he was, yoked to the permanent risk of a beloved fool's choices. Exactly like his mother, Ondine, all the days of her life, and her mother, Dolly, ahead of them both. Attachment ran hard in both our lines. I couldn't countenance letting go of Ondine, all those years ago when I'd had to accept the day would come anyway, so Charlie had held one pup for me out of her final litter. Ondine was a good mother, the few times we'd undertaken to breed her, and healthy pups from a good herder brought income we needed. But the goodbyes were awful. I asked for a male pup. Gaspard and I would avoid the torments of motherhood, I said, and so we had.

He stood up when I did, now, and glumly stuck to my heels as I went back in for another armload. I'd cleared so much out of the bedrooms, both mine and Cy's, I could picture the two of us dancing in the open space. I congratulated myself on the efficiency of the furniture-burning decision. A dresser stuffed to bursting with old cash register receipts and mouse nests could be carried out and burned whole, a drawer at a time. (The mice hightailed it.) Then it was easy to roll the empty remainder out the window and off the roof. That was also an efficient business, and I had Sigurd to thank for it. Sitting up there yesterday morning with my agitation and his calm voice on the phone, what else could I do? *Defenestration*, there was a word. Sigurd must have taught it to me. Something to do with toppled kings.

I set a wooden drawer full of receipts into the flame, carefully, like putting a baby in a carriage. Then sat back down on the grass and watched little whirlwinds of flame erupting inside the bigger inferno, a whole miniature weather system inside its heated atmosphere. I imagined each tiny firestorm as one of my mother's scoldings, burning itself out. Ancient accounting. I was just a few hours into this, and the ash pile was already heaped so high in our old block enclosure, the burn spilled out on both sides. My project looked less like disposal than the making of a pyre.

I pulled up a handful of grass that felt thick and wonderful in my fingers, like a fistful of the world's hair. Still damp. I'd hosed down the ground all around the incinerator before I lit the first cardboard box. I'd hit it lucky on the weather, no wind at all, clear sky, a perfect end-of-summer day. Perfectly empty or perfectly full, depending on whether you measure a day by clouds or birdsongs. I couldn't see a one of the former, but the trees in the fencerow woods were full of grackles praising the afternoon with high, wheedley notes and low chuckles. Those same woods where we used to hear bobcats screaming sometimes at night. Good day, this one.

I went back in the house and fetched out an armload of clothes, to try out fabric in between paper and furniture. I had high hopes, with so much here to get rid of. I'd set aside a handful of things that might go to a thrift shop or, at worst, would not offend the church charities. But the house bulged with useless garments: underwear and bras worn to tatters, laundered and folded in trash bags. The clothes Cy and I wore threadbare as children, same. Folded and bagged, of no use to anybody but myself, firebug for a day. From this cache I'd brought down from upstairs, I tossed in a couple of cotton dresses to see how they'd go. Next some polyester shirts that made good colors but didn't burn so much as they melted, withering to a kind of shrink wrap clinging to the wooden dresser top under it. I tossed in a wool sweater that immediately curled in on itself like a dead animal and smelled awful. Like burning hair. Of course. I tossed in more cotton dresses, and they did fine. The polyester would go okay if I layered in lots of junk mail; wool would be an occasional burnt sacrifice. I was getting the hang of this.

Next in the pile on the ground was the fringed cowgirl dress my mother made for Nashville. I held it up for Gaz and me to admire: my mother's hopeful career, seeing daylight for the first time in half a century. The silvery blue gown was here too, cut low in front and high on the thigh. I draped the satiny fabric over my arm. Her talisman that ran out of luck. The fire crackled, hungry for them both. *Naut but a ordanary canairy.* I closed my eyes, trying to see her in either one of these dresses, the jaunty Patsy Cline, the crooning siren. Feeling that satin on her skin. Arguing with her mother. *You don't understand. I'm going to win this.* There she was, I could see her. Not my mother in the store with the expensive black dresses, the meaty hand raised to slap down my confidence. The girl. Slight, determined, hunched over her sewing machine with hands pressed to the fabric of her ambitions, her mute mouth full of pins. Refusing to be saved

from her high-mindedness. Poor sweet thing. A child wants to climb. A mother can't help but see the fall from the top. All these different things called love, even the grasping, terrible ones, have to be given a home. Or else they'll wander and find trouble.

A few tears dotted the pale satin with a darker blue as I folded it carefully and set it by on a chair. Same with the cowgirl dress. I would put these away on a shelf somewhere.

"Great day in the morning. What are you doing?"

I jumped. I hadn't heard Charlie's truck. He was staring at my bonfire.

"Don't worry, there's plenty of stuff still in there."

He looked from me to the fire. Back to me.

"I mean the good stuff I sorted out for the estate sale. That's in the kitchen. I'm not meaning to burn down the whole business."

He nodded carefully. I hadn't answered his question.

"Pull up a seat?" I suggested.

He tested some chairs that were lying on their sides, and planted the sturdiest on its feet next to Gaz and me. I saw him look over his shoulder to see I'd dragged a water hose back here and connected it. Then he sat in his rescue chair and stared at the fire.

"Burning's not allowed till after four o'clock," he said, after a bit.

"Really? It's been pretty rainy. Oh, you're saying it's not allowed ever?"

"Ever. County rules for open burning. Only between four and midnight."

"What's so magical about four o'clock?"

"Wonder that myself."

I checked my watch. I was about an hour away from legal. "How's Teddy?" Charlie had taken Faye over to Garden Hill, where I imagined father and son discussing irrigation for one minute, looking at their shoes for another two, before he left Faye there to dote on her husband.

"Better, I guess. He hates it bad enough, he'll do whatever they say to get himself up."

"It's a strategy. Make your broken-hip patients so miserable they walk right out the door."

He smiled. "How were the Baptists?"

"It's the Presbyterians now, for Sunday service. I've told you that. Since back in the spring."

"*Did* you tell me that?"

"I think so." I might not have. I mostly kept my piano business to myself.

“How’d they steal you away from the Baptists?”

“By paying me more. They give me more leeway too. I get their program for the hymns, but for the quiet times like silent prayers while they pass the collection plate around, I can play whatever I want. So long as it suits the mood.”

“What do you play, then? Not more hymns?”

“No. Never.” I was surprised he asked. “Bach sometimes. Which is churchy, technically. But oftentimes I’ll slip in something by a composer that never darkened the door of a church. ‘Clair de Lune,’ by Debussy. I do that one a lot.”

“Not a churchgoer, was he?”

“No. But the churchgoers can’t tell. I think God gets around to more places than people want to think. Sometimes I play a little bit of Shostakovich, and that man was a sworn atheist.”

He chuckled. “Aren’t you the one. Blaspheming the burn laws and the Presbyterians, all in a day.”

“I plead ignorance on the burn laws. And the Presbyterians . . .” I thought about it. “It’s more like inviting people that haven’t met each other to a party. I like seeing how they get on.”

He was quiet for a long while, staring at the flames. I did the same, while Gaspard fixed his wistful gaze on the steep horizon. Funny how people can’t take their eyes off a fire, while every other kind of beast wants to look away.

“What are you doing this for, Livvie?”

“I’m sorry. I can’t tell you why.”

“Can’t say? Or don’t know?”

From thirty feet away, I could feel the heat on my face. I looked up at Charlie, and he held my eye. We were not the *penny for your thoughts* kind of people, Charlie and me. Maybe all that meant was a whole lot of pennies bankrolled. “A cremation?” I ventured.

“You’re mad at her,” he said. “Nobody blames you for it.”

At both of them, Cyrus too. At Sigurd, for showing up in my life. At my stupid younger self for falling down that well. Wanting too much, throwing my best parts away. I’d been mad about all of it for so long, I might have lost sight of the parts I had left.

“I’m trying not to be,” I said.

“She’d dead and gone.”

“Not hardly. But we’re getting there.”

I got up and brushed grass off myself and told Gazzie to stay while I went in for more kindling. Gaz didn’t move, but failed to quench a high, trembling whine that was almost above my hearing. I went in the back door and paused to look around the kitchen, which was fully organized: the duplicate-gift appliances, the stack of boxed books for the library. Her good china and other marketable treasures, also boxed up. The sale of this house would put a cushion of safety in the bank for Charlie and me, for the first time in our lives. Why did the place still scare me?

I marched into the living room with its teeming mouse-mountain of oatmeal canisters and berry baskets and egg cartons stacked high in wobbly gray columns like a Roman ruin. I gave the heap a couple of good kicks to put the tenants on notice, then scooped up a sundry armload. Dry as dust. This stuff would go up like gunpowder. I came out the back door feeling lightheaded, flung my haul of baskets and egg cartons onto the grass, and went back in for more, trying to be strategic, filling baskets and canisters with any burnable thing in my path: a handful of tarot cards, a used-up notepad with a rooster on the cover that we kept by the phone when I was in high school. Back outside, I pitched each vessel into the flames with purpose, like an athlete making a string of outstanding plays. But this wasn’t really the game. I hadn’t dealt with her bedroom.

I asked Charlie to help me with some bigger things. Both bedsteads from upstairs, and a dining table in the living room that nobody had seen in the present century. By size and weight, what she’d piled on top of it was in the ballpark of a piano. I excavated a sewing machine that looked truly ancient, built into a table with foot pedals where you’d want an electric cord. I dragged the thing out of the pile and down onto its feet with a powerful thud.

“Who do you reckon used *that*?” I asked.

Charlie studied it. “Eve, I’d say.”

“Gosh, I think you’re right. For making Cain and Abel’s dungarees.”

Then one son killed the other and on it goes, I thought. That’s what I’d always felt in this house, a perpetuity of grief. We hauled out more generations of sewing machines, regrettably unburnable, and countless trash bags with better promise. The table underneath all that turned out to be solid wood, maybe oak, and would have been worth saving if it had lived a happier life, but the leaves had broken under their burden. We pulled it apart

into sections we could carry. While Charlie got the last of that, I went in the kitchen and put on a pot of coffee with the one appliance I'd retained for personal use. Then went back to the empty living room and turned all around, taking in its size. We'd played in here. Sprawled on the floor together doing our homework.

The fire had died down, so I fed in tindery baskets to wake up the flames before I heaved in table sections. Charlie had turned on the hose and was spraying down the perimeter of the fire, as I'd done earlier, only the perimeter had expanded. A huge, dark mound was growing underneath the blaze. "That's going to leave some bewilderment behind it," he said.

Bewilderment was right. The permanent record of my vanished family. Hinges, hairpins, bolts, screws. Charred pearl buttons. Belt buckles.

"I was thinking I might ask James to bring over his backhoe and bury the evidence," I said. "Back there at the fence line. Before we put the house up for sale." I was more than thinking about it. I'd dragged the sewing machines onto a hefty pile of unburnables I'd already started back there, with exactly that backhoe in mind.

Charlie nodded. "James won't mind to do that."

"He'll mind it less than pulling his roll-off dumpster to the landfill twenty more times. He won't tell me what he has to pay them for every load. But I think it's a lot."

"Around a hundred bucks."

"Good night! Really? Now I feel awful."

Charlie had shut off the hose and was feeding bulky items onto the fire. A skeletal dresser without its drawers. Pieces of my brother's old desk. "You feel no worse than James does," he said. "Any of us, we all hate this for you. It's a sin, what that woman left you with."

I considered the word *sin*. Then considered what the woman left me with. A life of low expectations after getting shot down for chasing the pie in her sky. A heart held permanently on low simmer, lest any real passion boil over. Somewhere along the line, I guess I'd come to believe that one life of bereavement is equal to another.

"All that nonsense," he added, tilting his head toward the house. Seeing my faraway look. He meant stuff. She left me with her outrageous dragon's hoard that would take a normal daughter more than one lifetime to clean up.

"And here I am, a sinner myself. Smoke in the air and poison ash on the ground, burning up these treasures she loved better than life. Today's my

day for blaspheming everybody."

He looked at his watch. "Steele County's off your back. Presbyterians I can't say about. But if she's watching you from the hereafter with something to say, that line's disconnected."

"Oh, Charlie. If only."

I went in and fetched us two mugs of coffee. I handed them to Charlie while I shook a few sprawling chairs to find one that might hold me, then sat myself next to my husband. I slipped off one of my boots so I could rub Gaspard's spine with my sock. It occurred to me pretty regularly that I was a lot more affectionate with one of them than the other.

"Remember that day you brought me lunch over here, and I told you how every time she bought a gift, she bought a spare one to keep for herself?"

He nodded.

"I always thought that was her greed. But you said the sweetest thing. Maybe she wanted to keep the good feeling she got from the giving. I've thought about that. It's probably true."

He was listening.

"It's forgivable, if I think of it like that. Because who doesn't want to do that?"

He widened his eyes at the fire. "I've not met one to match her, on the two-for-one Santa Claus business."

"No, I mean we all accumulate. Not junk but feelings. We hold onto stuff we'd be better off letting go of." I looked at him. He was watching the fire. "You don't. Do you?"

He looked at me, surprised. "What, hold a grudge?"

"A grudge. Childhood fears, a teenage crush, everything that ever hurt you. I guess I always thought that was just being human. But you're not like that. You live your hour and your day, and then walk away from it. On to the next one."

He looked at his feet, smiling. "You're saying I'm simple."

"I'm saying you're smart. You're one in a million. I'm saying I wish I were you."

I wondered if I was scaring him, talking this way. I was scaring myself some. He took off his cap and looked at it, turning it in his hands. It was green, embroidered with the name of a tractor company, or used to be. Now it was so faded, I couldn't have guessed either color or tractor make if I hadn't known the man and the hat for so many years.

“I wish I could be like you,” I said, “and not like her. This sickness gets handed down.”

He looked up at me directly, puzzling me out. Like a case of mastitis or something, I thought. He was so patient with animals.

“Livia, are you worried you’re a keeper like her?”

“Yeah. I am.”

He smiled, shook his head, ran a hand backward through his short hair and put his hat back on. “You’ve got my old boots in the trash bin before I can get the new ones laced up. I never knew a woman to keep house like you do.”

“I know. That’s me telling my mother to keep out. Which is just another way of keeping her with me. In here, it looks like the inside of that house.” I aimed a finger at my skull.

His eyes shifted from my eyes to where I’d pointed, just above my ear.

“Berry baskets, huh?”

“So many. Full of blame, guilt, things I said or didn’t say, people I was mad at or that I thought were mad at me, that didn’t love me, or that I thought didn’t love me enough, but maybe they did. My brother, all the time. Certain people in my past. *Her.* So much useless stuff.”

He waited a little, to be sure I was done. “No mice, then?”

I choked on my coffee, laughing. Gaspard got up and looked to be sure I was well.

When I could talk, I apologized. “I don’t need to keep you here all afternoon with my nonsense. You’ve got animals to feed. You don’t have to stay with me.”

“I believe I do,” he said.

“All right. Thank you.”

He reached across and put a hand on the back of my chair. We sat for a long time, drinking coffee and watching the blaze. The fire was a bright wall of heat now, tall and wide, like a crackling orange window I could see through to the landscape on the other side. The old milking barn and sheds in the pasture were dancing, their straight edges shimmying into curves of light. I remembered watching my father and Dolly out there in the gray fog.

“Charlie, I want to be done with this. But there’s a bunch of stuff in my mother’s bedroom I need to burn. And I’m scared to death of it.”

Both man and dog alerted, looking at me. Ready to protect me, if I named the monster. If I could. The fire put a few loud cracks into our silence.

“You said it’s a sickness, this keeping,” he finally said.

I knew he listened. Twice as much as he spoke. It should never surprise me that Charlie remembered everything I told him. Probably also a good deal of what I didn’t.

“Maybe it’s not even a question of sick or well. People are just made different ways.” I stared into my empty cup, wondering how to say what I meant. “Some people come with more glue in them, I guess. They attach so hard to other people, it’s scary. Maybe it’s easier to attach to junk mail and cardboard instead. Or just keep a little distance around yourself, because it feels safer.”

He was listening.

“I’m saying *me*, Charlie. *I’m* made that way. If it has to be all or nothing, sometimes I’d rather it be nothing. When I think about Cyrus. Which I do, every single day, Cyrus and that train. And every time, this voice in my head yells, ‘Stop it! Look away!’ And I try to. It’s the main thing I’ve ever wanted. But if I let go of my brother, he’s gone. I’ve killed him all over again.”

Charlie looked troubled by this but offered no advice.

“His suicide note is in there. Two of them, if you can believe it. One he wrote to my mother, and one to me, that she hid. I never saw either one of them till the day before yesterday.”

“My word, Livvie. What did he say?”

“It was . . . surprising. All this time I thought he left me for this or that reason, but. It wasn’t me he left. I was no part of it. He thought I was great. And . . .” I wiped my eyes and looked at my hand, surprised that tears would decide to show up here now. Charlie was looking fairly wide-eyed, expecting more. Which I would tell him, of course. Gaspard stared with a simpler need, to dispatch the enemy that was giving me so much grief. If I knew where to point.

“That’s the stuff that’s scaring me,” I told Charlie. “There’s a lot more in there. Boxes of letters and keepsakes, and it mostly adds up to hatefulness. Well,” I laughed sadly, “also some bank statements. But mostly, generations of people being mean. Refusing to look at their own child and see the good in them. Lord, what my poor mother had to hear from *her* mother.”

I had to dry my eyes again and might soon have to wipe my nose on my shirttail, which would be embarrassing. “I always wondered what awfulness she saw in Cy and me, to hurt us like she did. But her problem . . .” I felt so

lost, without anger to lean on. I looked over at her long blue dress, folded on the chair. “Her problem with me wasn’t *me*. It was hatefulness that got to her before we were even born. She *kept* that, Charlie. Under her bed.”

He regarded me thoughtfully. “Are you aiming to burn it, then, or put it in a frame?”

I loved him so much. “Keep an eye on that fire,” I said, and stood up. “You too,” I told Gazzie, pointing at the ground. “You stay.”

This could be a day’s work. Just that. On the seventh day, she blew the whole mess of snake’s hair up to the heavens on a column of partly legal smoke. It took several trips to get all the shoeboxes out because they were falling apart. I didn’t need to be leaving a breadcrumb trail of soldier boys and fresh looks for brides. I lined them up like crumbling dominoes, putting the silverfish on notice, and then brought out the crown jewel. The wedding dress box.

“Okay, I’m starting with the easy stuff. A hundred children she wished she’d had instead of us.” I picked up a box and rifled my hand through all those boys in uniform. Charlie looked unsettled. I’d promised to think of her more generously, and already was slipping. Lifelong habit. “Or just boys and girls, I guess. That grew up. A thousand happy-ever-afters she kept beside her bed. Thanks, Mom. Here we go.”

I tipped the box of boys into the fire, watching the confetti of newsprint and faces swirl and catch. The girls followed right behind. Photos crumpled to purple-black twists, newspaper scraps burst in puffs of light. Happy-ever-afters. The crackling grew fast and percussive, a hungry, excited fire. Glowing paper flakes flew straight up on the column of smoke. I dumped in some boxes of receipts and tax records, no ceremony needed. Then. Oh, then, the box of recital programs, hers and mine. Those buttons and bows and hopes and heart-pounding nights. My triumph with the Knoxville Symphony. I looked into the box, trying to keep tears out of my eyes. What do you keep after all? A child wants to climb the ladder. She did, and I did, thinking we’d get somewhere. Here. *Here* to this cloudless day. Charlie, watching me patiently with his arms crossed. I turned up the box and ruffled the ladder of years into smoke and flame.

The grandmother letters I didn’t want to eulogize; I just wanted them gone. Not only gone today, erased from the length of my life and most of hers. I shook the box directly into the fire and watched that poison disappear in curls of heat. It was the best I could do for all of us.

I picked up the big envelope with the clippings about the Western Auto boys. Cy's two notes I'd already pulled out. I incinerated the rest, thinking of Marshall Sterling. It occurred to me only now, Marshall was a person, probably still walking around somewhere, who might be found if I looked. He would have heard the news about Cy such a long time ago; maybe he'd forgotten, or maybe not. He might like to hear from somebody else who thought Cy was perfect.

I worked the two letters out of my back pocket. The one with "Mom" scrawled on it, nobody needed. Whatever she'd said to him was unforgiven. He'd put that in writing. I delivered it to the pillar of fire. But hesitated over the other one. I looked at Charlie, who watched as attentively as if I were performing. I'd lost self-consciousness and was giving my full concentration to this piece, whatever it was. Danse Macabre, Ode to Joy, Pavane for a Dead Infant. Erlkönig, stealer of children. Treasure Keeper of the Night. A hell of a partita.

"This is . . ." I held it up to show Charlie. "His goodbye. I don't know if I want to let it go or keep it. What should I do?"

"Read it?" he suggested.

I didn't know whether he meant aloud or to myself. I did some of both. "He says he knows I'll be mad at him. That's not how he starts, but it's in there. He says he's sorry, but he knows I'll be okay." I glanced up at Charlie. "Good to hear, right?"

I scanned down the page.

"He was in love with somebody. I had no idea. He never told me. With a boy, or a young man, rather. A year or two older." I glanced up at Charlie. "Do you know any Sterlings?"

He thought about it. "I don't."

"Well, that's the terrible thing. When this boy's family found out, they made him join the marines so they'd not see each other again. Cy was in love for the first time in his life, so happy. He didn't want to go on living without that. He was just done."

Charlie looked as sad as I felt.

"He said he wasn't worried about me, I was going places. I had my music and nobody could ever take that from me, and he said . . . well, this is dumb."

"About you. What did he say?"

I read it. "'Hang tight sister, you are the righteous champion in our wasted family so don't ever look back. When you're famous I will tell everybody in heaven I'm your brother and we used to play chopsticks together.'"

Charlie was almost smiling, and also looked really sad.

"'Ha ha. Love, Cy.' What do I do with this?"

"Not mine to say. What do you want from him?"

I thought about it. "I want him to be a real person. Alive or dead, just my brother. Not some phantom with magical powers hiding in the fog."

"Then I believe I'd do what he says."

I looked at the paper in my hand. It had taken him, what, two minutes, to write this? Then he walked outside, and then he was gone. That's the one hour I'd been hoarding in the shoebox between my ears. Turning it over and over. Not all the other the mornings and nights and long afternoons with a brother teaching me card games in a milking stall, playing "Chopsticks," walking in the woods and screaming in the woods and lying on the blanket in the dark, talking about loneliness. The brother I'd been holding onto with all my might was the one who left me. He was so many more hours than that. I could have those now. I was ready.

I held the yellow paper to the flame and let it go.

Like a petulant child, this fire owed me its life but was trying my patience and appeared to have no plan on going to sleep. I told Charlie again, he didn't need to stay with me, and he stayed anyway. We sat in the last two surviving chairs and drank the rest of the coffee while we waited for the embers to die, wondering if we'd be set free by sunset. He had animal chores. We would get hungry. We already were. Even Gaspard was getting grumpy, first growling in his throat, then barking outright. Some big half-burnt thing down in the ash pile kept ruminating and popping, now and again shooting up a flare. Gaz must have registered that as a threat.

I'd set the wedding dress box aside and forgotten it briefly, but then remembered. *The wedding dress box!* I told Charlie I'd been waiting all my life to burn that thing, and was gleeful about dumping out the whole cardboard coffin of tissue paper and disintegrating lace and satin and more papers tucked away that I truly did not wish to know about. Her ritual anniversary toast was enough: *The day I slit my throat.* Blasphemy never

felt better, if we were still in that territory, though it felt more like letting a flock of cramped things go free. The flames got very excited about the crinolines. Then Gazzie started barking in a way that made me concerned for his mental health. He needed me to get back to normal. I sat down.

"So, Charlie. I've got something planned for tomorrow evening, spur-of-the-moment. Kind of a party, kind of a reunion, I don't quite know what it is. But I want you to come."

"All right. What kind of a reunion?"

"Well, I've been wanting to talk to you about that. An old friend from out of town is coming. *Gaspard!*" I frowned at his sudden barking. It was unlike him to interrupt conversation. Did he know I was about to bring up the man who made me throw things off the roof?

"What is it, boy?" Charlie asked. Gazzie went quiet.

"Listen. Do you hear that?" I asked. The fire was dying, but also making more noise than seemed to make sense.

"Do you *smell* that?"

Charlie was already on his feet, backing away from the house to get a better look at the roof. I did smell it. Burning tar shingles. From the back of the yard, we had a good view of the roof, and there was nothing to see up there. Except smoke, coming up from behind.

Gaspard and I raced around to the front while Charlie did the sensible thing, running to disconnect the hose and bring that with him.

"Oh, God *damn it* to hell, I'm so sorry. What have I done?"

We walked backward, staring, then backed up some more for a better look at the patch of flames spreading like a bright little lawn across the roof of the front porch. Charlie hooked up the hose while I dialed 9-1-1 and declared our emergency. I gave directions, and had to convince the operator she needed to *write down* the directions, because cell service is very spotty between here and town, and navigation systems go haywire. Anybody from around here would know that. After I hung up, Charlie reminded me it was Sunday evening. We'd have a better chance getting the Steele volunteer fire department together for a poker game than out here in any hurry.

Oh, hell, I said to that. I kept cursing, and apologizing to Charlie, and cursing some more. It was my day for blaspheming. Gaspard ran madly back and forth barking at the roof. Charlie stood quietly aiming the thin spray of the hose at the roof. It wasn't working.

"I'll call James," I said.

Charlie reminded me James had gone to Virginia to bid on a job and check on his sister who was getting out of rehab. I swore and then called Mickie. She was good in emergencies.

I don't know if it was ten minutes or thirty before we saw them coming slowly up the road: Ethan driving, Betts riding shotgun on Charlie's tractor rig, pulling the side-roll irrigator behind with the thousand-gallon tank. I've never seen Charlie Cable move so fast. In no time flat, they had it set with the sprayers aimed at the roof. We all got so wet. The water coming off the roof was black with melted tar, so there was that too. More clothes to get rid of.

After the roof was soaked cold and we were trying to laugh the panic out of our systems, the volunteer fire department showed up. We knew these men by name. One was a high school kid in Ethan's homeroom. But they'd put on those yellow reflective suits and driven all the way out here, by God, and it was their time to be large and in charge. They commanded us to stay clear as they tromped in the front door and all over the house with that black gunk on their boots. This house I would have to shine to a high polish before we put it on the market. I might be forgiven if I blasphemed the Steele volunteer firefighters along with my mother and the burn laws. All in a day.

We didn't get to bed until after eleven, a scandalous hour for burning the candles in a farmstead. I felt like all the lights inside my head were on, and I couldn't switch them off for anything. Just kept walking around the rooms in that skull, taking in the space. Charlie seemed as worked up as I was, thanks in part to our afternoon pot of coffee, but all of it, really. We kept going over how much worse it could have been, how lucky we were, considering. How in the world it could have happened. There was no wind. We'd kept an eye on that fire the whole time. Which one of my victims had sneaked its embers past our watch? It had to be the wedding dress. I had no doubt about it. Getting the last word about us and our sly marriage.

Only she wouldn't. I corrected my thinking. That was over. No lasting damage was left for that house to pass on. James could repair the porch roof in a couple of days, as soon as he had time. There was no smoke or water damage to the things I'd packed up, so our estate sale would go on as planned. The last of my mother's gifting feelings would be carried away to

households all over the county. I would scrub every dark footprint out of the empty rooms, and for some other family, the place would be new. I felt chilled almost to feverish with something risky I couldn't quite recognize. Happiness, maybe. I stood in the shower a long time making the water run hot, then cool, and still my whole body felt charged, like extra nerves had grown underneath my skin. I dried myself off and got into bed without a stitch of anything on.

Charlie had gone out one last time to settle the calves after their upset routine, so it was a while before he came upstairs. He'd showered longer than usual too, getting rid of the smoke and ash. We always kept the lights off in the bedroom—we'd never found the inclination to change our ways on that. I listened to the faint, familiar unbuckling sounds as he sat on the side of the bed to take his foot off. He set it down quietly, thinking I was already asleep. Then finished putting on his pajamas in the dark and slipped himself into the envelope of our sheets.

I lay still, listening to his breathing. He very often fell off right away, but tonight he was awake. I reached over and took his hand, squeezed it, and pulled it up to my chest, flattening out his fingers on the skin over my ribs just under my breast. I could feel the little startle in his body when I did that. He didn't take back his hand, but rolled on his side to face me.

"Livvie, what is it? Are you having a heart attack?"

I laughed quietly. "No. But you might."

"Why?"

"I don't have anything on."

He didn't move his hand, or any other part of himself. "I guess I could tell that."

"I just wanted your hand on me."

"All right."

He lay very still on his side, probably uncomfortably, with his hand on my heartbeat.

"You could take off your pajamas too."

At that, he fell away from me, onto his back, arms at his sides. "Oh, Livvie. I'm just an old, one-legged man."

"I know. And I'm a sad old woman with a bad hand and no womb. I don't mind the other things, but I don't want to be sad anymore."

"I don't suppose I knew that you were. I'm sorry."

“I don’t suppose I did either, till here just lately. You get used to things. I wasn’t crying myself to sleep or anything, not a big sadness like that. Just the ordinary, everyday kind.”

“What kind is that?” He seemed very wide awake. He put his hands behind his head.

“I want to say it’s the kind most people have, but that’s probably wrong. I see people wearing bright colors, or stopping to take notice of a beautiful day, and I envy them. It’s not the clothes I envy, or the day. It’s the deserving of it.” I rolled onto my side to look at him. “Does that make sense?”

“Not a bit,” he said, smiling. We could see each other perfectly well. The moon was in the window, and our eyes had made friends with the dark. We sat ourselves up with pillows against the headboard like this was a perfectly normal thing. Chatting in the moonlight. He kissed his fingertips and touched my nose. “There’s no *deserving* to life. If there was, I’d never have got the prettiest wife on the lane.”

“The *lane*?” I laughed. “Who else was there? Your sister and those hellcat Barnes girls.”

He was amused. “The county, then. A hobble-horse old boy like me. I asked myself, why in the world would she have me? You know what I finally figured out?”

“What did you figure out?”

“You never had to worry I would run off.”

“You’re right about that. And you never had to worry I’d get pregnant with some other man’s baby.”

“There we are. Lucky as we deserve to be.”

“I’m sorry I couldn’t,” I said.

He made a face of mock dismay. “Get pregnant with another man?”

I whacked him lightly on the arm. “I mean it. You’d have been good with kids.”

“I’ve seen enough of calving to keep me humble. And you’re a mother to every little key thumper in the county.”

“That’s hardly mothering.”

“The heck. I hear you down there in the living room. Little ones, teenagers with sass coming out their ears, even the ones with no more tune in them than a tree stump. They all love their Miss Livia. Because you

always find something sweet to tell them. *Always*. 'Nice job, Braden, that sure was *loud*.'"

"Oh my Lord. Braden."

We rested in the dark, a little amazed at ourselves, I think, for being awake together at this hour, talking like this. We were ourselves, and not ourselves.

"Why do you always call yourself an old man? We might be a little past halfway through, but that's not really *old* yet. Is it?"

He blew out a long, slow breath like a whistling wind. I thought for a minute that was going to be his answer. But he was thinking.

"I've always been old. I grew up old."

"Why is that? Being on crutches doesn't make you old."

"No. It wasn't the crutches. It was seeing other kids have the biggest fits over nothing. Every day. They lost their quarter in the pop machine. Somebody looked at them crossways, and it's the end of the world. No. Your family thinking they've lost you there in a hospital bed, from leaving your foot and half your blood outside on the grass. That's the end of the world. Then getting another chance at all this? You talk about your bright colors and your beautiful day? I'll take every bit of that. I like being old. It's a blessing."

I waited a little bit, to make sure he was finished. "I agree with you then. Also, that might be the most words I've ever heard you say at one time."

"Well," he said patiently, "that is because you never asked me about baling silage."

I reached under the sheet to find his hand and held it tight. My left, his right. "I would move a mountain for you, Charlie. I'm sorry if I don't say so, but it's true. I love you that much."

He laughed. "You needn't to bother. They're every one of them just right where they are."

"See, that's the reason. You make it pretty easy."

He was looking at me in a way I couldn't understand. Until he reached over and put his hand on my ribs again. "Would you like that? What you were wanting me to do before?"

"I would. I need you to hold me."

I helped him out of his pajamas, and we settled back into the bed, holding each other close, old skin against old skin. It felt as good as life is. We were suddenly so weary, it seemed likely we'd fall asleep this way, and that was

all I needed right now. If there was more to be had, we could work on that. I could. Work on deserving Charlie.

"Don't let me go," I whispered.

He roused a little. "Somebody's visiting, you said. Tomorrow. Do I need to run the mice out of Mammaw's house?"

"That's a good idea. If you'll do that, I'll make up the bed and take care of the rest."

"Who is it?"

"Just somebody I knew a long time ago."

"From around here?"

"California. He happened to be in the area. We've not spoken in forever, and I wasn't sure it made sense for him to visit. But I think it does. I'll tell you more in the morning."

"Okay."

I felt his limbs loosen around me and his breathing ease into sleep. I felt protective of whatever this was between us. And knew it could bear no falsehood. My coil of evasion had to open and let me out, if I meant to keep this. I felt a catch in my throat for what I'd just done, the untruth of offering up Sigurd in such harmless words. Not a phantom with magical powers, just a person. Somebody I knew a long time ago.

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Al Fine

I will say this for country people, or anyway the ones I know: If you call for a party, you'll have it. On a week's notice or two days, I don't care what it is, a family supper or a cornhole game in the backyard. Give people a reason to get together, and they'll be there with a covered dish. Mickie remarks on this because she knows people in more places, friends she's kept up with from her UT days. She says they're forever whining on Facebook how it takes four months for three people to agree on one day to have lunch together. When she speaks of it, I remember that too, from college. That the only answer to *How are you?* was *Too busy!*

Now I live among people who might have been up before dawn with a sick calf, or have hay to mow before rain gets here; they might work mornings at the dollar store and nights cleaning floors at the hospital and have to pick up their kids from school in between. Or take somebody to a court date. They might like you a lot or very little. No matter. If you run into each other pushing your groceries to your cars in the Kroger parking lot, they'll stop and talk to you. *Busy* is not a boastful thing. It might even be taken for a weakness. It's not our way to make a show of telling friends we have something better to do. We are each other's better thing.

I'd started calling my pupils soon after I spoke with Sigurd on Saturday, and in they came now through the door. Lord knows, nobody anywhere ever had a thing to do on a Monday night, but I was touched to see how

many families made the effort. All eleven Callisters got themselves in two cars, including all four parents, with the grandparents close behind. Their raft of children bounded out in clean, pressed clothes not very different from what they wore for their Saturday lessons. Whereas Deronne's family dressed up, Deronne and his father in sport coats, his mother in a blue suit with white piping and a small, neat hat. I admired them across the gravel lot and thought I'd like to attend their church, for the pleasure of being among such well-dressed people. I'd bet the singing was also exceptional, and wondered briefly if they needed a pianist. They'd have one, of course. And the poor soul was doomed to be unseated by Deronne.

The Callister kids brought a treat for Gaspard, trimmings from their draft horses' hooves, which he liked chewing on like hard candy. They wanted to run around with him in the parking lot, but he herded them inside, out of the way of arriving cars. A lot of my adult students came, including the soon-to-be-wed Edwina, my extension agent Gerald, and identical twins in their twenties named Grayson and Mason who I couldn't tell apart to save my life until they sat down to play. (Mason applied himself.) The Furies screeched in as a unit in Bella's ancient Honda Accord with one bright green fender. They got out in a flurry of boots and fishnet stockings and blue-black hair and jeweled special-occasion septum rings and Bella's mammaw. I wondered how this would all square up with Sigurd's expectations of our rural paradise.

I'd called it a free-for-all recital. Nobody really asked for much explanation, but I told them I had a visitor coming who'd been sick and needed cheering up. I said I wanted to show off their talents, because my friend was from California, and everybody knows Californians don't know a blooming thing about east Tennessee. I told these kids they were a star attraction. They could play whatever they wanted. Anything, truly. We wouldn't have a printed program like the fancy ones I made for our year-end recitals. The mood was different today, without the nerves our formal recitals could sometimes ring in. The kids frolicked while the grown-ups visited. I stood in the foyer inside the glass doors accepting a lot of hugs around my waist and handshakes from parents, and it felt festive, like a receiving line for a wedding.

Mickie wouldn't miss a recital, even an impromptu whatever-it-was, but she did want to know what was up. When *she* had an old friend in town, she stood them for a beer at the steak house. I conceded this was an old

boyfriend. And yes, there was more to tell. I promised I'd do that soon. She asked if I felt like I had something to prove to him. I did not say he'd spent these many years looking for my name in lights, expecting me to be famous by now. I said I wasn't sure what I wanted out of this, but after it was done, she'd probably tell me. I also mentioned he was at one time the most beautiful man I'd ever laid eyes on, and that was good enough for Mickie.

I told Charlie a good deal more. (And a little bit less.) That I'd known Sigurd in college. That he wasn't a student. A typesetter, when I knew him, who moved to California and worked for the railroad until he retired. He'd traveled to Nashville for a medical consultation, but didn't seem to be at death's door, and had the idea of driving over to see me. Charlie observed that Nashville was not all that close. I said I'd told him that, but he wanted to make the trip anyway. All this seemed satisfactory to Charlie, who then asked if he'd been my boyfriend. I said he was, that we'd lived together briefly, and he'd broken my heart, but I got over it. That seemed to satisfy Charlie too. It was at lunchtime when we had this chat, after he'd gone up to collect the mousetraps he'd set in the morning, and helped me get the vacuum up the stairs to what we still called Mammaw's house. He asked how long I'd known this fellow was coming, and if that was the reason I'd been wilder than a March hare all week. I was embarrassed to say yes, it was.

We had no time to go into it just then, but I planned on telling him the whole story as soon as this visit was behind us. It might be easier for Charlie to hear such things about a man he'd already met, rather than some monster he had to imagine. But I was so afraid of having that talk, my stomach hurt thinking about it. Simple words, *I got over it*, to patch over a brokenness that changed everything about my life, and Charlie's after that. I'd put a lot of bygones in the fire yesterday, and almost burned down our retirement while I was at it. But not everything will burn.

Still no Sigurd. How funny would *that* be, if he failed to show. Desertion, again, would settle my side of the story, anyway. I wondered if he was lost, but I'd purposefully made this church our meeting point because it would be a reliable dot on his GPS. He could follow us out to the house afterward. I had supper in the slow cooker. We'd eat and tell a few tales of old times, he'd sleep in that little bed over the garage, and tomorrow he'd be gone. I could manage all the rest, I thought, if I could get through the first hour. For that, I wanted people around me, more than just Charlie. Normal life. I'd

braided my hair as usual and put on an everyday green dress and hoped for nothing special, except for my heart to stop thumping so hard. Some of the families had started going in to find seats. I stayed near the door keeping watch. We'd had a little rainstorm come out of nowhere earlier, and the evening light had a washed, clean look. The trees on the mountainsides were starting to shift their colors, the wild cherries browning first, as they do. All the little deaths in their time.

Finally a black sedan with rental plates pulled in slowly. He got out of it the way men will after a long drive, arching and stretching like a disgruntled cat. Looking around with some hesitation. I waved through the glass door; he saw and smiled and locked his car, the only one in that lot to be locked, I guarantee. There he was. Same, different. Jarringly aged. Not in any terrible way, just older. As I was, but we are never to ourselves the same age inside as we are on the outside. His hair was gray at the temples, very short, a little receding. Same smile. Syncopated. I felt badly rattled on the question of who this was and what we were doing here. I opened the door, and we hesitated on the hug question until I extended my hand. His grip was painful, not his fault. My poor hand, held together with baling wire more or less. Charlie and even my students had taken such care with it for so long, I rarely thought to protect it. The painful handshake settled down some of my disturbance. This man didn't know me.

I introduced him to Charlie, and that was stranger still. Two entirely separate parts of my life that had never touched, at all. Heaven and earth. I halfway expected lightning to explode between them when they shook hands, but both men looked calm. Charlie a little taller, with the shoulders of a man who hauls grain and lifts bales. Exactly the age he was. Sigurd wore glasses now, and looked like somebody who worked at a desk. How funny. If I'd been missing something all my life, here it wasn't.

"This must be your assistant," Sigurd said to me.

Gazzie looked a little less than professional, peering up at us with moon eyes and the big C of horse hoof curving out of his mouth.

"It is, and don't be talking union to him either. We couldn't afford him."

Charlie was watching me closely. Mickie stood a little behind them making *Yeah, baby* eyes at me, which didn't help anything. I herded us into the chapel and put the men on either side of me up front, near the piano. The little spinet faced the pews, which was fine. In performance, I liked seeing my pupils' faces for a change, instead of their hands. I thanked

everybody for coming and made my guest stand up and accept their applause for making it here all the way from California. He must have thought this was some long-planned event, not organized on his behalf, which was fine with me. I suggested the Callisters go first. They had animal chores to get home to, so I'd told them, on the quiet, it was okay if they needed to slip out at some point. With this free-for-all program, Lord only knew. It might be over in twenty minutes, or we could be here all night.

The Callisters followed the lineup they were used to, youngest first. Greta, of the age of missing front teeth, sat up tall, settled her hair behind her shoulders, and put her hands on the Gurlitt Dance in C Major. It's a sweet little piece, easy as can be, both hands in the treble clef. She bobbed her head to the three-four beat of the repeating left-hand notes, arrived at the end efficiently, looked up and beamed, then jumped off the bench to make way for Liam.

Sigurd leaned close to me and whispered, "Are these the preppers?"

"My butter-and-eggs kids, yes," I whispered back, trying to imagine how they would look to him. A whole ladder of kids who looked alike, for sure. I had trouble keeping straight which were siblings or cousins, but knew them so well on the inside. Liam was going to overtake the others if they didn't watch it. He played Gurlitt's "Night Journey," leaning into it like a race he meant to win. It's a simple piece too, but sounds mysterious in the minor key. They'd all loved "Night Journey." It thrilled those kids to have heard these pieces in the possession of older siblings, then claim them for their own when their time came. Unlike their hand-me-down clothes, the music didn't get worn out. It was a lineage.

In my peripheral vision, Sigurd looked attentive, or anyway not outwardly peeved that I was putting him through amateur entertainment. If it's not what he had in mind, too bad; he'd invited himself. And who could fail to love my little Callisters?

"*Whoop!*" came a shriek from behind me. Then screaming, and more screaming, like teenagers on a roller coaster. I stood up to look. It was the Furies section. Mammaw whooping and Bella screaming, madly scouring at her vivid bangs with both hands.

"We're scared of birds!" Bella shrieked.

"You can *not* be scared of birds. You guys have fucking *chickens*," yelled Rose.

"Rose, watch your language," I said. "Is there a bird?"

"*A chicken is not a fucking bird*," screamed Bella.

"Let's settle that later, Bella. *Is* there a bird?"

There was. It flapped noisily down from the rafters on one side and up to the other side in a big U shape of churning wings, narrowly missing a lot of scalps. Then vanished into the trusses. All the kids and most of the adults were on their feet now, craning and gaping up at the ceiling beams. Gaz got up and walked down the side aisle, then stopped, staring straight up. Somebody said it was an owl; other people said no, it wasn't that big. Somebody suggested it was a wren; they were bad about getting into houses. It was much bigger than a wren.

"It must have been trapped in here since yesterday morning," I said. "They probably had the windows open during church. Poor thing. We're scaring it to death. Gaz, here to me."

Gaz came back up to the front and lay down with a patient exhale. The rest of us held our breath and stared into the rafters for what felt like a long time. Liam's hands were frozen on the keys, arrested mid–"Night Journey."

"I guess we can go ahead?" I asked. Everybody sat down. "Liam?"

As if I'd dropped a needle on a record, Liam charged forward with his minor-key eighth notes, and the whooping and screaming recommenced, spreading well past the Furies. This time the bird made several loops across and back. Liam stopped, looking at me with frightened eyes.

"Honey, this is not your fault. But I don't know what to do about this bird."

Bella mumbled something about a damn shotgun. One of the Callister dads stood up and asked if I thought they'd have some kind of a tray downstairs. I was sure I could find one.

"If we open up a window and set a big tray of water on the sill, it'll go out," he said.

I wasn't sure if this was superstition, an assumption about bird thirst, or what, but he sounded confident. I hurried downstairs to the fellowship hall and fetched a cafeteria tray and a pitcher of water. Things happened while I was down there—I could tell by the screaming.

The red-headed Mr. Callister, Jacob, had the window open as wide as it would go. He worked efficiently with the tools I provided, plus a couple of hymnals, to balance the tray on the sill and cover it with a thin film of water. He asked us all to sit down and be still, and we did. All eyes up. Nothing happened. I felt anxious on Jacob's behalf, honestly, but he seemed

unworried about looking foolish. Capable and devoid of nonsense was the way of that whole family, handling whatever came their way, including the daughter Hannah's recent diagnosis of lupus. I was surprised they kept up lessons after she got sick, as desperate as they were for funds to get her medical care. They needed their music too, I guess. In whatever world was coming to them, they'd have Mozart and Beethoven.

"Maybe Liam ought to play some more, to get it to come out," Jacob said after a minute or so. "It'll need to see the water."

Liam obliged, and so did the bird, making several wild loops around the whole sanctuary, and then, whoosh. Out the window. Jacob tipped out the water, set the tray aside, and closed the window. Everybody applauded.

I was mystified. "Why did it want water? It didn't even stop to drink."

"It didn't want water," Jacob explained. "It wanted the sky. It saw the reflection."

I felt a strange little burst of joy on the bird's behalf. Finding its freedom from such a simple thing. Perspective. I gave us all a moment to take that in, then asked Liam to take it from the top.

The polite Callisters played one piece each, taking no more time than their due. Sharing was in those kids' DNA. Brave Hannah went last with Bach's C Major Prelude, an easy piece she'd mastered years ago, but I understood the comfort in the ones you know by heart. I kept a mental list for the program I'd promised to make afterward. A waltz by Oesten, a Bartók, the Minuet in F by Mozart. Even young children have usually heard of Mozart, and were always cowed when I gave them this minuet. When I told them he wrote it when he was six years old, it changed the game. Famous people could actually be regular humans, such as kids.

When the Callisters finished, I congratulated them on what could have been one of our regular recitals, and reminded everybody it was free-for-all today. Nobody had to play a classical piece if some other music would please them better. I raised an eyebrow at Mickie. Slippery slope be damned. Liam asked if he could play something on the fiddle. I sent him out to their car to get it, and he fiddled out "Bile 'Em Cabbage Down" and "Turkey in the Straw."

Edwina needed to go next because she was, in her words, fixing to die. I knew she would play the Elgar, the surprise for her new husband she was so set on. As the day approached, I think she was putting all her bridal nerves in that basket. I wondered if she was nervous about getting married, and

what she might stand to lose. Now I watched her frown at her hands playing "Salut d'Amour," knowing exactly where she'd stumble on the chromatic alterations, how she'd relax when she came back to the melody at the end. She didn't get that far. She stopped, started over, stopped at the same place again, then fell apart completely. She looked like she might cry.

I got up and sat beside her on the bench, squeezed her hand, and talked to the audience to let her collect herself. I explained that Edwina was going to play this at her wedding reception. "It's a surprise for her new husband, so you can't mention it outside this room. She needs to play it in front of people to get used to that. Right, Edwina?"

She was crying now. I kept Kleenexes tucked in my sleeve. I'd been at this a long time.

I chatted with the audience to buy her time. I said stage fright wasn't a disease; it was just another part of your music you had to learn. "I'm going to tell you kids something you don't know about me. I used to play real concerts when I was young, in great big concert halls sometimes. When I was seventeen, I was a guest soloist with the Knoxville Symphony."

"Shut *up*!" said Rose quietly. The Furies looked impressed, across the board.

"Yes, ma'am, I did that. So I had to learn to handle nerves. What you do is, you talk to the audience in your mind. 'Hello there, friends, let me play you a tune.' You have to tell yourself you're no big deal, and they're not either. Over and over, till you believe it. It's just one more part of the music you have to practice, like those accidentals and tricky rhythms you hate. Practice till you've got that confidence solid in your tummy. Okay. What do you think, Edwina?"

She nodded, and played her Elgar all the way through beside me on the bench. A few bobbles but a lot less panic. While she saluted her amour, I looked at Charlie and Sigurd on the front row with the narrow space between them, the size of one woman. What a line I could talk, about nerves. I had nothing solid in my tummy about this. Charlie. Tomorrow. I wondered what I stood to lose. I really had to tell him all of it, the breakup, the state it put me in that cost me my college career and almost my hand. That I'd carried Sigurd's child and almost died of it. Charlie would hate this man who broke my life to pieces. And that made me uneasy too. Maybe on Monday or Tuesday, I'd have wanted a lot of outrage on my behalf. Even

on Saturday morning, I might have mentioned the rotisseries of hell. Now I didn't know.

Edwina finished, and we both took our seats. I reached over and took Charlie's hand. He seemed all right with that, so I kept hold of it. His left, my right. He knew how.

For the rest of the recital, I never let go of Charlie except for applause. We applauded Edwina grandly, everybody grandly. Next came more littles. Then we had a short pause while Bella went out to her car to get Mammaw's pills because she felt like one of her spells was coming on. "It's because of the fricking bird," Bella muttered, flouncing down the aisle. Mammaw waved off the people looking at her while we waited, insisting she was fine. I sent silent blessings to this woman who had put by the fifteen dollars a week for piano lessons all these years. She wasn't that much older than me, and might have looked younger, with her youthful bob and frosted tips. But probably felt old inside, considering. The son in prison, having this wild child on her hands to raise after her own kids were all out the door. I'd have spells too.

The twins went next. Mason played a Bach fugue and Grayson played "Any Ol' Barstool," by Jason Aldean. But for the most part, these kids were proudly playing what I'd taught them. It pleased me to know our arrangement was consensual. For a smattering of households across Steele County, the latch string was out for Bach and Mozart. Even the beginners played little classics. We didn't use the piano teaching books with the dumb little elves climbing the staves, good Lord. It wasn't just older beginners they offended. Children know when you're talking down to them. I spent a lot of time tracking down real pieces a beginner could play, leaning on Cornelius Gurlitt, bless that man's heart. He was a great pianist, a member of the papal academy and all that, but also taught little children, to the end of his days. I loved him for never getting too full of himself. He left us a trove of nice pieces for the youngest beginners.

I don't know how other teachers do this. How would I? In music school, my serious peers felt we were above pedagogy and skipped those courses. I rarely thought about those classmates, but could hardly avoid it while sitting with Sigurd. I had to correct all the mental images: They'd be this age. A little gray and a little humbled, or a lot. All bound for some version of glory back then, every one of them teaching somewhere now, I'd be willing to bet, even the great Stephania Schmidt. If all those syllables ever

got up onto a marquee at once, I'd have heard about it. I wondered if my old colleagues felt bored or downgraded by pedagogy. How different it had to be for me. Climbing my way up to this profession felt like scaling Mount Everest, truly that physical, that much a test of endurance. I took the flag at the top for the victory it was. I had some skills my students didn't yet, and they had hands that could reach and bend in places mine never would again. My deal with them was simple: We are all musicians here.

I tried to keep my attention on the performers, not the man who'd dragged my past into this room. And into my week, and my marriage. If I was going to have to explain this recital to Mickie later, we might both be out of luck. For a while, my goal was to stop zinging like a damaged nerve, hypersensitized to the history sitting next to me. To stop wondering what he thought of this. Of me, the size of what I'd become without him. Or hadn't. It came and it went. Went away during the bird kerfuffle, came back when I sat with Edwina and looked at Sigurd and Charlie side by side. Oof. I just wanted to be a happy godmother to all this sweet effort and creation, and forget he was there.

Elizabeth was helping, doing an impressive job of the Allemande I'd thought might frustrate her. She was my most accomplished student besides Deronne, and had been playing much longer. She grew up taking lessons in Atlanta, and found me after she moved here in her twenties to take the job as head of county libraries, ten years ago. She'd always wanted to play a Bach partita, so I guided her toward the C Minor, starting with the manageable slower movements. I'd advised her to skip the trilly ornaments for starters, which she was doing, and concentrate on the winsome eight-note melody that walks up and down the keyboard, begging the left hand for an answer. Elizabeth was like me; she heard words in the musical phrases. It helps with memorizing, but once those words are in there, they want to stay. In the Allemande, the right hand keeps asking: *Why do you never think of me?* And the left answers, *You know I do.*

I listened with my head down, studying the denim grain of Sigurd's jeans and his sidewalk-clean tennis shoes. I couldn't fit this physical presence into anything I remembered loving or hating or wishing for. I would have to ask him about his illness. He did seem diminished, not just by age. The word *broken* came to me. Not like a bone, like a horse. I'd heard it on the phone and sensed it now in his person. Maybe he hadn't faced down the end of the world in a hospital bed like Charlie and me, but he'd seen his big

hopes end. We started out as beautiful besotted people, keeping our beliefs alive with such small shreds of evidence. It's all so breakable.

Elizabeth finished and we applauded, and she asked a little sheepishly if she could play the Sarabande too. Both movements were short. I told her of course. The silence in that church was spectacular; even the little kids were listening as she set herself to the Sarabande. Somewhere between those two passages of the partita, it came clear to me there was really nothing so huge I needed to tell Charlie beyond the simple facts about the losses I suffered a long time ago. Surviving in broken parts is not such a bad thing. Probably it's the ordinary thing, maybe even something to count as lucky. Cyrus didn't because he couldn't see how to fit the pieces back into anything he had use for. I always thought he'd taken the easy way out, and the harder job was to survive. But Charlie would find no sense in that, given what he'd said about the bright colors and beautiful days. If I had a painful confession to make, it was that I'd made so much of the idea I wasn't whole because somebody broke me. Without crediting what a person might make from putting the pieces back together. What had become of me, I didn't need to tell Charlie. He knew.

The Furies wanted to go last, but Deronne had already asked for that because he had a surprise. The Furies went next to last. Rose took the piano bench while the other two stepped up onto the pulpit platform, Cleo in a black leather miniskirt, Bella more outlandish in a very short, pleated skirt like some naughty school uniform costume, with a corset sort of thing on top. Her squashed breasts heaved perilously as the two girls clomped around stage-managing the carpeted chancel, pushing the pulpit off to one side, a wobbly candelabra to the other. The wooden cross on the wall behind them, they were stuck with.

"This is a song we wrote together," Bella announced. "Mostly Rose. She did the music, and we all helped on the lyrics. It's called. . . ." She looked over at Rose. "What's it called?"

Rose held up her middle finger and said, "'Here's to Love.'"

"It's called that. It's about Jolene, like in the Dolly Parton song. You know, 'Jolene, please don't take my man!' But ours is from Jolene's point of view."

Rose played a bar of intro, and all three began to sing. Then a yelp. "Wait! Stop! Wardrobe malfunction!" Bella howled, holding her top

together. She and Cleo turned their backs to us, as if that made them invisible and their hissed argument inaudible.

"I told you not to borrow that, it's too small."

"You weigh the exact same as me, bitch!"

"Yeah, but I'm all junk and you're all up top."

I was glad Mammaw had her pills. Sigurd was laughing silently beside me. Elizabeth hurried up to the stage with a safety pin, and the malfunction was corrected. Rose started them again. The melody owed a serious debt to Ms. Parton, I would have to say in a court of law, but the improvised piano work was good. The lyrics, one hundred percent Furies.

"He never wore his wedding ring, I never did suspect a thing
Till you came in here with your crying eyes.
He wasn't all that in the sack. Oh, honey, you can take him back.
A cheating husband ain't nobody's prize."

The crowd approved, including young children I hoped were not getting the whole gist. Sigurd was entertained, for sure. The Furies lit up with our applause. These girls were so alive with their pissed-off passion and bursting young bodies. I loved them. And they wore me out. You want too much when you're young, it's just what you do. What we did. Made a fire with so much fuel, it had to burn itself out. That is the meanest trick of memory, looking back on a day and imagining it going on and on. A dollar spent is a dollar spent. You can watch that purchase again in your mind's eye a thousand more times, but it's not a thousand dollars in anybody's wallet. It's none.

Rose and Cleo switched places. Before sitting down at the piano, Cleo announced her piece. "This is a serious one. I'm going to play *Gnossienne,* by Erik Satie. Rose and Bella are going to interpret the directions for you that Mr. Satie wrote for this piece. Not kidding. This is for real."

Hoo boy.

Cleo delicately launched the *Gnossienne* No. 3, bringing out the melody in the high, bouncing quarter notes. Her teammates stood frozen on the chancel, waiting through sixteen beats for their first cue. Then Rose declared in exaggerated, terrible French, "*Conseillez-vous soigneusement,*" repeated by Bella in exaggerated English, "Counsel yourself cautiously," and they tiptoed quite dramatically around the pulpit with fingers held to their lips.

Next: “*Munissez-vous de clairvoyance!*” “Be clairvoyant!” They rolled their heads, gazing at an imminent future above us in the ceiling trusses. Ideally not a bird.

“*Seul, pendant un instant!*” “Alone for an instant!” Backs turned, arms crossed.

“*De manière a obtenir un creux!*” “So as to be a hole!” They dropped to the ground, spread-eagled on their backs.

By the measure of audience response, this was even better than Jolene’s revenge. I felt a little badly for Cleo, who had a nice touch with the *Gnossienne*. Nobody was watching her, but maybe this was all her idea, her stage fright strategy. Cleo was the shy one of the three. All eyes were on the dancers as they performed “Very lost” and “Carry this even further” (oh, they did) and “Think right!!” On the final instruction, “Muffle the sound,” they waited for her to play the last two chords before they ran and threw both their upper bodies onto the keyboard.

Cleo was correct: Mr. Satie really did write his *Gnossiennes* with these preposterous performance instructions, sometime around 1890. If he could step into our century, I don’t think he’d be half so pleased with automobiles and airplanes as with this interpretation of his work in a little church in east Tennessee. Immortality is a bendable thing. I tell my pupils all the time not to underestimate their own importance. Music is not the boss of you. It’s written down, wanting to live forever, but it’s not really here till you make it yours.

Bella took the bench next and announced she was playing “‘Go Rest High on That Mountain’ for my pappaw because Miss Livia wouldn’t let me at the recital, after he passed.”

A triumphant glare was thrown my way. I had it coming. But didn’t expect the three of them to sing. Their three voices together were arresting. They understood harmony and voicing a lot better than most singers of hymns in church, maybe better than some professionals who’d sung this country standard. That was their training too; I’d had a part in it. I should have let them do this at the recital. I was hearing a lot of snuffles and blown noses behind me, and not just the widowed Mammaw. I didn’t have enough Kleenex to go around. I’d save it for the black mascara that was running down the girls’ faces like water off a burnt porch roof. Even through tears, they held the pitch nicely through verse, chorus, and reprise. The Furies killed it.

Deronne was bursting for his turn. I wondered how anybody could not love this boy, in his little suit and red bow tie and earnest face. When he sat down, I could only see his high thin eyebrows under the neat curve of his hairline. But I knew he was staring into the keys before setting his hands there. He always did this, preparing to leave himself and go in. To what, today, I didn't know. Deronne was always agreeable to what I assigned him, but also knew how to find anything he wanted on the computer at the library and have it printed it out for him.

He announced without looking up, "This is an invention of my own invention."

His invention was the Bach Minuet in G that I'd given him some time ago. All right. And then, wow. He erupted into a jazz version of the Minuet in G. I'd stopped being surprised by Deronne, but did not know he could do that. Didn't know *how* he did that. I couldn't do it. I leaned forward to listen. He was pulling the left-hand arpeggios into chords, sliding the right-hand melody onto a different mode. A jazz scale. I wanted to take lessons from Deronne. Even transmogrified, it was still perfectly Bach. Contrapuntal, symmetrical, reliable Bach. As composers went, we were getting a runaway winner in this free-for-all, and that was my fault. We press our preferences on other people without realizing it, and then, at recital time, it all comes home to roost. I can't deny, I'm partial to the scrappy German orphan. He keeps his promises, even-steven, is all I can say. Every subject gets an answer, and it all comes right in the end. I've pressed those notes unconsciously into the skin of every man I ever trusted to hold me in my sleep. Hope is a stealthy business, with ideas of its own.

Deronne's jazzy minuet was short. He stood up at the end to accept our applause, then sat back down. "That wasn't the surprise," he said. "Now I'm doing the surprise."

He arranged some pages in front of him, settled himself, and played. Slow, double B-flat octaves in the right hand, like a bell ringing through fog. What in the everloving hell. The middle movement of *Gaspard de la Nuit*. My heart stopped, I swear. For the fourth time in my life, a little death. My hands went cold and my face went hot and I tried to make sense of this. Not that I thought the piece was beyond him. It wasn't the impossible "Ondine" movement or the utterly and truly impossible "Scarbo." Neither of which I ever played again, after. "Le Gibet" is slow, with the continuous upper ringing bell and the sad chords shifting under it. The pedaling might

be the trickiest part. It's a meditation. I could hear that he was leaving some notes out, simplifying as his small hands needed to do. But it was *Gaspard de la Nuit*. I'd played this for Sigurd so many times that spring. Not just the first time when he became, let's say, intimate with the "Ondine." All three parts I played for him, and explained the story poems behind each one. The middle story is gruesome, and I hoped Deronne didn't know it. Tucked between "Scarbo," the scrambly goblin, and sexy "Ondine," the flirtatious water nymph. For better and for worse, this was our song.

I realized I was holding my breath. I let it out slowly and looked over at Sigurd. He noticed, turning to me briefly, but had no recognition on his face. Just polite attention. This was no different from Hannah's Bach Prelude or "Go Rest High on That Mountain." Just more notes. Probably he was glad we were winding things up. I reached over and took his hand, and there was nothing to it. Somebody I knew a long time ago.

Deronne sat very still and let the last toll of the bell die away before he jumped up and took his bow. I gave him a standing ovation, which caused everybody else to do the same.

"The name of that was *Gaspard de la Nuit*, by Maurice Ravel," he informed us. Pronouncing the French about the way Sigurd did, once upon a time. Still no glimmer of recognition over there. "It's the easy part of it," he added. "The first and the last parts are *way* hard."

"They are," I agreed. "Did you know Mr. Ravel couldn't even play it himself?"

Deronne had started back toward his seat, but this stopped him. "Gah. Why did he even write it then?"

"For you, Deronne. You're going to play the whole thing one day. I'd put money on it."

He beamed.

"I'm curious, though." I was nervous to ask, and had to ask. "*Gaspard de la Nuit* is an unusual choice. What made you decide to play that for us today?"

Deronne looked slightly impatient with my slow wits. "Not for *you*. It's for *him*."

Him. The surprise was for my dog. Gaspard accepted it with his standard composure.

It was at Cross Creek Methodist where this happened. I'd hardly been back there in years, had no need since getting my own piano. I probably

should have asked permission for our gathering, but didn't, and wasn't worried about it. At the end of the night, Charlie would help me mop the foyer, and we'd leave everything the way we found it, before the three of us went home to have supper. Nobody ever needed this place on a Monday. I'd learned in childhood where I could go to be invisible and have my musical celebrations and funerals all to myself.

I was surprised, though, by the size of the feelings I'd had when I walked in that evening to turn the lights on. First love is the deepest, they say. I'd had so many private ceremonies here. Mozart, Chopin. "Chopsticks." The old minister had passed away, the one who'd first welcomed my little hands on that piano, and later on asked his congregation to abide my sneaking in here, because salvation comes in its own ways. I still had the key.

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Good writing begins with good listening, not just to dialogue and storytelling but also the musical elements of language: rhythm, inflection, pacing, dynamics, voice. Music and language are so conjoined for me, in fact, that I have to believe the people who gave me music were also helping me to become a writer. Some of my earliest memories are of my father, Wendell Kingsolver, putting records on his hi-fi so we could lie on the floor, close our eyes, and watch the pictures in our heads while we listened. We made stories out of Stravinsky's *Firebird* Suite and Rimsky-Korsakov's *Scheherazade* and Debussy's *Prelude to the Afternoon of a Faun*, which I thought was a baby deer. A long line of school music and piano teachers took over from there, stretching from Mrs. Edith Blake in Carlisle, Kentucky, to Dr. Mary Heller at the DePauw University School of Music. In rural, working-class places like the one where I grew up, classical music and fine arts are mostly out of reach; the teachers helping kids across that complicated bridge, then and now, deserve all the thanks they can get.

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BARBARA KINGSOLVER's eighteen previous books of fiction, nonfiction, and poetry have been translated throughout the world and earned literary awards at home and abroad, including a Pulitzer Prize for her 2022 novel, *Demon Copperhead*. She is a member of the American Academy of Arts and Letters, and in 2000 was awarded the National Humanities Medal, our country's highest honor for service through the arts. She lives with her family on a working farm in southern Appalachia.

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